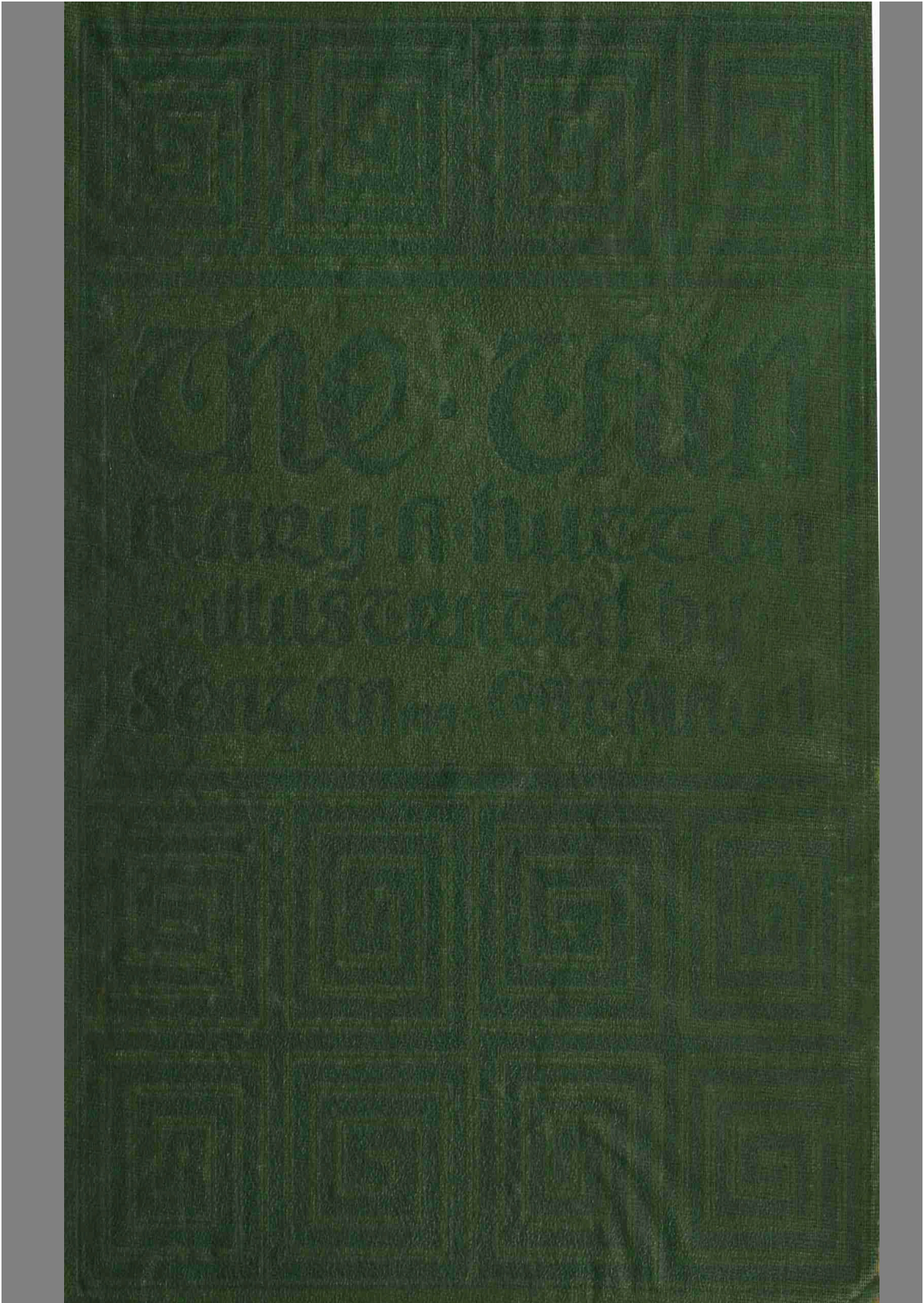








## **The Project Gutenberg eBook of The Táin**

This eBook is for the use of anyone anywhere in the United States and most other parts of the world at no cost and with almost no restrictions whatsoever. You may copy it, give it away or re-use it under the terms of the Project Gutenberg License included with this eBook or online at [www.gutenberg.org](http://www.gutenberg.org). If you are not located in the United States, you will have to check the laws of the country where you are located before using this eBook.

Title: The Táin

Translator: Mary A. Hutton

Illustrator: John Patrick Campbell

Release date: January 9, 2026 [eBook #77663]

Language: English

Original publication: Dublin: Talbot Press, 1924

Other information and formats: [www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/77663](http://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/77663)

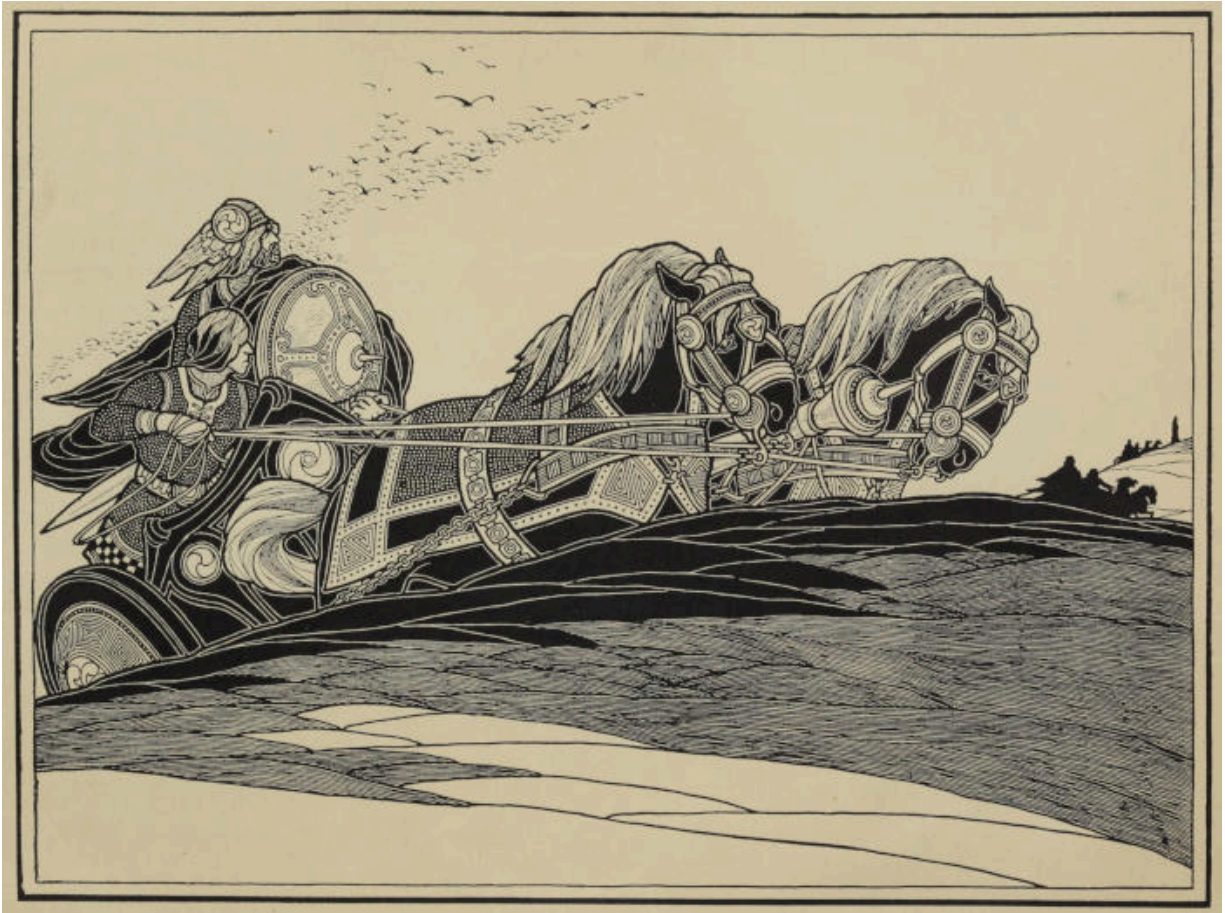
Credits: Tim Lindell and the Online Distributed Proofreading Team at <https://www.pgdp.net> (This file was produced from images generously made available by The Internet Archive/American Libraries.)

\*\*\* START OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK THE TÁIN \*\*\*

This volume  
has been presented by



the author  
Mrs. Mary A. Hutton,  
D. Litt.  
1948.



“FERGUS GOES TO MEET CUCULLIN.”

*Frontispiece.*



# THE TÁIN

Mary A Hutton

illustrated by

SEAGAN mac CATMAOIL

## PREFACE

The following poem, on which I have spent the careful and ardent labour of the past ten years, is an attempt to tell the whole story of the Táin in a complete and artistic form.

The great tale of the Táin Bó Cúalnge has come down to us in two widely differing recensions. Both of these are in prose with poetry interspersed. One of these recensions (L.L.) is found in the Book of Leinster, a manuscript dating from the middle of the twelfth century. The other recension (L.U.) is found partly in the *Leabhar na h-Uidhri*, a manuscript written by a scholar who died in Clonmacnoise in 1106, and who—we are told—“wrote and shaped this book from various books”; and part of the same recension is found in the Yellow Book of Lecan, a manuscript which, although later, contains some very archaic material. For a comparison of these two recensions, and for a consideration of the various and very interesting critical problems to which they give rise, I must refer my readers to the delightful *Einleitung und Vorrede* which Dr. Windisch has given us in his edition of the Book of Leinster text of the Táin: to No. 5 of Prof. Zimmer’s *Celtische Studien*; and to Miss Faraday’s short introduction to her translation of the texts of the L.U. recension. It suffices for me to say here that, while L.L. is the more literary, and L.U. the more scholarly, of the two versions, from the purely artistic point of view both of them are unsatisfactory and incomplete.

My general method of working has been this. As a rule, but not invariably, I have taken the L.L. recension as my basis. Having, as I have dared to believe, grasped the essential human facts of the story, I began by some re-arrangement of the material. Then I omitted all material that was either irrelevant to my conception or tedious in itself; and, finally, I completed the narrative by working into its texture a rather large amount of matter from other related sources. An enumeration of the more important of these sources will be found in [Appendix D](#). To give all my lesser sources would not be possible; for the same principles of re-arrangement, and selection, and introduction of new material have been carried out, not only



in the broad masses, but even in the smallest portions, each part being considered in relation to the whole.

In the main I have tried to work much as I imagine some scholarly Irish shanachie of a thousand years ago might have worked, if he had had the same object in view. And, in so far as the resources of the English language will allow, I have tried to preserve the Gaelic spirit, and to present a poem from which the modern spirit is as completely absent as would necessarily have been the case with my supposed old shanachie. In so far as I have succeeded, my readers will find themselves really transported into our old Irish epic world.

With regard to the vexed question of the anglicisation of the names, a word of explanation must be offered. The movement of the verse is sometimes intended to be very rapid. Nothing would more surely impede this movement than a doubt existing in the mind of the reader as to how the frequently recurring names are to be pronounced. It will not do for him to halt till he ascertains the pronunciation from an appendix. Therefore, in the verse, names are always spelt in such a way as to suggest their pronunciation; and in the various appendices I have given their most usual Middle-Irish spelling. For example, “Faerdeeah” is so spelt in order to show at a glance that there is a strongly accented ee sound in the second syllable—a bit of knowledge which is essential to the right reading of the verse. In [Appendix C](#) the reader may learn, if he wishes, that in Middle Irish this name is spelt in two words: *Fer Diad*.

In anglicising Old Gaelic names some writers will prefer to adopt the earliest, presumably unaspirated forms; others will prefer the modern aspirated forms. In some cases I have adopted the one, and in some the other; and I have had practically no rule in the matter except the pleasing of my own ear in relation to the verse. Where there happens to be a thoroughly established modern form, such as “Conor,” I have generally adopted it. In the case of some other names such as “Findabair,” where the old unaspirated spelling gives a beautiful sequence of sounds, I have left them to be pronounced as they are spelt. In modern Irish we should call “Findabair,” “Finn’-oor.”

All the place-names have been anglicised as frankly as the personal names, the important point in all cases being to suggest a definite and not



too difficult pronunciation. It matters little that some one else might have suggested a different pronunciation. It will be remembered that St. Bernard of Clairvaux, in writing the Life of our own St. Malachy, said in relation to a certain miracle which Malachy performed:—"This occurred at a place the name of which we do not mention, for its pronunciation is too barbarous." I could not wish that my non-Gaelic readers should have to echo these words of St. Bernard in the midst of a passage of my verse.

The word *Táin* alone I have not anglicised. It should be pronounced approximately *Tahn*.

In [Appendix A](#) brief notes will be found on all the Irish terms used. Sometimes I have used these untranslated forms simply because they are beautiful in themselves, and so bring an element of beauty into the verse. Sometimes I have used them because their meaning is not certain enough to make it wise to venture on an English equivalent; and sometimes because the nearest English equivalent would suggest an entirely wrong set of mental associations.

In [Appendix B](#) I have given an alphabetical list of all the place-names introduced, with notes on all those which have been identified, or towards the identification of which I have been able to make suggestions. There are about 250 of these names. To us who are Irish and who live in the old country, it is a source of intense pleasure to be able to associate our heroes and their heroic deeds with certain definite places, and to think of them when there. I have spared no pains in the endeavour to identify these place-names; and various suggestions of my own will be found scattered amongst the notes. But many places I have failed to identify at all.

In [Appendix C](#) I give an alphabetical list of the names of persons which occur in the narrative.

These first three divisions of the Appendix, though arranged in alphabetical order, are not indices. They are meant only for reference. In every case the usual Middle-Irish spelling of the word, or else the spelling in a more modern text which I have happened to use, is given in square brackets.

A word, perhaps, must be said about the verse. It has certain characteristics of its own, which have arisen naturally and almost

unconsciously out of my long and close study of our early Irish literature. Those of my readers who are interested in the technique of verse will notice these characteristics for themselves. There is, perhaps, only one point in this connexion which I need mention, and that is the frequency with which I allow two very short syllables, such as “of his,” “in her,” to scan as one syllable. This is done with a freedom which far exceeds the practice of most writers of English blank verse. In this matter I have had no rule but the pleasing of my own ear.

To conclude, let me express my hope, and, indeed, my belief, that before long there will be amongst us many able writers who will endeavour to re-create for us the ancient and glorious literature of our country, not in English, but in the language of the Gael.

M. A. H.

*Belfast, October, 1907.*

# CONTENTS

|                                                                  | PAGE                       |
|------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------|
| The Finding of the Táin                                          | <a href="#"><u>3</u></a>   |
| THE TÁIN                                                         |                            |
| Book I                                                           | <a href="#"><u>11</u></a>  |
| Book II                                                          | <a href="#"><u>41</u></a>  |
| Book III                                                         | <a href="#"><u>81</u></a>  |
| Book IV                                                          | <a href="#"><u>101</u></a> |
| Book V                                                           | <a href="#"><u>127</u></a> |
| Book VI                                                          | <a href="#"><u>163</u></a> |
| Book VII                                                         | <a href="#"><u>187</u></a> |
| Book VIII                                                        | <a href="#"><u>211</u></a> |
| Book IX                                                          | <a href="#"><u>239</u></a> |
| Book X                                                           | <a href="#"><u>259</u></a> |
| Book XI                                                          | <a href="#"><u>293</u></a> |
| Book XII                                                         | <a href="#"><u>323</u></a> |
| Book XIII                                                        | <a href="#"><u>357</u></a> |
| Book XIV                                                         | <a href="#"><u>383</u></a> |
| Book XV                                                          | <a href="#"><u>411</u></a> |
| The Writing of the Táin                                          | <a href="#"><u>447</u></a> |
| APPENDIX A:                                                      |                            |
| Irish Terms used in the Verse                                    | <a href="#"><u>453</u></a> |
| APPENDIX B:                                                      |                            |
| The Place-names occurring in the Verse                           | <a href="#"><u>460</u></a> |
| APPENDIX C:                                                      |                            |
| Names of Persons, Tribes, and Animals occurring in the Verse     | <a href="#"><u>479</u></a> |
| APPENDIX D:                                                      |                            |
| The Principal Sources from which the Narrative has been<br>drawn | <a href="#"><u>487</u></a> |
| APPENDIX E:                                                      |                            |
| Notes on Books VI and VII                                        | <a href="#"><u>491</u></a> |





# THE FINDING OF THE TÁIN

## THE FINDING OF THE TÁIN.

Shen'-cawn, the agéd poet, asked the poets  
Of Erin (for Mar-vawn', the Swineherd-Saint,  
Had laid that task on him) whether a poet  
Amidst them could relate the Táin Bo Cooley  
Unbroken from its opening; and no poet  
Amidst them could relate the Táin Bo Cooley  
Except in broken fragments. And the book,  
Wherein 'twas written, had been reft away  
And lost in Latin lands. And Shen'-cawn then  
(Because Mar-vawn' had laid that task on him)  
Said to his band of three times fifty poets,  
Both to the Ollavs and the humblest learners,  
"We must go forth throughout the lands of Erin,  
And must not tarry two nights in one stead  
Till we get knowledge of the Táin." Whereon  
The poets travelled through the lands of Erin,  
And searched from west to east and north to south;  
But they obtained no knowledge of the Táin  
Except in broken fragments; and they all  
Were weary, gloomy, downcast, and in sorrow.

They came to Leinster, then, to Connra Cae,  
The bounteous one, to whom they said, "O King,  
Give us a boat to put us o'er the waves  
To Alba, that we there may seek some poet  
Who knows the Táin." A ship was cleared for them  
And filled; and over the white-blossomed sea  
Northward they fared, and passed the crags of Manann,  
And came to Alba; and a year they searched  
From south to north and west to east through Alba,  
But got no knowledge of the Táin. Then Shen'-cawn

In trouble said, "Return we now to Erin."  
And o'er the proud-voiced ocean they returned;  
And put their prows on shore against Ath Cleea;  
And they were weary, downcast, and in sorrow.

Then they beheld Neev Caillin, who to Shen'-cawn  
Was mother's son: and he bestowed on Shen'-cawn  
Three kisses, and asked tidings, and they told him  
They yet had got no knowledge of the Táin.  
Then Caillin said: "I will now go with you  
To Connaught to Mar-vawn'; for he alone,  
Who laid this task on Shen'-cawn, can reveal  
Knowledge by help of which ye may obtain  
The Táin Bo Cooley whole." And so the poets  
Went to Mar-vawn' in Connaught; and Mar-vawn',  
Chief-prophet of the Heaven and the Earth,  
Gave kisses to Neev Caillin and to Shen'-cawn,  
And welcomed the thrice fifty weary poets,  
And said, "O Ollavs, there is not in Erin,  
Amongst the living or amongst the dead,  
One who can tell the Táin Bo Cooley wholly  
With all its deeds and feats—save only Fergus  
The son of Roy. Ye must send messengers  
To the chief saints amidst the saints of Erin,  
Bidding them come, and, by the grave of Fergus,  
Fast to the Deity three days and nights,  
That He may send them Fergus to relate  
The Táin Bo Cooley wholly." Then Neev Caillin  
Went forth; and he besought the saints of Erin,  
And brought them; and they feasted for one night;  
And on the morrow went with only Shen'-cawn  
By desert ways to Aenloch on Moy Wee,  
And found the flag-stone o'er the lying-place  
And grave of that great Fergus; and they prayed;  
And they were pleading and were fasting there  
That that great Fergus might be sent to them.

These were the saints who visited that grave.



Neev Columkillé, who, for splendid radiance  
Of noble birth, was as a moon in the air,  
Having a hue of gold on it, and shining  
Over Iona and the north-east sea.

Neev Kieran son of Faylim, who, for radiance  
Of holy mercy, was as a moon in the air,  
Having a hue of gold on it, and shining  
O'er the wide Shannon and the heart of Erin.

Neev Brendan, who, that he might find a land,  
Hidden, delightful, very far from men,  
Wherein to love the Lord, had voyaged far  
O'er the intolerable sea, and seen  
The gate of Hell,—and who once more should voyage  
For seven years, and at last find a land  
Hidden, delightful, lofty, lovable,  
And there abide in love of Christ the Lord.

Neev Kieran of green Sayer, who was old,  
Weighted with years; for he was the first saint  
E'er born in Erin, and his earliest monks  
Had been a fox and brock and wolf and doe,  
Who humbled themselves gently and were righteous,  
And dwelt with him within vast desert woods.

Neev Findian of Clonard, the pious one  
And scholar, in whose school three thousand saints  
Had studied wisdom, ere they wandered forth  
To build their cells and churches through vast Erin.

Neev Findian of Movilla, who was bishop  
And sage in Ulster, and a shining star.

Neev Caillin, who had brought these saints together.

And they were gathered in that desert place  
Round the flat flag above the grave of Fergus.

Then Shen'-cawn sang a poem to the gravestone,  
As though he sang to Fergus. "Rise," he said,  
"For these have supplicated Jesus Christ  
That Fergus may appear to us and tell  
That history, the wondrous Táin Bo Cooley,  
With its beginning and its deeds and end,

Which were enacted in old far-back days,  
Before the Tal-kend brought the Faith to Erin.”

With that, a mighty mist and fog grew round  
Those holy men and Shen´-cawn, who were there;  
So that if any man had sought to find them,  
He had not found them through the mist.

And Fergus

Came from the grave where five times five score years  
He had been hidden. And a beautiful  
And rich appearance was upon that warrior.  
Brown hair was on him; and a hooded layna  
With red inweaving of red gold. A bratt  
Of bright grass-green was round him; and he wore  
A golden-hilted sword, and round-toed shoes  
Wrought all of bronze. And when that warrior, Fergus,  
Perceived the holy men of Erin nigh him,  
It was his wish to stand, and standing, tell  
The Táin he had to tell. Howbeit those saints  
Would not hear aught from him till courteously  
They gave him seat; and, seated so amidst them,  
The while they fasted for three days and nights,  
Folded by mist, that warrior from the grave  
Taught them this History, the Táin Bo Cooley,  
With its beginning and its deeds and end,  
E’en as it had been acted in old days,  
Before Neev Patrick brought the Faith to Erin.

# BOOK I

## BOOK I

One eve it chanced to Al-yill and to Maev,  
—The while the beautiful, full-blazing sun  
Sank 'mid the bright cloud-rafters of the sky,—  
That they were standing on their green-grassed mound  
Of high Rath Croohan on Moy Wee; and thence,  
They, gazing outward from themselves athwart  
The pleasant, well-cleared land with plains and ridges,  
Beheld that it was full of groves with fruit,  
And lands with corn, and greens with flocks and herds,  
And lakes with fowl, and streams with fish and otters;  
And full of folk with growth and height and health  
And gladness and kindly, pleasant greeting;  
And full of peace and rule. And while they gazed,  
The very golden, fiery-blazing sun  
Went to his own deep place below the world,  
And fresh, cool, dewy airs o'erswept Moy Wee.  
Then that most royal pair went to their sleeping  
In their own rath and their own royal house;  
And while their heads were on their kingly pillow,  
There rose this talk betwixt them. Al-yill said:  
“’Tis a true word, O woman, it is good  
To be the wife of a strong man!” Maev said:  
“’Tis a true word; but wherefore dost thou cite it?”  
“For this cause,” answered Al-yill. “Thou art better  
To-day in wealth and riches, peace and rule,  
Than on the day whereon I came and took thee.”  
“Nay, I was well in power, strength, and riches,  
And wealth and rule and peace before that day,”  
Maev answered. “Of thy being well,” said Al-yill,  
“We never heard or knew; but heard instead

That thou wast busied with thy woman's work,  
The while the foemen of thy neighbouring regions  
Were violently bearing off from thee  
Great preys and plunders and vast driven spoils."

This was the answer which Maev made to him  
Before sleep came upon them there that night:

"Not so was I! My father, Yohee Fayla  
The son of Find the son of Findoman,  
Held the high-sovereignty of all wide Erin;  
And he had six choice daughters, Daerbra, namely,  
Ethna and Ella, Clothra, Moogawn, Maev.  
But, of those six, I, Maev, was most distinguished,  
Most noble. In bestowing of good gifts,  
And costly things and things of price and treasure,  
I was the noblest of them. In hard battle,  
And fighting and hard vigorous battle-combat,  
I was the strongest of them. And my father  
For that good cause gave me a goodly household,  
Which was much spoken of; so that with me  
There were full fifteen hundred kingly warriors  
Of sons of exiles out of extern lands,  
And fifteen hundreds of the sons of noble  
Dwellers amidst ourselves. And for that cause  
He also put me into sovereignty  
O'er Croohan and a Third 'midst the Three Thirds  
Of Connaught; and thereafter 'Maev of Croohan'  
Became my queenly name and designation.  
And here in Croohan then I ruled in strength  
And peace and power, till ere long I wedded  
Tinny the son of Conrig Cass, a king  
Above the men of Domnann in the west;  
And we ruled jointly here in peace and power.  
And after Tinny fell, I ruled once more  
Alone in strength and power.

Then men came  
From thy own brother who is king o'er Leinster,  
Namely, from Finn the son of Ross the Red,



To woo me for him. And men came as well  
From Carpry Neea Faer, thy second brother,  
The son of Ross the Red and king o'er Tara,  
To woo me for him; and men came as well  
From Yohee Bec from Munster. And I went not;  
For I was she who asked a wondrous bride-price,  
Which, before me, no woman e'er had asked  
Of any man from 'midst the men of Erin.  
I asked a man devoid of avarice,  
Devoid of jealousy, devoid of fear.  
Had the man, who should gain me, avarice,  
It were not fit that we should be together;  
For I myself am good for giving gifts  
And costly things, and things of price and treasure;  
And on my man it would bring raillery  
And scorn and very fierce, disdainful words  
Were I of greater bounteousness than he;  
Though it in truth would bring no raillery  
Were we of equal bounteousness. Again,  
Had the man, who should gain me, any fear,  
It were not fit that we should be together;  
For I myself, by myself and alone,  
Break battles and engage in wars and combats;  
And on my man it would bring raillery  
Were I of greater liveliness than he,  
Though it indeed would bring no raillery  
Were we of equal liveliness. Again,  
Had the man, who should win me, jealousy,  
It were not fit that we should be together,  
Seeing that I was ne'er without a man  
Beneath the shield and shelter of another.

Good, then, I found that man I sought for, namely,  
Thyself, O Al-yill son of Ross the Red,  
Of Leinster; for thou hadst no avarice:  
Thou hadst no jealousy: thou hadst no fear.  
And when I saw thee first, thou wast a youth  
Tender and fresh and young and free from blemish;

And thou wast strong in war, yet not so strong  
That thou wouldst e'er be able to o'ercome me  
Or rule or govern me whilst we should live.  
So, because thou couldst give that wondrous bride-price,  
And for thy love and dearness, then, I took thee;  
And I bestowed on thee a bridal gift  
(The best of such as men bestow on women)—  
An outfit for twelve men in costly cloth,  
A chariot costing three times seven bondmaids,  
The breadth of thine own face in rich red gold.  
The weight of thine own left fore-arm in pure,  
White-bright findrinny. Whosoe'er he be  
Who causes thee disgrace and loss of honour,  
There is for thee no honour-price therein,  
More than there is for me; because, in truth,  
A man upon a woman's maintenance,  
Is what thou art, O Al-yill!"

Al-yill said:

"Not so, indeed, am I. Though to my brothers,  
Namely, to Finn and Carpry Neea Faer  
(Seeing that they were older men than I),  
I left the sovereignty of kingly Tara  
And Leinster of delightful waters,—yet,  
In riches and in generous gift-bestowing,  
I was their equal. And I never heard  
Of any Fifth amidst the Fifths of Erin  
Being in woman-government, except  
This Fifth alone. Therefore I came here then.  
I took this kingship. An inheritance  
I deemed it from my mother, Mawta Murrisc,  
Who was the daughter of red-sworded Mahga,  
Of Connaught. And where might I find a queen  
Better than thee, thou being, as thou wert,  
The daughter of a famed high-king of Erin?"

They bore that night away in rest and sleep.  
Next morning, ere the glorious sun rose up  
Above the deep recesses of the world,

Above the eminences of that Fifth,  
Maev said to Al-yill: "There is yet a thing,  
Beyond those words I said at night, last night:—  
My precious things, my treasures and my wealth,  
Are more than thine are." "That seems strange to us,"  
Said Al-yill; "for there is not anyone  
With whom there is a greater store of riches  
And very precious things and wealth and treasure  
Than there is with myself, and this I know."

Then, that it might be known with which of these  
There was in truth the greater store of treasure,  
There were first brought to them their humble treasures,  
Their wooden drinking-mugs, their two-eared vats,  
Their cruses and their vessels wrought from iron,  
Their washing-troughs and tubs. And secondly,  
There were brought forth to them their costly treasures,  
Their arm-rings, finger-rings, and golden clasps,  
And all their radiant work of skilful goldsmiths,  
And their apparel, purple, blue, and green,  
Yellow and black and striped and tawny-grey;  
And these were viewed and counted severally;  
And they were found alike in costliness  
On one side and the other.

After that

There were brought forth to them from leas and lawns  
And immense treeless lands and chequered greens  
Their immense flocks of sheep; and these were told,  
Numbered, and reckoned; and were found alike  
In costliness and weight and multitude.  
Over Maev's sheep there was a wondrous ram,  
Distinguished, huge, costing a powerful bondmaid.  
An answering ram was o'er the ewes of Al-yill.

Then, from green, grassy grazing-grounds and pinfolds,  
There were brought forth for them their flocks of mares,  
And their fine, joyous steeds; and these were told,  
Numbered and reckoned; and were found alike  
In costliness and size and multitude.

Over Maev's mares there was a special stallion,  
Distinguished, huge, costing a powerful bondmaid:  
O'er Al-yill's mares there was an answering stallion.

And there were brought for them from fruitful oak-woods,  
And solitudes and hollow, shelving glens,  
Their immense herds of swine; and these were told,  
Numbered, and reckoned, and were found alike  
In costliness and weight and multitude.  
With Maev there was a boar distinguished, special,  
And there was one with Al-yill.

Last of all,

There were brought forth for them from desert groves,  
And lone, unpeopled lands throughout that Fifth,  
Their droves and herds and flocks of wandering kine,—  
Their immense herds well-nigh innumerable;  
And these were numbered, and were found alike  
In costliness and multitude and greatness.  
O'er Al-yill's herds there was a special bull,  
Distinguished, choice for size and hue and beauty.  
His four hooves and his head were very white:  
Three manes were on him, which were very white,  
Even like snow upon a noble mountain,—  
The rest of his vast, shapely form being red,  
As though he had been dyed with partar-red,  
As though he had been dipped in radiant blood,  
As though he had been rubbed with partar-dye.  
Upon his two white horns the men of Connaught  
Had set far-shining gold. Findbenna, "white-horned"—  
This was his name; and he had been calved, indeed,  
By a cow 'mid Maev's own herds; and he had held it  
Not famous or illustrious to abide  
On woman's maintenance; and he had gone,  
Till he was o'er the herds owned by the King.

To Maev that hour, her being without a bull  
Of equal choiceness o'er her herds of kine,  
Was like her being without any tittle  
Of precious things or treasures through vast Erin.

So that this was the hour wherein Mac Roth,  
The royal messenger and kingly envoy,  
Was called to Maev; and Maev commanded him  
To find out whether there was any place  
In any Fifth of the Five Fifths of Erin,  
Wherein there was a bull equal in choiceness  
Unto that bull above the herds of Al-yill.

Mac Roth replied: "I know a place already  
Wherein there is a bull which is the best  
In Erin. It is in the Ulster Fifth;  
And in the beautiful, high-mountained cantred  
Of Cooley of blossomful, sweet-watered glens,—  
In the strong house of Dawra, son of Feeacna,  
In Cooley. He is called the Donn of Cooley,  
And this is his description:—He is young  
And very huge; and his high horns are gold-decked:  
He is brown-black, smooth-sided, dark-maned, red-eyed:  
He is strong-breasted, strong-necked, strong-browed, bull-like:  
He is wide-nostrilled, wide-eyed, curled, high-headed:  
He is impetuous, vehement, swift, courageous:  
He is proud, envious, scornful, strong-attacking:  
He has a lion's rage, a sea-beast's ardour:  
He has a plunderer's blow, a wood-bear's onset.  
He is the sire of immense herds and droves.  
He has great victories. 'Tis of his victories  
To shield one hundred warriors from the heat  
And cold, with his far-spreading shade and shadow.  
'Tis of his victories that, every eve,  
Fifty young lads perform their childish games  
And childish sports on his long level back,  
Commodious and delightful—'tis no lie!  
'Tis of his victories that Bananahs  
And Bocanahs and dread Folk of the Glen,  
Dare not approach to that same land and cantred  
In which he is. 'Tis of his victories,  
When he fares home to his own liss and shelter,  
At falling of the shade of night, at night,



To utter forth his loud, deep, sweet cranndord  
Before him, so that to the men of Cooley,”  
Mac Roth said, “in the north or south or mid-part  
Of Cooley, it is their sufficiency  
Of music and of gladness, that cranndord  
Sung by their Donn of Cooley as he fares—  
With gait as of a king of lofty pride;  
With gait as of a rolling ocean-billow—  
To his own liss and his own green and shelter,  
At falling of the shade of night at night.”

So spake Mac Roth, Maev’s famous messenger.

A Druid and a man of might and knowledge  
Was standing near them there. “O Maev,” he said,  
“O daughter of great Yohee, I through knowledge  
Of druids and the arts of hidden knowledge,  
Can manifest the lives and history  
Of these two bulls, whereof ye are discoursing.  
They have had many shapes; for at the first  
Their names were Root and Riccny: and the two  
Were two choice swine-herds who belonged to Ōkill,  
King of the Shee in Connaught, and to Bove,  
King of the Shee in Munster; and, with venom  
As to their power to cast thin-withering spells  
Each on the other’s swine, those two contended.  
So the kings took their swine from them. And straightway,  
After their being swine-herds they were birds,  
Old ravens: at the Sheemound in Rath Croohan  
First they were heard; and, later, at the Sheemound  
On Feven; and the men from north and south  
Heard them with noise and loudness and hoarse clamours  
Contending; and their names were Etty and Inguen.  
And after being birds they were huge beasts,  
Who dwelt beneath the oceans and the waters.  
Their names were Bled and Blod. They dwelt one year  
Within the Suir to southward; and one year  
In the bright-streaming Shannon. In the Shannon  
Men saw them like two hills or mountain-peaks

Contending with hard blows, till swords of fire  
Came from their mouths e'en to the clouds of heaven.  
Then, in the sight of all the hosts who watched them,  
They left that river, and became two warriors  
There on the shore before them; and their names  
Were Rinn and Faebur; and they fought with weapons  
A fight of no hereditary tameness  
Throughout the space of three days and three nights;  
Till they became two stags who fought; and then  
Two towering, haughty phantoms, who fought long  
In phantom-fight,—their exploits were not small,—  
So that men died for fear and dread at watching  
That phantom-fight; and while they were two phantoms  
Their names were Scaw and Skeeath. Next they rose,  
Rising into the heaven; and, 'midst the clouds,  
Became two dragons who sent wondrous showers  
Of heavy snow, each on the other's country:  
In no man's memory had such been seen;—  
Till with career of headlong speed they fell  
Out of the air, and went into the shapes  
Of little water-worms, with every colour  
Shining upon them; and one went to Cooley  
Of peaks and blossomful, sweet-watered glens,  
And went into Glass Crond, a Cooley river;  
And one came hither to kind, gladsome Connaught,  
And went to the spring-well of Oorawn Garad  
Nigh to us here. Once, when at Oorawn Garad,  
Thou didst, O Queen, raise up this second worm  
In thy bronze vessel at the well. Thou sawest  
The colours shining on it: and it told thee  
Of things that should befall thee. Their two names  
While they were worms were Crinniuc and Timmiuc. Now,  
Lastly, those swine-herds are these two huge bulls,  
Namely, Findbenna and the Donn of Cooley,  
Wondrous for forms and powers. O great Queen,  
It is in Destiny that these shall meet,  
And in night-lasting, man-appalling combat,

Decide their long contention: yet I see not  
Which of the two shall in the end prevail.”

The Druid ended. Maev addressed Mac Roth.  
“Go thou, Mac Roth,” said Maev, “go hence to Cooley,  
Go to the house of Dawra. Beg from him  
For me, one year’s loan of that special bull.  
At the year’s end the loan-price of the bull  
Shall reach him, fifty heifers, and the bull  
Himself in safety back. And take with thee  
Another proposition, O Mac Roth:—  
If, to the people of that territory  
And of that land, it seem an evil thing  
To give that wonderful distinctive jewel,  
Their Donn of Cooley,—say to Dawra, then,  
He shall himself come with the bull to Connaught;  
And I will give him from my smooth Moy Wee  
A measure equalling the land he has  
In mountainous Cooley there. And he shall have  
A chariot costing three times seven bondmaids;  
And, beyond all, my own especial friendship.”

Mac Roth went forward on his way and journey.  
This was his number: nine. Across wide Erin  
To Cooley over unobstructed ways  
These travelled, that they soon might reach the house  
Of Dawra in the pleasant, high-peaked land.  
We leave Mac Roth upon that road and way.

This was the day and this the point of time  
Wherein Maev’s spies and envoys out of Ulster,  
Who had been spying out the men of Ulster  
In Avvin Maha and in each chiefs doon  
And each king’s house throughout the lands of Ulster,  
Came with great urgency to Croohan. Then  
Maev went to her own quiet House-for-Converse,  
To hear their tales and tidings out of Ulster;  
And her one daughter, namely, Findabair,  
Went with her there. (And thus was Findabair:

Of age to wed, white-browed and very radiant.)  
The envoys then with envoys' reverence  
Accosted Maev, and told their words and tidings;  
And having told them, they withdrew. But that  
Which there they told to her, we tell not now:  
We tell that later. Maev with liveliness  
Spake to her daughter, Findabair, and said:  
"O child," said Maev, "from what these say we know  
That this is now the time and the occasion  
For our unheard-of, long-prepared-for hosting  
Into the lands of Ulster; for we know  
From what these say that at this time no ill  
Is likely to befall us." Findabair  
Said to her mother, even to Maev: "Dear mother,  
What were the reasons for this marvellous hatred  
Between thyself and Ulster?" Then Maev said:  
"Child, it is natural to hate proud Ulster.  
But I perceive that thou hast heard indeed  
That for myself there were great reasons." Then,  
In that reposeful, quiet House-for-Converse  
In high Rath Croohan on Moy Wee, Maev spake  
These words to Findabair:

"O child!" said Maev,  
"There were great reasons for me; and those reasons  
Thou now shalt know, being of age to know them.  
My father, Yohee Fayla, was called Fayla,  
'Righteous,' because with constant righteousness  
He acted towards all people. In the battle  
Of Letteree in Corann, he had slain  
Wise Fahtna Fahee, great High-king of Erin,  
And had himself become High-king. We then  
To the High-king's most royal seat of Tara  
Went with great joy; and I myself had then  
Fulfilled my sixteen years. But Yohee Fayla,  
(Because with ever-upright righteousness  
He acted towards all people), paid to Conor  
The son of Fahtna Fahee a great eric

For the slain father. He bestowed on Conor  
The kingship of the high-proud Ulster Fifth  
In eric; and, O child, this was not all  
That eric: he allotted unto Conor  
Four of his daughters who were with himself  
In Tara; and those four, in fervent sorrow,  
Moogawn and Clothra, Ethna and I,—Maev,  
Were borne from Tara north to Avvin Maha  
To be of Conor's women. Child, I thought  
My pride would ne'er recover of that hurt.  
E'en then it ne'er had seemed to me too much  
That I myself should not be deedless. E'en,  
I young, it had not seemed to me too much  
That I should hope to be myself the chiefest  
Of rulers in all Erin. And we dwelt  
In Avvin; and in this wise there was I—  
Hated and without honour, hating greatly,  
Dejected, in dark sadness; and toward Conor,  
I had timidity and horror. Then,  
After one year my pride arose in me;  
And, through high pride of mind, I rode from Avvin,  
Forsaking Conor; and I rode towards Tara.  
It was a shining and extreme clear night;  
And I was chased; but like the wind of spring,  
My chariot-steeds went south toward kingly Tara,  
And crossed the boundary and came to Tara,  
Where was my father the High-king of Erin.

So, child, my being thus given unto Conor  
Without my will; and my sad days in Avvin;  
And, afterwards, my severance from Conor  
Without his will; were the first powerful causes  
And the first reasons for this eminent hatred  
Between myself and Ulster. It was then,  
When I had left stern-hearted Conor, so  
Escaping from that dreadful grief, that Yohee,  
My father, gave me that distinguished household,  
Which was much spoken of,—so that with me

There were full fifteen hundred kingly warriors  
Of sons of exiles out of extern lands;  
And fifteen hundreds of the sons of noble  
Dwellers amidst ourselves. And it was then  
That Yohee put me into sovereignty  
O'er Croohan and a Third 'midst the Three Thirds  
Of Connaught, where thenceforth in quietness  
I did possess,—the power of Conor here  
No more being on me; and ere long I wedded  
Tinny the son of Conrig Cass, a king  
Above the men of Domnann; and two years  
Passed thus in quietness. But it was then,  
Namely, at ending of these two good years,  
That the great Feast of Tara was made ready  
By Yohee Fayla; and the Five Great Fifths  
Of Erin were around him there in Tara,  
Except myself and Tinny. Seeing this,  
The men of Erin asked just Yohee Fayla  
To bring me to that Feast, and Yohee sent  
Sreblloo-a, his own woman-messenger,  
Hither to Croohan to invite me. Then,  
Upon the morrow, Tinny and myself  
Arrived together at that hero-seat,  
Tara, the meeting-place of kings and heroes.  
Amidst the vast assemblage I perceived,  
In his own Ulster place and seat of honour,  
Conor the son of Fahtna, King of Ulster,  
The hawk-like king; but at that Feast his power  
Was not upon me. Then, until the end  
Of fourteen days added on to a month,  
The racings of swift steeds and feats of riding  
Pertaining to that Feast were made, and then  
The men of Erin separated, each  
Going back to his own land and house and doon.

O child," said Maev, "Conor remained behind  
Each king and prince and chief who had been there,  
That he might watch and lurk for me. One morn,



As I was riding to the Boyne for bathing,  
The dreaded king, with his own men around him,  
Delivered a well-calculated onfall,  
With fury and with virulence, with callings  
And mockery. He forced me to his will  
Against my will; and I was bound and placed  
In angry bondage. That was heard in Tara;  
And when 'twas heard, the household of the King  
Of Erin round about the King of Erin  
Came forth from Tara. Tinny son of Conrig  
Came forth from Tara. Then red battle broke  
Between those people upon either side.  
Harsh was the battle-thunder through the battle:  
Abundant were the streams of blood that flowed;  
And I, hurt, bowed, bound, desperate, heard and saw.  
Tinny the son of Conrig Cass, my husband,  
And joint partaker with me over Croohan,  
Fell there; and ere the eve the household troops  
Of Yohee Fayla were defeated wholly,  
And driven o'er the Boyne before the men  
Of Conor son of Fahtna. Then, indeed,  
I deemed my overthrow complete. I seemed  
Helpless of all relief. But my own men  
From Connaught, my right-valiant, lusty heroes,  
Coming amidst the gory, crowded battle,  
By strength of fighting brought me from that danger  
And from that venomous bondage. They, by strength  
Of fighting, over the wide Plain of Meath,  
Over the wide expanse, taking me safely,  
We crossed the Shannon of green-flowing streams,  
To Croohan, here, my doon and rightful dwelling.

O child, this thing is truth without deceit,—  
I knew that my high pride of mind and spirit  
Would ne'er recover from this second hurt  
Until I should behold red-sworded Conor  
Pale in his death before me. And, O child,  
Untiring, throughout all my lifetime after,

I was preparing that I might fulfil  
That which I wished for. I, in no long time,  
Ruled the Three Thirds of Connaught. Then I wedded  
Thy father, Al-yill son of Mawta Murrisc,  
Winning the friendship of the sons of Mahga  
In Connaught, and the friendship and alliance  
Of Leinster and the war-skilled Leinster-men.  
My many sons, thy brothers, I bestowed  
In fosterage with powerful Munster princes,  
Winning their friendship. Five times five years so  
Have been consumed since that great hurt and danger  
Which I have spoken of. My people now  
Are multiplied in numbers. I have gotten  
Great wealth and power and great battle-strength;  
And I have triumphed and thriven in well-nigh all  
My enterprises and my purposes,  
Till now, indeed, I am accounted chiefest  
Of rulers in all Erin, save alone  
In that high-proud, strength-guarded Ulster Fifth,  
Where Conor, lofty and illustrious,  
Rules with huge power:—yea, even he gathers tribute  
Out of the Islands of the Foreigners  
Beyond the Northern Sea. But now, O daughter,  
From what these envoys have averred, we know  
That this is now the time and the occasion  
For dealing woe to Ulster. It is well  
That we have so despatched Mac Roth to Cooley  
To beg this year's loan of the Donn of Cooley  
For me. We know the bull will be refused.  
That will be cause to us for the great hosting,  
Which we have long prepared to trouble Ulster.  
Thereon a strange thing shall be seen in Ulster:  
We will destroy and spoil the men of Ulster:  
We will strike fear into them. In the end,  
If they shall rise and come and give us battle,  
It is my hope that Conor son of Fahtna,  
Of most stern valour, on that day may know

The grievousness of death; and that with sureness  
His numbing death-mists may lay hold of him.  
So we, indeed, shall put the pride off Ulster;  
And I, thereafter, shall, indeed, be chiefest  
Of rulers through the Five Great Fifths of Erin.

And for thyself, dear child, on this great hosting  
We shall perceive which are the great and true  
And lively warriors: and, when we return,  
Thou shalt be wedded to some noble warrior  
And kingly hero midst our battle-heroes.”

This was the talk ’twixt Maev and Findabair  
In Maev’s own quiet, private House-for-Converse  
In high Rath Croohan, on Moy Wee in Connaught,  
Before the Táin.

As for those messengers  
Which Maev had sent,—across wide, noble Erin  
To Cooley, over unobstructed ways  
They travelled till they reached the well-roofed house  
Of Dawra, son of Feeacna. Therein  
Mac Roth received a truly joyful welcome.  
(That was befitting, for Mac Roth indeed  
Was chief of all the messengers of Erin.)  
Dawra inquired what cause had brought on them  
That travel, and Mac Roth related all  
That friendly emulation and contention  
’Twixt Maev and Al-yill. “And to ask,” he said,  
“For Maev one year’s loan of thy Donn of Cooley  
To rival that huge, beautiful Findbenna,  
Is that which I have come for. Thou shalt get  
Fifty fair heifers, and the bull himself  
In safety back. And, yet another thing:  
If, to the people of this territory  
And of this land, it seems an evil thing  
To give that wonderful, distinctive jewel,  
Their Donn of Cooley, come thou then thyself  
To Connaught, to Rath Croohan, with the bull;

And Maev will give thee from her smooth Moy Wee  
A measure equalling the land thou hast  
In mountainous Cooley here; and thou shalt get  
A chariot costing three times seven bondmaids;  
And, beyond all, Maev's own especial friendship."

That proposition gave much joy and gladness  
To Dawra son of Feeacna. He shook  
Till the seam-sewings of his down-filled bed  
Brake underneath him. "By our faith of conscience!"  
He said, "however bad, however good,  
This may appear unto the men of Ulster,—  
On this occasion this distinguished treasure,  
Namely, the Donn of Cooley, shall be taken  
To Maev and Al-yill, to the realm of Connaught!"  
And to Mac Roth it gave much joy and gladness  
To find that answer to his words and message.

Then they were served. Green rushes and green reeds  
Were strown beneath them. Pleasing food was brought.  
A feast was poured for them. Anon they grew  
Loud-voiced, confused; and soon this colloquy  
Happened betwixt two of those messengers.

"'Tis a true word," said one, "the man of this house  
Is a great man!" "He is a great man, truly,"  
The second said. "Is there," the first man asked,  
"Midst all the men of Ulster any man  
Greater than this man is?" The second said,  
"Truly there is! Greater than this man is,  
Is Conor whose he is. Yet were the men  
Of Ulster all to rally to this man,  
It were to them no shame or loss of honour."  
The first man said, "He shows to us great honour,  
When this thing (which to take by force from Ulster  
Would be a work for the Four Fifths of Erin)  
Namely, the Donn of Cooley, is thus given  
Freely to us nine messengers alone."

A third then came on them to join that talk;  
And this one was a woman. "What," said she,

“Is being talked of here betwixt you two?”  
They told their talk, and how the one had said,  
That Dawra truly showed to them great honour,  
Since that thing (which to take by force from Ulster  
Would be a work for the Four Fifths of Erin),  
Namely, the Donn of Cooley, was thus given  
To those nine messengers alone. She said:  
“Fain in this hour were I to see a burst  
Of blood and clotted gore out of that mouth  
Whereout that saying came! Because,” said she,  
“Were not the bull thus yielded willingly,  
He would be taken forcibly. The hosts  
Of Al-yill and of Maev, with skilful guidance  
From powerful Fergus son of Roy, would take him!”

This was the time when the Distributor  
To Dawra came into that separate house  
Where these were feasted: and a man laden  
With drink was with him, and a man laden  
With food; and he had heard all that they said.  
And anger came on him; and he set down  
His food and drink before them; and he said not  
To them that they should take it; and he said not  
That they should leave it. He went after that  
Into that house where Dawra was himself,  
And said with haste: “Is it thyself who gavest  
That wondrous jewel to these messengers,—  
The Donn of Cooley?” “It is I, indeed,”  
Said Dawra. “In the place where he was given,”  
The man said, “there was neither king nor kingship!  
There was no strength or sway or government!  
They say the truth!” “What say they, then?” asked Dawra.  
“They say,” the man said, “that unless thou givest  
Him willingly, thou then ere long shalt give him  
Unwillingly, constrained by the great hosts  
Of Al-yill and of Maev, guided and led  
By Fergus son of Roy!” “I swear,” said Dawra,  
“By all the gods whom I adore, that that

Which I bestow not on them willingly,  
They shall not make me yield unwillingly.”

They slept till morn. Early upon the morrow  
The messengers arose; and they went straightway  
Into that house where Dawra slept himself,  
And said to him: “O Noble One, allow us  
Place-guidance that we thus may find the place  
Wherein thy Donn of Cooley is.” “Not so!  
In truth or deed,” Dawra replied to them;  
“But were it wont of mine to violate  
Travellers, messengers, or journeying folk,  
Who travel by these passes and these ways,  
Not one of you should journey hence alive.”  
“For what cause?” asked Mac Roth. “There is great cause,”  
Dawra replied. “Ye said unless the bull  
Should be delivered to you willingly,  
He should be seized on forcibly by hosts  
Of Maev’s and Al-yill’s, guided on their way  
By Fergus son of Roy.” Mac Roth responded,  
Deprecating, “Yet, O Noble One,  
Whate’er they may have said, these messengers,  
Made heady by thy viands and thy ale,  
It is not right so to take cognizance  
Or heed of it, or so to make of it  
Ground of reproach to Al-yill and to Maev.”

These were the words that Dawra said to him:—  
“Yet, O Mac Roth, I will not give my bull  
On this occasion, if I have strength to help it.”

Thus, with these words, those messengers returned.  
They traversed Erin, till they reached at length  
Rath Croohan on Moy Wee in Connaught. Then  
Maev asked of them their tidings, and Mac Roth  
Told her those tidings;—that they had not brought  
The bull from Dawra. “Through what cause?” asked Maev.  
Mac Roth related all. Maev said to him:  
“This is no cause for trouble, O Mac Roth;

There is no need to trim these knots away.  
We knew the bull would be refused. And now  
He shall be taken by strength of mighty hosts,  
With guidance from our Fergus son of Roy.  
And we will not alone take their great bull:  
There is no ill we will not do to them.  
E'en though the dangerous, storm-troubled days  
Of winter now come near, we yet will go.  
We will lay waste, harry, and devastate  
All Ulster and all Crithny. We will take  
Their wives, their children, and their tender sons,  
Their steeds and flocks of mares, their troops of kine,  
Their herds of every sort of grazing kine.  
And we will not alone burn to the grass  
Their strongly-timbered houses, wide and fair;  
But their high, fortified green mounds, whereon  
Their houses are, we will so level down  
That all their glens and trenches will be filled  
After our track. And at the end of all  
The Donn of Cooley shall be brought to Croohan.  
Whoever shall arrive or not arrive  
In safety here after this powerful hosting,  
The Donn of Cooley shall arrive. I swear,  
By all the gods by whom my people swear,  
The Bull of Cooley then shall come to Croohan."



## BOOK II

### BOOK II

These were Maev's words. Then messengers went forth  
To Maev's own seven sons, the seven Mahn-yas,  
That each might come, each with his folk and cantred,  
To Croohan on Moy Wee. And messengers  
Went forth unto each king and under-king  
And prince and chief through the Four Fifths of Erin,  
That each might come with his own folk and cantred  
To join that hosting.

It was on an eve,  
While all were waiting for those many hosts  
And bands and troops to come unto Rath Croohan,  
That Maev and Al-yill, with their kingly household,  
Were feasting in their royal house. And this  
Was the array of that most royal house:—  
It was round, vast, and built of powerful oak,  
Roofed o'er with shingles; and it held within it  
Seven concentric ranks of imdas, railed  
With bronze, and panelled with choice, rich red yew.  
And there were brought into that house that night  
The newest of each kind of pleasant food  
And oldest of each kind of pleasant drink;  
And when each man had eaten and had drunk  
His measure and his full sufficiency,  
Al-yill the son of Mawta Murrisc said  
Aloud:—"Let now some tale be told to us."  
"What tale wouldst thou have told?" asked Findabair.  
"Let it," said Al-yill, "be some tale from Ulster;  
For (since we soon shall go upon our hosting)  
To hear some tale or famous history  
Of those famed tribes and that famed warlike folk

Toward whom we go, will indeed be to us  
A pastime, and will while away the eve.”

“Let it,” said Maev, “be that most woful tale  
Of the Three Sons of Usna and their deaths;  
For ’tis a tale which men hear willingly.”

“And who shall tell the tale?” asked Findabair.

“Who,” answered Maev, “but agèd Lowercam,  
The woman-poet, satirist, and envoy,

Who is in exile here in Croohan?”—Now

This was the reason in Maev’s mind for choosing

That tale. She deemed that Fergus son of Roy,

Who was there with them in that house that night,

Would be (when he should freshly hear this tale

Of all the wrong which he had borne from Conor)

So much the more ready and fresh and eager

To help her with his kingly hero-valour

On that great hosting to the lands of Ulster.

Throughout that household then there was great silence;  
And Lowercam began her tale and told it.

The men of Ulster once (she said) were drinking

At nightfall on the floor of the house of Faylim,

Conor’s own High-historian. And the wife

Of Faylim was presiding o’er those hosts,

Above them; and she served and dealt to them;

And she was great with child. Horns brimmed with ale,

Cause of loud mirth, passed round; and shares of food

Passed round; and mixed inebriate shouts were heard.

When each was faring to his sleeping-place

Within that house, the wife of Faylim too

Fared to her sleeping-place; and, as she fared

Across the wide-floored house, the child within her

Cried, so that everywhere inside that liss

Its cry was heard. The men of Ulster rose,

Each man against the other, when they heard

The shrill, lone, terror-causing, grief-full cry.

But Shenca, straight, the truly-prudent one,

Rose up and called to them: "Stir not yourselves,  
Ye men; but let the woman come up hither,  
That thus the cause and presage of that cry  
May be made known to us." They took the woman  
To truly-prudent Shenca, then,—that hero  
Whose words of eloquence are strong to calm  
The hosts of Ulster, and whose calming words  
Might still the war and tumult of the world.

Whilst they were passing through the wide-floored house,  
Faylim, the woman's husband, High-historian  
And Poet unto Conor, said to her:

"What was that cry which we have heard ascending,  
O woman? By our ears the cry was heard.  
Great terror has seized hold of me. My heart  
Is wounded as by weapons." Unto him  
Shenca, the truly-prudent one, said then:

"Trouble the woman not; but let her now  
Be led to Cathbad, the good marvellous Druid;  
For 'tis with him that there is knowledge." Then  
The woman moved towards Cathbad, and she said,  
Speaking to Cathbad, the renowned Druid:  
"Let Cathbad, the good, lovable Druid, hear me;  
For not with me are the white words of knowledge  
Wherewith to answer Faylim; for the woman  
Knows not herself what stirs beneath her breast."

'Twas then that Cathbad said: "O wife of Faylim,  
Beneath thy breast there cried a yellow-haired  
Bright maiden, with bright blue-green eyes, and cheeks  
Crimson like foxglove, and a faultless treasure  
Of teeth like autumn snow, and two curved lips  
Red like red rowan-fruit o'er shining snow.

Beneath thy breast there cried a yellow-haired  
Bright maiden, with long shining waving hair.  
High heroes strongly will contend for her.  
Noble high-kings will deeply long for her.  
There will be woe throughout this Fifth of Conor's.

There cried beneath thy breast a yellow-haired

Bright maiden, with red lips like fruit of rowan.  
High-queens shall envy them. High-queens shall envy  
Her excellent, unblemished, faultless form.”

And Cathbad laid his hand against the woman,  
So that the child was troubled beneath his hand.  
“Yea, it is true,” he said, “it is a maiden,  
Indeed, who is troubled there. And Daerdra, ‘Trouble,’  
Shall be her name: and there shall be much ill  
Because of her, through all this Fifth of Erin.”

After that, then, the child was born; and Cathbad,  
When she was brought unto him, said to her:

“O Daerdra, ‘Trouble,’ comely, of renown  
Most wonderful, ’tis in thy time of life,  
That woe and torture shall arrive for Ulster.

There will be envy, there will be hate in Ulster;  
There will be wars, even after thy time of life,  
Through thee, indeed, O generous daughter of Faylim.

It is through thee, and in thy time of life,  
That ears of men shall hear of a sad exile,—  
The exile of the three high Sons of Usna.

It is through thee, and in thy time of life,  
That a dread deed shall be performed in Avvin,  
In violation of the words of Fergus.

It is through thee, and in thy time of life,  
That ears of men shall hear of a great exile,—  
The exile of great Fergus from our Ulster.

Thou shalt thyself perform a rough, dread deed,  
In anger towards the king of high-proud Ulster.  
Thy grave shall be in a lone, rock-high place.  
Thy history shall be renowned, O Daerdra.”

“Let the maid-child be slain,” the warriors said.  
But Conor, the High-king of Ulster, looking  
Upon the child, straight loved it; and he said:  
“Not so, O warriors; since it is not well  
To war against things fated; for things fated  
May not by us be so avoided. Truly,

Beautiful is the smiling of this child.  
Let her be brought to me at dawn to-morrow:  
She shall be reared obedient to myself;  
And she shall be the wife who shall be near me.”

The chiefs were silent; for they dared not speak  
Against the words and verdict of the King.  
But Fergus son of Roy soon rose and spoke,  
And said: “O Conor, O High-king of Ulster,  
Thy judgment errs not. All things shall be done  
According to thy ruling and thy judgment.”

And all was done even as Conor had said.  
The child was reared within a closed-up liss  
Nigh the high mound of splendid Avvin Maha;  
And none (said Lowercam) was e’er admitted  
Within that liss, except these four alone,—  
Namely, her gentle, careful foster-mother  
And foster-father, who there tended her;  
And Conor, the High-sovereign; and myself,  
Lowercam;—they dared not close me out,  
I being the skilled she-satirist. And Daerdra  
By Conor there was reared, until she was  
The maiden of most splendour which there was  
Throughout the expanse of Erin. And to Conor  
She was the treasure which he loved more strongly  
Than any treasure. And the time drew nigh  
When she should go to his high pillow.

Then,

One day upon white snow in one night fallen,  
The foster-father of the maid was skinning  
A cooking-calf to seethe for her; and Daerdra,—  
I being with her there,—perceived a raven  
Drink the calf’s blood upon the snow. ’Twas then  
She cried: “O Lowercam, how lovable  
To me that man would be on whom should be  
These three pure colours, namely, on his hair  
The black of this black raven; on his cheeks  
The red of this red blood, and on his body

The white of this white snow." Whereon I said:  
"O maiden, dignity and bliss be thine!  
In Conor's own king's household, very near  
To where thou art, that man is; and his name  
Is Neesha son of Usna." And she said:  
"'Twill not be well with me until I see him."

At day-dawn on the morrow, while the sun  
Rose through the beautiful, lustrous clouds of dawning  
Neesha the son of Usna stood alone  
On the high mound of splendid Avvin Maha,  
Singing his rich andord. And, O ye men  
(Said Lowercam), sonorous and melodious  
Was the andord sung by the Sons of Usna,  
By Neesha and by Annly and Ardawn,  
The three high sons of Usna. Every cow  
And every beast, hearing that rich andord,  
Yielded a two-thirds increase of her milk;  
And to all folk who heard that melody  
It was their fill and their sufficiency  
Of harmony and calm and peacefulness.  
Moreover, men, high was the valour too  
Of those three sons. E'en had the Hosts of Ulster  
Been all around them in one place to slay them,—  
They three being back to back amidst those hosts,—  
The hosts would not have gained the battle o'er them,  
So good at warding-off and at defence  
Were those three valorous, dauntless hero-ones.  
And they were fleet as hounds are in the chase:  
They slew the fleet, wild deer by their own fleetness:  
Their leap was like the salmon's.—

And so Daerdra,

Lying at dawn in her still lying-place,  
Heard that unrivalled one; and in her mind  
She knew that it was Neesha. Then she rose,  
Unseen by those who reared her. She passed out,  
Outside the liss, and climbed on the high mound  
Of Avvin Maha, and saw Neesha there.

She passed as though she would pass unperceived.  
He knew her not. He said, as she went past:  
“Fair is that heifer who goes past us there.”  
“There must be heifers where there are no bulls,”  
She answered. That struck fear into him. Truly,  
He knew her then. “Maiden,” he said to her,  
“The Bull of all this Fifth, namely, the King,  
Will be for thee.” “I would have leave to choose  
Between you two,” she said, “and I would choose  
A young bull even like thee.” “Not so,” said he.  
He held in memory the words of Cathbad.  
“Is it refusing me thou sayest that?”  
She asked. “It is refusing thee indeed,”  
He answered her.

With speed and vehemence  
And fervency she sprang at him and seized  
The two ears on his head. She said, “Two ears  
Of shame and of disgrace these ears will be  
Unless thou takest me!” “Arise from me,  
Remove from me, O woman,” Neesha said.  
“I will be thine,” she said; whereat from Neesha  
There rose his loud andord; and when the Ultonians  
Heard the andord, as thus it rose from him,  
They rose against each other,—each incited  
To mutual wounding, and to broils, and war.

The Sons of Usna came to restrain their brother.  
“What ails thee,” said they, “that the men of Ulster  
Thus wound each other by thy fault?” He told  
What had been done to him. “Evil,” said they,  
“Will come of it; but thou shalt never be  
Beneath disgrace and taint and shame and scorn  
While we two live. We will depart with her  
Into some other land. There is no king  
In Erin who will not make joy before us.”

Those were their counsels. They went forth that night.  
They took with them thrice fifty fighting men,

Thrice fifty gillies, and thrice fifty women,  
And Daerdra 'midst them, so that none might see her.

After that night wherein they fled with her,  
They for a long while lived beneath protection,  
All round wide Erin,—though their annihilation  
Was oft attempted in the lands of Erin  
By the contrivances and plans of Conor,  
South-westward from white-foaming Assaroe,  
And round the south, until they turned once more  
North-eastward to Ben Edar. In the end  
The Ultonians drove them o'er the sea to Alba.

There they abode in a desert. In a season,  
When the wild creatures of the mountains failed them,  
They took to falling on the kine and sheep  
Of the men of Alba, till the men of Alba  
Rose in one day to attack them. Then they went  
And took war-service with the King of Alba.  
They set their houses on his green. They slept not  
In the King's house. It was because of Daerdra  
That they did that,—so that no man might see her:  
They feared they might be slain because of her.

Then, on a time, one day, at early morn,  
The steward of the king of Alba took his circuit  
Around their houses; and he saw that pair,  
Neesha and Daerdra, in their sleep. He went  
Forthwith and roused the king. "We ne'er have found  
Until this day," he said, "a woman worthy  
To be thy mate. With Neesha Son of Usna  
There is a woman worthy to be mated  
With the king of the Western World. Let Neesha, therefore,  
Straightway be slain; and let this woman sleep  
With thee thyself," the steward said. "Nay," the king said,  
"But rise and supplicate her secretly,  
Daily to come to me." That then was done.  
What the steward said to her she told to Neesha.  
When the king got from her only refusal,  
The sons of Usna were commissioned forth



Into hard combats, battles, and hard dangers,  
So that they might be slain; but they were firm  
In every place of wounding and of danger.  
Nought was attained. The men of Alba then  
Were mustered strongly to attack those sons  
And slay them. She was told that. And she told  
Neesha immediately. "Ye must depart,"  
She said. "Unless ye will depart to-night,  
Ye will be slain to-morrow." So that night  
They left the king; and a long time they wandered  
In desert woods and lands, and in lone glens  
Set up their booths and tents. In time they came  
Unto Loch Etive and subdued the lands  
Around Loch Etive; and they made a stronghold;  
And for a while in peace they sojourned there.

These things were told, now, to the men of Ulster,  
Who spoke together, and then said: "O Conor,  
This is to all our minds a cause of grief,—  
The Sons of Usna to be wandering  
In hostile lands, finding their death and end,  
Because of one bad woman." Conor said:  
"Let one go forth to them to take that message,  
And offer them protection here in Avvin."  
Then I (said Lowercam) was ordered forth  
To bear that message to the Sons of Usna.  
I found them, and they gave me trustful kisses,  
Kindly and fervently and loyally.  
And I, at finding them, wept floodlike tears;  
Because there were no two on the ridge of the world  
Who were so dear to me as were those two,  
Neesha and Daerdra. Then I spake my message.  
"We will return," said Neesha, "if great Fergus  
Will come to be our safeguard and our pledge;  
And if a son of Conor's and a chief  
Amidst the chiefs of Ulster will await  
To take our hands on landing." I returned  
To give this word. When Conor heard this word,

He weighed that matter for a space and season.  
Among the heroes of the Western World  
There was not any greater than was Fergus,  
In stalwartness and beauty and high race,  
In bounteousness and kindness; and to Conor  
He, without change, was ever dear and loyal.  
He by his prowess had broken thirty battles  
O'er chiefs in distant lands, e'en to the City  
Of Moorn in the far Land of Ice and Snow.  
Conor, then, pondered for a space and season.  
Then he took Fergus to a place apart,  
And said: "O royal warrior of the world,  
If thou wert sent to fetch the Sons of Usna,  
And they, in violation of thy safeguard,  
Were slain,—a thing which never would be done,—  
What wouldst thou do?" And this (said Lowercam)  
Was what great Fergus said: he said, "O King,  
Thy own blood, thy own flesh, I would not touch;  
But there is not another man of Ulster  
Whom I should find doing them injury,  
Who from my hands would not obtain his death."

"O royal warrior of the world," said Conor,  
"Thou shalt go forth to fetch the Sons of Usna;  
For 'tis with thee that they will come. Depart  
To-morrow; and, when coming from the east,  
Land at the doon of Borrig son of Annty,  
Where Cormac, my own son, and Duffa Dael  
Will take their hands on landing. And, besides,  
Give me thy word that when they shall arrive,  
No stop or stay shall be allowed to them;  
So that the first food which they eat in Erin  
May be with me in Avvin." Fergus promised;  
And early on the morrow he arose,  
And took with him no hosts or multitudes  
Except his own two sons, Illann Finn, namely,  
And Bwinn-ye the Rude-Red. And they set forth  
Upon that mission and that embassy.

Then Conor sent for Borrig son of Annty.  
He said: "Hast thou a feast for me, O Borrig?"  
"I have," said Borrig. "It was possible  
To make it, but it was not possible  
To bear it hither." "That being so," said Conor,  
"Give it to Fergus, when he comes to thee.  
And it belongs to his high hero-gassa  
And to his powerful hero-prohibitions,  
Both to refuse a feast when offered one,  
And to forsake a feast, ere it be ended."  
Borrig, instructed, fared to his own doon.

And Conor sent for Cormac, his own son,  
With Duffa Dael, the chafer-tongued of Ulster.  
"Go forth," he said, "unto Dunseverick  
To meet the Sons of Usna when they come there;  
And take their hands on landing." So he spake,  
Giving them wrong direction.

As for Fergus,

He, with his own two sons, Illann Finn, namely,  
And Bwinn-ye the Rude-Red, in his own boat,  
The Eura, sailed north-eastward, till he came  
To the strong place where dwelt the Sons of Usna,  
And to Loch Etive. And (said Lowercam)  
'Tis thus that those three Sons of Usna were:—  
They had three wide and spacious hunting-booths;  
And in the booth wherein they cooked their food,  
Therein they ate it not; and in the booth  
Wherein they ate, therein they rested not.  
And Fergus let from him a mighty shout  
Within the harbour, so that it was heard  
Through all that country near to him. And thus  
Were Neesha and bright Daerdra,—with the Kenncaem  
Of Conor placed between them, while they played  
At royal feehill on the Kenncaem. Then  
Neesha looked up and said: "I hear the shout  
Of a man of Erin." Daerdra, too, had heard  
The shout: she knew it was the shout of Fergus;

But she concealed it from them. And again  
Fergus let forth from him his mighty shout  
Within the harbour; so that Neesha said:  
“I hear another shout. It is the shout  
Of a man of Erin.” “It is not,” said Daerdra,  
“It is, indeed, the shout of a man of Alba.”  
But Fergus let from him his third loud shout  
Within the harbour; and the Sons of Usna  
Then knew it was, indeed, the shout of Fergus.  
And Neesha bade Ardawn go to the shore  
To meet great Fergus: whereon Daerdra said  
That she had recognized the first loud shout  
Which Fergus had let forth. “Wherefore,” said Neesha,  
“Didst thou conceal it?” Daerdra said to him:  
“I saw a vision in the night last night,—  
Namely, three birds which came to us from Avvin,  
Carrying in their mouths three drops of honey:  
And they with us left their three drops of honey;  
But took with them three drops of our own blood.”  
“How dost thou judge that vision?” Neesha said.  
“Thus,” answered she. “Fergus has come to us,  
Out of our native land to bear us peace;  
And honey is not sweeter to a man  
Than is an embassy of peace. The three  
Sips of our blood which the birds took from us,—  
They are yourselves who now will go with Fergus,  
And be betrayed.”

But it seemed ill to them  
That Daerdra should speak so; and they were grieved;  
And Neesha bade Ardawn go to the shore  
To meet great Fergus. And Ardawn went down;  
And when he saw great Fergus and his sons,  
He gave them each three kisses fervently  
And loyally, and took them to the stronghold  
Where Neesha was with Daerdra; and they, too,  
Gave their three kisses very fervently  
To Fergus and his sons. And Neesha sought

Their tidings of all Erin; and in special  
Their tidings of the Ulster Fifth. And Fergus  
Replied: "These tidings are indeed our best,—  
Namely, that Conor has sent myself to fetch you;  
And I am now your warranty and safeguard,  
And I am dear to you, and true, and loyal;  
And I have taken my word, and it is on me  
Now to fulfil my covenant and safeguard.  
And Cormac son of Conor son of Fahtna,  
And Duffa Dael of Ulster will be waiting  
At Borrig's Doon to take your hands on landing."

"It is not fit that ye should go," said Daerdra;  
"For greater is your store of wealth and riches  
In Alba than it e'er will be in Erin."

And it was then, indeed (said Lowercam),  
That Fergus spake these very fervent words:—  
"Better than all things is one's native land;  
For not delightful unto any man  
Is any store of wealth, however great,  
Unless he sees his own dear native land."

(Lowercam paused; for she perceived that Fergus,  
Hearing these words which he once so had spoken,  
Wept o'er his breast his flood-like showers of tears;  
And all perceived that like a sudden storm  
He rose; and, rushing like a sudden storm,  
Passed from the house. But Lowercam went on.)

When Fergus so had said these thoughtful words,  
"Better than all things is one's native land;  
For not delightful unto any man  
Is any store of wealth, howsoe'er great,  
Unless he sees his native land," with fervour  
Neesha replied: "That thing is true, O Fergus;  
For dearer to myself is our own Erin  
Than Alba is, although by hap in Alba  
I might obtain more wealth."

“My word and safeguard  
And warranty are firm and strong for you,”  
Fergus said, urging. “They are firm and strong,”  
Said Neesha. “We indeed will go with thee  
Again to Erin.”

Now (said Lowercam)  
It verily was not with Daerdra’s will  
That all these things were said. And she was trying  
To hinder them; but Fergus son of Roy  
Gave them his word that even if all the men  
Of Erin should betray them at one time,  
Not shield or sword or cathbarr should protect  
One such betraying from the wrath and vengeance  
Which he, great Fergus, would inflict on him.

And Neesha answered very ardently:  
“O generous Fergus, Fergus of Avvin Maha,  
Thy word is firm, and we will go with thee  
Again to Erin and to Avvin Maha.”

They passed that night away. Upon the morrow,  
Though early was the singing of the birds  
Amid the oaks, yet earlier than that,  
In the pale morn, was the fresh early rising  
Of Fergus and of Neesha. And they went  
Down to the creek and made their curraghs ready,  
And made the Eura ready; and ere yet  
The sun was high, Fergus and his two sons,  
And the three Sons of Usna,—Neesha, namely,  
And Annly and Ardawn,—with bright-cheeked Daerdra,  
And with their folk and people, bore away  
Along the sea, out to the awful ocean,  
To go to Erin. As for mournful Daerdra,  
She from the Eura gazed along their track,  
Back to the lands of Alba; and she said:  
“My love to thee, thou land there in the east;  
And I am wearying, indeed, at leaving  
The borders of thy cherishing creeks and havens,  
And thy smooth-flowering, unblemished plains,

And thy green-sided hills. And very little  
Indeed does it now profit us to leave them.”  
Then o’er the wave-voice of the billowing sea  
She sang her words of highest love of Alba.

“Belovéd land, thou land there in the east,  
Alba with wonders! I would never leave thee,  
Did I not leave with Neesha, my belovéd.

Belovéd are Doon Feea and Doon Finn  
And the high doon above them; and belovéd  
Is Innish Draiguen o’er its strong loud beach.

Kyle Coonan! O thick-branching wood of Coonan,  
Into which Annly oft would wend. Alas!  
Short seemed the time unto myself and Neesha,  
While we were in yon paling land of Alba.

Glen Lawee! in Glen Lawee I would sleep  
Beneath a gentle crag. Deer-flesh and fish  
And badger-flesh they brought me in Glen Lawee.

Glen Massan! in Glen Massan grows the garlic,  
Tall and pure-white. We had a rocking sleep  
Above the white-haired inver of Glen Massan.

Glen Etive! O Glen Etive! there I built  
My first house. Tender are its circling woods.  
A cattle-fold for sunshine is Glen Etive.

Glen Urkeen! O Glen Urkeen is a glen  
With straight, fair ridges. At his age no man  
Was prouder than was Neesha in Glen Urkeen.

And Glen Dau Roo! My love to every man  
Who dwells therein. Sweet is the cuckoo’s voice  
From curved bough on the peak o’er Glen Dau Roo.

And Innish Draiguen o’er its strong, loud beach!  
Dear are its pure-brinked waters where they shine  
Above pure sands; and I would ne’er have left it,  
Had I not left with my beloved, with Neesha.”

So o’er the waves she sang her mournful words,  
While to their own dear land and heritage  
The Sons of Usna travelled. And delight

Shone on the brows of these, while with their oars  
They beat the water-ways, until at length  
Beneath Doon Borrig, that long-famous doon  
Upon the cliff-high bounds of high-proud Ulster  
They put their prows on shore. And Borrig ran  
Down to that shore to take their hands on landing.  
He made great joy toward Fergus and his sons;  
And gave three kisses to the Sons of Usna;  
And said to Neesha that great grief was his  
That Cormac son of Conor son of Fahtna,  
And Duffa Dael of Ulster had not come  
North to his doon to take their hands on landing.  
Then, in a little while, he said to Fergus:  
“I have a feast prepared for thee, O Fergus;  
And it belongs to thy high hero-gassa,  
And to thy strong high hero-prohibitions,  
Both to refuse a feast when offered one,  
And to forsake a feast ere it be ended.”

When Fergus heard these words which Borrig spake,  
He flushed an angry red from crown to ground.  
“Thou hast done ill, O Borrig,” Fergus said,  
“To place me under gassa, seeing that Conor  
Put my strong word on me to bring the Sons  
Of Usna south to Avvin on the day  
When they should land in Erin.” Borrig said:  
“I place thee under gassa, yea, such gassa,  
That no true hero henceforth will endure thee,  
Unless thou comest to consume my feast.”

Then Fergus asked of Neesha what to do  
Concerning that. “Do,” answered Daerdra, fiercely,  
“That which appears the best to thee! Abandon  
The Sons of Usna. Drink thy feast. But truly  
'Tis a high price to pay for any feast,  
Thus to abandon them.” It seemed to Fergus  
It was an evil thing to break his gassa  
And his high hero-prohibitions. Sadly  
He said to Daerdra: “I abandon not



The Sons of Usna; for my own two sons,  
True Illann Finn and Bwinn-ye the Rude-Red,  
Go at their sides to Avvin. And my word  
And warranty go with them too," said Fergus.

"That is enough of excellence," said Neesha;  
"For no one yet hath e'er defended us  
In battle or in combat or in conflict,  
Except ourselves." And Neesha, in great anger,  
Moved from the spot. And Daerdra followed him;  
And Annly followed, and Ardawn, and all  
Their folk and people, and the Sons of Fergus.

Yet it was not with Daerdra's will and counsel  
That they made forth; and they left Fergus there  
Gloomy and sorrowful. Howbeit, to Fergus  
One thing seemed sure,—that if the Five Great Fifths  
Of Erin should take counsel all together,  
In the one spot, they still would not attain  
To daring to infringe his word and safeguard.

As to the Sons of Usna, they moved forward  
By each well-shortened way and fair direction,  
Till Daerdra said to them: "O Sons of Usna,  
How will it hurt you, though ye wait awhile?  
I now would give you a wise, fitting counsel;  
Although ye may not do it for me." Neesha  
Replied: "What then, O woman, is thy counsel?"  
She said, "To go to Rathlin, there, between  
Erin and Alba; and to stay in Rathlin  
Till Fergus shall have taken his feast; and that  
Will be a keeping of the word of Fergus;  
And to yourselves, O glorious Sons of Usna,  
'Twill be an increase of your length of princship."

"Toward us that is a saying of great ill,"  
Said the two sons of Fergus: "and to us  
It is impossible to do that counsel.  
E'en were there not the might of your own hands  
And ours, and the word of powerful Fergus  
Protecting you, ye would not be betrayed."

“Mourning and woe came with that word of Fergus,”  
Said Daerdra, “when he left us for a feast.”  
And she was in great grief and great dejection  
At having come to Erin on the word  
Of Fergus. And she said: “Woe that we came  
To Erin on the word of too-wild Fergus  
The son of Roy; and bitter is my heart.  
My heart to-day is as one clot of sorrow  
Beneath great shame. Alas! O princely Sons,  
Your end of days has come.” Neesha replied:  
“Say not these words, O eager, vehement Daerdra,  
O woman who art brighter than the sun.  
The word and warranty of generous Fergus  
Are strong to us.” But still she grieved and said:  
“Alas! I grieve for you, O Sons of Usna.  
To come from Alba of the red, swift deer,—  
Perpetual will be the woe from it.”

After that arguing again they journeyed  
By each well-shortened way and fair direction,  
Until, half-way upon their way to Avvin,  
Daerdra remained behind in a deep glen;  
And sleep descended on her; and they left her  
Without perceiving it. But in a while  
Neesha perceived it; and he turned to meet her;  
And she was rising from her sleep. He said:  
“Why didst thou stay behind me here, O Queen?”  
“I had a sleep,” said Daerdra; “and a vision  
And dream appeared to me.” “What dream?” said Neesha.  
Daerdra said: “Sad the vision which appeared!  
I beheld each of you without his head;  
And Illann Finn without his head. Of help  
There was not any.” Neesha said to her:  
“O Daerdra, heed not visions of thy sleep.  
Thy mouth hath sung to us nothing save evil,  
O shining, radiant damsel!” Daerdra said:  
“Better to me were ill for every man  
Than for you three, O gentle Sons of Usna,

With whom I have searched sea and mighty land.”

After those words, again they journeyed forward,  
Until they came unto the Height of Willows  
Not far from splendid Avvin. And thence Daerdra,  
While gazing outward from herself, perceived  
A hateful cloud, whereat she said these words:

“O Neesha, look upon thy cloud. I see it  
Before me in the air. Above green Avvin  
I see a very red, thin cloud of blood.  
A sudden starting has laid hold of me  
Before yon cloud. Like to a sod of blood  
Is yon red, awful cloud I see before me.  
And I would counsel you, dear Sons of Usna,  
Not to proceed to-night to Avvin Maha,  
With all this danger which there is on you;  
But let us go instead south to Doon Dalgan,  
To Dectora and Sooaltim; and later,  
When Fergus shall have come to us, we then  
Will go to Avvin.” Neesha angrily  
Answered wise, red-cheeked Daerdra: “Since, indeed,  
There is no fear on us, we will not do  
This counsel which thou givest.” And she, weeping,  
Said: “It has seldom happened before this,  
O thou descendant of distinguished Rury,  
That we have been without accord in counsel,  
Myself and thou, O Neesha. On the day  
When Manannawn bestowed on us a cup,  
Thou wouldst not on that day have been against me,  
I say to thee, O Neesha. On the day  
When thou didst bear me with thee on our flight  
Across white-foaming Assaroe of oars  
Thou wouldst not then, indeed, have been against me,  
I say to thee, O Neesha.”

After that  
They moved ahead by each well-shortened way,  
Till they beheld high-glorious Avvin Maha  
Before their eyes. O men (said Lowercam),

Owen the son of Doorha, King of Farney,  
Had had long strife with Conor; and the price  
Which he now paid for peace with powerful Conor  
Was this—to watch upon the Green of Avvin  
With hirelings; and to slay the Sons of Usna,  
So that they might not reach to Conor himself,  
And that Conor might not see them. Only Owen,  
Of all the men amidst the men of Ulster,  
Would have accepted that.

The Sons of Usna

Had reached the midpart of the green, when Owen,  
Searching the green through the dim-thickening dusk,  
Found Neesha; and, for welcome back to Avvin,  
In a fierce, evil, powerful wolf's-onset,  
Gave him a thrust with his long-shafted spear,  
So that he clove his back. Then Illann Finn  
The son of Fergus threw his own two arms  
Round Neesha; and he put him under him,  
And lay on him; and he himself was slain.  
And, rapidly thereafter, east and west,  
Along the plain beneath the dusk-dark vault,  
Ardawn and Annly, and all folk and people  
Who had come thither with them out of Alba,  
Were slain with wounds, till every sod became  
A red death-pillow; and each man had fallen  
In his sick pool of slaughter and of dying.

After that wounding, after those murder-strokes,  
After that falling, after that slaughter, loudly  
The men of Ulster cried three cries of woe  
And grief and mourning and loud lamentation.

After that falling, after that slaughter, Cathbad  
Came on the green; and he cursed Avvin Maha  
In punishment for that great ill. He said:  
“In punishment for that great ill, no son  
Of Conor's and no man of Conor's seed  
Shall reign in Avvin, even though Conor himself,  
Who, till this deed, hath been a great safe Rudder

To all this Fifth, procuring peace with riches,  
May yet reign many years." So Cathbad spake.  
His saying is no hidden saying. Soon  
Their graves were dug for those three noble ones;  
And their three mounds were heaped on them. And Daerdra,  
With her hands tied behind her back, was put  
In Conor's house.

O men (said Lowercam),  
Her mournful tragic end I tell not now.  
I first must speak of Fergus. On the morrow  
He swiftly came towards Avvin; and I went  
Swiftly myself (said Lowercam) to meet him.  
I told him how those three heroic ones,  
The Candles of the Valour of the Gael,  
The three fleet-footed, harp-voiced Sons of Usna,  
Had been betrayed and slain in Avvin Maha,  
Though underneath his honour and protection.  
Fergus, at first, could not believe that tale.  
To him it seemed impossible that Conor,  
The regal one, whom he and all the Ultonians  
Held in great reverence and love, should so  
Have outraged him,—he, Fergus, being moreover  
The greatest of the warriors of all Ulster.  
When he believed it, word was sent to Cormac  
And Duffa Dael; and from Dunseverick  
These came to join with Fergus; and with them  
Was Feeaha the son of Conall Carna.

The anger of the men cannot be told.  
In fury and huge wrath and vehemence  
They moved to do their deeds. They gave red battle  
To Conor's household; and with violence  
They ravaged and laid bare and scorched and wounded  
From east to west and north to south round Avvin;  
And Fergus put a fringe of fire round Avvin  
To burn it; and no man amidst the men  
Of Ulster dared attack them or oppose them.  
Then they collected all their folk and people,

Even to the number of a cantred,—thrice  
Ten hundred warriors; and they went from Ulster  
In rage and wrath. And yet (said Lowercam),  
Though thus they put their own dear land behind them,  
They could not put behind them their heart-love  
For Ulster; but they loved their own land still.

This was the road they went by,—o'er Slieve Foo-id,  
Then o'er wide Meath to westward, till they reached  
The beautiful, smooth Hill of Usna. There  
They stayed awhile; and they deliberated  
As to which Fifth to go to,—whether to go  
To Finn the son of Ross the Red of Leinster;  
Or to Finn's brother, Carpry Neea Faer;  
Or to the far south-west of mirthful Munster  
To Cooroi son of Dawra, who, some said,  
Was the best chief in Erin. Then one said:  
“The best of Fifths is Connaught; and the best  
Of kings is Al-yill; and the best of warriors  
Is Maev; and Croohan is the place of counsel  
For Erin all; since Maev in sway and power  
Is as a sovereign of all Erin. Also  
In Croohan there are found the choicest heroes  
And battle-champions, and the choicest poets  
And choicest men of learning and deep science  
And knowledge, in the circle of this world.”

That was the counsel which all deemed the best.  
A messenger was straightway sent to Croohan;  
And Maev and Al-yill made great joy before him.  
He said to Maev: “O Queen, thou wilt indeed  
Be sovereign o'er wide Erin, if great Fergus  
Shall come to aid thee.” And it was not long  
Ere Fergus went himself. And when Maev saw him,  
She rose to meet him; and she welcomed him,  
And kissed him. And the women and the poets  
Kissed him, and welcomed him, and welcomed Cormac  
And Duffa Dael and all the chiefs from Ulster.

Then Maev herself addressed great Fergus, saying:

“This gift from me to thee, O upright hero,  
O Fergus: I will give perpetual keeping  
To all thy cantred,—thrice ten hundred men,—  
Together with their women and their poets,  
And their young lads, and all their folk and gillies;  
And thou thyself shalt have a full equipment  
For three score powerful men; and thou shalt have  
Red gold, in value worth thrice seven bondmaids,  
And wine each night in my own house in Croohan.”

Fergus accepted that. And since that day,  
Now seven years past, Maev has bestowed on Fergus,  
And on the cantred which he brought from Ulster,  
That maintenance and keeping which she promised.  
Is it not true, O Maev? (said Lowercam)  
“Yea, it is true,” said Maev. Then Lowercam,  
After a little waiting, said:

O men,  
I now must speak of Daerdra, and must tell you  
Of her sad, mournful ending. She remained  
A year near Conor; and in all that time  
She never laughed her gladly smiling laugh,  
Or took her fill of food or of deep sleep;  
And she ne’er raised her head from off her knees.  
And I (said Lowercam) was with her there,  
Tending her in that horror and affliction.  
When they would bring to her the men of music  
And folk of entertainment, she would answer:

“Though beautiful to you your valiant champions  
Stepping to Avvin after expeditions,  
More beautifully stepped they toward their house,  
The three high-valiant, glorious Sons of Usna.

Neesha with burden of mirth-kindling mead;  
I with a bath for him and with warm fire;  
Ardawn with a slain ox or a fat hog;  
And Annly on his high back carrying faggots.

Though sweet to you the rich mirth-kindling mead  
Quaffed by the son of Fahtna of great valour,

I have oft known a chase upon a doe,  
The food of which was many times more sweet.

When noble Neesha would prepare for us  
A cooking-pit within the wild-floored forest,  
Sweeter than honey was each kind of food,  
Which there the Sons of Usna would make ready.

Though sweet in every month, indeed, to you  
Your fluters and your players on the horn,  
This thing is what my conscience knows to-day:—  
That I have heard a music which was sweeter.

Though sweet to Conor, the renowned king,  
His fluters and his players on the horn,  
Sweeter to me was the cloud-rich cloth-nell  
The song the Sons of Usna used to sing.

A voice as of the heavy waves had Neesha;  
It was sweet music to be ever hearing.  
The Cola of Ardawn, it was good music,  
And the andord of Annly towards his booth.

Much would I bear of hardness and of want,  
When I was with the three delightful heroes;  
I would endure without a house or fire;  
And 'tis not I that would be sorrowful.

The three shields of the heroes and their spears  
Were many a time my bed. O many a time  
Have I been with them in a solitude;  
But till their death-day I was ne'er alone.

Neesha—his little grave-hill has been made.  
My sight departed out of my two eyes  
As I beheld the grave of Neesha. Soon  
My soul will leave me. I shall find my end.

Belovéd was his spirit firm and just.  
Belovéd was the warrior, high, most noble.  
After our wandering through the woods of Fawl,  
Belovéd was our hidden, lonely rest.

Belovéd was the blue eye dear to women,  
And cause of terror to his enemies.  
After their circuit of great woods and forests,



Belovéd their andord through the dark way.

I sleep no more. Alas! I sleep no more,  
And I stain not my finger-nails with crimson.  
No joy comes now upon my mind and spirit,  
Since the three noble Sons of Usna come not.

I sleep no more. Alas! I sleep no more  
Through half the night-time in my lying-place;  
My senses fly away from me in crowds,  
Seeing that I now neither eat nor sleep.

I now, to-day, for joy have no occasion;  
Or for the pouring of rich mead or ale,  
Or for delight or peace or gentle rest,  
Or for a house, or for rich covering.”

And when (said Lowercam) Conor would try  
To be consoling her and pleasing her,  
'Tis then that she would say to him these words:

“O Conor, what, then, art thou thinking of?  
Thou hast heaped up on me sorrow and weeping.  
That is what I shall have while I shall live.  
Thy love for me will not endure for long.

The thing which was most beautiful to me,  
Under the heaven, and which was the dearest,  
Thou tookest from me,—great the wrongful deed,—  
So that I shall not see it till I die.

These things to me are lasting grief and sorrow:—  
The death for me of the three Sons of Usna,  
A little dark-black cairn o'er the white body  
Which was distinguished above countless men.

Two crimson cheeks and lips comely and red,  
And eye-lashes as black as is the dael,  
And rows of teeth beneath a pearly lustre,  
Like to the very noble tint of snow.

Distinguished was his clean and pure array  
Amidst the warriors of the men of Alba.  
A comely, crimson, fit, five-folding fooan,  
With its rich borderings of pure red gold.

An innar of rich royal sról, a treasure  
Around him—with one hundred varied gems  
Upon its bright and splendid broidery,  
And fifty ounces of pure white findrinny.

A golden-hilted sword in his one hand;  
And in his second hand two blue-grey spears;  
A shield with a surrounding rim of gold;  
And on it a bright central boss of silver.

Fergus, the fair-haired, wronged us and betrayed us,  
Bringing us hither o'er the mighty sea.  
He sold his hero-honour for an ale-feast.  
His great and wondrous deeds, indeed, have fallen.

Though they were all upon the plain before me,  
The men of Ulster, and thou, Conor, with them,  
I,—and I hide it not,—would give them all,  
To see the face of Neesha, son of Usna.

Break not my heart, to-day, beneath thy woe.  
Soon I shall come unto my early grave.  
Sorrow is more powerful than the sea,—  
If thou wouldst know it—it is true—O Conor.”

“What dost thou hate the most of all the things  
Which thou dost see here?” Conor said to her.  
“Thyself,” she said, “and Owen.”

“Thou shalt bide

A year with Owen,” Conor said to her.  
He gave her then to Owen. On the morrow  
They journeyed to the Fair of Maha. Daerdra  
Was behind Owen in a chariot. “Good,  
O Daerdra,” Conor, mocking, said to her;  
“It is the eye of a sheep between two rams  
That thou now hast between myself and Owen.”  
There was a cliff of stone against the way.  
She threw her head against the cliff of stone,  
So that she made bruised fragments of her head,  
And she was dead.

There is no more to tell  
(Said Lowercam). O men, after that woe

I myself went from Ulster, and I came  
To the Black Exile here in Connaught, namely,  
To Cormac and to Duffa and to Fergus;  
And here, far distant from my native land,  
The mists of sad old age lay hold of me.

Lowercam ended; and in that great house  
In Croohan on Moy Wee in Connaught, each  
Went to his sleeping-place, and all was still.  
But Maev stepped forth out of her royal house,  
And went to the great mound; and on the mound  
Found Fergus standing; and his face was turned  
Toward the north-east, toward Ulster. Then Maev laid  
Her queenly arm around his royal neck,  
And said: "O Fergus, thou hast, verily,  
Great love for Ulster, thine own land; and yet  
Thou, who wast once the greatest of all warriors  
Throughout the Western World, wast scorned, insulted,  
And driven forth out of thy native land,  
To have thy dwelling in wild desert forests  
With foxes and wild deer; and 'tis with us  
That thou didst find a country and a land  
And an inheritance; and wondrous kindness  
We have bestowed on thee. Yea, even, O Fergus,  
Because of thy great manliness and vigour,  
I gave thee my own love and bare thee sons,  
Kear and Corc and Conmac—(great the deed)—  
Three goodly sons from whom, in aftertime,  
Distinguished clans and kindreds shall descend.  
It is now right that without any urging  
From us, thou shouldst with care and diligence  
Take thy own share of battle on this hosting  
And Táin. It would not seem to me too much  
Were Conor slain, that thou thyself, O Fergus,  
Shouldst become king o'er all the kings of Ulster."

These were Maev's words. When they had thus been spoken,  
She went again into her royal house  
And to her royal bed and sleeping-place.

And Fergus went to his own house and people.

## BOOK III

### BOOK III

The many bands and troops which Maev had summoned  
Began to come upon Moy Wee. The first  
(And they arrived upon Moy Wee next day)  
Were Maev's own seven sons, the seven Mahn-yas,  
Whom she had borne to Al-yill. These they were:—  
Mahn-ya Mathroo-il, who resembled Maev:  
Mahn-ya Athroo-il, who resembled Al-yill:  
Mahn-ya Mo-aepert, the much-talking Mahn-ya:  
Dumb Mahn-ya Toi, the mute and silent Mahn-ya:  
Good Mahn-ya More-gar, of great piety  
To Al-yill son of Mawta, to his father:  
Good Mahn-ya Meen-gar, of great piety  
To Maev the daughter of Yohee, to his mother.  
Mahn-ya Condagau Illy, who had beauty  
From father and from mother, being like both.

Now, at the first, their names had not been Mahn-ya;  
But these had been their names:—Faylimy, Carpry,  
Yohee, Ket, Fergus, Sheen, and Dawra. Then,  
Suddenly, on a day, Maev had bestowed  
On each that new name, Mahn-ya. For one day  
(And it was many years before this time)  
While she was on the playing-field of Croohan,  
And they were playing round her, she had said  
Unto her Druid: "Say to me, O Druid,  
By which of all my sons Conor shall fall."

"Thou hast not borne him yet," the Druid answered,  
"Unless thou wilt re-name them." "How is that?  
Make this thing clear," said Maev. The Druid answered:  
"By Mahn-ya Conor shall be slain." Then Maev  
Re-named her sons, and gave unto each one

That new name, Mahn-ya; so that by a son  
Of hers great Conor son of Fahtna Fahee  
Might fall in time to come. (Howbeit, a thing  
There was, which was not known to Maev that day:—  
It was not Conor son of Fahtna Fahee,  
But Conor son of a famed King of Alba,  
Of whom the Druid prophesied, and who  
Was destined to be slain in time to come  
By one of Maev's own sons.) So now these Mahn-yas  
Arrived upon Moy Wee; and each one brought  
His cantred, thrice ten hundred men; and all  
Encamped upon Moy Wee, and joyfully  
Maev saw her valorous offspring.

After these,

The seven sons of Mahga came the next  
Upon that plain. They were experienced warriors,  
Brethren to Al-yill's mother, Mawta Murrisc;  
And they were scarred and grey. These were their names:—  
Anloo-an, Baskell, Maccorb, Scandall, Aen,  
Five sons of Mahga. Doha son of Mahga,  
Who was—it happened so—a foster-brother  
To Laery the Victorious of Loch Laery,  
A chief in Ulster. Last, but most renowned,  
Ket son of Mahga, who a wolf of evil  
Was unto all in Ulster. These arrived,  
Each with his cantred (thrice ten hundred men)  
On smooth Moy Wee; and on Moy Wee encamped,  
And gladly Maev beheld them.

After these

Seven great noble under-kings arrived  
From wide and mirthful Munster. To each one  
(In order, so, the more to bind him to her)  
Maev, through her envoys, secretly had offered  
Her daughter, Findabair, the White-beam. Now,  
Each of those seven with his cantred came—  
His thrice ten hundred—in the hope to wed  
That maiden when the hosting should return.

The maiden of that thing knew nought. These camped  
On smooth Moy Wee. Maev gladly saw them there.

A warlike cantred next from Leinster came,  
Fighters replete with fames and victories.  
Their wide blue lance-heads, like those Lawry Ling-sha  
Had brought of old across the ocean, flashed  
Now, being borne across Moy Wee.

And next

Came a contingent of the Folk of Tara;  
And next, some small and varied bands; and then,  
A certain small but beautiful bright band,  
Mounted on soft, grey mares, which had gold bits  
And little bells of gold; the men themselves  
Having upon them wan-white laynas, worked  
With threads of gold, and, over these, eared bratts  
Blue like the sky, and clasped with deep red gold.  
Their silver shields and varied weapons, set  
With carbuncle and gems of worth, flamed bright  
With sparkles, as they faced the westering sun.  
This was the band of Frae the son of Eedath,  
Whose mother, Baefinn, sister was to Boyne  
Of the Immortal Shee. From the Shee-mound  
On green Moy Bray, that robing and equipment  
Had been bestowed upon him. Findabair,  
Far-gazing from the lofty greeanawn  
Above the high main gateway of the doon,  
Perceived that band arriving on the plain;  
Whereat her cheeks and countenance waxed bright  
Like sunrise in the month of May. She thought,  
Communing with herself, of that past day—  
Yet not long past—when, in the same array,  
Frae had approached to woo her. And she thought  
Upon his beauty on that other day,  
During the sojourn he had made at Croohan—  
The day when he had swum the dark-pooled stream,  
To pluck a branch of rowan red with fruit,  
That fringed the further brink. For, beautiful

She had then thought it—o'er the black-dark pool  
To see him—his fresh body all clear white,  
His hair of radiant brightness, and his eyes  
Of blue-green greyness; and the branch with fruit  
Between his throat and his bright face. Then e'en  
Calling, "Is it not beautiful he looks?"  
She had perceived that the wild river-beast  
Had caught him in mid-stream. Whereat at once  
(Those who were round her being loth and slow)  
She, flinging off her raiment, had leapt down  
To swim the stream, carrying him a sword,  
Wherewith to slay the beast. After that day,  
And after some events and happenings,  
Al-yill and Maev had said to Frae: "Come, then,  
To join our hosting to the land of Cooley.  
Bring kine for sustenance to kings and princes.  
Bring thy three gentle and far-famed musicians  
For gladdening of the Hosts; and, at the end,  
When we again shall have returned to Croohan,  
Thou shalt have Findabair." Now, therefore, Frae  
Came to the hosting on Moy Wee. He camped  
Upon Moy Wee, ere yet the twilight fell;  
And Findabair was glad. "I see," said Maev,  
"O daughter, thou art glad to see them there."

The last of those to come upon Moy Wee  
Was the Black Exile. Fergus had sent word  
To Cormac, who was then in a far part  
Of Connaught; and he hasted not, but now,  
Almost at juncture of the day and night,  
He came with three great bands, the three together  
Making one cantred. From the Green of Croohan  
The men of Croohan watched these bands arrive.

The first band was arrayed in bratts of green—  
Green like spring-grass, with silvery dagger-pins  
Fastening the bratts. Their laynas, stitched with gold,  
Descended to their knees. Their shields were long.  
A spear with wide grey head and slender shaft



Was in the hand of every man of them.

“Is this now Cormac?” shouted everyone.

“It is not Cormac yet,” responded Maev.

The second band wore bratts of dark black-grey.  
Their laynas next their skin, which were bright white,  
Descended past their thighs. Their shields were white.  
A spear which had five points on one stout shaft  
Was in the hand of every man of them.

“Is this now Cormac?” shouted everyone.

“It is not Cormac yet,” responded Maev.

The third band was arrayed in purple bratts  
Of hill-heath purple; and their dagger-pins  
Above their breasts were all of rich chased gold.  
Their silken laynas, rich and soft and smooth,  
Descended to their insteps. Their curved shields  
Had blade-keen edges; and a towering spear,  
Like to a pillar in some kingly stead,  
Was in the hand of every man of them.  
While they drew near, they all in unison  
Lifted their feet, and all in unison  
Lowered their feet; so toward the doon they came.  
“Is this now Cormac?” shouted everyone.  
“Yea, this indeed is Cormac,” answered Maev.  
And very gladly on her plain of Wee  
Maev saw the Ulster King’s great exiled son.

So the Four Fifths of Erin had assembled  
Until they were upon Moy Wee in Connaught.  
And on Moy Wee all made their camps that night,  
So that between the four famed fords of Wee,  
The Ford of Moga and the Ford of Bercna,  
The Ford of Slissen and the Ford of Coltna,  
The plain was as one cloak of smoke and fire,  
With their camp-fires enkindled there that night.  
And they remained the space of fifteen nights  
Encamped around Rath Croohan; for their poets  
And druids would not let them travel forth

Until the end of fifteen days and nights,  
While they were waiting for a happy sign  
Of luck and fortune to that war and hosting.  
Therefore, throughout that time they had regalement  
And pleasing drinks and pastime, so that haply  
The hardships of their coming war and hosting  
Might seem the less severe and hard to them.

When, at the end of all those fifteen nights,  
From her high mound and stronghold for outlooking  
And for surveying, Maev surveyed those troops  
And those vast multitudes and bands and throngs  
In point to break up camp and journey east  
Upon her war and hosting into Ulster—  
Into her mind there came uneasiness,  
Doubt and uncertainty and trouble. “Here,”  
She said within her mind, “are multitudes  
Parting to-day from loved ones and from kindred,  
From territory and from heritage,  
From father and from mother; and unless  
Whole and unharmed they here return again,  
It is on me that they will strike their groans  
And sighs and curses. And moreover now—  
Though I am now (outside high-powerful Ulster)  
The greatest ruler through the lands of Erin—  
Though I have now assembled this great hosting,  
That I may so avenge my bitter groans,  
And the disgrace and wrong and shame and insult  
Which were inflicted on me in my youth—  
Yet there is not true certainty with me  
That I shall have success, or that, indeed,  
I shall myself escape dark death, or even  
That I shall not be captured and be taken  
By Conor, and be given a far worse shame,  
And a worse wrong and contumely and insult,  
Than were inflicted on me in my youth.”

This was the time wherein Maev called and spake  
Unto her charioteer, and bade him catch

Her steeds and yoke her chariot, so that straightway  
She might repair to speak with her own Druid  
And ask for prophecy and knowledge. "Wait  
One while, O Queen," the charioteer made answer,  
"That I may three times wheel the chariot round  
Sunwise, to win a sign of luck and fortune."  
He wheeled the chariot sunwise, and then Maev  
Rode to her Druid. When she reached the Druid,  
She asked for prophecy and knowledge. "Here,"  
Said Maev, "are many throngs and multitudes  
Parting to-day from loved ones and from kindred,  
From territory and from heritage,  
From father and from mother; and unless  
Whole and unharmed they here return again,  
It is on me that they will strike their groans  
And sighs and curses, for 'tis I alone  
Who have assembled all this wondrous hosting.  
And yet, let that be as it will. There goes  
Not forth to Ulster and there bides not here  
Life dearer to us than our own. Find, then,  
O Druid, whether we, at least, ourselves,  
In safety from this hosting shall return."

The Druid said, "O great and prosperous Maev,  
Daughter of Yóhee Fayla, here I have  
Knowledge to hearten and enliven thee:—  
This knowledge, namely. Conor son of Fahtna  
Lies at this hour in splendid Avvin Maha  
In torment and in weakness. On all chiefs  
And kings in Ulster, each in his own doon,  
Torment and pain and weakness have descended.  
This is the curse of Maha daughter of Sanrith;  
And here now is the reason of that curse.

Some six score years before the year in which  
We speak, Crunniuc the son of Agnoman,  
A wealthy brewer of the Ultonians, lived  
In Ulster, 'mid high, wild, and lonely moors.  
Many sons dwelt with him. His wife was dead.

One day, when he was in his house alone,  
A thing occurred. For he perceived a woman  
Stately and young move by; and wonderful  
He deemed her guise and semblance. He perceived  
How, without uttering word, she kneaded, baked,  
And milked, and ruled the folk, even as though  
She in that stead had e'er been wont to be.  
At night she slept with him. So, a long time  
They dwelt together; and, through her good rule,  
There was no scarcity of each good increase  
In viands, vesture, wealth. A festival  
Was held in Ulster then. The folk of Ulster,  
Both men and wives and growing lads and maids  
Were faring to that festival; and Crunniuc  
Made to fare thither too. Excellent vesture  
Was round him; and a blooming, rich appearance  
Was on him. Then the woman said to him:  
"It will become thee at that festival  
To be discreet, O Crunniuc." And he went  
With every other to the Green of Meeting.  
The festival was held. At close of day  
The steeds and chariot of the Ulster king  
Were brought on to the green; and those two steeds,  
Drawing his chariot, gained the victory.  
And the hosts cried, "There is not in this world  
Aught fleeter than those steeds are!" Crunniuc said:  
"My wife is fleeter than the steeds." Whereat,  
He by the king was placed in cords and bonds.  
They told the woman that. "'Tis hard," said she,  
"For me to go there to release him now;  
Since I am great with child, and nigh my hour."  
"However hard," the messenger replied,  
"Unless thou goest to race with the king's steeds,  
Thy man will presently be slain." She went  
So to the green. Then, when she reached the green,  
Her pangs of travail came on her. She cried  
Aloud unto the hosts. "Help me," said she.

“Help me. Show mercy; for it was a mother  
Who bore each one of you. Grant me delay  
Until I be delivered.” By them all  
She was refused that respite and delay.  
“Then,” she called out, “worse ill shall come of it—  
Ill that shall press on the Ultonians all  
For a long space of time.” “What is thy name?”  
The king put query to her. “I will tell  
My name,” said she. “Moreover, by the name  
Of that Birth I shall bear, this green for ever  
Will be denominated. I am Maha  
Daughter of Sanrith son of Imba.” Then  
She raced the chariot. Even with the speed  
Of windy ripples blown athwart a mere  
Or of blown foam flitting o’er some sea-strand,  
She raced the chariot; and she reached the goal,  
And, ere the chariot too had reached the goal,  
She was delivered; and she brought forth twins,  
“The Twins of Maha,” “Avvin Maha.” This,  
Then, “Avvin Maha,” thus became the name  
Whereby that green is known. Now, she had cried  
With agony of childbirth, and each man  
Who heard that cry immediately was cast  
Into great helplessness and grief and pain.  
She said: “Ye men of Ulster, from this hour—  
For nine full generations from this hour—  
When most oppression from your enemies  
Falls on your country, then on every man  
Descended from you men who here to-day  
Have done this shame to me, there shall come down  
A curse of torment and of pain and weakness,  
Like to the pain and weakness of a woman  
Approaching to her hour. And three alone,  
Namely, the women and the tender children,  
And also he who will be named Cucullin,  
Shall be exempted from this Curse.

This Curse,

Namely, the Kesh upon the Ulster warriors,  
It is," the Druid said, "O Queen, which now—Now  
when thy mighty hosts fare forth to Ulster—  
Has fallen on each Ulster chief and king."

So spake the Druid, yielding knowledge. Then  
Maev answered: "Long ago I heard that tale,  
What time I was in Avvin in my youth,  
When I had been given to Conor against my will.  
This is the thing which I have hoped for, ever.  
And not long since, just ere Mac Roth returned  
From Cooley, certain of my envoys came  
From spying out proud Ulster; and I knew  
By their sure words that at this time the Kesh  
Was falling on the Ulster chiefs and kings.  
E'en had their bull been rendered eagerly,  
We should have gone to Ulster at this time.  
And yet a cloud of darkness and of doubt  
And apprehension weighs on me. Find then,  
O Druid, whether we, at least, ourselves,  
In safety shall return." The Druid said,  
"Whoever may return or not return,  
Thou wilt return thyself." The charioteer  
Then turned the chariot round; and Maev came back.

Then, even as Maev came, she saw a thing  
Which was to her a wonder; for she saw,  
Fronting her, poised upon a chariot-pole,  
A just-grown maid move towards her. In this way  
That maid was. In her right hand she was holding  
A weaving-sword of white findrinny, set  
With hooklets of red gold; and she was weaving  
A bordering fringe. Folded around her shape,  
A bratt of leafy green, chequered and pied,  
Was held by a full fruit-like heavy clasp  
Over her breast. Her face was rosy, bright.  
Her eyes were laughing, blue; and her two lips  
Were shapely-thin and red. Within her lips

Her teeth were glistening, pearly-glimmering—  
One might have deemed a white rain-shower of pearls  
Had rained in there. Her light, long, yellow hair  
Divided; three gold tresses of it wound  
About her head; another long gold tress  
Fell round her, making shade around her calves.  
Her feet were long and slender, very white.  
Her nails were trim and sharp and crimson-stained.  
Whiter than snow in one night softly fallen,  
The whiteness of her flesh was, where it shined  
And gleamed athwart her quivering, blown apparel.

Maev looked at her. “What makest thou?” said Maev,  
“O damsel now and here?” The maiden spoke;  
And, when she spoke, as sweet as are the strings  
Of peaked harps played by the skilful hands  
Of master-players, was the sweet, clear sound  
Of her calm, pleasant voice and utterance.

“I am illuminating and revealing,”  
She said, “O Queen, the profit and the loss  
Which are before thee now, while thou dost gather,  
And muster here the Four great Fifths of Erin,  
To go unto the land of Ulster.” “Wherefore  
Dost thou this thing for me?” Maev asked of her.  
“I have much cause,” she said, “I am indeed  
A handmaid ’mid thy people.” “Of my people  
Who art thou?” Maev made question. And the maid  
Replied, “Not hard to tell; for I am Fedelm,  
A prophetess from ’midst thy unseen Shee.  
At Sowin, now, out of thy green Shee-mound  
Of Croohan, I have come, O Queen, to thee.”

And it was then that Maev began to ask  
For prophecy; and Fedelm answered her.  
And this is what was said between them there.  
Maev said: “Speak then, O Fedelm, Prophetess,  
How seest thou our great hosts?” And Fedelm answered:  
“I see them red. I see them crimson-red.”

“Conor the son of Fahtna lies,” said Maev,

“In Avvin in his Kesh, the curse of Maha.  
My messengers were there; and there is nothing  
That we need dread, now, from the men of Ulster.  
But speak the truth, O Fedelm, Prophetess—  
How seest thou these our hosts?” Fedelm replied:  
“I see them red. I see them crimson-red.”

“Cooscree Mend Maha, Conor’s son,” said Maev,  
“Lies in his Kesh in his own Innish Cooscree.  
My messengers were there; and there is nothing  
That we need fear, now, from the men of Ulster.  
But speak the truth, O Fedelm, Prophetess—How  
seest thou our great hosts?” Fedelm replied:  
“I see them red. I see them crimson-red.”

“Owen the son of Doorha lies,” said Maev,  
“In his own rath, Rath Aer-heer, in his Kesh.  
My messengers were there, and there is nothing  
That we need fear, now, from the men of Ulster.  
But speak the truth, O Fedelm, Prophetess.  
How seest thou our great hosts?” Fedelm repeated:  
“I see them red. I see them crimson-red.”

“This is not truth, O Prophetess,” said Maev.  
“Keltar the son of Oo-hider,” said Maev,  
“With a full third of all the men of Ulster,  
Lies in his Kesh in Doon Le-glass. And Fergus  
The son of Roy the son of Yóhee Lenny,  
Is with us here in exile, and he has  
His thrice ten hundred men; and we shall surely  
Bring victory and triumph out of Ulster.  
Speak then the truth, O Fedelm, Prophetess,  
How seest thou these great hosts?” She still repeated:  
“I see them red. I see them crimson-red.”

“This thing to me,” said Maev, “is not the same  
As ’tis to thee. For when the men of Erin  
Shall meet in the one place, there will be quarrels,  
Occasions of dissension and disunion,  
And frays and fallings-out and feuds and broils—  
About their being in the van or rear,



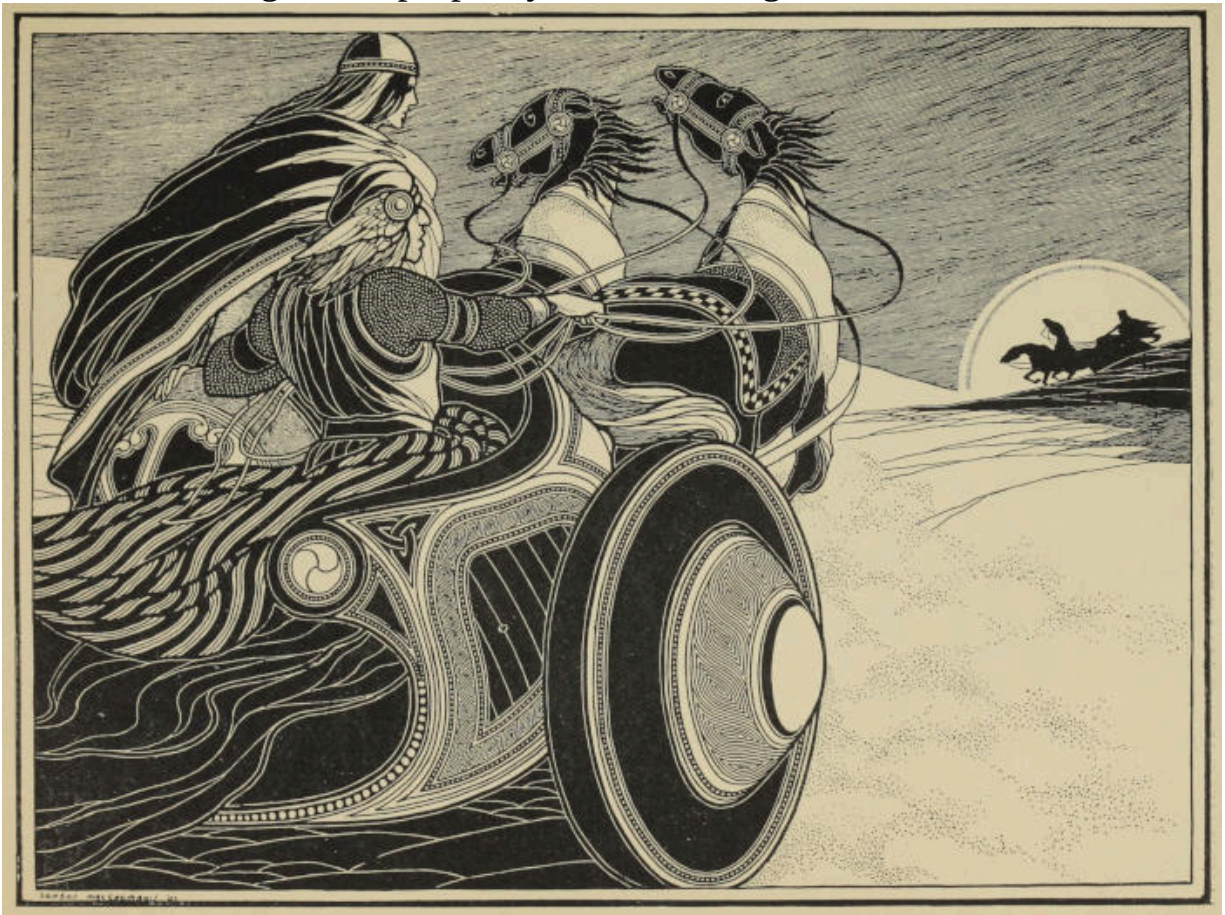
And about fords and rivers, and about  
First-slaying of swine and hares and stags and deer.  
Then look again for us, O Prophetess,  
And speak the truth to us.” The maiden answered:  
“I see them red. I see them crimson-red.  
I see a man who will perform great feats.”  
And she began to sing and prophesy  
And to foretell things that would be thereafter.  
And this was what she sang then at that time.

“I see a man youthful and very fair,  
Who will perform great deeds, and win his fill  
Of hurts and wounds in his smooth fine-fair skin.  
Upon his brow, which is a meeting-place  
For victories, the hero’s light flames high.  
Amidst each eye the seven dragon-gems  
Of a pure hero-champion flame and burn.  
Plain to perceive, his intellect is keen.  
A red hooked layna folds him. His fresh face  
Is beautiful and noble. He observes  
Towards women courtesy and modesty.  
Though a mere stripling, blooming, dainty-cheeked,  
He in the battle shows a dragon’s form.  
His fairness and his valour now resemble  
Cucullin of Mweerhevna; and though, truly,  
Who this Cucullin of green Moy Mweerhevna  
May be I know not, yet this thing I know—  
These hosts by him will all be very red.  
Four little swords for feats of special skill  
He carries in each hand: he will attain  
To plying these upon the hosts: the hosts  
Will flee from him on every road and way.  
When, in addition to his spear and sword,  
He brings his dread Gae Bulg, he plants his feet  
On every slope and hill. Two spears project  
O’er his bright chariot-wheels: he rides to battle.  
Fury distorts him, battle-fury changes  
That form which hitherto I have perceived.

He is Cucullin son of Sooaltim,  
Hound of the Forge: he wends unto a battle.  
Your hosts, now whole, he will hack down and fell.  
He will compel your slain thickly to lie.  
Strong men will leave their heads with him. This I,  
Fedelm the Prophetess, will not conceal.  
Red blood shall drip from the white skins of heroes—  
Lasting and long the memory shall be—  
Bodies shall there be torn, women shall wail,  
Through deeds of that renowned Hound of the Forge,  
Whom now, O Queen, I see.”

The Prophetess

Ended her prophecy: and Maev rode back  
From seeking-out of prophecy and knowledge.



“MAEV RIDES FORTH TO SPEAK WITH HER DRUID.”

## BOOK IV

### BOOK IV

That day those many hosts and bands and throngs,  
Ending their feasting on Moy Wee, had moved  
Forth on their travel and their arduous hosting.  
Their travel unto Ulster now we tell;  
And all the ways they went by; and events  
That chanced upon those ways. First, then, they went  
South-eastward from Rath Croohan; and they crossed  
Moy Cronn, and passed Toom Mona, and the lake  
Where three bounds march; and at that first day's end  
They camped on Cool Shillinny. There his tent  
That night was pitched for Al-yill son of Mawta.  
Fit furniture of cloths and coverlets  
Was ranged in it; and in that plenished tent  
On Al-yill's right at pleasant feasting sat  
Fergus the son of Roy, Cormac Conlinghish,  
And Feeaha, young son to Conall Carna;  
While on his left sat Maev daughter of Yóhee;  
And Findabair, daughter of Maev and Al-yill.  
Servants, attendants, and distributors  
Were also in that tent. At eve that day  
Maev's band had come the last of all those hosts;  
For Maev had lingered and delayed that day,  
Searching for prophecy and knowledge. Then,  
When she at length had come, she had commanded  
Her charioteer to fit for her her nine  
War-chariots (for 'twas in this manner ever,  
On every hosting, Maev was wont to fare:—  
Namely,—with two war-chariots in her front,  
Two in her rear, and two upon each side,  
The chariot on the which she rode herself

Being amidmost of them. For this cause  
She so was wont to fare—namely, that so  
The turves and ooze flung from the hooves of steeds,  
Or flakes of foam flung from their bridle-bits,  
Or clouds of dust caused by vast, moving hosts,  
Might not attain to tarnishing or spoiling  
The flashing mind of gold worn by the queen).  
The charioteer had brought these chariots then;  
And Maev had taken a circuit through the camp,  
Riding—that she herself might ascertain  
Which of those many bands were loth and slow,  
And which were active, rapid, animated  
Upon that hosting. Now she had come (that done)  
Into the tent, and sat by Al-yill’s side.  
Maev’s mind within her vexed her grievously  
That night; and she was troubled and perturbed  
And chafed and anxious, thinking of those things  
Which she had heard in way of prophecy.

Then Al-yill asked for tidings of the camp.  
“There is no need,” said Maev, “for any folk  
To fare upon this hosting, save one folk—The  
cantred of the Leinster-men.” “What good,”  
Asked Al-yill, “have they wrought, so to be praised  
Beyond all others?” “When the others first  
Halted to camp,” said Maev, “these had already  
Built up their bothies and their booths and shelters.  
And when the others had built up their shelters,  
Those men of Leinster had served round their meat  
And ale; and when the others had served their meat,  
The Leinster-men had made an end of eating,  
And harpers played to them. As thus their slaves  
And bond-folk are distinguished ’mid the slaves  
And bond-folk of all Erin: so their leaders  
Will be distinguished ’mid the battle-leaders  
Of Erin; and ’tis with that Leinster cantred  
Each victory will be.” “The better that  
For us,” said Al-yill; “for it is with us

They travel, and for us they will contend.”  
“With us they shall not travel,” Maev affirmed,  
“And for us not contend.” “Then,” answered Al-yill,  
“Let them stay here.” “They shall not stay,” said Maev;  
“When we have gone from Connaught with our hosts,  
They will rise up and take our land from us,  
If they stay here.” Findabair, Bright-beam,  
Daughter of Maev and Al-yill, asked her then:  
“What shall the Leinster-men then do, if thus  
They neither bide nor go?” And Maev replied:  
“Their death and violent end and slaughter—that  
Is what I crave for them!” “Woe,” answered Al-yill,  
“That thou shouldst say that thing,—only for this,  
That with dexterity and speed and swiftness  
They made their camp to-night! We will not hide  
That that is woman-counsel!” Fergus, then,  
The son of Roy, said: “By our truth of conscience!  
It shall not fall out so. They are a people  
Bound to us Ulster-men by bonds. No man  
Shall give them death but him who first gives death  
To me myself.” “E’en that we could achieve,  
O Fergus,” Maev responded. “We have numbers  
Enough to slay thee and thy Ulster-men  
And all those Leinster-men around thee. Here  
We have of Connaught folk upon this hosting  
The seven Mahn-yas with their seven cantreds,  
The seven sons of Mahga with their cantreds,  
Al-yill the son of Mawta with his cantred,  
And I myself with my own household troops.  
We are enough to slay you Ulster-men  
And all the Leinster-men around you.” Fergus  
Replied: “O Maev, it would not happen so.  
Upon my side there are the seven chiefs  
From wide and mirthful Munster; and with each  
Is his own cantred. I have here with me  
Two cantreds of the best of fighting-men  
Of Erin all, namely, our Ulster Exiles,

And this same cantred of the Leinster-men.  
And to these last I have been pledge and surety,  
Since first they left their native territory,  
And came to Connaught; and 'tis on my part  
That they would fight in every place of battle.  
There is a thing, however, now," said Fergus.  
"These men need not be made a cause of strife  
Between us. It is all one thing to me  
So that they be not injured. They by me  
Shall now be scattered and distributed  
Amongst the men of Erin, so that henceforth  
Not five of them shall be in the one place."

"It is one thing to me, indeed," said Maev,  
"So that they stay not in that strong array  
Wherein they are this hour." That, then, was done.  
The cantred of the Leinster-men was scattered  
Amidst the men of Erin, so that thenceforth,  
Not five of them were found in the one place.

The hosts next day moved on from Cool Shillinny,  
Continuing their progress and their course.  
They passed by Doolough, and they crossed Slieve Bawne,  
And reached Mone Coltna. There, on that wide moor,  
They chanced on eight score deer in one thick herd,  
Which they surrounded; and in whate'er place  
There was a man of those same Leinster-men,  
'Twas he who got the deer, except five deer,  
Which were obtained by others on that hosting.

Across the wide, reed-bordered Shannon next  
The hosts passed eastward. On Moy Traega next  
They camped to east of it. Now, it was hard  
To wield and manage that vast host, composed  
Of many various folks and tribes and kindreds,  
And to make sure that everyone should be  
With his own friends and his own tribe and kindred.  
And then all said this was the fitting mode  
For their advance, namely, that each great throng  
Should be round its own king, and each division

Round its own sub-king, and each lesser band  
Round its own captain; and that every king  
And everyone of kingly rank should make  
A camping-mound apart. Further, they said  
It must be thought of who was the fit man  
To go before the hosts, and show the way  
Between the two great Fifths. And then all said  
That Fergus was that man; because to him  
This hosting was a hosting for revenge  
And for retaliation on that king  
Who had insulted him, in causing death  
To those who had come to Erin 'neath his safeguard  
And sworn protection. So to Fergus then  
The leadership was given, and Fergus went  
Before the hosts to guide them on to Ulster.

Then, e'en as he so led those warlike throngs  
Toward Ulster, toward the east, on Fergus fell  
His fervent love for his own land, that land  
Of proud-high Ulster. Each renowned old doon  
Therein was known to him. Famed men therein,  
Who now in resting-houses of old age  
Rested from wars, had been his fosterers.  
Famed battle-breakers, war-trained men therein,  
Had been his comrades in the use of arms,  
His dear, near foster-brothers. And young men  
Therein, and eager striplings, and fresh youths  
Had been his foster-children. And he thought  
Of one young lad, his foster-son, who dwelt  
Nigh Cooley—thinking of whom Fergus sent  
Swift warnings privily to Ulster. Then,  
By a long, devious route o'er bogs and streams  
He led the hosts, delaying their advance  
Toward Ulster, till they came at length to Granard  
In Northern Teffia. There a while they camped.  
Again the hosts moved onward, and again  
On Fergus came his pity for his land  
And kindred; and again sharp memory

Of that young foster-son who dwelt beside  
The bounds of Cooley came; and then again  
He led the hosts by a long devious course.  
Through Northern Teffia and Southern Teffia  
Southward in loops he went, till he arrived  
Beside the streaming Inn-yone. Al-yill, then,  
And Maev perceived that thing which Fergus did.  
Maev challenged Fergus; and he answered her.  
“Fergus,” said Maev, “what kind of way is this?  
Wandering to north and south, in turn we stray  
Through every other folk.” “O Maev,” said Fergus,  
“Wherefore be troubled? ’Tis not for the harm  
Of these your hosts that I go wandering  
On every way in turn. ’Tis to avoid  
A certain Slaughter-hound of Moy Mweerhevna  
Who else would spring at you; and I forewarn you  
To fear that Hound.” Maev said, “It is unrighteous  
In thee to work the harm of this our hosting,  
O Fergus son of Roy! Thou, in thy exile,  
Hast found much kindness at our hands, O Fergus.”  
Then Fergus said, “I will no longer go  
Before these hosts. Let some one else,” said Fergus,  
“Go on before these battle-throngs to Ulster.”  
So Fergus yielded up the leadership.

The hosts then took the nearest course to Ulster.  
Through Meath and by the great high road of Assal  
They went; and crossed the Finnglass, Delt, and Delind;  
And so drew near the Ultonian outer bounds.  
On high Ardcullin, at the pillar-stone  
Which marks the boundary of Ulster, soon  
Two scouts arrived, the sons of Renc of Croohan.  
Their names were Err and Inn-yel: and the names  
Of those who drove their chariots, Frae and Fohnam.  
The function these men had was, to precede  
The hosts in every hosting and encampment,  
Protecting all the clasps, blankets, and bratts,  
Brought by the royal sons, from getting soilure



Through dust or mire raised by the moving hosts.  
These now, arriving on Ardcullin, gazed  
Abroad upon the trackless, unknown land—  
To them all strange and trackless and unknown—  
The land of Ulster. They began to see,  
Then, that around that boundary pillar-stone  
Steeds had been grazing. On the northern side  
The grass was cropped away e'en with its roots  
From out the earth. Upon the southern side  
The earth was licked away down to the stones  
And flags beneath the grass. And then they saw,  
Hooping the thick part of the pillar-stone,  
A new-made spancel-withe, made from an oakling  
New-felled and twisted: and a graven inscription  
In ogam was upon the withe. At that,  
They sat and rested; and their men of music  
Played to them till the host should come. First Fergus  
Arrived upon that height. They gave the withe  
Into his hand: and Fergus read the ogam  
Engraven upon the withe. When Maev arrived,  
She asked, "Why wait you here?" "We wait," said Fergus,  
"Owing to yonder withe. There is an ogam  
Engraven on it." Fergus gave the withe  
Into the hands of Maev's own Druids. Then  
He said, "Good Druids, here is a spancel-withe.  
Whom names it to us? What now is its secret?  
What number threw it there, few or a host?  
Will it work injury to these great hosts  
If they shall journey past it? Find, O Druids,  
The secret of the withe." Whereon the Druids  
Answered:—"This withe is a delay of chieftains,  
Misfortune unto fighters, fierce in import.  
By one man it was flung, who, using only  
One hand, one eye, one foot, felled from the forest  
The sapling tree, and firmly twisted it  
Into this withe and wrote the ogam. And now  
'Tis gass to all your hosts to pass yon stone

Without their spending here one night encamped,  
Unless some man amongst your hosts can make  
A spancel-withe like this one, using only  
One hand, one eye, one foot, and shaping it  
From the one stick. And thus the ogam closes:—  
‘And I prohibit my dear Master, Fergus,  
From making it.’” “I give my word,” said Fergus,  
“If ye shall set that spancel-withe at nought,  
Insulting him who made it, if—that is—  
Ye neither camp one night upon these bounds,  
Nor see that some one from among yourselves  
Construct an equal withe, using one foot,  
One eye, one hand, as this one was constructed,  
Then, wheresoever ye may lie to-night,  
In house or doon or lodgment underground,  
That hero will for certain find you out;  
And some of you will pale in red death-pools  
Ere comes the hour of rising in the morn.”

“Not that,” said Maev, “is it, which pleases us—One  
to take blood from us and redden us  
On our first entering yon foreign Fifth,  
The Ulster Fifth. Rather it pleases us  
To draw first-blood ourselves.” Al-yill then spake.  
“We will not violate this withe,” said he.  
“We will not violate the kingly hero,  
Who made the withe: we will not cross this height.  
Into the neck of yonder wide, great forest  
To southward, we will go till morning. There  
Our camp and our encampment shall be made.”

The hosts turned southward then. With their strong swords  
They hewed the wood before them, hewing so  
A road-path for their chariots. Slahta, therefore,  
“Hewn road,” that place is named. In Cool Shibrilly,  
Just where the Little Partry is, it is,  
South-west of Cennannus of Kings. That night  
A heavy snow fell round the men of Erin.  
So much it was, it mounted to men’s shoulders;

It reached the thick parts and the thighs of steeds,  
And reached their chariot shafts. One even floor  
Were the Five Fifths of Erin with that snow  
That night. And no pavilions and no booths  
And huts were made that night. There was no service  
Of food and ale; no eating or regalement  
Was there; and no one of the men of Erin  
That night knew whether 'twas his friend or foe,  
Who was next man to him, till the light came  
At rising-hour upon the morrow. Surely  
The men of Erin ne'er before had found  
A night in camp wherein they had more hardness  
And hardship to endure than they endured  
That night in Cool Shibrilly. On the morrow,  
As the sun rose and flashed along the snow,  
The four Great Fifths of Erin started onward;  
And from that territory to another  
They passed; they crossed the boundary, and passed  
Into the land of Ulster. Then those two,  
Who e'er were wont to go before the hosts—  
On every hosting and on every foray,  
In every pass and gap and river-ford—  
Inn-yel and Err, to wit, two of Maev's people,  
Rode onward now as always. And each hoped  
He might himself be first to find and slay  
That warrior who had flung the withe; and thus  
Might gain much praise and fame. The hosts moved eastward;  
They crossed the Duv, the Ohawn, and the Caha,  
The Cromma and the Thromma and Fo-dromma  
Which flow into the Boyne. They came to Slane;  
And passed the field of Slane, and reached Drum Leek;  
And entered on the Pass through the great forest,  
Northward of Knowth of Kings. There something chanced.  
Those folks who were to vanward of the hosts  
Perceived the chariots of swift Err and Inn-yel  
Returning toward them, and the bloody forms  
Of Err and Inn-yel headless, and the forms

Of their two charioteers, Fohnam and Frae,  
Headless, upon the chariots; and the blood  
From the four headless necks flowed o'er the wicker  
And frame-parts of the chariots. At that sight  
The vanguard halted; all the hosts were put  
To fear and dread and weapon-shuddering.  
Maev, then, with Fergus and the seven Mahn-yas  
And seven sons of Mahga, reached the front  
Which halted; and Maev asked, "What is this here?"  
"Not hard to tell," said all; "these are the steeds  
Of that small band which ever went before us  
On every hosting and on every foray,  
In every pass and gap, river and ford.  
Here are the bodies of the heroes, headless."

Advice was shaped thereafter; and it seemed  
Certain to them that this was evidence  
Of numbers; and that some great host was there;  
And that it was the Ultonians who had come  
Into that place; and this was the advice  
There shaped by them:—namely, to send from them  
Cormac Conlingish son of Conor son  
Of Fahtna Fahee, that he might find out  
Who held the ford in front of them. They said,  
That e'en should the Ultonian hosts be there  
Upon that ford, they would not slay the son  
Of their own Ulster king. Cormac Conlingish  
The son of Conor son of Fahtna Fahee  
Then went from them to see who held the ford;  
And twenty hundred and ten hundred men  
Armed, made the force who went with him. He reached  
The turlough 'mid the forest, and the ford  
Whereby to pass that water; and he saw  
Nothing, save, lonely 'mid the water there,  
A four-pronged shaft, from every point whereof  
A head of one of those four slain dropped blood  
Down to the joining of the prongs and down  
Thence to the water's current. And he saw

Out of the ford, eastward, beyond, the ruts  
Of a chariot, and the hoof-prints of two steeds,  
The track-marks of one man. The chiefs of Erin  
Came to the ford; and all began to gaze  
On that pronged shaft; and on them all was wonder  
As to who could have placed the trophy there.  
“What name with you was on this ford, O Fergus,  
Until this hour?” said Al-yill. Fergus said:  
“Ath Greena; but henceforth, till Doom, Ath Greena  
Shall be Ath Gowla. From yon bold, rough deed;  
From yon pronged shaft upon two points of which  
Ye see the heads of In-yel and of Err,  
And on the other two the heads of Frae  
And Fohnam, this famed ford shall now be called  
Ath Gowla, ‘Ford of the forked tree.’” Then Fergus  
Said to Maev’s Druid, “O Druid, Pleasing One,  
What is yon ogam on the shaft? And were they  
Few or a host who dug this turlough-bed,  
Planting it there?” The Druid answered him,  
“That four-pronged tree which I see there, O Fergus,  
By one man it was cut: with one swift sword-sweep  
He cut it, root and branches. And he cast it  
With a choice cast from off the hinder-part  
Of his war-chariot, using one hand alone;  
And its two-thirds went firm into the earth;  
So that one-third of it alone is there  
Outside the earth. And he dug not its road  
Before it with his sword; but through the stones  
And flags and gravel of the turlough-bed  
It pierced its road. And to the men of Erin  
’Tis gass to reach the mid-part of yon ford  
Before one man amongst themselves has drawn it  
Out of its bed, using one hand alone,  
Even as with one hand alone ’twas cast  
Into yon ford but now.” Al-yill then said:  
“There is much wonder and perplexity  
With me, O Fergus, owing to the speed

Wherewith those four were slain." Fergus replied:  
"Fitter it were to marvel at the skill  
Wherewith yon shaft was hurled; and this I tell you—  
If ye shall set that four-pronged tree at nought,  
Insulting him who hurled it—if ye pass  
This ford without that one among yourselves  
Have drawn this shaft, using one hand alone,  
Even as with one hand alone 'twas hurled  
Into the ford but now—then verily  
Wherever ye may make your camp to-night,  
He whom ye so insult will visit you,  
And many will be slain, as these were slain,  
Ere comes the hour of rising in the morn."

"Thou art thyself of these our hosts, O Fergus,"  
Said Maev. "Avert this hindrance. Pluck us up  
This pole from out the ford." "Bring me a chariot,"  
Said Fergus, "Ye shall see whether 'tis true  
That with one curvéd sword-sweep it was cut,  
Both root and head." A chariot then was brought  
To Fergus; and he stood on it, and gave  
A strong pull at the pole: and of the chariot  
He made small bits and pieces. "Bring me a chariot,"  
Said Fergus; and they brought a second chariot  
To Fergus; and he gave a stronger pull  
At the fixed pole, but made small bits and pieces  
And splinters of the chariot. "Bring me a chariot,"  
Cried Fergus. A third chariot then was brought;  
And Fergus put forth powerful strength and effort  
To draw the pole; but made crushed bits and pieces  
And fragments of that chariot. Seven and ten  
Chariots of Connaught, each after each, men brought;  
And of them all, each after each, great Fergus  
Made broken, bruised bits, splinters, and fragments,  
But had not yet been able to drag up  
The pole from midmost of the ford. Then Maev  
Cried to him, interposing: "Good, now, leave it,  
O Fergus. Be no longer breaking down

The chariots of our people. Well we know  
That hadst thou not been with us on this hosting,  
On this occasion, we long since had reached  
The Ultonians, and had driven forth great prey  
Of captives and of kine. And well we know  
Why thou art acting thus. It is to stay  
And to delay the advance of our great hosts,  
Until the Ultonians rise from out their Kesh,  
And haste to give us battle, the great battle,  
The battle of the Táin.” Then Fergus cried,  
“Bring me my own good chariot.” And men brought  
To Fergus his own chariot. He put forth  
The utmost measure of his strength and effort;  
And not a pole or shaft or wheel or frame-bit  
Of that good chariot cried, grated, or groaned.  
Though great the prowess and the hero-strength  
Wherewith the pole was cast into the ford  
By him who cast it, yet with equal strength  
And equal prowess it was now plucked up  
Out of the ford again by that renowned,  
Famed battle-warrior and that hurdle-fence  
Against a hundred, that strong-smiting hammer,  
That foeman of vast hosts, that cutter-off  
Of multitudes, that flaming link, that chief  
Of huge battalions. Fergus drew it up  
With his one hand, steadily, till it reached  
His shoulder’s level; and he took and gave it  
Into the hands of Al-yill. Al-yill gazed  
Upon the pole, and scrutinized it. “True,”  
Said he, “I see that with one cut, one stroke,  
This has been finished, foot and head. This tells us  
The nature and the training of that people  
Toward whom we go. Go we to-day no further;  
But let our tents and booths be placed for us:  
Let pleasant food and ale be served to us:  
Let music and old lays be sung to us:  
Let us have banqueting and mirth. For never

On any hosting did the men of Erin  
Meet with a night of camping in a camp,  
Wherein they had more dolour to endure  
Than they endured last night in Cool Shibrilly  
In the thick-driving snow.”

A camp was made

Beside Ath Gowla then. Bondmen and serfs  
From out the forest carried kindling-wood  
For fires, and young trees and bending boughs  
For bothies and for shelters: all began  
To broil their food and to make hot their ale.  
Maev made the circuit of the camp: whereon,  
She, seeing that thronged camp within the bounds  
Of Ulster, much exulted. “For when Conor  
Hears of this thing,” said she, “’twill be to him  
A fire within his heart, a gnawing cancer  
Beside his girdle.” So Maev thought, exulting.  
And Al-yill spake to Frae the son of Eedath.  
“O Frae,” said Al-yill, “bring thy three musicians—  
Thy three melodious and far-famed musicians—  
And let them play for us.” “Yea, let them play,”  
Frae said; and then those harpers were led forth.  
And the first harper touched his strings and played  
The mournful Goltree, the deep weeping-song,  
Until twelve men amongst Maev’s household troops,  
Hearing it, died with wailing and with grief.  
The second harper touched his strings and played  
The merry Gantree, the fresh laughing-song,  
So that the men around forgot their woe  
In laughter, and enjoyment, and delight.  
Last, the third harper touched his strings and played  
The Sooantree, the low, sweet sleeping-song,—  
Until on all the weary men around  
A sleep of soothingness descended. So,  
Slept those o’er-weary hosts. Howbeit, not yet  
Slept the great chieftains; but in Al-yill’s tent  
Of ample wideness, round the glowing brands



Assembled, they conversed. Then Al-yill spake,  
The while they sat thus in the kingly tent,—  
“There is with me,” said he, “marvel and wonder  
As to who came to-day unto these bounds,  
Slaying those four who ever went before us  
On every hosting. Tell us, is it likely  
That it was Conor son of Fahtna Fahee,  
High-king of Ulster?” “Verily,” said Fergus,  
“It is not likely. Had it been great Conor  
Who came there, there had come along with him  
Those culled, choice bands and troops, which are the best  
Amongst the men of Erin, and which serve him  
Continually. Though the men of Erin,  
Together with the men of Alba, Britain,  
And Saxon-land should gather in one stead,  
One meeting-place, one course, one camp, one hill,  
Over against him, he would give them battle;  
Before him they would be defeated, scattered,  
And not o’er him would they gain victory.”

“Who, then,” asked Al-yill, “was it? Is it likely  
That it was Cooscree Mend, the son of Conor,  
From Innish Cooscree?” “Nay, it is not likely,”  
Fergus replied, “for had it been the son  
Of the High-king who came there, there had come  
Together with him all those sons of kings  
And sons of chieftains who are ever with him  
In tutelage and training. Though the men  
Of Erin, with the men of Alba, Britain,  
And Saxon-land were gathered in one stead  
Over against him, he would give them battle  
With courage, and he would not flee before them.”

“Who was it, then?” said Al-yill. “Is it likely  
That it was Owen son of Doorha king  
O’er wooded Farney?” “Nay, not so,” said Fergus.  
“Had it been he, he would have brought with him  
His goodly forces of the men of Farney:  
He would have stayed to fight a hard-fought battle.”

“Who was it, then?” said Al-yill. “Thinkest thou  
That it was Keltar son of Oohider  
Who came there?” “Nay, in sooth, not he,” said Fergus.  
“He is a bruising quern-stone to the foes  
Of all the Fifth: he is a head of battle:  
He is an oaken door against the foes  
Of all his country! Though the men of Alba,  
With men of Britain and of Saxon-land,  
Together with the men of Erin all,  
From west to east, from south to north, should meet  
In the one stead, one doon, one camp, one hill,  
Over against him, he would give them battle:  
Before him they would be dispersed and scattered,  
And not o’er him would they gain victory.”

“Who was it, then, that came unto these bounds?”  
Al-yill exclaimed. “I know not,” Fergus said;  
“Unless, indeed, there came that little lad,  
My fosterling and Conor’s fosterling,  
Whom we all called Cucullin of the Forge.”  
“Ah!” Al-yill said, “full many a time in Croohan  
I heard thee speak of that young child. Well, then,  
What may his age be now?” “’Tis not his age  
At all that matters to you,” Fergus said,  
“He was more celebrated for his actions  
When he was but a babe, than even now  
At his full seventeen years.” “How, then,” said Maev,  
“Have you among the Ultonians now some youth  
Of a like age with him, who is yet harder  
In combats and encounters?” “No,” said Fergus,  
And spake with vehemence. And as they sat  
At pleasant feasting in the kingly tent,  
And drank the sweet, enlivening wine which Maev  
Had brought with her from Croohan, he began  
Passionately to praise and glorify  
His foster-child Cucullin. “No,” said Fergus,  
“Ye will not find among the Ulster youths  
Another like him. ’Midst all other youths,

He is a ram amid the flocks, a bull  
'Mid timorous herds, a high and flaming torch  
Of a king's house amidst the little lights  
Of shepherd-booths. Yea, and I say this, too:—  
Ye will not find over to northward there,  
Amongst the mighty warriors of this land,—  
Hard, dire sledge-hammers, barricades of battle,  
Huge gates against flood-waters, though these be,—  
Ye will not find among them all, I say,  
One of more firm resistance in a fight,  
Of greater vehemence in rapid onrush,  
Of faculty more airy, swift, and fresh  
In varied weapon-play, feats, and exploits  
Than is Cucullin. No, ye will not find  
Over against you, in this land ye enter,  
Another of like power, or a youth  
Who, in illustrious noble qualities,—  
In trophy-taking, in the feat of nine  
O'er pointed weapons, in address, in valour,  
In voice, in sweet and skilful utterance,  
In charm, in courtesy, in all distinction,—  
Attains unto the third part or the fourth  
Of that which is attained by that distinguished  
And noble Hound, Cucullin.” “Of this all,”  
Said Maev, “we will not make too much. One body  
Is all he has; and it, like any other,  
Receiving sore death-wounds will die. Moreover,  
It is the age of a but just-grown girl  
That ye attribute to him. Not for long  
Will this young beardless stripling ye describe  
Hold out against our armies!” “Think not so,”  
Said Fergus, “for the deeds of that young lad  
Were even more great and manly at the time  
When he was but a babe than even now  
At his full seventeen years.” Then Al-yill said:  
“On entering a strange and foreign land,  
To hear the adventures and the histories

Of the famed, warlike tribes toward whom one goes,  
Is pleasant and a pastime. Tell us, then,  
The adventures of this child ye speak of.”

Fergus

Began to tell the adventures and exploits  
Wrought by his foster-child in those glad days  
Ere the Black Exile; and with joy the tale  
Of those old, happy days was taken up  
In turn by Cormac and by Feeaha.



“FERGUS RELATES THE YOUTHFUL ADVENTURES OF CUCULLIN.”

## BOOK V

### BOOK V

That little lad (said Fergus) was reared up  
On Moy Mweerhevna, in the noble house  
Where dwelt his father, and his mother, namely,  
In bright Doon Dalgan. There men told him tales  
About the boys in Avvin. For 'twas thus  
Conor was wont to spend his sovereignty  
Since first he took the sovereignty: at morn,  
On rising, he adjusted and arranged  
All business of that Fifth; and then he dealt  
The day in three. One third of it he passed  
Watching the boys upon the green of Avvin  
Perform their games of skill. One third he passed  
Playing himself at feehill and at branduv.  
And the last third he passed consuming food  
And ale, till sleep unto all men drew down;  
Whereat the skilful men of music came  
To gladden and to soothe them to their sleep.  
Aye, though we now be exiled (Fergus said),  
Though Conor dealt me a most grievous wrong,  
And a most grievous insult,—I aver,  
That not in noble Erin, not in Alba,  
Is there another hero-king, the like  
Of wise, red-sworded Conor. Well, the child  
Was told the tidings and adventurous tales  
Of that incorporated band of youths  
In Avvin Maha. So, the little lad  
Besought his mother to permit him straightway  
To go and play upon the playing-green  
Of Avvin Maha. “Nay, it is too soon,”  
The mother answered. “Thou must wait awhile,

Until some champion of the mighty champions  
Of Ulster, or some house-friend of good Conor's,  
Come to convey thee safely, and to put  
The firm protection of the boys upon thee."  
"It seems to me too long to wait till then,  
O Mother," said the child; "I may not wait.  
But teach me now the quarter and direction  
Where Avvin is." His mother answered him:  
"'Tis far from thee,—the place where Avvin is;  
For all the lone hill-region of Slieve Foo-id  
Lies between thee and Avvin." But the child  
Said: "I will try to find it." And he went,  
Leaving the sheltering doon, and took with him  
All his play-weapons; for he took with him  
His small bronze hurley and his silver ball,  
His feathered dart for shooting, and his spear,  
With butt flame-hardened; and he straightway fell  
To shortening and enlivening of his way  
With these child's-weapons. With his hurley first  
He struck the ball, compelling it to spring  
To a far distance. Fleetly he let fly  
The hurley in its track, with the like force;  
And then he flung the dart, and then the spear.  
And lastly, with a playful rush, he flew  
After them all; and caught the hurley first;  
And then the ball, and then the feathered dart;  
Nor did the charred butt of his playing-spear  
Ere reach the ground; but by the point he caught it  
While it was whirling in mid-air. So, gaily,  
Athwart the lonely hills, he came at length  
To glorious Avvin Maha.

And he saw  
The green, cleared plain of Avvin, where the boys  
Were gathered at their sports. Thrice fifty boys  
He saw, commanded nobly by Folloon  
The son of Conor, at their game of hurling  
Upon the green of Avvin. Then the child

Made for the green; and, all unbidden, he went  
Amongst the boys to play with them. He grasped  
Their ball betwixt his legs and held it there;  
Nor let it travel higher than his knees  
Upwards, nor lower than his ankle-bones  
Downward; but he did so manœuvre it  
That not one player of them all could reach it  
With stroke or thrust or blow; and so he brought it  
Over the goal's brink; and he won the goal  
From all those others; and they stared at him  
Befooled and dazed by utter wonderment.  
Thereat upspake Folloon the son of Conor:  
"Good now, O youths! fall on that youngster there.  
Through me his death shall come. 'Tis gass to you  
To let an outside youth come to your green,  
Unless he courteously hath placed himself  
Beneath your firm protection. Fall on him;  
We know he is the son of some Ultonian.  
'Tis not the rule for your compatriots  
To intrude into your game without first seeking  
Your safeguard and protection." Then it was  
That all at once, and moving all together,  
They fell upon the child. Aloft they raised  
Their three times fifty hurleys, to strike blows  
Upon his crown. He, standing all alone,  
Lifted his one small playing-club, and parried  
Their three times fifty hurleys. Then they took  
Their three times fifty balls; and all at once  
They cast them at the child. He with his fists,  
And with his fore-arms, and his palms, put back  
The three times fifty balls. They lastly aimed  
Their three times fifty playing-spears, with butts  
Flame-hardened; but he raised his little shield,  
Which was designed for childish feats of skill,  
And fended off the three times fifty spears.  
And then it was that with swift energy  
He turned on them, attacking; and he laid

Fifty kings' sons upon the ground beneath him.  
Five more of them (said Fergus, telling the tale)  
Came up between myself and wide-eyed Conor,  
Where we sat playing feehill on the board  
Of Conor, namely, the bright Kenncaem. There  
The little lad came, rushing after them.  
And Conor, with his kingly hands, laid hold  
Of the child's fore-arms; and he said to him:  
"Halt, little lad, I see thou art ungentle  
Towards thy companions here!" "I have much cause,"  
The child replied. "I came from a far land;  
And when I came, they did not give to me  
A guest's good welcome." "Why, who art thou then?"  
The king inquired; and the child answered: "I  
Am little Setanta son of Sooaltim,  
And son of thine own sister, Dectora;  
And not from thee did I expect to find  
Reception like to this." "Why, little lad,"  
Said Conor, "Didst thou then not know the law  
Which binds the corps of boys? 'Tis gass to them  
To let a youth of our own country come  
Into their games, till he hath placed himself  
Beneath their firm protection." "Nay, in truth,"  
The child replied; "for had I known their law,  
I should have had some fear and care before them."  
"Well, youths," said Conor, "now receive the child  
Beneath your firm protection." And they said:  
"We will receive him." So the little lad  
Went underneath the safeguard of the youths;  
And the good king released him. But the child  
Turned on them once again, attacking them  
With energy and violence, and laid  
Fifty kings' sons upon the ground beneath him.  
Their fathers thought that they were stilled in death.  
It was not so; but they were stilled by terror  
Of those great forehead-blows, and middle-blows,  
And blows from underneath, which with swift skill



He dealt against them. "How now?" Conor said,  
Checking the boy; "what art thou doing now?"  
"I swear by all the gods of my own folk,"  
Exclaimed the child, "unless they place themselves  
Beneath my safeguard and my firm protection,  
Even as I was forced to place myself  
Beneath their safeguard and their firm protection,  
I will not stay my hands from striking them  
Till I have laid them all upon the ground!"  
"Well, little lad," said Conor, "take the youths  
Beneath thy safeguard." "I accept them gladly,"  
The child said. And those three times fifty lads  
Passed underneath the safeguard and protection  
Of the young child, Setanta.

"Now (said Fergus,  
Ending his tale), if as a mere young child,  
At ending of the fifth year from his birth,  
He overthrew those sons of kings and heroes,  
Before the very gate of their own liss,  
And doon, and city—namely, of Avvin Maha—  
Is there a marvel or a wonder now,  
E'en though he come unto a boundary,  
And set a four-pronged pole into a stream,  
And slay a man, or two, or three, or four,  
Now that he hath fulfilled his seventeen years,  
On this, your Táin, to take the bull of Cooley?"

Cormac Conlingish, now, the son of Conor,  
Began to speak; he said: "That child we speak of,  
At ending of the next succeeding year,  
Performed his next great deed." "What deed was that?"  
Asked Al-yill. Cormac said:

Cullan the smith  
Lived in the land of Ulster. He prepared  
A feast for Conor; and he went to Avvin  
To bid the king unto his feast. He said:  
"O king, bring with thee but a few. Not land

Or territory have I; but alone  
My hammer and my anvil and my tongs,  
And my own two skilled hands.” The kindly king  
Said he would go to him, and bring but few.

Cullan went back unto his doon, to arrange  
And to set forth his food and ale. The king  
Abode in Avvin till day’s closing. Then  
He donned his light, free garb of travelling,  
And went down to the green to say farewell  
To the young band of boys. When Conor came  
Out on the green, he witnessed a thing there  
Which caused him wonder. Three times fifty boys  
Defended one end of the green; one boy  
Stood at the other end; and that one boy  
From those thrice fifty others gained the goal.  
After, they played that hole-game, which is played  
By custom on the green of Avvin Maha;  
And first it was their turn to drive the balls,  
And his turn to defend. Thrice fifty balls  
Arrived before the hole; but not one ball  
Shot past him, reaching to the hole itself.  
And next it was their turn to guard the hole,  
And his to drive the balls; and, one by one,  
He safely launched the three times fifty balls  
Into that hole, without mistake or error.  
Thirdly, they played at reaving of their clothes  
From one another; and he quickly reft  
Their three times fifty coverings. As for them—  
Not so much as the pin which held his bratt  
Could they deprive him of. They lastly played  
At oversetting of each other. He  
Laid those thrice fifty on the ground, while they  
Could not so much as win firm hold of him.  
And Conor wondered while he watched the child.  
“O men-at-arms,” he said, “if but this child  
Come to excel in manly deeds, as now  
He doth excel in these, his deeds of childhood,

It will be well for this our land, and well  
For all the lands of Ulster!" "'Tis not right  
To doubt that he will so excel," said Fergus.  
"E'en as his limbs will grow, so will his deeds."  
"Let the young child be summoned," said the king,  
"And he shall go with us to drink this feast,  
To which we go." The child was summoned then.  
"Well, little one," said Conor, "wilt thou come  
With us to drink this feast?" "Nay," said the child.  
"Why, how is that?" the king said. He replied:  
"Those, my companions, the brave band of youths,  
Have not yet had their fill of games and sports.  
I will not leave till they have had their fill."  
"It is too long for us to wait till then,"  
The king replied; "we cannot wait for thee."  
"Wait not," the child said. "Go, and I will follow."  
"Thou dost not know that road at all, my son,"  
The King replied, demurring; but the child  
Said: "I will follow on thy chariot-trail,  
And on the track left by the host and steeds."

Thereafter Conor went unto the house  
Of Cullan the artificer. With honour  
The king was welcomed; and the guests were ranged  
In keeping with each rank and art and law,  
And noble breeding and fair habitude.  
And green-topped rushes, paling towards the roots,  
Were strown beneath them; and all straightway fell  
To quaffing and to merriment. "O king!"  
Cullan inquired of Conor, "tell me now,  
Hast thou appointed e'er a one to come  
To-night unto this doon?" "Nay," said the king,  
"I have not done so"; for he had forgotten  
That the young lad was going to follow him.  
"Why dost thou ask?" said Conor. Cullan answered:  
"'Tis that I have a ban-dog, huge and fierce,  
To guard the doon throughout the long, dark night.  
When he is loosened from his hound-chain, none

Dare stay in the one cantred with him, he  
Making his nightly circuit round the doon.  
In him there dwells the vigour of an hundred;  
And he knows no one save myself alone.”  
Then Conor said, “Let the good hound be loosened  
That he may guard the cantred.” So that hound  
Was loosened from his hound-chain; and he made  
His circuit of the cantred, and then came  
Unto that bench whence he was wont to guard  
The doon and dwellings; and he couched thereon,  
With head on paws, and he was fierce and cruel,  
And wild and savage, and filled with rage and ire  
Toward everyone who would approach that stead.

Now, with regard to the fair band of youths,  
They ’bode at Avvin till the hour for parting;  
Then each of them went home unto the house  
Of his own father and mother, or the house  
Of his kind foster-parents. Then the child  
Followed with speed upon the chariot-trail  
To reach the house of Cullan. And he fell  
To shortening and enlivening of his way  
By sporting with his small toy-weapons. Soon  
He reached the green which spread around the doon  
Where Conor was with Cullan; and he cast  
His weapons all in front of him, reserving  
His ball alone. And the great dog perceived  
The child approaching; and he uttered forth  
His snarling growl, so that men heard that growl  
Throughout the region round. It did not seem  
That he would even rend his prey; it seemed  
He would engulf it whole within the breadth  
Of his huge throat and his wide breast. The child  
Had not one weapon of defence before him.  
But, on the instant, with his playing-ball,  
He made a choice, swift cast into the jaws  
Of the great hound, and into his huge throat,  
And through his inward part and entrails; then,

While the great hound was staggering helpless, swift  
He seized him by the feet; and with the body  
Dealt such a blow against the pillar-stone  
Which stood upon the green, that from his hands  
It fell in dead and scattered pieces. Now,  
Conor had heard the belling of the hound.  
“Alas! O heroes,” he cried out, “alas!  
That e’er we came to drink this feast!” “Why so?”  
Asked everyone; and Conor spake with haste:  
“There is a little gillie whom I bade  
To follow us. He is my sister’s son,  
Setanta son of Sooaltim; and now  
He has fallen by the hound!” All in an instant  
Rose the renowned Ultonians; though the gates  
Were flung wide open, out o’er the ring-fence  
Which topped the ramparts, each man stormed in haste.  
And swiftly though each went, swiftlier than all  
Went Fergus; and he seized the little lad  
From the ground’s surface, and he hoisted him  
On to his own broad shoulder; and he bore him  
Into the presence of Conor. Cullan came  
Out on the green, and saw his noble hound  
In its dead, scattered pieces. Then his heart  
Made mighty blows against his chest; he went  
Inside into the house forthwith and said:  
“Welcome, thy coming, child, now for the sake  
Of thy most noble mother and thy father.  
For thine own sake thou art unwelcome!” “Why,  
What grudge hast thou against the lad?” asked Conor,  
“It was a day of evil fate,” said Cullan,  
“That day when I set forth my ale to make  
A feast for thee, O King. To-day my substance  
Is substance wasted; and my livelihood  
Is a lost livelihood. Thou, little lad,  
Of one of mine own kindly household folk  
Hast robbed me now; for thou hast slain the guardian  
Of all my goods and of my flocks and herds.”

Then the child spake: "Be thou not wroth with me,  
My master Cullan. I will speak the doom  
And the just judgment now upon myself."

"What judgment wilt thou speak upon thyself?"

Conor inquired; and the boy replied:

"If in all Erin there exist a whelp  
Of that hound's seed, by me he shall be reared,  
Till he be able like his sire. Meanwhile,  
I will be Hound of Watching at this doon,  
And will defend the flocks and goods and kine."

"Good is the judgment thou hast given, my son,"

Said Conor. "And I think Cathbad himself  
Could not have given a better. Wherefore, now,  
Hence, from this hour, I thee will designate  
*Cucullin, Hound of Cullan.*" "Nay, not so,"  
Besought the child. "I like my own name more,  
Namely, Setanta son of Soo-altim."

But Cathbad spake. "O little lad," he said,

"Reject not this. It is thy hero-name.

The men of Erin and the men of Alba,  
Telling their famous tales, shall speak that name.  
Long as the wave-great sea shall girdle Erin  
Men's lips shall speak it; yea, the mouths of men  
In Erin and in Alba shall be full  
Of that renowned name." "Then," said the child,  
"I take the name. I take it willingly."

And so it came to pass that from that hour  
Wherein he slew the hound, there clung to him  
This most distinguished name, Cucullin.

So,

If as a little lad he did that deed  
(Cormac Conlingish said, ending his tale),  
If at the end of six years from his birth,  
He slew that ban-dog, which the hosts and troops  
Of all the cantred did not dare to approach,  
Is there a marvel or a wonder, now,—  
E'en though he come unto a boundary,

And set a four-pronged pole into a stream,  
And slay a man, or two, or three, or four,—  
He having now fulfilled his seventeen years,  
On this, your Táin, to take the kine of Cooley?

Next, Feeaha the son of Conall Carna  
Took up the tale. “That little child,” said he,  
“At ending of the next succeeding year,  
Performed his third and most renowned deed.”  
“What deed was that?” asked Al-yill. Feeaha  
Made answer, saying:

Cathbad, the good Druid,  
One day, north-eastward of resplendent Avvin,  
Was giving knowledge, wisdom, and instruction  
To his own pupils. Eight there were around him  
Of those who learnt druidic art and lore.  
And one of these asked of great Cathbad then  
Whether it chanced that any special charm  
Or mystic virtue rested on that day  
Wherein they were. And Cathbad straight replied:  
“The little lad who shall take arms to-day  
Will win great fame and glory, though his life  
Will be but brief and transitory.” Now  
Our little lad, playing his childish games  
To the south-west of Avvin, heard this thing;  
And straightway he flung down his childish arms  
And his toy-weapons; and with speed he sought  
The sleeping-house of Conor. “Every good  
Be thine, O King of Warriors!” cried the child.  
“That is an asker’s greeting,” the king said;  
“What dost thou ask, child?” “To take arms to-day,”  
The boy cried breathlessly. “Who taught thee that?”  
Questioned the king. “Great Cathbad,” said the child  
“If it was Cathbad, I must not refuse thee,”  
Conor replied, and straight bestowed on him  
An outfit of two spears with sword and shield.  
The boy, to test their virtue, brandished these,

Bent them, and bowed them; and he made of them  
Small bits and broken pieces. Then the king  
Gave him two other spears with sword and shield;  
And these he likewise brandished, bent, and bowed:  
Making them bits and pieces. So the king  
Led him unto that house wherein were stored  
The fourteen suits of arms which he reserved  
For service of the corporate band of youths.  
—To this end he reserved them: that each youth  
On first assuming arms might be invested  
By the High-king himself, and so win luck  
And happy fortune for his arms thereafter.  
Howbeit, of these fourteen suits of arms,  
The little lad, testing them one by one,  
Made broken bits and pieces. Last, the king  
Gave him his own two spears, and his own shield,  
And his own sword; and the boy brandished them,  
And curved and bent them; and he doubled them,—  
Yea, even till head met butt and point met hilt, and yet  
They brake not, but endured him. “These are good!”  
Exclaimed the child; “these are a match for me!  
Long live the king, whose arms and gear these are!  
Long last the land he reigns o’er!” It was then  
That Cathbad, the good Druid, came. He asked,  
Dismayed: “Is yonder child taking on arms?”  
“He is,” replied the king; and Cathbad said:  
“Not for his mother’s son would I have chosen  
This day, of all the days, to be the day  
Of his first taking arms!” “How?” said the king,  
“Was it not thou thyself who taught him this?”  
“Not I,” said Cathbad. Then the king, in wrath,  
Turned to the child, saying: “What ailed thee, then,  
Thou changeling imp, that thou shouldst lie to me  
About this thing?” “Nay, be not wroth with me,  
My guardian, Conor,” said the child. “In truth  
It was great Cathbad who incited me.  
For one of his own pupils asked him, saying:



‘What charm or luck pertains unto this day  
Wherein we are?’—And Cathbad answered him:

‘The little lad who shall take arms to-day  
Will win great fame and glory, but his life  
Shall quickly pass; and early he will die.’”

“He tells the truth of me,” said Cathbad. “So  
Thou, little child, shalt win great fame and glory,  
But early thou shalt perish!” “What reck I,”  
Exclaimed the lad, “though I remain in being  
But one day and one night; so that my deeds  
Live after me, and my exploits be told?”

“Well, little lad,” said Cathbad, “since ’tis so,  
Arise and mount a chariot! ’Tis thy first.”  
He leapt on to a chariot; and he shook  
And bent it round about him, testing it;  
And brake it into fragments. Then a second  
He likewise brake; and then the seventeen  
New chariots that by Conor were held reserved  
For service of the corporate band of youths,  
The little lad, testing them one by one,  
Brake likewise into bits. “These are not good,  
These chariots! My kind guardian, Conor, not  
From these may I obtain my fitting match!”  
So spake the child. Then Conor called out, loudly:  
“Where now is Ivor son of Reeangowra?”

“Here am I,” Ivor answered. Conor said:  
“Harness my own two steeds there, and prepare  
My own war-chariot.” Then the charioteer  
Prepared the chariot; and the little lad  
Mounted it; and he shook and bent it round him;  
And it endured him; and it brake not. “Good!”  
The child cried gaily. “This is my fit match!”

“Well, little lad,” said Ivor, “let the steeds  
Be now turned out to graze.” “It is too soon,”  
Replied the little lad. “Drive now ahead,  
Three times round Avvin Maha; for to-day  
Is my first day of taking arms; and I

Must now win fortune for my deeds." They drove  
Three times round Avvin Maha. "Let the steeds  
Be now turned out to graze," said Ivor. "Nay!  
'Tis still too soon," the boy said. "Drive ahead!  
That my companions, the brave band of youths,  
May speak their blessing to me, on this day,  
The first day of my taking arms." They drove,  
And reached the plain where the boys played; and all  
Shouted, "Arms hast thou really?" "Yea!" he said;  
And then they gave to him their blessing, saying:  
"Victory, first-wounding, every triumph,  
Be thine henceforward! But to us it seems  
Too soon for thee to leave us. We shall miss thee  
In all our sports and games." "Nay!" said the child;  
"I am not yet to part from you at all.  
'Twas but to win a happy sign of fortune  
That I took arms for the first time to-day."

"Now, little lad," said Ivor, "let the steeds  
Be turned to graze." "It is, indeed, too soon,  
O Ivor," said the child. "And tell me now,  
What is the name of yonder great high-road,  
Which passes there; and whither does it go?"

"Why, how can that concern thee?" Ivor said.  
"Howbeit, I see thou art a talking youth,  
A dallier and a trifler." "It seems well  
To me," the child replied with dignity,  
"To ask, concerning one of the chief roads  
Of Ulster, where it leads to." Ivor so  
Replied to him: "The road, then, leads straight on  
To Ath na Foraire, the Ford of Watching,  
On wild Slieve Foo-id." "Wherefore is it named  
The Ford of Watching, knowest thou, perchance?"  
The boy made question. "To be sure, I know!"  
Said Ivor. "Daily there some man-at-arms  
Of the Ultonians keeps good watch and ward,  
Guarding the way, lest outside warriors come  
To challenge the Ultonians. If such come,

It is his duty to do combat with them  
For the whole Fifth. Howbeit, if men of verse  
And science pass there, passing out of Ulster  
Indignant at their treatment, 'tis his duty  
To soothe them with rich gifts, and so to save  
The honour of all Ulster. And, again,  
If men of verse arrive there, entering  
Rich Ulster, 'tis his duty to provide  
Safe-conduct for them to the pillared couch  
Of Conor; so that their own songs and lays  
May be the first that shall be sung in Avvin  
When they arrive there." "Knowest thou, perchance,  
O Ivor," said the child, "what man to-day  
Keeps watch upon that ford?" "I know," said Ivor,  
"'Tis combat-great, courageous Conall Carna,  
The son of Avver-guin, a king of heroes  
Amongst the battle-heroes of all Erin."  
"Drive thou ahead, O gillie," said the child,  
"That we may reach that ford." They drove ahead,  
And reached the ford whereon great Conall was.  
"Has yonder one been armed?" asked Conall. "Truly,  
That is just it," said Ivor. "Well," said Conall,  
"Victory and trophies and first-wounding  
Be thine, O little lad; but to my mind  
'Twas far too soon to arm thee; for indeed  
Thou art not fit for deeds. However, though,  
If it be merely to provide protection  
To any who may come unto these bounds,  
It is enough for any who may come  
Unto these bounds; for the Ultonians all  
Will rise on thy behalf." "What dost thou here,  
My good friend, Conall?" asked the child. "I keep,"  
Conall replied, "incessant watch and ward  
Over all Ulster here." "Rise to thy house,  
O Conall," said the child, "leave me here now  
To keep that watch and ward for Ulster here."  
"Not so, O little lad," Conall replied;

“Thou art not yet of force or skill to combat  
With a trained man-at-arms.” “Then,” cried the child,  
“I will ride past thee straightway toward the south,  
E’en to the Fertas of Loch Ahtra. There  
I will seek out some chance of reddening  
My hands on friends or foemen on this day.”  
“I will go with thee, little lad,” said Conall,  
“To guard thee, that thou mayst not go alone  
Over a boundary.” “Not so,” the child said.  
“Yea, I will go,” said Conall. “The Ultonians  
Would blame me greatly all, did I permit  
Thee all alone to cross a boundary.”  
For Conall then his chariot was prepared:  
His steeds were caught for him; and he rode forth  
To guard the little lad. When Conall’s chariot  
Came thus abreast of his, it to the child  
Became a certainty that even if  
He should obtain a chance for some great deed,  
Great Conall would not let him do the deed.  
He from the ground picked up a handstone, then,  
Which filled his grasp. He made a choice, good cast  
With this against the yoke of Conall’s chariot,  
So that he broke the yoke of Conall’s chariot  
In two; and Conall through the broken yoke  
Fell to the ground, and with the fall his shoulder  
Was cut and wounded. “What caused that, my son?”  
Asked Conall. “It was I,” the child replied.  
“I made the cast to try whether my cast  
Was straight and true, and whether I could aim  
At all, and whether there were yet in me  
The makings of a warrior.” “Venom, then,  
Be on thy cast!” cried Conall. “Venom be  
Upon thyself as well. Leave or leave not  
Thy head amongst thy foes. I now will go  
No further to protect thee.” “That exactly  
Is what I asked of thee,” the child said then;  
“Because ’tis gass to all of you in Ulster

To ride on in the company of one  
Who in such way has done you injury.”  
Conall went north again to keep his watch  
Upon the Ford of Watching in Slieve Foo-id.

As for the little lad, southwards he went,  
E’en to the Fertas of Loch Ahtra; and there  
He waited till day’s ending. Then spake Ivor:  
“If I may dare to say so much to thee,  
My little lad, ’tis time for us to turn  
And journey back to Avvin. There already  
The carving, and the dealing-out and sharing  
Have well begun; and now, whereas for thee  
There is a place reserved, where thou wilt sit  
Between the feet of Conor, there for me  
Is nothing but to be among the jesters  
And messengers and horsemen that belong  
To the great house of Conor. It is time  
That I were back to scramble with them.” “Well,”  
The boy replied, “harness the steeds again.”  
The steeds were harnessed; and the little lad  
Mounted the chariot-seat. “Why, tell me, Ivor,”  
He said, “What hill is yonder hill up there?”  
“That is Slieve Mourne,” said Ivor. “And what cairn  
Is that white cairn I see upon its summit?”  
The child asked. “That is Finncarn of Slieve Mourne,”  
Said Ivor. “It is pleasant at that cairn,”  
The child said. “It is pleasant,” answered Ivor.  
“Then drive ahead, that we may reach that cairn!”  
The boy commanded. “Well, in sooth,” said Ivor,  
“Thou art a dawdling and a lingering youth!  
But this is my first journey with thee. Be it  
My last until the ending of the world,  
If ever we reach Avvin once again!”

Howbeit, soon they came to the white cairn  
Upon the summit of Slieve Mourne. “Now, Ivor,”  
The child said, “teach me Ulster on all sides;  
As yet I do not know my way at all

About this country of my guardian Conor.”

The gillie from that vantage pointed out  
The hills and hillocks and green steep-down fields  
Of Ulster all around. He pointed out  
Its plains and doons and strongholds. “That will do,  
Good Ivor,” said the boy. “And tell me now  
What is the name of yonder square, cleared plain,  
All dappled, and all seamed with vales, that reaches  
Beneath us towards the south?” “That is Moy Bray,”  
Said Ivor. And the boy said: “Point me out  
The doons and buildings and great fortresses  
Of yonder plain.” Then Ivor pointed out  
Taltin and lordly Tara, Knowth and Cletty,  
The Broo of Angus Ōg, and the dark doon  
Where dwelt the sons of Nahta Scaena. “Tell me,”  
The child cried eagerly, “are those the sons  
Of Nahta who are wont to vaunt and boast  
That the whole number of Ultonians living  
Doth not exceed the number they have slain?”  
“They are the same,” said Ivor. “Drive ahead!”  
The child cried joyously. “Away with us,  
That we may reach the doon of Nahta’s sons!”  
“Woe waits thy speech!” said Ivor. “But we know  
’Tis childish folly to give such commands.  
And this is sure,” said Ivor, “whosoever  
May now go thither, it shall not be I.”  
“Living or dead, thou shalt go thither now,”  
The little lad said sternly. “Well, then, living  
I will go southward,” Ivor said, “but dead  
I shall be left beside that doon we know of,  
The doon of Nahta’s sons.” They drove ahead,  
And reached the doon. The little lad leapt down  
From off his chariot, lighting on the green.  
And thus that green was.—In the midst of it  
There stood a pillar-stone; a ring of iron  
Encircled this; and round the ring of iron  
Was cut an ogam script. This was the ogam:

“Whoso arrives upon this green—he holding  
The rank of an armed man—’tis gass to him  
To leave the green, without first challenging  
To combat some one dweller in this doon.”

The child perused the ogam. Then with strength  
He flung his arms around that pillar-stone,  
As though it had been a faggot of small wood,  
And cast it in the pool; and the bright wave  
Laughed over it. “It seems to me,” said Ivor,  
“It is no better there than where it was  
Before; and this is clear to me: that here  
Thou wilt obtain that thing which thou art seeking,  
Namely, thy death and sudden, violent end.”

“Good Ivor,” said the child, “prepare for me  
The blankets of the chariot. I will sleep  
Now for a little while.” “Alas!” said Ivor,  
“This is thy foeman’s country, not some green  
Of gatherings.” Yet obediently he spread  
The blankets of the chariot; and the child  
There, on the foeman’s green, slept his deep sleep.  
And then it was that a dread son of Nahta,  
Namely, great Foill, the first-born son of Nahta,  
Came forth upon the green. “Unharness not  
Those steeds,” he shouted. Ivor quickly said:  
“I did not try to do so. See, their bridles  
Are still within my hand.” “Whose are the steeds?”  
Asked Foill. “They are two piebald steeds of Conor’s,  
The two Cannbracks,” said Ivor. “That is true,”  
Said Foill, “I recognize them. And what man  
Has brought them thus hither across the frontier?”

“It was a tender youth,” Ivor replied,  
“Who in our country first took arms to-day.  
Merely to show his beauty and his form,  
He came unto these marches.” Foill cried out:  
“May it not bring him victory or triumph!  
And if I knew that he were fit for deeds,  
Dead he should journey back, northward, to Avvin,

And not in life.” “He is not fit for deeds,”  
Urged Ivor; “and whoever calls him fit  
Speaks wrongly; for this year, in which we are,  
Is only the seventh year since he was born.”

Just then the little lad lifted his face  
From off the ground, and quickly passed his hand  
Across his face; and, hearing Ivor’s words,  
He flushed from crown to ground. “I am, in truth,  
Fit for great actions and for hero-deeds,”  
He cried. Great Foill replied: “I rather think  
Thou art unfit.” “Thou shalt know what to think  
When once I meet thee at the battle-ford,”  
The child made answer. “Rise now. Fetch thine arms.  
I see that like a coward thou hast come,  
Knowing ’tis not my wont to wound or slay  
Heralds or charioteers, or folk unarmed.”

Then Foill went headlong for his weapons. Ivor  
Said breathlessly: “’Tis fit that thou beware  
Of yonder man, my little lad.” “Why so?”  
The child demanded. Ivor said: “That man  
Is Foill the son of Nahta Scaena. Him  
Nor point nor edge may wound.” “I think, good Ivor,  
It is not fit that thou shouldst so address me,”  
The boy said. “See now. I will set my hand  
To my own dael-feat, namely, to my apple  
Of tempered iron, which shall make its way  
Through his shield’s tract and through his forehead’s tract,  
Hewing a blood-red roadway through his head  
And through his nape, and making a free way  
For the clear air beyond.” Foill son of Nahta  
Came to that combat. The child set his hand  
To his own dael-feat; and he made a cast  
That pierced the shield’s tract, and the forehead’s tract,  
And made a blood-red roadway through the head  
Of Foill the son of Nahta; and Foill fell;  
And then the little lad severed the head  
Clean from the neck, to be his sign and trophy.



The second son of Nahta now came forth,  
Namely, great Toohal son of Nahta. "Well,"  
Cried Toohal, "so thou wouldst exult and triumph  
About this deed!" "Nay," said the child, "not yet  
Have I e'er deemed the slaying of one man  
A cause for triumph or for exultation."  
"This time, at least, thou shalt not boast," said Toohal.  
"By me thou shalt be slain." "Go, fetch thine arms,"  
The boy said. "Like a coward thou hast come,  
Knowing 'tis not my wont to wound or slay  
Heralds or charioteers or folk unarmed."  
And Toohal went for his war-weapons. Ivor  
Said anxiously: "'Tis fit that thou beware  
Of yonder man, my little lad." "Why so?"  
The boy demanded. Ivor said: "That man  
Is Toohal son of Nahta Scaena. Him,  
Unless thou slay him at thy first attempt,  
By thy first blow, first cast, or first strong thrust,  
Thou mayst not slay at all, so great his skill  
In warding off, and parrying, and defence,  
In front of pointed weapons." "My good Ivor,  
It is not fit that thou shouldst so address me,"  
The boy replied. "See, I will set my hand  
To Conor's own great spear, the Venomed Spear,  
And it shall pierce the shield above his breast,  
And pierce the heart within his breast, and break  
Three ribs upon his further side; 'twill be  
A stern, determined cast. It will not be  
A deed of tenderness. For mighty Toohal  
There will be no delightful house of healing,  
Or sick man's bed, until the end of time,  
After that cast." Then Toohal son of Nahta  
Came on the green; and the child set his hand  
To Conor's own great spear, the Venomed Spear,  
Which pierced the shield o'er Toohal's breast, and clove  
The heart within his breast, and broke three ribs.  
And the boy swept his head clear from his neck,

Even or ere his body touched the ground.

And now the last of the three sons of Nahta,  
Namely, swift Fannla, youngest son of Nahta,  
Came forth upon the green. "They were but fools,"  
He cried, "these two, who have encountered thee!"  
"How so?" the boy inquired. "Come!" said Fannla,  
"Down unto yonder water, where thy feet  
Will not touch ground." And Fannla darted thence,  
And out upon the water. "It is fit,"  
Urged Ivor, "that thou be upon thy guard  
Before yon man." "Why so?" the child demanded  
Impatiently. And Ivor said: "That man  
Is Fannla son of Nahta. For this cause  
He bears that name: that with a weasel's swiftness,  
And with the swiftness of a swallow flying,  
He travels o'er the water. In this world  
There is no swimmer who can cope with him."  
"It is not right that thou shouldst warn me so,"  
The boy replied; "for it is known to thee,  
That river which we have at Avvin Maha,  
The green-banked Callan. Once upon a time,  
The band of youths, leaving their games of skill,  
Plunged in the stream; and I held up a lad  
On each one of my shoulders, and a lad  
On each one of my wrists, nor did I wet  
More than my under part." The boy went down  
To wrestle on the stream with Fannla. Quickly  
He flung his fore-arms above Fannla, forcing  
His body downwards, level with the wave;  
And then he struck a powerful downward stroke  
With Conor's sword, severing Fannla's head  
Clear from his neck. He let the body float  
Down the wide stream; but brought the head to shore,  
To be the trophy of his victory.

So were those dreadful foes of Ulster slain;  
And the child gathered up his heads and trophies,  
And gave them to his charioteer; and then,

Hearing the cries of Nahta, their fierce mother,  
And tumult of men issuing from the doon,  
To avenge those deaths, he said to Ivor: "Rise,  
And drive ahead, northward, across Moy Bray.  
I will not part with these my heads and trophies  
Till we reach Avvin Maha." So they placed  
The three heads on the chariot; and they rode,  
With speed like to the speed of flying birds,  
Or to the speed of the cold, pure, spring wind,  
Northward across Moy Bray; and they outstripped  
Those who pursued them, and arrived in safety  
At the lone region of Slieve Foo-id.—There,  
Crossing the red-haired mountains, they descried  
A far-off herd of deer; and the young lad  
Said: "Tell me, Ivor, what is that great herd  
Of moving cattle? Are they tame or wild?"  
"Why, wild," said Ivor; "those are the wild deer  
Who on these lonely spaces of Slieve Foo-id  
Do keep and roam." "Now prick the steeds, good Ivor,  
And we will try to reach them." Ivor pricked  
The steeds; howbeit, the o'er-weary steeds  
Could not come up with the swift mountain-deer.  
Then the young lad leaped from his chariot-seat,  
And darted o'er the heather and the rocks;  
And captured one swift, stalwart buck of them,  
And bound him to the chariot. On they drove,  
Northward, and reached the brink of the cleared land  
Which lies round Avvin. There they chanced to see  
A flock of beautiful wild geese, which flew  
Straight past them. "What are those white birds, O Ivor?"  
The boy inquired. "Are they pets or wild?"  
"Wild," replied Ivor. "They are flocks of geese  
Who from the rocks and cliffs of the Great Sea  
Fly inland, seeking goodly food and pasture  
On the green plains of Erin." "Which were rarer  
And more distinguished," asked the eager child,  
"To bring them living, or to bring them dead,

Home unto Avvin Maha?" "It were rarer  
To bring them living," Ivor said; "for not  
By everyone is owned the art and skill  
To capture them alive." Thereon the boy  
Made with his sling a little, gentle cast,  
Arresting eight of them. A second time  
He made a cast, but with a heavier stone,  
And stopped sixteen of them. "Alight, O Ivor!  
Collect the birds," he said, "for if I go  
To gather them myself, this untamed stag  
Will spring at thee." "It is, indeed, not easy  
For me to go," the charioteer said. "See,  
The two steeds have grown mad; I dare not pass them.  
I dare not pass either of these two wheels  
Of iron, for the sharpness of their rims.  
I dare not pass behind, for the stag's antlers  
Have filled the space 'twixt the two chariot poles."  
"I see, indeed, O Ivor," said the child,  
"Thou art not yet a true, accomplished hero.  
Step from the antlers of the stag. I swear  
Now by the gods by whom the Ultonians swear,  
The bending wherewith I will bend my head  
Upon him, and the eye that I will make  
While eyeing him, will hold him; so that truly  
He will not dare to turn his head at thee,  
And will not dare to move." This, then, was done.  
The charioteer gathered the birds. The child  
Tethered them then with ropes, braces, and thongs  
Belonging to the chariot. Then, "Good Ivor,"  
He shouted gleefully, "convey the birds  
Along with me to Avvin." And 'twas thus  
He rode toward Avvin: the three severed heads  
Of foes upon his chariot, white-bright birds  
Fluttering above it, a wild mountain-stag  
Running behind it. And in a short time  
They came to Avvin Maha.

Lowercam

Daughter of Oy and I-ark saw them coming.  
She said to Conor: "Yon a chariot-rider  
Approaches terribly. Red, bleeding heads  
Of foes are on his chariot; bright, white birds  
Are round about him; a wild, untamed stag  
Is bound and tethered at the chariot's rear.  
We must make ready to receive that rider."  
Then Conor said: "Indeed, I know that rider!  
It is the little lad, my sister's son,  
Who went to-day unto a boundary  
To seek first-reddening of his hands. Make ready  
Now to receive him fitly!" Then three vats  
Of pure, cold water were prepared; and raiment  
Was laid out fairly. And the warriors met  
The child; and quick, obedient servitors  
Took him, and plunged him, first in the one vat,  
Then in the second vat, and last of all  
In the third vat; and so his battle-rage  
Was cooled; and all his skin was cleansed, and shone,  
And flushed a crimson-pink from crown to ground.  
And then they combed his tresses of fair hair,  
Which gleamed pale-golden, like the wax of bees,  
Or like a clasp of fair, pale gold, when shining  
Towards the bright sun. This done, they took a layna,  
That was inwoven with bright threads of gold,  
And put it round him; and they took a bratt  
Of bright grass-green, and pinned it with a pin  
Of white, wrought silver o'er his breast. And then  
They led the child to sit between the feet  
Of Conor, the great king, who, with his hand,  
Stroked the child's brow.

So, now (said Feeaha),

If, as a little lad, he did that deed—  
If, at the end of his first seven years  
He slew those champions and those battle-fighters  
By whom two-thirds of all the men of Ulster  
Had fallen, and had fallen unavenged—

There is indeed no wonder and no marvel,  
E'en though he come unto a boundary,  
And plant a four-pronged pole into a mere,  
And slay a man, or two, or three, or four,  
Now that he hath fulfilled his seventeen years,  
On this, your Táin, to waste the land of Cooley.

## BOOK VI

### BOOK VI

Now, there was in the tent with them that night,  
Amidst the warriors and the noble chiefs,  
A warrior of the men of Domnann, namely,  
Faerdeeah son of Daman son of Dawra,  
A young, choice warrior of the men of Domnann,  
From Irrus Domnann in the far-off west;  
And while all quaffed still in that kingly tent  
Beside Ath Gowla, and discoursed and wondered,  
Wondering at those boy-deeds, Faerdeeah said:  
“O King and Queen,” he said, “I, if ye will,  
Will tell you all the tale and history  
How that Cucullin was trained up to arms  
And wondrous deeds and feats of warlike skill  
By Scawtha in the East; for I can tell it,  
Having been there with him myself; and that  
Which I saw not myself my dear companion,  
Cucullin, hath narrated to me. Truly,  
If ye shall hear this tale, when ye have heard it,  
Ye will no longer wonder at yon deed,  
Namely, his coming to this boundary,  
And setting yon pronged pole into the mere,  
And slaying those who ever went before you  
In every war and hosting.” Al-yill said:  
“Good, O Faerdeeah, tell us, then, that tale.”  
Whereon Faerdeeah told his tale in order,  
And in progression, and with oratory  
And choice and learned words.

O men (said he)

Ye have heard tell of the restraint and rule  
And excellent lordship found in Avvin Maha

Under the admirable, able king,  
Conor the son of Fahtna, in whose time  
Concord and quietness and peaceful pleasure,  
With plenteous yield from forest, field, and ocean,  
Have stayed with the Ultonians. Ye have heard  
Of the great dignity and rank and plenty  
In the king's house in Avvin. That king's house,  
The long Creev Roe of Conor, was designed  
After the likeness of the Meadhall House  
In Tara. Nine score feet and fifteen feet  
Its length from door to door; and it is built  
Of fitted planks of rich, red yew, and roofed  
With planks of yew thatched o'er with lapping shingles.  
Inside the house from fire-hearth unto wall  
There are nine imdas; and of these each pillar  
Of bronze has thrice ten feet in height, and each  
Partition is of rich, red boards of yew.  
Within the chief place in that house is placed  
The imda of Conor; and round about it stand  
Pillars of bronze with silvern capitals;  
And on each capital a bird of gold  
Perches; and flashing gems of carbuncle  
They are which serve for the birds' eyes; and so  
These flash that in that house the day and night  
Seem of like brightness. A tall, narrow band  
Of silver reaches from above the king  
Up toward the roof-tree of the kingly house  
And what time Conor with his royal wand  
Strikes the resounding silver, all the men  
Of Ulster become silent, so that even  
A needle falling on the vast house-floor  
Is heard, because of the great hush and silence  
Wherein men are through reverence for him.

Ranged

About this imda are the twelve tall imdas  
Of the twelve chariot-chiefs of Ulster. Yea,  
And all the valiant warriors of the land



Of Ulster find a place in the Creev Roe  
At feasting. Many noble gatherings  
And many wonderful and varied pastimes  
Are there; and nightly, when the twilight falls,  
The I-arn Gool, that wondrous cask, is filled  
With heart-enlivening wine. One hundred brewings:  
That is the measure that is poured at eve  
Into the Gool: that is the goodly measure  
Which satisfies the Ulster men assembled  
At the one time. And when the night descends,  
And the tall, kingly candle of the house  
Is lighted, then from door to door are stretched  
Long ropes on which the chariot-chiefs of Ulster  
Perform with skill. Three other feats of skill  
Those chiefs perform as well:—the apple-feat,  
The sword-edge feat, the dart-feat. Well ye know  
The names of those renowned chariot-chiefs,  
As Conall Carna son of Avver-guin,  
And Laery the Victorious son of Connud,  
And mighty Keltar son of Oo-hider;  
But, in the happiest time, the Sons of Usna,  
Since slain, were there; and Fergus son of Roy  
Was there, the noblest chief of all; and there  
Were Duffa Dael and Cormac son of Conor.  
They three are absent now; but Avvin yet  
Is wonderful and splendid. So at night  
The chariot-chiefs perform their feats of skill  
In the great house; and, as the night goes on,  
The folk of music and of art and verse  
Arise and sound their stringed melodious harps  
And their bright timpanes; and they chant aloud  
The boughs of genealogy and boughs  
Of Ulster kinship; and they sing their songs  
Of skilful harmony, until sweet sleep  
Falls on the hosts, and all the house is still.

Now, when Cucullin had fulfilled from birth  
His fifteen years, in feats and in swift skill

He went beyond all others of his time;  
And greatly did the Ulster women love him  
For his swift skill and for his nimble leap,  
For his sweet utterance, and for the beauty  
Of his fresh face, and for his ardent looks,  
And for his wisdom. Many were his gifts;  
For—saving when his battle-rage flamed high—  
He had the gift of wisdom and of reason:  
He had a wondrous gift for feats of skill:  
He had a gift for boonanbac and feehill:  
He had the gift of estimating numbers:  
He had the druid's gift of prophecy:  
He had the gift of shape in face and form.  
Three faults alone he had. He was too young;  
And older warriors hailing from strange lands  
Would taunt him for his ungrown beard. Besides,  
He was too daring and too beautiful.  
The men of Ulster then deliberated  
About Cucullin; for they held in mind  
Great Cathbad's prophecy; and they were troubled,  
Being in great fear that their beloved Cucullin  
Would perish from them early; and they wished  
To give a wife to him, that he might leave  
A son. They knew that only from himself  
Could such another as himself gain life.

Thereafter Conor sent nine messengers  
Into each Fifth of the Five Fifths of Erin,  
To see whether in any royal doon  
Or chieftain's doon in Erin they could find  
The daughter of a king or of a chieftain  
Or of a wealthy brewy, whom Cucullin  
Might choose to woo. The messengers returned,  
But had not found a maiden whom Cucullin  
Could choose to woo. Beyond the white-bright Boyne,  
Beyond the bounds of Ulster, in the plain  
Of rich Loolohta Loha, nigh the sea,  
Cucullin knew a maiden whom he loved

And chose to woo. And this, indeed, was Emer,  
A daughter of the wily Forgall Mona,  
The lordly, wealthy brewy, who is nephew  
To Tethra, king of the Fomorians. Her  
Alone, of all the maidens of wide Erin,  
Cucullin chose to visit and to woo.  
For she had the six gifts:—the gift of beauty,  
The gift of a sweet voice, the gift of utterance,  
The gift of needlework, the gift of wisdom,  
The gift of chastity. Cucullin said  
He would woo none but one who should be equal  
Unto himself in lineage and in age,  
In beauty and in skill, and who should be  
The best hand-worker of the maids of Erin.  
And only Emer, daughter of Forgall Mona,  
Had this description. Therefore her alone  
Cucullin chose to woo.

In bright array

Cucullin travelled south to visit Emer  
And show to her his beauty. For at first  
He called unto his own good charioteer,  
Laeg son of Reeangowra, who was brother  
To the good charioteer of Conor, namely,  
To Ivor son of Reeangowra. “Now,  
My good friend Laeg,” Cucullin said, “bring up  
My own two steeds. Bring up the Leea Maha,  
Who rose from out the lake in wild Slieve Foo-id,  
So that I cast my arms about his neck  
And wrestled with him, making him my own.  
Bring up the black Doo Sanglenn, whom I found  
In that dark lake I named him after. Bring  
My chariot which no steeds of all the steeds  
Of Ulster may o’ertake, it being drawn  
By those two steeds I speak of.” Laeg brought up  
The steeds, and he prepared the chariot. Then  
In festive raiment and in bright array  
Cucullin travelled south to visit Emer

And show to her his beauty.

On a day

In rich Loolohta Loha, Emer came  
Out on her playing-field, outside the doon;  
And round her were her foster-sisters, daughters  
Of lords of land who lived around the doon  
Of Forgall. On the bench of gatherings  
Beside the doon these sat; and they were learning  
Rich needlework and fair, choice handiwork  
From Emer. As they sat upon the bench,  
The maidens heard somewhat approaching them.  
They heard the rapid thuds of hooves of steeds,  
The creaking of a chariot, the quick cracks  
Of leathern straps, the grinding of swift wheels,  
The clang of weapons. Emer spake to them.  
“Let one of you rise up,” said she, “and see  
Who is’t that through the land rides towards us so.”

Then Feeal daughter of Forgall rose and said:  
“I see two steeds equal in size and beauty  
And bounding speed; and they are broad of brow  
And slender-mouthed, with crispéd manes and tails,  
And heads uplifted haughtily. The steed  
Against the chariot’s right pole is dark grey,  
And he looks fierce and wild. The rock-strewn turf  
Flames underneath his four hard hooves. A flock  
Of swift birds follows. While he takes his course  
Along the track there darts from him a flash  
Of fiery breath, and bright-red sparkling fire  
Streams from his curbed jaws. The second steed  
Is black as is the dael; and beautiful  
He looks, as easily he bounds along,  
Following the levels of the green mid-glen  
And the cleared river-mead. Behind I see  
A chariot of fine wood and woven osiers,  
Whereto are white bronze wheels, and a long pole  
Of white bright silver set with white findrinny.  
Its yoke is high, arched, and o’erlaid with gold.

The plaited reins are yellow. The hind poles  
Are straight as are two daggers. On the seat  
Sits a fresh, ardent youth, most beautiful  
Of all the youths of Erin. Round him falls  
A crimson and five-folded foon, held  
By a gold, graven brooch, against the which  
His white breast heaves, beating full strokes. The layna  
He wears is white, and has a pure, white hood  
All interwoven red with flaming gold.  
Two blue-white, blood-red cheeks breathe fire and flame.  
Darker than is a winter night is each  
Of his two eyebrows. Underneath them flash  
Seven red dragon-gems within the midst  
Of each of his two eyes. I think, indeed,  
A ray of love burns in his look. A sword,  
Long and gold-hilted, rests on his two thighs.  
His spear is bound fast to the chariot-frame.  
Upon his shoulders hangs his crimson shield,  
All silver-rimmed and decked with beasts of gold.  
And now he leaps the hero's salmon-leap;  
And many other wondrous feats he shows,  
That chariot-chief of the distinguished chariot.  
In front of him there is a charioteer,  
A man tall, stooping, slender, freckled greatly,  
With very curly, gold-red hair confined  
About his brow by a findrinny circlet,  
And at his neck by cups of shining gold.  
He wears a small, short cloak with openings  
At his two elbows. In his hand he bears  
A red-gold rod for ruling of the steeds."

Thus Feeal daughter of Forgall spake. Ere long  
Cucullin came upon the playing-field  
Wherein the maidens were. He greeted them;  
And Emer lifted up her sweet, fair face,  
And recognized Cucullin. Then she said:  
"May Dess make smooth thy travelling-way before thee."  
He answered: "May all here be safe from harm!"

“Whence hast thou come?” she asked. And he replied,  
Speaking in learned language: “I have come  
From the resounding, smooth-bright City of Twins.”  
“Where did you sleep?” she asked. “We slept,” he said,  
“Within the house of him who tends the kine  
Of the green plain of Tethra.” “In that house  
What was your food?” she asked. He answered her:  
“The Ruining of a Chariot there was cooked  
To be our food.” “And what way did ye come?”  
She asked. “Betwixt two Hard ones of the Forest,”  
He said. “By which way did ye travel then?”  
She further asked. He said. “Not hard to tell;  
Athwart the thick-green Covering-Veil of Sea,  
O’er the Great Secret of the men of Deea,  
Across the Foam of the Two Steeds of Avvin,  
Across the Garden of the Red More-reega,  
Over the back of the Great Sow, and down  
The Glen of Dam, and down the trodden road  
Between the God and his great Druid-Seer;  
Then o’er the Marrow of the Woman Fedelm,  
Between the Boar and his own Dam; and then  
Over the Washing of the Steeds of Deea,  
Between the King of Ahna and his Servant,  
O’er the four-cornered Manncool, o’er Great Crime;  
And, lastly, o’er the Remnants of the Banquet,  
Unto these fields of Loo the son of Ethlenn,  
Namely, Loolotha Loha. Here I greet  
The daughters of the nephew of great Tethra,  
The king of the Fomorians.—And for thee,  
O maiden, what is the account of thee?”  
Cucullin asked. “It is not hard to tell,”  
The maiden said, “for I am called indeed  
The high and well-walled Tara among women;  
The unattainable, fair, glittering star  
Of chastity; the secret jewelled worm,  
Deep in a well; the flame of fire; the road  
Which none may enter.—For around me here

Are champions and strong men that follow me,  
Guarding me always that I be not taken  
Without their knowledge, or great Forgall's will."

"Who are the champions who thus follow thee,  
O maiden?" said Cucullin. Emer said:

"Two Looees, and three Looaths, and Lath Gobla  
The son of Tethra; Tuath and Trescath too;  
Brian and Balor; Bas the son of Omna;  
Eight Connlas; and my brother Conn the son  
Of Forgall. Every separate man of them  
Has in himself the vigour of one hundred,  
Besides the feats of nine. Forgall alone  
Is such that it were hard indeed to tell  
His many powers. He is stronger far  
Than any bondman; and more learned far  
Than any druid; of more sharp perception  
Than any poet. More than all the feats  
Of skill that thou mayst own would not suffice  
For fighting against Forgall. Great the deeds  
Of valour that have been narrated of him."

"Why dost thou not account me as the match  
Of these strong men, O maiden?" said Cucullin.

"Why should I not account thee so," said Emer,  
"If deeds like theirs have been recounted of thee?"

"Maiden, I swear," Cucullin said, "my deeds  
Shall be recounted amidst glorious deeds  
Of battle-heroes." "What then, is thy strength?"

The maiden asked. "It is not hard to tell,"

He said; "when I am weak in fight, I fend  
For twenty; and the third part of my strength  
Suffices thirty. I alone give combat  
To forty; and the mention of my name  
Protects one hundred. Fords and battle-fields  
Are shunned for dread of me; and multitudes  
And hosts of armed men flee far away  
Through terror of my look and face alone."

"Those are good fights for a young, tender lad,"

The maiden said; “but thou hast not as yet  
Attained the strength of chariot-chiefs.” “O maiden,”  
Cucullin said, “if I have so attained,  
It is not strange; for not as a churl rears  
His child between the flagstone and the hearth  
Have I been reared by my kind guardian, Conor.  
I have been reared among the learned men,  
Among the druids and among the poets,  
Among the chieftains and the battle-champions,  
Among the jesters, harpers, and musicians,  
Among the brewies and rich lords of land,  
Of our dear realm of Ulster; and by them  
I have been given their manners and their gifts.”

“Who, then, have brought thee up to all these deeds  
Whereof thou vauntest?” Emer said. He answered:

“It is not hard to tell. Sweet-worded Shenca  
Has taught me, so that I am wise in judgment  
And not forgetful. Blai, the lord of lands  
Of Tara in the Ards of Ulster, took me  
Because of the close kinship of his race:  
So that I got my due of wealth with him,  
And learnt the way to entertain the men  
Of Ulster, for the week of entertainment,  
Together with their king, red-sworded Conor;  
And for that week to settle all their gifts  
And spoils, and aid them in each fine and eric,  
And in their honour. While I yet was small,  
And ere through woful cause he left our land,  
The noble Fergus fostered me. From him  
I learnt to slay great warriors through the strength  
Of valour: yea, by valour and by prowess  
I guard our border against foreign foes—  
Being a bush of shelter to the poor,  
And a protecting rampart to the wealthy.  
I comfort each poor wight, and slay the strong,  
All through the kindly fosterage of Fergus.  
Then to the knee of Avver-guin I came,



The skilful poet and father of Conall Carna,  
So that I learnt the way to praise a king  
For any excellency that he has;  
And the sweet Finncaem, mother of Conall Carna,  
Cared for me kindly, that victorious Conall  
Might thus become my foster-brother. Cathbad,  
The good, renowned druid, taught me then,  
For the dear sake of Dectora, my mother—  
Making me skilful in druidic arts,  
And learned in the excellence of knowledge.  
Yea, all the men of Ulster equally  
Have brought me up, both kings and kingly poets,  
Both chariot-chiefs and their good charioteers;  
So that I am the loved one of the host  
And multitude; and for them all I fight,  
And for the honour of them all. Moreover,  
O maiden, one amongst the bright Immortals,  
Namely, great Loo, long-handed son of Ethlenn,  
Hath noticed me; and there will come a day  
When he will help me. So, for thee, O maiden,”  
Cucullin asked, “say how hast thou been reared  
Here in Loolohta Loha?” Emer said:  
“It is not hard to tell. I have been reared  
In antique virtues and in fine behaviour,  
In noble manners, in a queenly carriage,  
In truth, in courtesy, in chastity;  
So that to me there is attributed  
Each noble quality which men may find  
Amongst the hosts of women.” He replied:  
“Good are these virtues verily. Why, then,  
O maiden, should it not be right and fit  
For us two to be one? I never yet  
Have found a maiden able to converse  
In this wise at a meeting.” Emer said:  
“A question first. Hast thou a wife?” “Not so,”  
Cucullin answered. Emer spake again,  
And said: “This thing would not become me well,

I thus to go unto a man, ere goes  
My elder sister Feeal daughter of Forgall,  
Whom thou seest near me here. She is distinguished  
For wondrous handiwork." "Nay," said Cucullin,  
"It is not she whom I have loved." Just then  
Cucullin saw the two breasts of the maiden  
Athwart her layna's opening. Then he said:  
"Fair is this plain, the Plain of the Noble Yoke."  
And Emer, understanding, answered him:  
"None comes unto this plain but him who slays  
As many as one hundred at each ford  
Between the Ford of Skenn-menn at Ollbinny  
And Banquin Airked where the swift Brae breaks  
The brow of Fedelm, fleeing wife of Nahtan."  
"Fair is this plain, the Plain of the Noble Yoke,"  
Cucullin said; and Emer answered him:  
"None comes unto this plain but him who slays  
Thrice nine men at one blow, and with such skill  
As to save one man 'midst each nine of them."  
"Fair is this plain, the Plain of the Noble Yoke,"  
Cucullin said; and Emer answered him:  
"None comes unto this plain but him who slays  
Benn Soan son of Rossmelc, from the end  
Of summer till the opening of the spring,  
And from the opening spring until May-day,  
And from May-day until full winter falls."  
Cucullin said: "'Tis said. It shall be done."  
"It is accepted," Emer said. And so  
Those two were plighted. When those noble words  
Had thus been said, Cucullin moved from her,  
Holding no longer converse.

O'er Moy Bray

He rode to northward. Silently he rode  
Awhile, but in a while his charioteer,  
Namely, good Laeg, aweary of the silence,  
Said to him: "Good, now, Cucuc, those strange words  
And unknown names the which I heard thee use—Thee

and the maiden as ye talked together—  
What did ye mean to say by them?” Cucullin  
Replied: “Dost thou not know, good Master Laeg,  
How that I woo that maiden? We concealed  
The sense of our discourse, enfolding it  
In learned terms of scholars and of poets,  
That her companions who were round her there  
Might not have understanding of it. Forgall,  
Were he aware I wooed her, would prevent  
Our meeting thus for converse.” Then Cucullin  
Began at the beginning of that talk  
Which he had held with Emer. He explained  
Its terms to Laeg, who listened. So with tales  
And antique lore he shortened and made joyful  
The tedious way; and ever north they travelled.  
“Well, first of all,” said he, “I said I came  
From the resounding, smooth-bright City of Twins.  
That is great Avvin Maha. Well thou knowest  
The story of Maha, wave-swift wife of Crunniuc,  
Who raced the steeds of the High-king of Ulster,  
And at the goal bore twins, from whom men named  
The city raised there. Next, I said we slept  
Within the house of him who tends the kine  
Of the Green Plain of Tethra. That is Roncu,  
King Conor’s fisherman. He with his line  
Catches his fish; and poets call the fishes  
The kine of the green sea. “The Plain of Tethra,”  
That is the sea; for Tethra is a king  
Above the fierce Fomorians who range  
The seas in search of plunder. Guileful Forgall  
Is sister’s son to him. We ate, I said,  
The Ruining of a Chariot. Now, thereby,  
I meant that little foal which in that house  
Was killed and cooked for us. Thou dost remember  
How for three nomads there we were detained,  
Having partaken of it. For ’tis gass  
On every chariot that a man should mount it

For three whole nomads, when he hath partaken  
Of flesh of steeds; because the steed it is  
Which doth bear up the chariot. After that,  
I said, betwixt two Hard Ones of the Forest  
We came: I meant Slieve Gullion and Slieve Foo-id.  
We came through Orkill, the dark wood which fills  
The space between them. Then, I said, we rode  
Athwart the thick-green Covering-Veil of Sea;  
That is green Moy Mweerhevna, where we passed  
My own dear doon, Doon Dalgan. In old days  
A dark enchanted sea covered that plain—  
A sea so dense that warriors dressed in arms  
Might rest upon its billows—till the Dagda,  
Distinguished God o'er the fruit-bearing earth,  
Arriving with his Club of Storm and Tempest,  
Conjured it; and it dried and left the plain  
For the sweet grass to grow on. Then, I said,  
We passed the Secret of the Men of Deea;  
And that is Grellah Dollud. On that moor  
In old, old days—ere came the Sons of Mil—  
The Thoo-aha Dae Danann, Men of Deea,  
Assembled secretly; and there they planned  
That battle of Moy Twirra, where at last  
They freed themselves from the hard rent and tribute,  
That the Fomorians, the strong Ocean-rangers,  
Exacted from them year by year. Good, then,  
Over the Foam of the two Steeds of Avvin,  
I said: I meant the river Oo-anub,  
The Foaming One. Within the hollow Mound  
Of Ercmon, by the Thoo-aha Dae Danann,  
Two steeds were reared—reared for a famous king  
Then ruling in great Avvin. When the steeds  
Were freed from out the mound, a glorious stream  
Broke after them; and it was white with foam;  
And foam o'erspread the country. Thence is named  
White Oo-anub, that water which we forded.  
Across the Garden of the Red More-reega,

We came, I said; and that is Oughter Netmon.  
The Dagda gave that height to the More-reega,  
To the great horror-breathing Queen, the quaffer  
Of men's red blood, inciter by her cries  
To furious, blood-red battle. In that place  
She made her herb-field, and there dwelt. Well, then,  
Over the Back of the Great Sow we climbed,  
I said: I meant Drum Bray; for when from Spain  
Our ancestors, the noble sons of Mil,  
Arrived against these shores, on every hill  
And every ridge the Thoo-aha Dae Danann,  
By powerful spells, impressed the loathly shape  
Of a long-sided sow. So by their spells,  
Breeding dislike and dread, they hoped to drive  
The sons of Mil from off their shores. And then,  
Down through the Glen of Dam—that is Glen Bray—  
I said we came; and down the trodden road  
Between the God and his great Druid-seer.  
The God I meant is Angus Ōg, bright son  
Of the great Dagda; and his habitation  
Is, as thou knowest, in his lordly Broo,  
Beside the white-bright Boyne. West of the Broo  
One sees the Shee of Brassil, who is Druid  
And Seer to Angus; and the great South Road  
Passes between the two. And now we crossed,  
I said, the Marrow of the Woman Fedelm:  
That is the reach of the bright river Boyne  
Betwixt the river Thromma and the Inver,  
Where the Boyne mingles with the sea. And then—  
But now (Faerdeeah said), to tell the tale  
Of all those names upon the river Boyne,  
Which then Cucullin told; and all the tales  
He told besides of famous forts and doons  
South of the Boyne; and the long tale he told  
Of beautiful, sweet women who abide  
On a large plain beneath the sea and give  
Gold urns to those who visit them,—to tell

These at this time would surely weary you.  
Laeg asked Cucullin: "Those strange, darksome words  
The maiden spake at parting, what were they?"  
Cucullin answered: "When I said to her,  
'Fair is this plain, the Plain of the Noble Yoke,'  
'Twas not Moy Bray, good Laeg, that thus I praised.  
It was the maiden's shape. I saw the yoke  
Of her two breasts athwart the opening  
Of her fair layna; and of them I spoke  
Those words; and when she answered me, she meant  
She is so strictly guarded that no man  
May come unto that plain, but him who slays  
As many as one hundred at each ford  
Between Ollbinni and the Boyne. No man  
May come unto that Plain but him who leaps  
The hero's salmon-leap o'er the three ramparts  
That fortify the doon; and who—that done—  
Meets her three brothers, Ibbur, Skibbur, and Catt,  
And slays the eight each brother has with him;  
But in such wise that not a blow may reach  
Or hurt those brothers. Finally, she said,  
In way of prophecy, that I shall fight  
Incessantly and all alone against  
Great odds, from Sowin unto Balt-thana,  
Ere I shall find my time to pass the Boyne  
And journey south to win her. So good Laeg,  
Thou seest now all that I must needs perform  
Ere I can wed the maid." Cucullin so  
Went driving on his way. In Avvin Maha,  
His cheerful travelling done, he slept that night.

## BOOK VII

### BOOK VII

Now (said Faerdeeah, as he told his tale)  
Their daughters told those brewies and those lords  
Of land, who dwelt around the doon of Forgall,  
About that youthful warrior, who had come  
In his resplendent chariot, and had talked  
Upon the green with Emer. What the two  
Had said, these said they knew not; but they knew  
That he had turned to northward o'er Moy Bray  
On taking leave of them. The brewies told  
That thing to Forgall. "It is true," said Forgall.  
"It was the Ree-astartha who came there  
From Avvin Maha; and the maid has yielded  
Her heart-affection to him. Therefore talked they.  
Yet it shall not avail them. I by craft  
Will balk them; so that that which they desire  
Shall not be gained by them."

Then Forgall Mona  
Called to himself two of his own sure folk,  
And told them all his plan; whereon, they three  
Featly arrayed themselves in foreign raiment,  
And crossed Moy Bray and grass-green Moy Mweerhevna,  
And wild Slieve Foo-id; and they fared to Avvin  
As though they were a Gaulish embassy,  
Bringing sweet wine of Gaul and costly gifts  
To Conor from the Gaulish King. Great joy  
And welcome greeted them. On the third day,  
At banqueting, it chanced that Conall Carna,  
Cucullin, and the champions all of Ulster,  
Were praised in Forgall's presence. Then he said:  
"That praise is just. The method of their feats

Is wonderful; yet if your bright and gifted  
And much-beloved Cucullin were to go  
To Domnall, the great warrior on the Alps,  
There to be trained by him, his feats would be  
E'en the more wonderful; and if thereafter  
He were to reach to Scawtha, who is daughter  
To Airdgama, a king in Scythia, there  
By that fierce warrior-woman, that renowned  
Preceptress of the heroes of the east,  
To be well taught, he—gifted as he is—  
Would soon excel the warriors of all Europe.”  
Cucullin said that he would go. He vowed  
He never would return to Avvin Maha  
Till he had learnt from Domnall and from Scawtha  
All which they had to teach. And Conall Carna  
And Laery the Victorious said they too  
Would go to get that training, and began  
To make them ready for that long, hard travel.  
Forgall took courteous leave of Conor, and went  
To his own house. Now for this cause and reason  
Forgall had spoken so: he thought Cucullin,  
Being in training with that warrior-woman,  
Namely, with Scawtha, through her well-known hardness  
And her severity and battle-wildness,  
Would get his death; and so would ne'er return  
Again to Avvin Maha.

Ere he went,  
Cucullin rode across Moy Bray to visit  
The maiden once again. Beyond the Boyne,  
Beyond the bounds of Ulster, on the plain  
Of rich Loolohta Loha, nigh the sea,  
He spoke with her at night-fall; and she told him  
That it was Forgall who in smooth-bright Avvin  
Had urged his travel thus; and that he had urged it  
So that she—Emer, namely—and himself  
Never might come together. Then she told him  
To have much heed; for Forgall would send snares



To be destroying him and breaking him  
On every road and land where he might go.  
Each vowed unto the other then the keeping  
Of chastity until that day should come  
When they should come together. And Cucullin  
Vowed that if once he should return with safety  
He straight would tell the maiden of his safety.  
The Enga, Conall Carna's long-famed ship,  
Was waiting nigh that strand. Cucullin, then,  
And Emer daughter of Forgall, spake their partings;  
And o'er the bitter-green, salt, great-waved sea,  
O'er the green-sided and white-ridgéd billows,  
O'er the wild, treacherous currents and swift streams  
Of Ocean, the three friends fared on their way  
For distant warrior-training.

Of their deeds

Until they came to Domnall on the Alps,  
And of the feats which there they learned from Domnall  
(Faerdeeah said) I treat not. Dorndoll daughter  
Of Domnall afterward desired Cucullin.  
That damsel's shape was vile. Her knees were big,  
Her heels in front, her feet behind, her eyes  
Inside her head black-grey and big. As black  
As is the side of a burnt, lonely ruin,  
After its burning by night-reaving foemen,  
Her face appeared; and round about her bulking  
Strong brow her earth-red hair wound in thick wisps.  
When he denied her, she vowed utter vengeance  
On him for that. She said unto Cucullin,  
He would not win his finished warrior-training,  
Till he should reach to Scawtha far in Scythia  
To eastward of those Alps. Thereon they three,  
Laery and Conall Carna and Cucullin,  
Fared eastward o'er the Alps; and it was then,  
E'en as they passed those places lofty, dreadful,  
Unfruitful, barren, hungry, perilous,  
That there appeared to them before their eyes

Their smooth-bright Avvin Maha, plentiful  
In bright, melodious feastings and ale-banquets  
'Mid lands of health and joy. Nor Conall Carna  
Nor Laery the Victorious then could pass  
That vision and appearance. Dorndoll daughter  
Of Domnall—it was she who had given that vision,  
So that Cucullin at it might turn back  
And win reproach and shame through his thus breaking  
That vow which he had made, to reach to Scawtha  
Or find his death; or—should he not turn back—  
So that he, being parted from his friends,  
Might the more surely find his death. Cucullin  
Of his own mind and will fared on alone  
Over the unknown ways; though, as he fared,  
He was sad, sorrowful, and very heavy  
For loss of his companions. And he knew not  
Whither to wend to reach the doon of Scawtha,  
And yet had sworn to reach the doon of Scawtha  
Or find his death. He lingered then some while;  
For he perceived his straying and his darkness.

While he thus lingered for a while in darkness  
Of counsel, he espied, coming straight towards him,  
An awe-inspiring beast, dreadful and huge  
And lion-like. It came to him and watched him,  
And hurt him no-wise. On whichever way  
He tried to go, it came to him and met him,  
And turned its side to him. With confidence  
He sprang aloft then on to the beast's neck,  
Letting it travel on each way it would;  
And so for four full days they in that mode  
Travelled, until at last they reached a land  
Where dwellers were, and saw there some young lads  
Rowing athwart a lake; and the lads laughed,  
Owing to the great wonder which was on them  
At that so harmful beast's being in service  
So to a man. Cucullin leapt from it;  
And the beast parted from him; and he blessed it.

He went then on the road he saw before him,  
And chanced on a great house in a great glen.  
A damsel very fair and shapely came  
Out from that house then; and she greeted him,  
And spoke his welcome. "Welcome is thy coming,  
Cucullin," she exclaimed to him. He asked her  
How she thus knew him; and she said to him:  
"We two were friendly fellow-fosterlings  
With Ulbecawn the Saxon, at that time  
When we were learning from him melody  
And eloquence and poetry." She gave him  
For maintenance of strength, then, drink and viands;  
And he went from her, wending towards his way.

He chanced ere long upon an admirable  
Young warrior, who then also spake a welcome.  
They made exchange of tidings and of knowledge.  
Cucullin asked for knowledge of the way  
To the great doon of Scawtha. Then the youth  
Gave him the knowledge of the way. "It lies,"  
He said, "across the Plain of Evil there,  
Which widely spreads, upon whose hither half  
The feet of men will freeze, and will be frozen  
To the ground's face; but on whose further half  
The grass will rise, and will impale men's feet,  
Even as on a battle-field of spears."  
That youth then gave a wheel unto Cucullin,  
And bade him follow it o'er the hither half  
Of the Plain of Evil. Then he gave an apple,  
And bade him follow it o'er the further half.  
And then he told him that beyond that plain  
He would discover a great valley-gorge,  
And through it one thin path; and all the gorge  
He would find full of horrors and of shapes,  
Of spectres and of loathly apparitions,  
Which had been sent, some by shrewd Forgall Mona,  
And some by incenséd Dorndoll, to destroy  
His courage and to be his end and ruin.

Mounting the gorge, the path would lead him on  
Through high and strong and terrible regions: it,  
And it alone, would lead him unto Scawtha.  
Then the youth taught Cucullin how to win  
Respect and honour in great Scawtha's house.  
They blessed each other. And Cucullin passed  
In safety o'er the perilous Plain of Evil,  
And through the spectred gorge, and through the high  
And strong and terrible regions. And he came  
To a wide green nigh to the doon of Scawtha,  
And saw bright bands of fresh and glittering youths,  
Pupils of Scawtha, playing at hurling there  
In mingled groups. He, after his long travel,  
Was tired and drooping, weak and hunger-worn.

Now (said Faerdeeah, as he told his tale)  
Amidst great Scawtha's pupils at that time  
Were certain youths from Erin. Six we were,—  
Faerbay the son of Baetan; and Faerbay  
Son of Faerbend; and Bress the son of Ferb;  
And Lewy son of Solmoy; and Faerdaet,  
A son of Daman; and myself, Faerdeeah,  
A son of Daman. And we six from Erin,  
Perceiving thus a youth from Erin come,  
Ran to him; and we each one, fervently,  
Gave him three kisses. And we asked of him  
Tidings of Erin for ourselves; and he,  
All weary as he was, asked for himself  
What arts of valour and what feats of skill  
We six had learnt. "We six have learnt," I said,  
"To cross the Bridge of the Cliff, whereby men go  
To the seven-doored house of Scawtha." Then he asked:  
"How long have ye been learning it?" We said:  
"We have been learning it three nights and days  
And one month and one season and one year."  
"Youths, quick," Cucullin said, "show me this bridge."  
"It will not profit thee to see the bridge,"

We said, "till Scawtha shall begin to teach thee  
Safely to pass it, as she taught us all."

"I would but see it," he replied. Thereat  
We led him to the bridge. And thus it was:  
At one time when a youth should leap on it,  
It would put on the thinness of a hair,  
And the sleek smoothness of a long lake-eel:  
Another time it would rise up and grow  
E'en to the height of a ship's mast. Cucullin  
Leapt on the bridge and fell; and leapt again  
And fell; and a third time he leapt; that time  
He reached the mid-part of the bridge, and there  
He wavered, and he hovered in mid-air  
Over the black lake-waters which it bridged.

That now was seen by Ooaha, the daughter  
Of Scawtha from their seven-doored house, their high  
And rooféd stronghold; and she paled and whitened,  
And cried to her dread mother, Scawtha, crying:  
"My grief! a beautiful unrivalled youth  
Stands poised amidmost of yon bridge. He shakes  
And wavers toward a fall. I fear, indeed,  
That he will never more behold the land  
Of his dear father and his mother." Scawtha,  
Her mother, warlike fighter and renowned  
Preceptress of the heroes of the east,  
Replied: "It was foretold to me long since  
That a fresh, child-like youth should come to us  
From Erin in the west. It was foretold  
That in one hour alone he would achieve  
The victory of the Bridge, which every other  
Only achieves after three days and nights  
And one month and one season and one year.  
And 'twas foretold that his great deeds of valour  
Would be related by the mouths of men  
Until the ending of the world. I think  
Thou seest that youth whose coming was foretold."  
Cucullin wavered still upon the crest

Of the Bridge of the Cliff. Then, nigh in act to fall,  
He leapt aloft his hero's salmon-leap:  
He lighted on the island of the doon  
Of Scawtha, at the door of the huge doon  
Of Scawtha; and we six of Erin, pupils  
Of Scawtha, raised aloud our shouts of joy  
And wonder, at that passing of the bridge.

Howbeit, notwithstanding this achievement,  
Great Scawtha placed Cucullin for a time  
Beneath her daughter Ooaha, to learn  
Amidst the youthful pupils. Ooaha  
Then spake unto Cucullin, and she said:  
"If thou wilt learn true valour, thou must go  
To Scawtha in the vast and antique yew  
Wherein she holds communion with her gods,  
Wherein she doth instruct her own two sons,  
Coo-ar and Ket. And thou must set thy sword  
Betwixt her breasts, until she promise thee  
Three wishes. Then demand of her to train thee  
Without neglect: to send thee with Faerdeeah  
The son of Daman to be taught by Weefa,  
The hardest woman-warrior of this world,  
Who in Great Greece abides: last, to foretell  
What shall befall when thou again shalt go  
To far-off, noble Erin." Then Cucullin  
Obeyed her; and he leapt his salmon-leap  
Into the yew-tree; and he set his sword  
Betwixt the breasts of Scawtha; and he cried:  
"Death is above thee!" Then she said to him:  
"I give thee thy three wishes. Utter them  
In the one breath." Thereat he uttered them.  
"Train me," he said, "in arms and feats of skill  
Without neglect: then send me with Faerdeeah  
The son of Daman to be taught by Weefa,  
The hardest woman-warrior of this world,  
Who in Great Greece abides: lastly, foretell  
What shall befall when I again shall go

To far-off, noble Erin." After that  
Scawtha herself trained him to skill in arms;  
And—for that I was more in years than he—  
(Faerdeeah said, telling his warrior-tale)  
She placed him under me, to dress my spears,  
And to prepare my bed, and to perform  
A gillie's service. We together practised  
All feats which Scawtha taught:—the apple-feat,  
The blade-feat, the small-javelin feat, the faen-feat,  
The body-feat, the rope-cord feat, the cat-feat,  
The chariot-hero's rapid salmon-feat,  
The wielding of the chariot-driver's staff,  
The leap across a fence, the "baw-ee brashee,"  
The red whirl of a finished valiant champion,  
The wheel-feat, the mouth-fury feat, the breath-feat,  
The warrior's whoop, the furious counter-blow,  
The sod-blow, the swift running up a lance  
And poising of the body above its point,  
The feat of the scythed chariot. And we went  
Together amidst crags and through dark forests,  
And many wild and lone and desert places,  
Learning from Scawtha. And she taught us well.  
And 'twixt Cucullin and myself there grew  
Heart-friendship. Of one kindred and one tribe  
We seemed to be, so strong was our affection.

Ere long great wars occurred. The foes of Scawtha  
Pressed on her densely. We went out with her  
Into hard battles; and we fought her foes.  
Howbeit, of these fights I tell not now.  
We fought the king of the great Snowy Land  
Which lay to northward. Then upon the south  
Fresh trouble came; and one day Scawtha spake  
Her words of rousing import. "Get ye ready,"  
She said, "to go unto the able battle,  
That will be fought against us on the south  
By cruel, battle-skilled, grey-haired Germanus."  
Thereat Cucullin, who was ever daring,

Spake unto me and to the son of Baetan,  
“Let us arise,” he said, “and gather men,  
And seize the fort of battle-skilled Germanus  
Ere he can give us battle.” So we went.  
We took with us four hundred fighting men  
Out of the Islands of the Athishec.  
We reached the doon which towers above the loch  
Of sparkle-bright Lind Format. On the beach  
I slew great Blawth son of red-sworded Calba.  
The son of Baetan slew a grim, fierce man,  
Mugarny of the Tyrrhene Sea. We reached  
The gate-way of the doon; and there Cucullin  
Slew Rind who guarded it; and I slew Rood.  
We forced our way within: Cucullin slew  
Four fifties of strong fighters; and I slew  
Two terrible companies. We pillaged all  
The wealthy doon; and battle-wise Germanus—  
For all his plans and skilful strategy—  
We brought with us alive out of his doon  
That towers above the waters. To great Scawtha,  
With swift exhilaration and with triumph,  
We carried him a captive.

And so Scawtha

(Faerdeeah said, telling his valour-tale)  
Had trained us up in arms and feats of skill  
Without neglect. Cucullin and myself,  
She now, fulfilling so her second promise,  
Sent from her, therefore, to be taught by Weefa,  
The hardest warrior-woman of the world,  
Who in Great Greece abides. After long travel,  
We reached the doon of Weefa; and loyally  
And kindly Weefa welcomed us. She put us  
Soon to a sword-fight with her; and Cucullin  
Fought first; and straightway, with her weapon-play,  
She broke his sword, till what remained of it  
Was hardly longer than his hand. Thereafter  
She taught us all that wondrous weapon-play.



She took us into battles and to combats.  
She led us on a dangerous expedition,  
Even to the Mountain of Armenia. Great  
The war-experience and the battle-knowledge  
We gained while thus we served her.

Now, awhile,

I leave to speak of these our deeds of arms  
(Faerdeeah said), and, instead, speak awhile  
Of things that chanced—I tell a truthful tale—  
In Erin here. While we two were with Weefa,  
An admirable man who was in Munster,  
And who is with you now upon your hosting,  
A king renowned, Lewy the son of Nōs  
The son of Alamac—a foster-brother  
Unto Cucullin—fared from the south-west,  
From Munster, taking with him twelve good chiefs  
Of Munster, to this end, that these might woo  
Twelve maids in Tara, twelve fair daughters, namely,  
Of Neea Faer the son of Ross the Red.  
Those maids, howbeit, had been all affianced  
Ere Lewy reached to Tara. Forgall Mona,  
Hearing of that, journeyed to Tara straightway.  
He said to Lewy that there was with him  
In rich Loolohta Loha nigh the sea,  
The maid who was the best of maids of Erin—  
The best for beauty and sweet voice and language,  
The best for chastity and for handiwork,  
The best for wisdom. Lewy said to him  
That that to him seemed well; and Forgall Mona  
Plighted his daughter, therefore, to that king;  
And the twelve daughters of the lords of land,  
Who dwelt around his doon—folk of Moy Bray—  
He plighted to the twelve good chiefs of Munster,  
Who had arrived with Lewy. So then Lewy  
The son of Nōs the son of Alamac,  
Went in one band and troop with Forgall Mona  
To Forgall's doon in rich Loolohta Loha

To have his marriage and bride-festival.  
The time, howbeit, when Emer was brought forth  
To Lewy, to the place in which he was,  
To sit at his one hand, she with her hands  
Took his two cheeks. "Upon thy truth of honour  
And truth of soul to me," she said; and then  
She made confession that it was Cucullin  
Who loved her and who had her love. She said  
It, therefore, would be hot, face-reddening insult,  
And honour-violation toward Cucullin,  
To take her—whosoe'er should take her from him.  
At that, that king dared not then sleep with Emer:  
He feared Cucullin. Straightway he returned  
To his own doon and fort in the south-west.

I now again (Faerdeeah said) set forth  
Cucullin's own adventures. When—our time  
With Weefa in Great Greece being fulfilled—  
We journeyed to the Island of the doon  
Of Scawtha, again, and reached the seven-doored house  
Of Scawtha, we found there those five of Erin,  
Our comrades, and our friends, and our co-pupils:  
Faerbay the son of Baetan; and Faerbay  
Son of Faerbend; and Bress the son of Ferb;  
And Lewy son of Solmoy; and Faerdaet,  
My brother, son of Daman. And those five,  
Having fulfilled their training with great Scawtha,  
Were now in point to leave her: they were saying  
Their blessings and their partings. Then Cucullin  
Said he desired to fare back to Erin  
In company with those companions. Scawtha  
Spoke to him words of solemn warrior-import.  
"Thou shalt not go with them," she said, "till I  
Have tied a hard, encircling fold and friendship  
About you all; so that the men of the world  
May never put you one against the other  
Unto a combat. For there is no danger  
That any other man in all this world

Will cause you danger, unless danger rise  
From one of you against his fellow. Therefore,  
These are the gassa which I leave to you:  
If it shall be the better man of you,  
Who shall seek combat with the less good man,  
Then it shall be the better man of you  
Who shall be conquered; and, in the same way,  
If it shall be the less good man of you  
Who shall seek combat with the better man,  
Then it shall be the less good man of you  
Who shall be conquered. Let not one of you  
Transgress these gassa and this testament.”  
Thereat we gave our hands unto each other,  
So covenanting fulfilment of that league,  
Each toward the other, till the Breast of Doom.  
And then it was that upon me great Scawtha  
Bestowed a conganess, a horn-skin armour;  
And then it was that to renowned Cucullin  
She gave her dread Gae Bulg. No other man  
Of Erin has its like; and to him only  
She taught the wielding of it. After that  
Scawtha fulfilled her third great vow to him,  
Namely, to tell him what things should befall,  
When he, with all of us, should go again  
To far-off, noble Erin. And she sang,  
Through power of the Imbas Forosnai,  
These words to him, foreshowing deeds to come:

“My strong affection to thee, welcoming,  
O Shield of Fury, Shield of Victory!  
I see, O Shield, thy hound-strong combating.

Alone against rough, reaving multitudes,  
By Maev brought east with great hostility,  
I view thee, unsubdued, yet combating.

On fords from Sowin unto Balt-thana,  
I see high heroes, huge, illustrious,  
Fall in death-pools, with thee, Shield, combating.

I see thy three-day sleep—sleep wonderful:

I see three fifties slain—deed sorrowful:

I see thy Bressla More, red, terrible.

I see thee lying, wounded, languishing:

Erin contends in battle pitiless:

The bive screams o'er that field, wild, ravenous.

Thy fill of years is brief, ephemeral;

But thy war-deeds men hold in memory,

While Erin yet by waves is combated.

My strong affection to thee, welcoming,

O Shield of Fury, Shield of Victory!

I see, O Shield, thy fame uncombated."

Well, after that (Faerdeeah said) we said  
Our partings and farewells. On that same night  
We started on our long and arduous travel,  
To our own land, to Erin. I relate  
One event only of that arduous travel.

Toward summer's end we reached the doon of Rood,  
King of the Isles; and there were Conall Carna,  
And Laery the Victorious, gathering tribute  
And rent; for on those islands of the Gall  
There is strong tribute to the men of Ulster.  
Cucullin heard a sorrowing in the doon  
Ere yet he reached it. "Wherefore is that cry?"  
Cucullin asked. "The daughter of our king,"  
They said, "is being handed o'er as tribute  
To the Fomorians, to the Sea-plunderers,  
And therefore this hard sorrowing in our doon."  
"Where is the maid?" he said. "Down on yon shore,"  
They answered him. Cucullin went from them,  
And came into the presence of the maid  
On the shore-sands. He asked of her her tidings;  
And the maid told that grief fully, completely.  
"Whence will the men arrive?" Cucullin asked.  
"From yonder somewhat distant isle," she said;  
"And bide not here to face their violence."  
Cucullin, notwithstanding, bode with her

To face them; and he slew the three Fomorians  
With one-man valour. The last man of them  
Had wounded him, however, in his hand;  
And the maid wound a piece from her own raiment  
About his wounded hand. Cucullin then  
Went up to the king's doon like every other:  
He had not told his name unto the maiden.  
The maiden came then to the doon and told  
Her father all that tale. Cucullin came  
Like every other guest; and Conall Carna  
And Laery the Victorious had great joy  
At seeing him; and much they welcomed him.  
Many a man within that doon then boasted  
Himself the slayer of those ocean-thieves;  
But the maid credited no whit his boasting.  
And then it was that the king caused a bath  
To be prepared; and every man in turn  
Was brought to it; and when Cucullin came,  
As each one came, the maiden knew him straightway.  
"I give my daughter to thee," Rooad said;  
"And her bride-outfit I myself will pay."  
"Not so," Cucullin said. "After a year,  
Let her come after me, if so she will,  
To Erin; and I, 'midst my comrades there  
Will find for her a very noble consort."

After that hour (Faerdeeah said) we stayed  
Three nights beneath kind tendance in that doon,  
With banqueting. At ending of that time  
We put our hands unto our ships to sail  
Again to Erin. We put prow on shore  
On a North Ulster strand. We blessed each other,  
We comrades; and each one of us fared then  
To his own people, his own tribe and land.  
I (said Faerdeeah) fared to my own folk  
In Irrus Domnann in the west. Cucullin  
Fared to smooth, beautiful, bright Avvin Maha,  
Where was great Conor son of Fahtna Fahee,

High-king of Ulster. There he told his tidings,  
And put his weariness away. And then—This  
(said Faerdeeah) I have heard from one  
Who tells true tidings—to his own bright doon,  
Doon Dalgan, next he journeyed, where he had,  
O King and Queen, some warning of these hosts  
And this your hosting. He with Sooaltim,  
His father—husband unto Dectora,  
His noble mother—rode then to the marches,  
And reached Ardcullin. While their steeds grazed there  
He made that spancel-withe, made from an oakling  
New-felled and twisted; and he cut the inscription  
In ogam; and he flung the spancel-withe  
Around the pillar-stone, so to delay  
Your hosts for one full night while he should go  
South o’er the Boyne to rich Loolohta Loha,  
There to tell Emer daughter of Forgall Mona  
How he again had come to noble Erin  
In safety from his travel. Sooaltim  
He sent with words of warning north to Avvin.

And now (Faerdeeah said) I have related  
The tale I said I would relate. A thing  
There is, howbeit:—One of our battle-comrades,  
Faerbay the son of Baetan, said to me  
That Scawtha, one hour prophesying, said  
It was in Destiny, or that Cucullin  
Should fall by me, or else that I, Faerdeeah,  
Should fall by him. Therein the son of Baetan  
Reported erringly. It were a thing  
Not possible; for this I say to you:  
A dearer, truer friend I never found  
Than was Cucullin son of Dectora.  
Oh! he was half my heart, and I to him  
Was half his heart; and this I say to you:  
By my hard shield, by my ringed battle-shield,  
Were sword of mine to slay that valiant Hound,  
I would then thrust my dripping slender sword

Through my own side, through my own breast and heart.  
Yea, by my sword, by my red battle-sword,  
Were I to slay that Hound of Moy Mweerhevna,  
I would be buried in his raised earth-mound,  
And the one stone should lie o'er him and me.  
By my war-spear, by my far-flaming spear,  
If any folk should come betwixt us two,  
And should incite me, so that I should slay him,  
I would then turn against that folk in fury,  
And they with all their armies should be slain.  
By my strong hand, by my trained hero's hand,  
Rather than that in unjust battle-fight  
I should destroy that glorious, valiant Hound,  
I would myself be slain and thrown as meat  
To every wolf and every screaming bive.

Faerdeeah ended so his warrior-tale  
Of all Cucullin's training-up to arms  
By Ooaha, by Scawtha, and by Weefa  
Far in the East. Beside Ath Gowla still  
The Four Great Fifths of Erin stayed that night.

## BOOK VIII

### BOOK VIII

The Four Great Fifths beside Ath Gowla so  
Remained that night; and so with histories,  
Recounting notable things, Al-yill and Maev  
With all the kings and chieftains whiled away  
The fore-part of that night. And if thereafter  
Upon the men of Ulster there was joy  
And gladness and delight of mind and spirit,—  
Upon the chiefs of Erin there was grief,  
Because they knew the youth who had performed  
Those things recounted would perform yet greater  
Before them in the land whereto they journeyed,  
The land of Cooley. When the glorious sun  
Next morn filled up with light each hollow glen  
Throughout the lands of Erin, Al-yill said:  
“Let us move forward.” Then they crossed Ath Gowla,  
And moved along through the long forest-pass.

Cucullin went before them where they went.  
He felled an oak athwart the forest-passage  
Ahead of them; and on its side he wrote  
In ogam that ’twas gass on any man  
To go beyond it till some chariot-rider  
Should leap it with his chariot. The hosts pitched  
Their tents in front of it; and chariot-riders  
Went in their chariots to o’erleap it. Thirty  
Good steeds fell there; and thirty chariots there  
Were broken wretchedly. The Pass of Awny,—  
That is the name upon that pass for ever.

They stayed there till the morrow’s dawning-time.  
Then Maev procured that Frae, the glistering,  
Strong son of Eedath, should be brought to her.



“Help us, O Frae,” said Maev, “remove from us  
This strait and hindrance. Rise from us. Go forth,  
That thou perchance mayst fight and slay Cucullin.”

Frae at that early dawning-hour went forth:

He took with him eight others: he arrived  
Beside Ath Foo-id and descried the youth  
At bathing in the pure, cold river there.

“Bide for me here,” Frae said then to his people,

“While I myself go to yon man ye see.

The water is not good,” said he. He flung  
His raiment from him then; and he stepped forth  
Into the ice-cold stream to meet Cucullin.

“Come not against me, Frae, bright son of Eedath,”

Cucullin cried to him, “for thou wilt die  
Thereby, and it were grief with me to slay thee.”

“Against thee I will go,” Frae said to him;

“Here in this snow-cold stream we two will combat;  
And let thy fight with me be fair and noble.”

“Whatever mode of fight seems best to thee,”

Cucullin said, “that choose thou.” Frae replied:

“The arm of each, then, round his fellow’s body  
Is what I choose.” They wrestled a long time,  
With powerful grips each round his fellow’s body,  
There in that water. Frae was then submerged.

Cucullin raised him to the air and said

With courtesy: “I raise thee up again,

O Frae, bright son of Eedath. Own thou now

That I have won; accept thou from me now

This sparing of thy life.” Frae answered him:

“I own it not; and I accept it not.”

Cucullin put him under once again,

Until Frae died of that. His form was brought

Out from the water to the river’s brink,

Drowned, without life; and his own people bore him

Away, till they had reached the camp and hosting.

Ath Frae, “the Ford of Frae,” then, is the name

Which has been given for ever to that ford

Wherein Frae died. The camp and hosting all  
Cried out with grief for Frae the son of Eedath.  
Findabair daughter of Maev and Al-yill  
Wept in still grief, seeing him drowned and pale,  
And thinking of that beauty which he had  
That day when in his sparkling bright array  
He had approached to woo, and of the beauty  
Which was upon him on that other day  
When she herself had swum the dark-pooled stream  
To succour and to aid him. Soon the hosts  
Perceived a band of women, robed in innars  
Of pure grass-green, come to that drowned, pale form  
Of Frae the son of Eedath; and these drew him  
With them away into the green Shee-mound,  
Where, with her sister Boyne, his mother Baefinn  
Dwelt 'midst the deathless Shee. Then, with his chariot,  
Fergus the son of Roy leapt the felled oak.

The hosts moved on until they reached Ard Ahad.  
Cucullin there slew six, six Dungalls, namely,  
From Irrus Domnann in the far-off west.  
And the hosts moved until they reached Drum Saulinn.  
There was with Maev upon that hosting then  
A little much-loved whelp: its name was Bashny.  
Cucullin, going before them where they went,  
Launched from his sling, from his cranntowl, a stone,  
Which, striking to the mid-part of their camp  
Upon Drum Saulinn, struck from Maev's whelp its head.  
That Maev took very grievously. She said:  
"Great is the mockery and shame to you,  
O men, that ye do not pursue and hunt  
That wild deer of misfortune, who each day  
Is slaying some of you!" Then many warriors  
Fell to pursuing him and hunting him,  
Until at hunting him they broke the poles  
And hind-shafts of their chariots. And the hosts  
In the meantime moved on and reached Drum Keen.  
Cucullin, near by, there, in the red morn,

At milking-time, heard from a holly-forest  
The sounds of breaking boughs. "Alas! O Laeg,"  
Cucullin said to his good charioteer:  
"It is too bold a mode in the Ultonians,  
If it be they who thus hew down their forests  
In front of the Four Fifths of Erin. Therefore,  
Wait here awhile, good Laeg, while I go hence  
To see who cuts the forests." Then Cucullin  
Went to that place whence he had heard the sounds  
Of breaking boughs, and found a gillie there.  
"Who art thou, gillie, and what dost thou here?"  
Cucullin said to him. The gillie answered:  
"I am the charioteer to Orlam son  
Of Al-yill and of Maev; and I am cutting  
New holly chariot-shafts, because our shafts  
Were shattered yesterday while we were hunting  
That famed wild deer, Cucullin; and, brave youth,  
By all the honour of thy bravery,  
Help me to finish, lest that famed Cucullin  
Should come upon me here." "Thy choice, O gillie,"  
Cucullin said, "shall I cut down the poles  
For thee, or trim them?" "I myself will cut them,"  
The gillie said, "for it is easier."  
Cucullin then began to trim the poles.  
He took one by its upper end and dragged it  
Betwixt his toes and then betwixt his fingers,  
Against its branches and excrescences,  
Till he had trimmed, and shaped, and smoothened it,  
And polished it, so that not even a fly  
Could stay on it; and then he laid it from him.  
And each rough pole he in that fashion trimmed.  
The gillie looked at him, and said: "I think  
This work which I have given thee to do  
Is not thy daily work. Who, in all Erin,  
Art thou, O youth?" Cucullin said to him:  
"I am that famed wild deer, even Cucullin,  
Of whom thou spak'st at morn, at milking-time."

“Woe on me then!” exclaimed the charioteer.  
“I die by that until the Breast of Doom.”  
“Fear not, O gillie,” said Cucullin. “Never  
Slay I good charioteers or messengers,  
Or folk unarmed. But tell me in what place  
Thy lord is, namely, Orlam.” “At yon grave-hill,”  
The gillie said. “Go to him,” said Cucullin.  
“Carry him warning. Tell him to have fear.  
If I shall reach him, he by me shall fall.”  
The charioteer thereat went towards his lord.  
He took the nearest way through the dense forest;  
But howe’er rapidly he went, Cucullin,  
Taking a longer way through the same forest,  
Arrived more rapidly. He cut the head  
From Orlam son of Al-yill and of Maev;  
And, from the grave-hill since called Tamlaht Orlam,  
He toward the hosts of Erin brandished it.

The hosts moved on until they reached Ard Keenaht.  
And then it was that the three sons of Aurac  
Came to the river-ford by high Ard Keenaht  
Against Cucullin. These, then, were those sons:  
Mess-Linny and Mess-Leea and Mess-Lahan.  
And Loo-an and Oo-al and Milhy were the names  
Of their three chariot-drivers. For this cause  
They went against Cucullin: it to them  
Seemed overmuch of action and performance,—  
That which Cucullin had performed against them  
On those preceding days; namely, his slaying  
Those sons of Renc, two foster-sons of Al-yill’s,  
Beside Ath Gowla; and his overwhelming  
Of Frae the son of Eedath; and his slaying  
Of Orlam son of Al-yill and of Maev  
At Tamlaht Orlam; and his brandishing  
That head in full view of the hosts of Erin.  
They meant to slay Cucullin in return,  
And of themselves to lift that sore oppression  
From the great hosts of Erin. To the woods

They went, and cut there three white hazel-rods,  
And gave these to their charioteers; and then  
They went, the six of them, against Cucullin,  
Six against one, breaking the faith of men.  
Cucullin at the ford by high Ard Keenaht  
Slew four of them; but Lahan broke in flight  
To northward. With his chariot-driver, Milhy,  
He reached the Nith in Connallia Mweerhevna;  
And there his chariot broke. Ath Carpat, therefore,  
“Ford of the Chariot,” has since been the name  
Upon that ford. And Lahan straightway turned  
To face Cucullin who had swiftly chased him.  
He met him on the second ford hard by.  
He fell there by Cucullin; and Ath Lahan,  
“The Ford of Lahan,” since has been the name  
Upon that ford on the green river Nith.  
Now, on the shoulder of hill between those fords—  
Ath Carpat and Ath Lahan in the Nith—  
Laeg son of Reeangowra, charioteer  
Of famed Cucullin, fought the charioteer  
Of Lahan, namely Milhy; and Laeg slew him:  
Whence, Goola Milhy, “Shoulder of Milhy,” since  
Has been the name on that low eminence  
In Connallia Mweerhevna ’twixt those fords,  
Ath Carpat and Ath Lahan in the Nith.  
And that was “Laeg’s One Combat on the Táin.”

The hosts moved on and came to Edon More.  
This was the time when from the far north-west,  
From fair white-foaming Assaroe, the harpers  
Of Keenbili arrived, with will to gladden  
The hosts with harping and with magic music.  
Because of friendship unto Maev and Al-yill  
These came; but it appeared to Maev and Al-yill  
That they were spies from the Ultonians. Wherefore,  
The hosts gave chase to them, till at Leek More  
“The Great Flat Flag,” those harpers went from them  
In shapes of swift, wild stags; for they were men

Of druidism and great art and knowledge.

This was the time wherein Cucullin promised  
That in whatever place he should see Maev,  
He from his sling, from his cranntowl, would sling  
A stone at her, which would not be far off  
From one side of her head. That thing was done.  
He, seeing Maev, cast from his sling a stone,  
Which killed her little bird on her one shoulder  
West of the ford. Maev crossed the ford; and then,  
He, from his sling casting a second stone,  
Killed her pet squirrel, which was on her shoulder  
East of the ford. And “Maeda of the Bird,”  
And “Maeda of the Squirrel,” are the names  
Upon those places, even unto this hour.

This was the time wherein the men of Erin  
Deliberated and took counsel, planning  
At dawn upon the morrow to begin  
Their ravaging and laying waste and spoiling  
Of Meath and wide Moy Bray and Moy Mweerhevna  
Up to Cucullin’s country. In the presence  
Of Fergus son of Roy they planned; and then  
To Fergus came his fervent memory  
And sharp affection for his fosterling;  
And he began to warn the men of Erin  
To have much fear; and he began to praise  
His fosterling, Cucullin, and to praise  
His gifts and deeds, as he before had praised them  
Beside Ath Gowla. Notwithstanding that,  
The hosts upon the morrow morn began  
Their ravaging and laying waste and spoiling  
Of all those lands. A cloud of red-brown fire,  
Heavy, wide-spread, they carried o’er those lands;  
And Maev made sword-land of Mweerhevna. Then,  
With all their captives and their herds of kine,  
Which they had taken, and their preys and spoils,  
They drew together, and moved on towards Cooley.

Cucullin, in the margin-land of Cooley,  
Upon a day, at midday, in a forest,  
Rested a little on his spear. His head  
Was on his fists: his fists were round his spear:  
His spear was on his knees. He rested so,  
And slept his sleep, until he heard a cry  
Coming right towards him from the north; and awful  
And fear-inspiring it sounded to him.  
Then he saw Laeg. "Whence was that cry, O Laeg?"  
Cucullin said to him. "From the north-west,"  
Laeg answered him, "upon the great highway  
Unto Kell Coo-an." "We will after it,"  
Cucullin said. They went until they reached  
The Ford of the Two Magic Deeds; and there  
They heard the chariot-sound of chariot-wheels  
Sound from the side of Grellah Culgary.  
Ere long they saw one chariot before them;  
And one red steed beneath it; and one leg  
Beneath the steed; and the long chariot-pole  
Through the steed's body, so that a thole-pin passed  
Through the pole's end across his powerful forehead.  
A blood-red woman with two blood-red eyebrows  
Sat on that chariot; and her bratt and raiment  
Were all blood-red. Betwixt the two hind-shafts  
Her long, red bratt trailed o'er the earth behind her.  
Nigh to the chariot walked one big, large man  
Arrayed in red. He, with his hazel-fork,  
Was driving on one cow in front of them.

"The cow rejoices not to be so driven,"  
Cucullin said. The woman answered him:  
"The cow pertains not to thee. She belongs  
To no near kinsman and no friend of thine."  
"The cows of Ulster all pertain to me,"  
Cucullin said; "and why is it the woman  
Who answers me? Why is it not the man?"  
"He is no man," the woman said to him.  
"He is Cold Wind, Reeds, Rushes." "And thyself?"

Cucullin said, "what is thy name?" She answered:  
"Keen-cutting Edge, Hair, Little Mouth, Hate, Horror."  
"Ye mock at me," Cucullin cried. With that  
He leapt on to the chariot. His two feet  
He placed on her two shoulders; and his dart  
He held above her crown. "Play not on me  
With thy edged weapons!" she cried out. "Then name  
Thy genuine name," he said. "Depart from me,"  
She said, "I am a woman-satirist;  
And it was Dawra son of Feeacna  
In Cooley, who, in payment for a song,  
Bestowed on me this cow." "Let us, then, hear  
Thy song," Cucullin said. "Depart from me,"  
She said; "no more be trembling o'er me here."  
Cucullin then went down; and she to him  
Sang a cheek-reddening, chafing, chiding song  
Composed in learned words. He understood;  
For he was trained and skilled in learned words;  
And, filled with ire, he made to leap again  
On to that chariot. Then he saw no chariot,  
No steed, no man, no cow, no blood-red woman  
With dragging, blood-red bratt; but saw, instead,  
That she, the woman with the blood-red bratt,  
Had now become one lonely carrion-bird,  
Red-mouthed and black, on a tree-branch near by.  
He comprehended then that he had seen  
That dread More-reega, daughter of Ernmas, queen  
Of heavy slaughters, who drinks up men's blood,  
Who shrieks on high for pale-lipped carcasses,  
Dispensing her confusion, famine, battle,  
Betwixt the seas of Erin; and he said:  
"Had I but known that it was thou, O Queen,  
We had not parted so." She answered him,  
Speaking in semblance of that carrion-bird:  
"E'en the small ill which thou hast done to me,  
Will cause thee ill, Cucullin. I had brought  
That cow, thou sawest, from a far Shee-mound



To visit the Donn of Cooley: I was wending  
To that Shee-mound again. Because, Cucullin,  
Thou didst attempt to stay me on my way  
Thou shalt find ill. Thou shalt have cause to rue  
Thy deed to me; and thou shalt rue Maev's Táin."

"How shall I rue this Táin?" Cucullin said.

"For I thereby shall gain much fame and glory.  
I shall break mighty battles. I shall slay  
Their mighty men. I shall survive this Táin."

"How wilt thou gain thy glory on this Táin?"

She said. "And how wilt thou survive this Táin?"

For when thou first shalt meet upon a ford  
A man commensurate with thyself in skill,  
I, in the shape of a lithe water-eel,  
Will wind around thy feet and cause thee there,  
Within that ford, unequal, death-sure combat."

"By all the gods by whom my people swear,  
I swear," Cucullin said, "that I will bruise thee  
Against the grey rock-flags within that ford;  
And ne'er shalt thou obtain from me thy healing  
Till Doom, unless thou then shalt rise from me."

"I, in the shape of a starved, grey bitch-wolf,  
Will come," she said, "and chase the startled kine  
Down towards that ford to overwhelm thee there."

"By all the gods by whom my people swear,  
I swear," Cucullin said, "that I will aim  
A stone and break thy right eye, or thy left eye;  
And thou shalt ne'er obtain from me thy healing  
Till Doom, unless thou then shalt rise and flee."

"I, in the shape of a red, hornless heifer,  
Will come," she said, "and guide one hundred heifers,  
Hornless and red, to trample through that ford  
Where thou wilt be; and thou shalt get thereby  
Unequal, death-sure fight. Thy head, Cucullin,  
Will be removed from thy curved throat that day."

"By all the gods by whom our Ulster swears,  
I swear," Cucullin said, "that I will hurl

A stone, and break on thee one hindward leg;  
And thou shalt ne'er obtain from me thy healing  
Till Doom, unless thou then shalt rise and flee."

After those words, the bitter-threatening bive  
Went from that place. Cucullin turned again  
Toward the same forest-watch whence he had come.

'Twas this same day that the great Donn of Cooley,  
Having around him fifty of his heifers,  
Came to the margin-land of Cooley. There  
He pawed and dug the earth in front of him.  
Then the More-reega, daughter of Ernmas, still  
In semblance of the flesh-consuming bive,  
The bitter-throated bird, flew till she lighted  
Upon the lofty boundary-marking stone  
In Tara of the land of Cooley. There  
She cried her words of warning and of pity  
Unto the Donn of Cooley; and she said,  
Addressing him: "O miserable one!  
O wretched Donn of Cooley! Hear my words.  
Have fear! The men of Erin come to hunt thee.  
Maev the daughter of Yohee Fayla comes  
To hunt thee, and to capture thee, and bind thee.  
Great her desire and her longing for thee!  
Have fear! Hear warning! Flee, O bull of Cooley!"

The Donn of Cooley, then, with fifty heifers,  
To the black, hidden Corrie of Glen Gatt  
In Cooley, went into retreat and hiding.

Cucullin, in the salt and marshy flats  
Of Connallia Mweerhevna in those days  
Slew no one. On the low foot-hills of Cooley,  
In his own natural country, he awaited  
Those hosts of Erin. Then Maev told her people  
To make a shed of shelter. With their shields  
Over their heads they made a shed of shelter;  
So that Cucullin from the little knolls,

And smooth and plain-topped hills, and rising hills,  
Might not achieve their shooting. And Cucullin  
Achieved no shooting of the men of Erin  
Along those fore-shores or around the knolls  
And hillocks of the margin-land of Cooley  
Upon that day. In Raeda Loha, then,  
In Cooley, the Four Fifths of Erin set  
Their rest: 'twas there they made their camp that night.

That night Cucullin with his charioteer  
Moved on beyond Glass Crond, a rapid stream  
Of Cooley, his own natural country. There  
He called to the quick mountain-streams of Cooley.  
He said: "I supplicate the river-streams,  
That they for me may fight. I supplicate  
The torrents and the waters of my country.  
I call to my Glass Crond." The men of Erin  
Moved on next day until they reached Glass Crond.  
They sought to pass it. Then that river rose  
And fought against them. And it swelled, and grew  
Into the tree-tops; and it spread, and swept  
One hundred of their battle-chariots down  
Its rapid-waved, wild inver; and it whelmed them  
In the deep-drowning sea. And none could cross  
That river on that day. Next day Maev said  
To her own people that some man should go  
To prove the river. At those words a man  
Of huge, tall bigness, one of Maev's own people,  
Rose to achieve that. Oola was his name.  
Upon his back he put a flag of stone  
For firmness; then he went to prove the stream.  
Then the stream hurled him down and made him dead,  
Deprived of life, the stone being on his back.  
Maev told her folk to lift him forth again  
And dig his grave-mound and erect his flag.  
His grave-mound and his flag beside the way  
Nigh to Glass Crond are to be seen this hour.

After that death the Four Great Fifths of Erin,

Because they could not pass Glass Crond, went up,  
Coasting the stream, until they reached the place  
Where the stream issued from the mountain. Closely  
Cucullin on that journey followed them;  
And, from the other side of the same stream,  
With his cranntowl shooting at them, he slew  
One hundred fighting-men of them; and slew  
Amidst those fighting-men, both Raen and Roy,  
The two historians of the Táin. Arrived  
Beside the well whence the stream issued forth,  
The people wished to pass between the well  
And mountain, and descend the vale again.  
But Maev allowed that not; for it to her  
Seemed well to leave her track upon that mountain  
Till Doom, to be a shame and a reproach  
To the Ultonians. Therefore they camped there  
Three days and nights, and dug the ground before them,  
Digging a pass across that mountain-ridge  
To be a lasting shame and strong disgrace  
To the Ultonians. "Barna Tána Bo,"  
That is the name upon that mountain-pass  
Since then; because it was across the mountain  
That the hosts passed. They passed, and so came down  
To Findabair of Cooley. There the hosts  
Divided, and they set the land in fire  
And flame, and gathered what there were of women  
And boys and maids and kine in mountainous Cooley,  
Till they were gathered all at Findabair.  
Then Maev surveyed each prey and prize and spoil.  
"It is not well that ye have gone," said Maev.  
"The Donn of Cooley is not with you here  
'Midst your great spoil." "He is not in the spoil,"  
All said. And then Maev's cowherd, namely, Lohar,  
Was called to Maev. "Where is the bull?" said she,  
"Know'st thou, perchance?" "I fear to tell," he answered.  
"E'en as we came nigh to this land of Cooley,  
He, with three twenties of his heifers round him,

To the black hidden Corrie of Glen Gatt  
In Cooley went into retreat and hiding.”

“Rise ye,” said Maev. “Between each two of you  
Carry a withe.” They did that (and from that  
That glen is called “Glen of the Withes,” Glen Gatt).  
They found the bull, and drove him forth with triumph  
Until he was in Findabair of Cooley.  
In which place, seeing Maev’s own cowherd there—  
Lohar, to wit—the bull repaired to him.  
He brought the entrails and the inward parts  
Of Lohar out on his high, lofty horns.  
With all his heifers he attacked that camp  
In Findabair till fifty fighting-men  
Had fallen and died. He went from them, then, straight  
Out of the camp and doon in Findabair;  
And not a man of all the men of Erin  
Knew whither he had gone. These things to them  
Seemed shame and taint, dishonour and disgrace.

To the wild desert woods around Slieve Gullion  
It was that the great Donn of Cooley now  
Had gone from them to new retreat and hiding.

The hosts moved on, driving their prey and spoil,  
Which they had taken. At Glen Taul that night  
They made their camp and fort. That glen is called  
Glen Taul, because of the abundant milk  
Yielded that night to all the hosts of Erin  
By the great flocks and herds which they had taken.

The hosts next day moved on until they reached  
Glass Colpa, a swift mountain-stream of Cooley.  
Glass Colpa rose against them; and it swept  
One hundred of their battle-chariots down  
Its rapid-waved, wild torrent, till it lost them  
In the deep-drowning sea. They skirted Colpa  
Up to its spring, even to Bally Al-yone,  
And slept that night at Leessa Leek,—so called  
Because of the enclosures for their calves  
Which they constructed in that place that night.

Next day the hosts moved on. As they moved on  
A thing occurred touching the sword of Fergus,  
Occurring as hereafter follows. Al-yill  
Early that day said to his charioteer,  
Namely, Faer-lōga: “Go from me, Faer-lōga!  
Discover Maev and Fergus. It with me  
Seems well to have some new memorial  
And index of their union and their friendship.”  
That charioteer rose forth. He found the queen,  
The daughter of Yohee Fayla, and great Fergus,  
Where that pair stayed behind in a fair brake  
The while the hosts moved on. The two heard not  
That spy beside them. Now, the sword of Fergus,  
His Calad-colg, his musical sword, which Leddy  
Had brought one time out from the magic Shee,  
And had bequeathed to Fergus—that curved sword,  
Which was a flaming candle, and whose voice  
Was sweeter than the sound of pipes of gold  
When played at evening in a royal house—  
Lay nigh him in that place wherein he lay  
Companioned by great Maev. Faer-lōga drew  
That sword from out its sheath, and left the sheath  
Empty and void not far from Fergus there.  
He went to Al-yill. “Is it so, indeed?”  
Said Al-yill. “It is so,” Faer-lōga said.  
“Here is the token.” “That is a good token,”  
Said Al-yill; and they smiled each at the other.  
“For her ’twas right,” said Al-yill. “’Tis for help  
On this her Táin that she hath done it. See  
Now that the wondrous sword be kept by thee  
Bright and well polished. Put it ’neath the seat  
Of my own chariot with a cloth of linen  
Folded about it there.” Fergus rose up  
Ere long, and made to don his sword again.  
“Alas!” said he. “What is thy grief?” asked Maev.  
“’Tis an ill deed that I have done to Al-yill,”  
He said; “and bide thou here while I go up

Into yon wood; and wonder not at all,  
Though it be long till I come back." Maev knew not  
That he had lost his sword. Fergus went up  
Amidst the trees, and took with him the sword  
Of his own charioteer. He made a sword  
Of wood amidst those trees, and thrust that sword  
Into his empty sheath. "We will go on  
Now to the hosts," he said. And they went on  
To the great hosts of the Four Fifths of Erin.

The hosts that day passed over swift Glass Gatlig.  
Glass Gatlig it was called because with gads  
And withes and ropes and cords they dragged their kine  
And brought their calves across it. After that,  
On steep Drumenna in the border-land  
'Twixt Connallia and Cooley they that night  
Encamped. They made a very strong encampment.

Fergus was called that night to play at feehill  
With Al-yill in his tent. He went; and Al-yill  
Laughed at him railingly. Fergus was wroth;  
But Al-yill said: "Be not wroth, then, O Fergus;  
For welcome is thy coming. Sit thou down.  
We will play feehill here and boo-an-bac."  
Fergus sat down, then, in the royal tent;  
And the two played at feehill on a board  
Of bronze: of gold and silver were the men.

The hour the cloudy shades of night came down,  
Cucullin, from Slieve Fauhan very near  
The hosts of Erin, with his strong cranntowl  
Began to hurl his sling-stones at that camp  
On cragged Drumenna; and all night he hurled;  
So that before the light of rising-time  
Upon the morrow, he had slain one hundred  
Firm fighting-men from 'midst the men of Erin.  
And all the hosts at light of rising-time  
Were dulled and deadened by their apprehension  
And fear and dread and terror of Cucullin.

Maev at that early dawning-hour then spake  
To Feeaha the son of Conall Carna  
Of Ulster, who was kinsman to Cucullin.  
She bade him go to seek Cucullin out,  
And offer terms. "What terms?" said Feeaha.  
"Not hard to tell," said Maev; "indemnity  
For aught of his that we have spoiled or taken:  
A feast in Croohan for him never-ending:  
Wine and sweet mead there to be poured for him:  
And he to come into the warlike service  
Of Al-yill and myself; for I myself  
Am, in real power, the sovereign of all Erin;  
And so, to serve me would advantage him  
More than his serving of that minor lord  
Whose he now is." (Now this, by the Ultonians,  
Has been accounted ever as the saying  
Most mirth-producing, droll, and laughable,  
That e'er was spoken on the Táin,—Maev's making  
"A minor lord" of that renowned great ruler  
Over a Fifth, who was the best in Erin,  
Namely, of Conor son of Fahtna son  
Of Ross the Red-haired son of Rury More.)  
Feeaha went upon that embassy.  
Cucullin welcomed him; and Feeaha  
Related all Maev's terms. Cucullin said:  
"I will not change the brother of my mother  
For e'er another sovereign. But let Maev  
And Fergus come to-morrow to Glen Fauhan,  
And meet me there in the red light of morning,  
And I will speak with Maev." Then Feeaha  
Went with these words back to the men of Erin.

So the next day in the red light of morning  
Fergus and Maev went down into Glen Fauhan  
To meet Cucullin. And across the glen  
Maev looked upon Cucullin; and her mind  
Tortured her greatly on that day, because  
No more than a fair, adolescent youth



He seemed to her to be. "Is yonder one,"  
She said, "that wonderful, renowned Cucullin  
Of whom ye speak, O Fergus?" But on Fergus  
A silence had fallen. In his breast there grew  
His pain of sharp affection while he viewed,  
For the first time, the little tender lad,  
His fosterling, whom he had left in Avvin  
Many long years before, and who had come  
Now to his seventeen years. "Well, let Cucullin  
Be spoken to by thee," Maev said. "Not so,"  
Fergus replied. "Let him be spoken to  
By thee thyself; for there is little distance  
Betwixt you here across the glen." Maev then  
Spake to the lad herself. She said to him:  
    "Thou young Cucullin son of Dectora,  
Featful swift hound of Cooley and Mweerhevna,  
I offer thee complete indemnity  
For aught of thine that we have spoiled or taken:  
A feast in Croohan for thee, never-ending,  
With wine and mead there to be poured for thee,  
If thou wilt come into the warlike service  
Of Al-yill and myself, and leave the service  
Of him whom now thou servest." Thus said Maev.  
Over the glen Cucullin answered her:  
    "O most proud Maev daughter of Yōhee Fayla,  
I will not change the brother of my mother  
For e'er another sovereign in all Erin.  
I will not stay from you my strong cranntowl,  
Unless ye will restore to me all women  
Whom ye have taken in this realm of Ulster.  
I will not stay my terrible cranntowl,  
Unless ye will restore to me, not only  
The kine of my own lands, but all the kine  
Which ye have taken in this realm of Ulster.  
For all the folk and all the kine of Ulster  
Pertain to me on this your great Invasion;  
And for them all I here keep watch and ward."

Maev at these words had anger. "This," she said,  
"Were far too much to give for warding-off  
The attacks of a young, tender lad." In anger,  
Then, on each side, they parted from each other,  
Leaving Glen Fauhan. Maev and Fergus went  
Back to their camp and to the hosts of Erin.



"MAEV AND FERGUS MEET CUCULLIN IN GLEN FAUHAN."

## BOOK IX

### BOOK IX

The Four Great Fifths of Erin kept their camp  
On cragged Drumenna yet three days and nights.  
But there no tents or booths were placed for them:  
No pleasant food or ale was served to them:  
No music and old lays were sung to them:  
They had no banqueting or mirth. For nightly,  
The hour the cloudy shades of night came down,  
Cucullin, from Slieve Fauhan, very near  
Those hosts of Erin, with his strong cranntowl  
Hurling his sling-stones 'mid their people, slew  
One hundred valiant fighting-men of them  
Ere came the light of rising in the morn.

Then Maev said: "These our hosts will not endure,  
And will not stay, Cucullin slaying so  
One hundred from us every night. And wherefore  
Should terms not now be carried to him? Wherefore  
Should he not be addressed from us?" "What terms  
Are these?" said Al-yill. "He shall have," said Maev,  
"The milch-kine and the bond-folk, and shall stay  
His dread cranntowl from the Four Fifths of Erin,  
Leaving our hosts to sleep." "Who shall go forth  
To carry him the terms?" asked Al-yill. "Who,"  
Maev asked him, "but Mac Roth, chief-messenger  
Of messengers of Erin?" "Nay," Mac Roth said,  
"I have not the place-knowledge; and I know not  
Where I shall find him." "Ask thou then of Fergus,"  
Maev answered him; "'tis likely that that knowledge  
Is with great Fergus." Fergus said to her:  
"Not so, O Maev; I know not where he is;

But there is one thing I think likely, namely,  
His being now 'twixt Fauhan and the sea,  
Letting the winds and sun be o'er his body,  
After his sleeplessness of night last night,  
While he was slaying and was striking down  
Your hosts, he all alone." That thing was true  
In Fergus. In that night a heavy snow  
Had fallen, so that all the Fifths of Erin  
Were with that snow as one white, level floor.  
Then down between Glen Fauhan and the sea  
Cucullin came for sunlight and for wind,  
After his sleeplessness of night that night;  
And there he cast from him his seven and twenty  
Waxed, board-smooth laynas, which with cords and ropes  
Next his white skin were wont to be tied fast,  
So that his prudence might not go from him  
When his war-fury should rise up. The snow  
Melted for thirty feet on each side round him,  
With the abundance of the heat of body  
And war-glow of Cucullin; and the gillie  
Could not stay very near to him because  
Of the abundance of the battle-anger  
And war-glow of that champion, and the ardour  
Then in Cucullin, and the heat of body.  
"A warrior now comes near us, O Cucullin,"  
Laeg cried to him. "What warrior?" asked Cucullin.  
"He is a brown-haired gillie," Laeg replied,  
"Wide-faced and beautiful. The bratt around him  
Is brown, distinctive. A short copper spear  
Secures that bratt; a profitable layna  
Is next his skin; and he has two barnbrogues  
Betwixt his two feet and the ground. He carries  
In one hand a white hazel club, in one  
A one-edged and tooth-hilted sword." "O gillie,"  
Cucullin said, "those are the signs, marks, badges  
Of messengers. One of the messengers  
Of Erin, that is there, who has come forth

To address me with a message." In short while  
Mac Roth attained that place wherein Laeg watched.  
"Under what service dost thou serve, O gillie?"  
Mac Roth inquired. "I serve the warrior-youth  
Yonder, above," said Laeg. Mac Roth came up  
Into that place wherein Cucullin was.  
"Under what service dost thou serve, O warrior?"  
Mac Roth inquired. "I serve," Cucullin said,  
"Conor the son of Fahtna Fahee son  
Of Ross the Red-haired son of Rury More."  
"Hast thou no nearer, more immediate service?"  
Mac Roth made question. "That," replied Cucullin,  
"Suffices now, this hour." "Couldst thou inform me,"  
Mac Roth went on, "in what place I might find  
That famed Cucullin, about whom the hosts  
Of Erin let from them an outcry, now  
Upon this hosting?" "What is to be said  
To him," Cucullin answered, "may be said  
To me." "I come," Mac Roth said, "to address him  
From Al-yill and from Maev. I carry to him  
Their terms and war-conditions." "What conditions  
Carriest thou?" Cucullin asked of him.  
"He shall be given," Mac Roth replied to him,  
"The milch-kine and the bond-folk, and shall stay  
His dread cranntowl from the Four Fifths of Erin,  
Leaving the hosts to sleep. Not mild or gentle  
That thunder-shower feat is, which he pours  
Upon them each long night." Cucullin said:  
"E'en were Cucullin here to hear these terms,  
He would not take them. For the men of Ulster,  
Being incited and attacked with satire,  
And hot, cheek-reddening insult and invective,  
Would slay their milch-kine to redeem their honour,  
If they possessed no dry kine; and, moreover,  
They would take up to them their bondwomen  
On to their beds, and would beget a folk  
Who would be bond-folk through their mothers."

Mac Roth returned. "Didst thou not find that youth?"

Maev asked of him. "I found," Mac Roth replied,

"An awe-inspiring, angry, glowing youth

Between Glen Fauhan and the sea. I know not

Whether he was Cucullin." "Took he from thee

The terms we sent?" "Nay, truly," said Mac Roth;

And he related to them then the reasons

Why the terms were not taken. Fergus said:

"'Tis he, indeed, with whom thou wast conferring."

"Let other terms be borne to him," said Maev.

"What terms?" asked Al-yill. "He shall have," said Maev,

"The dry kine and the free folk, and shall stay

His dread cranntowl from the Four Fifths of Erin,

Leaving our hosts to sleep. Not mild or gentle

That thunder-shower feat is which he works

Upon them each dark night." "Who shall go forth

To carry him the terms?" asked Al-yill. "Who,"

Maev asked him, "but Mac Roth?" "Yea, I will go,"

Mac Roth said; "this time I have the place-knowledge."

Mac Roth went forth then to address Cucullin.

"'Tis to address thyself that I have come

This time," he said, "because this time I know

Thou art thyself that greatly-famed Cucullin."

"What hast thou brought?" Cucullin asked of him.

"Thou shalt be given," Mac Roth replied to him,

"The dry kine and the free folk, and shalt stay

Thy dread cranntowl from the Four Fifths of Erin,

Leaving the hosts to sleep. Not mild or gentle

That thunder-shower feat is, which thou pourest

Upon them each dark night." Cucullin said:

"I will not take the terms. The men of Ulster

Will slay their dry kine to redeem their honour,

For they are generous; and they will be

Without dry kine or milch-kine. And, moreover,

They to the querns and kneading-troughs will put

Their free women, unto slave services

And into bond-work. 'Tis not good with me  
To leave that plight in Ulster after me—  
Bond-maids and serf-women being so made  
Of daughters of the kings and chiefs of Ulster.”  
“Exist there, then, terms that thou wilt accept  
On this occasion?” “There exist such terms.”  
“Tell me thy terms,” Mac Roth said. “By my word,”  
Cucullin said, “’tis not I who will tell them.”  
“What then?” Mac Roth said. “If,” Cucullin answered,  
“There be amidst your doon one who can tell  
The terms I have, let him recount them to you;  
And if there be not, let there be no sending  
To address me any more with messages  
Of terms and war-conditions. For whoe’er  
He be who comes, his life shall here have ending.”  
Mac Roth went back. “Didst thou not find him then?”  
Maev asked of him. “I found him,” said Mac Roth.  
“Took he the terms?” said Maev. “He took them not,”  
Mac Roth replied. “Exist there terms,” said Maev,  
“Which he will take?” “He has terms,” said Mac Roth.  
“Related he the terms?” said Maev. “This, truly,”  
Mac Roth said, “was his word: not he himself  
Will tell the terms to you.” “What then?” said Maev.  
“If,” said Mac Roth, “amidst ourselves there be  
One who can tell his terms, let him relate them.  
And if there be not, let there be no sending  
To address him any more with messages  
Of terms and war-conditions. And one thing  
I here aver,” Mac Roth said, “though it be  
To carry him the sovereignty of Erin,  
It is not I who will go forth to him  
To find from him my death and final ending.”

Then it was, truly, that Maev looked on Fergus.  
“What are these terms which that one asks of us,  
O Fergus?” Maev said. “I perceive no good,  
Even the least good, for you from his terms,”  
Fergus replied. “What are these terms?” said Maev.

“A man,” said Fergus, “of the men of Erin  
Each day to meet him on a ford in combat;  
And, for such time as he shall be at slaying  
That man, to let the hosts move freely forth;  
But, when the man is slain, an obligation  
To be upon the hosts, with their great prey,  
To bide within their doon and strong encampment  
Till hour of rising next day in the morn.”  
“This is our conscience,” Al-yill said, “these terms  
Are slight and easy.” “What he asks is good,”  
Maev said to them. “He asks these terms,” said Fergus,  
“That so he may detain you here and hold you,  
With all your captives and great prey of kine,  
Until the Ultonians rise from their long Kesh,  
And muster all their hosts, and journey south,  
And grind you to the sand and earth and gravel.  
And it is wonderful to me,” said Fergus,  
“Their being so long at rising from that Kesh.”  
“We take the terms,” said Maev. “We deem it lighter  
Daily to lose from us one man than nightly  
To lose from us one hundred. And, moreover,  
There will be one amongst our battle-champions  
And battle-chiefs, who, meeting in a combat  
That slight, unbearded youth, will by his strength  
O’erthrow him, and so clear us of this strait.”  
“Who,” Al-yill said, “shall go to bear these terms,  
And to relate them to Cucullin?” “Who,”  
Maev asked of him, “but Fergus?” “Nay,” said Fergus,  
“Not so. I will not go till there is given  
A contract, with securities and sureties  
And warranties enough to bind you fast  
To keep the terms, and to bind him fast, too,  
To keep the terms.” “We accept that,” said Maev.  
And with strong pledges Fergus bound them down.  
His steeds were caught for Fergus, and his chariot  
Made ready; whereupon for Edarcool,  
A tender youth of Maev’s and Al-yill’s folk,



A son of Feda and of Leth´-riny,  
His own two steeds were caught. "Whither," said Fergus,  
"Wilt thou fare forth?" "I will fare forth with thee,"  
Said Edarcool, "to look upon the shape  
And figure of Cucullin." Fergus said:  
"There is no wish with me that thou shouldst go,  
Albeit I hate thee not; but I am loth  
That thou and he should meet. Thou art a lad,  
Brisk, lively, gay, insolent, arrogant,  
Pert, overweening; and that other lad  
Is angerful, hot, ardent. And I think  
Some cause of anger will arise between you  
Before ye part." "Canst thou, then, not protect me?"  
Asked Edarcool. "I can, indeed," said Fergus,  
"Provided only that thou showest him  
No scorning and no disesteem." They rode  
In their war-chariots then upon their way  
To reach that place wherein Cucullin was.

Between Glen Fauhan and the sea Cucullin  
With his own charioteer, even with Laeg,  
Was playing at boo-an-bac. And not a thing  
Could pass there unperceived by Laeg, so true  
His watching was; and still each second game  
He won from his young lord, Cucullin. "Cucuc,"  
Said Laeg, "here comes a chariot-rider towards us."  
"Describe him, then, good Laeg," Cucullin said;  
And Laeg described him thus:

"Larger," said he,

"Than is some heathy knoll, rising alone  
From out a grassy level, seems to me  
His noble chariot. Larger than the tree,  
Reverenced and old, that stands upon the green  
Of some king's doon, appears to me the hair  
That curls and waves in golden bright abundance  
About that warrior's head. A crimson fooan,  
Fringed and embroidered, folds him round: a spike  
Of graven gold secures it. In his hand

He holds a wide, red-flaming spear. A shield,  
Carven, and compassed by a ridge of gold,  
He has; and a long sword-sheath, which for size  
Is like the rudder of some kingly vessel,  
Reposes on the huge and seated thighs  
Of that great, haughty warrior, planted there  
'Midst of his chariot."

Then Cucullin cried:

"Oh, welcome, ever welcome is the coming  
Of that belovéd guest! I know that guest.  
It is my guardian and my fosterer,  
My gentle, noble Fergus, who comes there.  
But, my good Laeg, as for the long, great sword,  
Great like the rudder of some kingly vessel,  
I have been told that 'tis a sword of wood,  
Which now fills up that sword-sheath of our Fergus."  
"I see," said Laeg, "a second chariot-rider  
Approaching us. To him it seems to be  
Sufficiency of joy and entertainment  
Merely to watch the prancing of his steeds,  
And the swift course they make across the land."  
"That rider," said Cucullin, "is some youth  
Amongst the men of Erin who comes hither  
To spy upon my shape, and scrutinize  
Each form and feature. For—thou knowest it well—  
I am much spoken of and talked about  
Amongst those lads beyond there, in their doon."

Fergus arrived, and leapt from out his chariot.

"Speak," said he, "art thou true and trusty towards me?"

"Trusty and true I am," Cucullin said,

"O dear and welcome, ever-welcome guest!

If a bird-flock shall come unto this plain,

A wild-goose thou shalt have, with half another;

If fish shall come into these river-invers,

A salmon thou shalt have, with half another;

And thou shalt have a drink from the sand-pools,

And have thy fistful of green river-cress,

Thy fistful of sweet sea-weed and sea-herbs;  
And if necessity be laid on thee  
To fight a combat, I myself will go  
To meet thy foeman at the danger-ford;  
And Laeg shall stay to watch and guard thee here,  
While thou dost take thy deep repose and sleep.”

“Well do I know, belovéd fosterling,”  
Said Fergus, “how it stands with thee, and how  
These means are all the best thou canst command  
For entertainment of a welcome guest  
Now on this Táin. But I have come this time  
To bring a message from the men of Erin.  
They offer single combat. I have come  
To bind thee thereunto. Accept it, thou.”

“I bind myself to that, my master Fergus,”  
Cucullin answered. And no longer time  
Their talk continued, lest the men of Erin  
Should say that Fergus had deceived, betrayed,  
And left them, for his fosterling and pupil.

For Fergus then his chariot was prepared,  
And he rode back; but Edarcool remained  
Nigh to that much-famed lad, who there alone  
Defended Ulster; and he stared upon  
Each form and feature of that other lad,  
For a long while and a great space of time.

Cucullin said: “What little animal  
Art thou observing with great care, O gillie?”  
“Thyself,” said Edarcool. Cucullin said:  
“The eye could swiftly make a circuit o’er it.”  
“That is what I observe,” said Edarcool;  
“Thou art not large. I know not anything  
For which thou needst be feared. I see in thee  
No overwhelming of a host, or cause  
For hate and horror and great dread. A shapely,  
Fair youth, thou art, I own it. Thou hast feats  
Sightly and various; but for counting thee  
Where fighters, warriors, and great battle-champions

Might be—it is most true we should not count thee.”

“I will not slay thee,” said Cucullin, “knowing  
The safeguard under which thou camest hither,  
Namely, the safeguard of my master, Fergus.  
I swear by all the gods of my own folk,  
Howbeit, that if ’twere not for that safeguard,  
It would now be thy cloven, scattered quarters  
Which would return from me to yon great camp  
Behind thy chariot-wheels.” “Provoke me not,”  
Said Edarcool, “and—for this wondrous contract,  
Which has been bound by Fergus on the hosts  
And on thyself, namely, a one-man combat—  
It will be I who, of the men of Erin,  
Will be the first to come to thee to-morrow.”

Edarcool straight turned back. He took to talking  
Then to his charioteer. “Gillie,” said he,  
“An obligation is upon me truly  
To meet Cucullin at the ford to-morrow.”  
“Truly thou didst so vow,” the gillie said.  
“Howbeit, I know not that the thing so vowed  
Will be accomplished.” “Which thing were the better,”  
Said Edarcool, “to do the deed to-morrow,  
Or now, to-night, to do it?” “’Tis our conscience,  
Better to miss a victory to-morrow,”  
The gillie said, “than to win death to-night.”  
“Nay, turn the chariot round again, O gillie,”  
The lad said. “By the gods of my own folk,  
I swear that never till the Breast of Doom  
Will I again return unto the camp,  
Until I take the head from yonder lad,  
And show Cucullin’s head.” The charioteer  
Then turned the chariot once again, and turned  
Its left side towards the ford. Laeg saw that thing.  
“Cucuc,” said Leag, “there is the chariot-rider  
Who was here last.” “What of that, O my gillie?”  
Cucullin said. “His left board,” said the gillie,  
“Is now turned towards us, as he nears the ford.”

“O gillie, that is Edarcool, who seeks  
A combat from me now,” Cucullin said;  
“And ’tis not well with me to slay him, knowing  
The safeguard under which he travelled hither,  
Namely, the safeguard of my master, Fergus;  
But there is on me, verily, no bond  
Or obligation to reject fair combat.  
Carry my weapons to the ford. Unworthy  
I should esteem myself, were he to be  
Down at yon ford before me.” And Cucullin  
Went to the stream, and straightway bared his sword  
Above his curved bright shoulder; and was ready,  
So, on the ford for the other lad to come.  
Then Edarcool arrived. “What dost thou ask,  
O gillie?” said Cucullin. He replied:  
“Combat with thee is what I ask and wish for;  
And thou art bound to grant it manfully.”  
Cucullin made a sod-stroke at the sod  
Which was beneath the feet of the other lad,  
Slicing the sod; and the lad fell supine,  
The sod being on his upturned breast. “Go now,”  
Cucullin said, “for I have given thee warning.”  
“I will not go from thee,” said Edarcool,  
“Till I have reached thee.” Whereupon, Cucullin  
Made with his sword an edge-blow, shaving swiftly  
The hair of that other lad from nape to brow,  
From ear to ear,—as though with a light razor  
It was he shaved,—drawing no drop of blood.  
“Go now,” he said, “Thou hast a two-fold warning.  
And I have made of thee a cause of laughter.”  
“I will not go from thee,” said Edarcool,  
“Till I have reached thee.” At which words Cucullin  
Struck at the armpits of the other lad,  
With his sword lightly; and the raiment fell  
From Edarcool; and his skin was not reddened.  
“Go now,” Cucullin said, “for I have given  
A proof of power.” The other lad replied:

“I will not go, till I have taken thy head  
And trophies; or till thou hast taken my head  
And trophies.” “’Tis this last,” Cucullin said,  
“To wit, that I shall take thy head and trophies,  
Which shall be brought to pass.” Whereat Cucullin  
Made with his sword a crown-stroke from the crown  
Of Edarcool e’en to his navel; and made,  
Swift upon that, a cross-stroke through his navel,  
So that the three disjointed parts of him  
Fell to the earth in the one point of time.

That was the downfall, then of Edarcool,  
A son of Feda and of Leth’-rĭny,  
A tender youth of Maev’s and Al-yill’s folk.

Now of that combat naught was known to Fergus.  
And that was natural for him; since Fergus  
Never for aught looked rearwards o’er his back,  
At sitting, or at rising, or on travels,  
Or at departing, or in fights and strivings  
And battles—that thus no one e’er could say,  
That he in fear gazed rearwards o’er his back.

The charioteer of Edarcool ere long  
Came up with him. “Where is thy lord, thou gillie?”  
Cried Fergus. “He has fallen,” said the servant,  
“Slain by Cucullin in the ford.” Full wrath,  
Swift, fire-fleet, sudden, leaped in Fergus then.  
“It was not fitting, truly,” he cried out,  
“In that unearthly sprite so to insult  
And wound me with regard to one who came  
Beneath my safeguard and protection. Turn  
The chariot for us, gillie,” Fergus said.  
“I will turn back now to address Cucullin.”

The gillie turned the chariot; and they fared  
Back toward the ford, and saw Cucullin there.  
“What caused thee, thou uncouth, unearthly sprite,”  
Fergus cried out to him, “so to insult  
And wound me with regard to one who came

Beneath my safeguard and protection?" Then,  
Cucullin fell down kneeling before Fergus;  
And Fergus, in his anger and hot wrath,  
Rode three times in his chariot past him. Kneeling  
And bowed, Cucullin cried: "My master, Fergus,  
By the good fosterage which thou didst give me,  
Say which would seem to thee the better, namely,  
I to take his life and his spoils, or he  
To take my life and my spoils? Furthermore,  
Ask his own gillie which one of us two  
Was sinful in what happened." Fergus said,  
Looking upon the lad, his fosterling:  
"That which has happened seems the best to me."

Then Fergus tied a withy round the feet  
Of Edarcool, and round his cloven neck;  
And dragged him o'er the ground behind the steeds  
And chariot-wheels; and where the ground was rough,  
The cloven fragments parted round the juts  
And points of rock; and where the ground was smooth,  
They met again. And Fergus trailed them thus  
Across the sloping camp, up to the tent  
Of Al-yill and of Maev, and called aloud:  
"Here is your tender youth for you, and here  
The message that ye sent him out to bring!"

And Maev came forth, and stood without the door  
Of her own tent; and there she lifted up  
Her voice of lamentation; and she said:  
"It seemed to us that this young hound was full  
Of life and ardour when he left the camp;  
And now, it seems to us, he did not leave it  
Beneath a true man's safeguard when he left it  
Guarded by Fergus."

From great Fergus then  
Broke forth his chuckle of laughter. "How," said he,  
"Should this mere whelp, this woman's lap-dog, dare  
To approach that slaughter-hound, whom now the Four  
Great Fifths of Erin will not dare to pass,

Or move beyond, to reach their native homes?  
Yea, I myself might deem it fortunate  
To escape thus safe and whole from out his hands.”  
For Edarcool his grave-mound then was made:  
His stone was set: his name was writ in ogam:  
His funeral-cry was wailed above him there.  
That night Cucullin stayed his famed cranntowl;  
And o’er the weary hosts came welcome sleep.



## BOOK X

### BOOK X

A man of powerful bigness, excellent  
In shape and race, arose to attack Cucullin  
At milking-time next morn. This was Nathcrantil,  
A prowess-full man of Maev's and Al-yill's folk.  
He deemed it not worth while to bear his weapons  
Down to the pool; but thrice nine little spits  
Of holly, sharpened, singed, and burned, he took  
Down to the pool, wherewith to kill Cucullin.  
Finding the youth before him in the ford,  
He hurled a spit on him, whereat Cucullin  
Leapt in the air, and lighted very lightly  
Upon the upper end of the little spit,  
E'en as it struck into the ground. Nathcrantil  
Then hurled on him his second spit. Cucullin,  
Like any bird, flew from the first spit, lighting  
Upon the upper end of the second spit,  
E'en as it struck into the ground. Nathcrantil  
Then hurled on him his third spit; and Cucullin  
Flew to the third; and so from spit to spit  
He passed, until the last of those thrice nine  
Had been discharged at him: there were no more.

It was just then that a long bird-flock came  
O'er the cleared plain hard by them; and Cucullin,  
Like any bird, went after them, that so  
They might not go from him, and that he so  
Might get his share of food for night that night;  
For fish and birds and deer-flesh on this Táin  
Were all he had to serve and nourish him.  
But this is what seemed plain now to Nathcrantil—  
Namely, that it was in a road of rout,

Of flight and of defeat that thus Cucullin  
Had gone from him. He went upon his way  
To the tent-door of Al-yill and of Maev;  
And there he lifted his loud voice on high  
Like to the wave-roar of the sea. "That youth,"  
He said to them, "whom ye denominate  
'The most renowned Cucullin' went from me  
In road of rout, of flight, and of defeat,  
At milking-time this morn." Maev answered him:  
"We knew it would be true that when a hero  
And a good warrior should advance to him,  
That young, unbearded wildling would not stand  
For long before him. We see now 'tis true;  
For when a deedful warrior goes, the youth  
Fights not, but flees in rout and flight before him."  
That thing was heard by Fergus; and to him  
'Twas as his death-wound that a man should boast  
Of having made Cucullin flee. He said  
To Feeaha the son of Conall Carna:  
"Go, Feeaha, address Cucullin. Say  
From me that he was noble, generous,  
While he was bravely out before the hosts;  
And it were nobler now to hide himself  
Than to flee thus before one man of them.  
It is no greater shame to him to hide  
Than 'tis to others who are hiding now."  
Feeaha, therefore, went to address Cucullin.  
Cucullin welcomed him. "Faithful to me  
I deem that welcome," Feeaha replied;  
"But this time I have come to thee from Fergus.  
He says that thou wast noble, generous,  
While thou wast bravely out before the hosts;  
And it were nobler now to hide thyself  
Than thus to flee before one man of them;  
For 'tis no greater shame to thee to hide  
Than 'tis to others who are hiding now."  
"Which man among you boasts?" Cucullin asked.

“Nathcrantil, verily,” said Feeaha.  
“The feat which I performed upon his spits,”  
Cucullin said, “should have debarred that boasting.  
But do not Fergus and all chiefs in Ulster  
Know that I ne’er do harm to charioteers  
Or messengers or folk unarmed? Not arms  
Were with this man, but little spits of wood.  
I will not wound him till he brings his arms.  
Let him come down ’twixt Fauhan and the sea  
To-morrow, armed; and then, however early  
He comes there, he will find me ready there;  
And, verily, I will not flee before him.”  
Feeaha straight returned unto the camp.  
He told these words. It to Nathcrantil then  
Seemed long until the light of day should come  
Next day when he should go to attack Cucullin.

At earliest light of dawning-time next day  
Cucullin rose after the watch of the night  
His anger came on him. In rapid anger  
He flung his bratt around him, and observed not  
The stone of rock which was beside him there;  
So that he flung his bratt around the stone,  
Plucking it from the earth; and it remained  
Between his body and his bratt. He knew not  
That he had plucked it, owing to that anger  
Which was upon him then. Nathcrantil came.  
His arms that day were carried on a wain,  
So many were they. Then he saw Cucullin,  
Who was transformed with ire and battle-rage.  
He knew him not. “Art thou indeed Cucullin?”  
He said. “And if I am?” Cucullin asked.  
“Then,” said Nathcrantil, “thou art more a warrior  
Than thou wast yesterday. Nevertheless,  
It would not be the head of a small lamb  
That I would carry to the camp to be  
My trophy; and I will not take the head  
Of any beardless boy.” “I am not he,”

Cucullin said; "go to him round the hill."  
Cucullin came to Laeg. "O Laeg," he said,  
"Pluck up thy fistfuls of this winter grass,  
Which is brown-yellow, withered. Bind the grass  
Around my chin that I may have my beard;  
He will not slay me while I lack it." Laeg  
Plucked up the grass, and made the beard, and then  
Cucullin met Nathcrantil round the hill.  
"I think that is more fitting," said Nathcrantil,  
Mocking, disdainful; "but I now will fight thee.  
Take the right way of fighting with me now."  
"Instruct me in the way," Cucullin said.  
"When I shall throw a cast," Nathcrantil answered,  
"Elude it not; but keep thy ground." Cucullin  
Replied: "I vow that I will not elude it,  
Except by ascending." Then Nathcrantil threw  
A powerful cast. Cucullin leapt a leap  
Into the air, ascending; and the spear  
Passed underneath him as he leapt. Nathcrantil  
Cried angrily: "Thou workest ill, thou wildling,  
Thus to elude my cast." Cucullin said:  
"Elude my cast by ascending." Then he threw  
A powerful cast on high, so that the spear  
Struck on Nathcrantil from on high, and struck  
The crown of his head, and pierced the bone of his crown.  
"Alas!" Nathcrantil said, "thou art indeed  
The best war-champion which there is in Erin.  
I in the camp have four and twenty sons.  
I will go tell them now what hidden riches  
I have; and I will come to thee again,  
That thou mayst take from me my head. I die  
If once thy spear be taken from my head."  
"Good," said Cucullin, "thou wilt come again."  
Nathcrantil went to the camp of the men of Erin.  
Each one then came to meet him. "Where," said each,  
"Is the head of the Ree-astartha? Hast thou slain him?"  
"Wait, heroes," said Nathcrantil, "I must speak

To my own sons, and then go back again  
To fight Cucullin at the ford." He came  
Soon to the stream again. He cast his sword  
Against Cucullin; and the sword broke in two  
Against the stone of rock which was between  
Cucullin's body and his bratt; and then  
Cucullin with his sword sprang at Nathcrantil,  
And took from him his head to be a trophy  
And war-memorial of this first combat  
Which he had fought with a great battle-hero  
Amidst the heroes of the men of Erin.

The men of Erin then deliberated  
As to who should be sent from them the next  
To attack Cucullin; and all said that Coor  
Son of Daw-loath' was he. For Coor was thus:  
A rough and bitter hero, very surly;  
And it was difficult to be with him  
In eating or in sleeping. All averred  
That should it be this Coor who should be slain,  
That would remove from them a sore oppression;  
Yet should it be Cucullin who should fall,  
That would be better. Then Maev sent for Coor.  
"Ye think my powers sure and wonderful!"  
Said Coor. "A youth like that one is too tender  
For such as I am. Had I known this thing,  
I had not come; but I had found a gillie  
Of equal age with him from 'midst my people,  
To go against him at the ford." "O Coor,"  
Cormac Conlingish, then (the son of Conor),  
Said to him, "it will be a marvel to us  
If thine own strength avails to slay Cucullin."  
"Good, then," said Coor, "since on myself 'tis laid,  
Make ready to fare forth to-morrow morn  
Early upon your road. 'Twill not delay me  
For long to kill that little, young wild deer.  
I will prepare a clear, free road before you."

When the bright-lofty, fiery-blazing sun  
Arose next morn above the mountain, Coor  
Son of Daw-loath' arose. He took with him  
A loaded wain of war-gear and of weapons,  
Wherewith to kill Cucullin. That same morn  
Cucullin very early fell to playing  
His various feats of skill which he had learnt  
From Oo-aha, from Scawtha, and from Weefa  
Far in the east. At rising-hour each morn  
It was his wont to play each feat of them,  
That so not one might ever go from him  
Into oblivion and forgetfulness.

Coor for a third-part of the day remained  
Behind the rampart of his shield, expecting  
To kill Cucullin; and Cucullin ceased not  
The madness of his feats; and he observed not  
Coor who lurked there. 'Twas then Laeg said: "O Cucuc,  
'Twere well to serve that man who is expecting  
To kill thee here." Cucullin then was playing  
His apple-feat; and the eight apples rose  
And fell from hand to hand through the clear air,  
Like flying bees on a bright summer's day.  
He, with the apple in his hand, then made  
A warrior-cast, which pierced Coor's shield, and pierced  
His brow, and bore a portion of Coor's brains  
Out through the rearward hollow of his nape.  
So at that ford Coor found his end of life-time.

Fergus went up to speak with Maev and Al-yill.  
"Arrest your course!" he cried. "Make your camp here  
Till light of rising-time to-morrow morn.  
Then ye must find some other champion. Coor  
Son of Daw-loath' hath found his end of life-time."

The Four Great Fifths of Erin rested then  
A little to the westward of Drumenna,  
And made their camp and their encampment there.  
After that day, for very many days,

Even weeks of days, in combat with Cucullin  
Each day a warrior fell. Of the distinguished  
Men who fell so were Lath son of Daw-bro',  
Srub Dawra son of Fedig, Bove and Cruthen,  
Nathcorpa, Marc, Maellia and Boguina.  
Howbeit, to tell the manner of the fall  
Of every separate man of these were tedious.

After those weeks of days of daily combat,  
On that lone lad who there defended Ulster—  
On that Cucullin—there grew weariness,  
And wearing-out of strength, and hard exhaustion,  
By reason of the hardness of those combats  
And their great number; and he feared indeed  
That he himself, through that great weariness,  
Would fall in fight with some unwearied champion,  
Some fresh, unwasted man from 'midst those hosts.

This was the time and hour wherein Cucullin  
Said to his charioteer, even to Laeg:  
“Go from me, Laeg; go unto yonder camp  
Of the men of Erin; bear interrogation  
To those who have a bond with me, my brethren  
In arms, my fellow-learners and co-pupils:  
Faerdeeah son of Daman son of Dawra,  
Faerbay the son of Baetan, and Faerbay  
Son of Faerbend, and Bress the son of Ferb,  
And Lewy son of Solmoy, and Faerdaet  
A son of Daman. And bear, furthermore,  
His own interrogation separately  
To my own genuine foster-brother, Lewy  
The son of Nōs the son of Alamac,  
Who, when I was far distant, with regard  
To Emer daughter of Forgall, held in honour  
My honour. Bear to him my special blessing.  
Ask him, that he may tell to thee what man  
Will come to attack me at the ford to-morrow.”

Laeg, at those words, went forth into the camp

Of the men of Erin; and he took with him  
Interrogation to the fellow-pupils  
And comrades of Cucullin; and he went  
After that straight into the tent of Lewy  
The son of Nōs; and Lewy welcomed him.

“Truly, I think that thou art faithful,” Laeg said.  
“Faithful toward thee I am indeed,” said Lewy.  
“I come,” said Laeg, “to address thee from Cucullin.  
To thee especially and separately  
He sent interrogation and his special  
Blessing, that thou mayst tell to me what man  
Will go to attack him at the ford to-morrow.”

Lewy replied: “May the anathema  
Of all his friendship and his comradeship  
Be on the man who will go! It is Cucullin’s  
Own fellow-learner, brother-in-arms, and comrade,  
Faerbay son of Faerbend. A while ago  
He was convoyed to the wide, royal tent  
Of Maev and Al-yill. The maid Findabair  
Was placed at his one hand. ’Tis she who brimmed  
His drinking-horn. ’Tis she who gave a kiss  
With every draught she poured. ’Tis she who set  
Her own hands to his portion. Not for all  
Does Maev intend that wine which was poured out  
There for Faerbay; for only fifty wains  
Thereof were brought from Croohan.” Laeg went back,  
Grieved, heavy-headed, very sad, unjoyful,  
Sighing. Cucullin saw him, and he said:  
“’Tis heavy-headed, very sad, unjoyful,  
Sighing, that Laeg is as he comes. ’Tis truly  
One of my comrades and my fellow-pupils  
Who will come forth to fight with me to-morrow.  
Good, my good Laeg,” Cucullin said, “who comes  
To attack me here to-morrow?” Laeg replied:  
“May the sure malediction of his bond  
And of his friendship and his comradeship  
Be on the man who will come! It is thy very



Own fellow-learner, brother-in-arms, and comrade,  
Faerbay son of Faerbend. A while ago  
He was convoyed to the wide, royal tent  
Of Maev and Al-yill. The maid Findabair  
Was placed at his one hand. 'Tis she who brimmed  
His drinking-horn. 'Tis she who gave a kiss  
With every draught she poured. 'Tis she who set  
Her own hands to his portion. Not for all  
Does Maev intend that wine which was poured out  
There for Faerbay; for only fifty wains  
Thereof were brought from Croohan." "O good Laeg,"  
Cucullin cried, "return again to Lewy.  
Bid him come hither to this hill of Crannig,  
Here to have speech with me." Lewy came there.  
"Is it indeed Faerbay son of Faerbend,"  
Cucullin said, "who will come forth to-morrow?"  
"'Tis he indeed," said Lewy. "Alas! for that!"  
Cucullin said, "I shall not be in life  
After that combat and that meeting. Two  
Of equal age we are, of equal deftness,  
Two equal when we meet. And he is fresh,  
Not having fought, while I am worn and wearied  
By reason of the number of these combats,  
And watching here alone before yon hosts.  
O Lewy, greet Faerbay from me. Say this:  
'Tis not true soldiership to come against me.  
Bid him come down beneath this hill to-night  
And speak with me himself." Lewy went back.  
He gave Cucullin's words; yet, notwithstanding  
Those words, Faerbay would not refuse the combat.  
When, then, he thus would not refuse the combat,  
Faerbay delayed not till the morn, but went  
At meeting-time of day with night that night,  
To address Cucullin, and to put away  
His league and his sword-friendship with Cucullin.  
And Feeaha the son of Conall Carna  
Went with him to the glen. Cucullin there,

Meeting Faerbay, firmly appealed to him  
By the great foster-mother and preceptress  
Who had taught both of them, namely, by Scawtha,  
Preceptress of the warriors of the east;  
And still Faerbay would not refuse that combat.  
When, then, Faerbay would not refuse the combat,  
Hot ire, fire-fleet, vehement, very sudden,  
Laid hold upon Cucullin. "Then, Faerbay,"  
He cried, "recant thy league and thy sword-friendship."  
And he moved off from him in rage and anger.

As he was going, then, up the rough, dark hill,  
Sharply he trod on a sharp holly-shoot,  
Which pierced the sole of his foot, and bathed itself  
Amidst his skin and blood and bones. He dragged it  
Out from his sole, and dragged it from its roots,  
And shouted to Faerbay: "Go not, Faerbay,  
Till thou hast seen this find which I have found."  
"Throw it," Faerbay said; and Cucullin threw  
Over his shoulder backward the sharp spike  
Which had been bathed in the blood and flesh of his foot.  
It was one thing to him whether it reached  
Faerbay or reached him not; and he looked not  
Behind him once to know whether it reached.  
That missile struck Faerbay in his hollow nape,  
And issued 'twixt his lips to the ground. Whereat,  
Feeaha son of Conall Carna shouted—  
"Mah thra an faughard" (Good is the cast indeed).  
He thought it wonderful that one should slay  
A champion with a little holly-spine.  
Faerbay son of Faerbend died there that eve  
Within that glen beside the height of Crannig.

Something was heard. Fergus it was, who sang  
With hatred and great scorn and joyfulness:  
"Truly, Faerbay, foolish thy journey was,  
Unto this glen where now thy grave shall be.  
Death and last end have reached thee in this place,  
Where thou didst put from thee thy friendship-vow.

And Faughard now (The Cast) shall be the name  
On Crannig, yonder high, rough-sided hill,  
Whence that good cast of the holly-shaft was made.  
And Glen Faerbay shall be the undying name  
On thy death-glen, where now thou liest, Faerbay.”

At morn Cucullin sent his charioteer,  
Laeg son of Ree-angowra, unto Lewy,  
That he might ask whether Faerbay still lived,  
And whether he was coming to that combat,  
Which he had vowed to fight. Then Lewy said:  
“A blessing on the hand which served that service!  
Faerbay fell dying down in yon glen last night.”

When Laeg had fared to his own lord again,  
Lewy went up to the tent of Maev and Al-yill.  
“A man of you to go against that other!”  
He cried; then went to his own tent again.

Then Maev devised a plan. “Listen, O Al-yill,”  
She said; “upon this Táin with yonder Lewy  
The son of Nōs the son of Alamac  
There is a brother. He is a young youth,  
Unwise, weak, childish, vain, puffed, insolent.  
We will caress him, till, enticed by us,  
He shall go down to the ford to fight Cucullin.  
He will be slain; whereon that hero, Lewy  
The son of Nōs the son of Alamac,  
Despite his foster-friendship for Cucullin,  
Will be compelled by honour to go down  
And slay Cucullin to avenge that brother.  
Lewy, we think, indeed, can overcome him.”

“The plan is good,” said Al-yill. That same night  
That youth they spoke of, namely, Laeriny  
The son of Nōs the son of Alamac  
Was summoned to their tent. His satisfaction  
And glorying in that honour which Maev showed him  
Were very great. The maiden Findabair  
Was placed at his one side. ’Twas she who brimmed

His drinking-horn. 'Twas she who gave a kiss  
With every draught she poured. 'Twas she who set  
Her own hands to his food. Maev said to him:  
“We give thee this, thou hero Laeriny:  
It is the last of the wine we brought from Croohan.”  
“What art thou saying there, O Maev?” said Al-yill,  
Speaking as though he knew not Laeriny.  
“I am addressing that man there,” said Maev.  
“Who is the man?” said Al-yill. Maev replied  
To Al-yill, speaking so that Laeriny  
Should hear the words she said: “Often, O Al-yill,  
Thou hast bestowed thy care on things unfit.  
'Tis fit that thou shouldst now bestow thy care  
On yonder couple who have greater beauty  
And worthiness and pride than any couple  
On any road in Erin,—Findabair,  
I mean, and Laeriny.” “Yea,” Al-yill said,  
“I see them so. That union would be fitting.  
I will not hinder it, if he but bring  
Here to the camp the head of the Ree-astartha.”

It was then, in his joy, that Laeriny  
Gave to himself a bending and a shaking,  
So that he broke the seams of the quilted cushion  
Which was beneath him; and the grassy green  
Was sprinkled with its feathers. It to him  
Seemed that it would be easy to o'ercome  
The Ree-astartha, and to take his head,  
And bring that head to Al-yill. It to him  
Seemed long until the light of day should come,  
When he should go to combat with Cucullin.

Lewy went down that night to address Cucullin.  
They met in Glen Faerbay. Each one of them  
Welcomed the other. “I have come,” said Lewy,  
“To tell thee of my brother, Laeriny,  
Who comes to meet thee at the ford to-morrow.  
He is a youth, young and unwise and weak  
And insolent and vain. And for this reason

It is that Maev has put him to this combat:—  
That when thou shalt have slain him, I may go  
To avenge my brother. I will never go  
Until the Breast of Doom, because he goes  
In violation of my truth and honour.  
Nevertheless, because of the great friendship  
Between thyself and me, my friend Cucullin,  
Slay not my brother.” In the early morn,  
At the red-glorious light of rising-time,  
Laeriny fared unto the battle-ford,  
To meet Cucullin. To the battle-heroes  
And warriors of that camp it seemed unworthy  
To go to watch that combat: only women  
And lads and maidens went. Cucullin came  
Then to the ford: to him it seemed unworthy  
To bring his weapons. He met Laeriny.  
He took from Laeriny his battle-weapons  
Out of his hands, as one would take play-weapons  
Out of the hands of a young child. He rubbed  
And bruised him ’twixt his own hands, then, and shook him,  
And hurled him from the mid-part of the ford  
To the green bank; and he was borne away  
Fainting and bruised up to the door of the tent  
Of his brother Lewy. He was the only man  
Who had retained his life after a combat  
Fought with Cucullin on that Táin; and never  
From that day till his death was Laeriny  
Without the grief of illness, or without  
Trouble of chest, or without being borne  
On horseback in his sickness and his pain.

When Maev was told of that escape, annoyance  
Grew in her, for that her keen plan had failed;  
And her mind tortured her because not yet  
Had she found one to overthrow Cucullin.

That night she sent for all the kings and princes  
Who were upon that hosting; and she said:  
“Whom shall we now send forth to assail this youth?

There is none other of his friends and comrades  
Who will consent to violate his bond.”  
Whereat all said: “Except his friends and comrades,  
Throughout the expanse of Erin of wide compass  
We know of none able for that hard combat,  
Except two men alone; and, of these, one  
Is Cooroi son of Dawra, who hath reddened  
His sword in distant lands; and one is Lōk  
The son of Emonis, who years ago  
Was taught in Scawtha’s land, and who, even like  
Faerdeeah son of Daman son of Dawra,  
Owns a tough conganess, a horn-skin armour,  
The gift of Scawtha ere he left her land;  
And neither sword nor spear will pierce that armour.”

Now there was present in the tent a man  
Of Cooroi’s folk from the far-off south-west,  
Who said: “Great Cooroi will not come. To him,  
Truly, it seems enough to have sent this number  
Of his own household folk to help the hosting.”

After that conference, then, and that prime-council,  
Maev sent for Lōk the son of Emonis—For  
Lōk the Great—who like Cucullin himself  
Had been trained up to arms far in the east.  
Lōk came; and Maev besought him, promising  
Land on Moy Wee equal to Moy Mweerhevna,  
An outfit for twelve men of each right hue,  
A chariot costing seven powerful bondmaids,  
And Findabair to be his own one wife.  
And he esteemed it mean and unbecoming  
To combat with a gillie. “O Maev!” he said,  
“I will not go for combat with that youth,  
Who is tender, young, and without any beard.  
But I have one to meet him, that is, Long  
The son of Emonis, my brother. Give  
The same rewards to Long. He shall go forth  
To meet Cucullin at the ford.” Maev sent,  
Therefore, for Long the son of Emonis,

And offered the same gifts and same rewards.  
He went next day down to the ford of combat.  
Cucullin slew him there; and his folk carried  
His body back to his great brother, Lōk.

Then Maev incited Lōk to avenge his brother.  
Lōk hesitated still, and was reluctant;  
For he esteemed it mean and unbecoming  
To combat with a gillie. "O Maev," he said,  
"I may not make that combat till the end  
Of seven days from this day." "'Tis not fitting,"  
Maev said, "that we should be without attacking  
The hound for all that space. Therefore, each night,  
While we are waiting for thy conquering combat,  
We will send forth a party of night-hunters  
To hunt Cucullin and endanger him;  
And so we may, perhaps, arrest this peril."

That, then, was done. A party of night-hunters  
Went forth from Maev each night to hunt Cucullin;  
But every night Cucullin slew those hunters.  
These were their names: seven Oo-arguses,  
Ten Delbaes, seven Conalls, seven Keltars,  
Eight Feeacs, seven Anguses, ten Al-yills.  
Each of the seven nights a troop was slain.

At the end of the seven nights Maev urgently,  
With strong persuasions and hard settings-on,  
Again incited Lōk to avenge his brother.  
She said: "O Lōk, great son of Emonis,  
Truly thou art a targe for mockery  
Unto that man who slew thy brother, and still,  
By thee unchecked and unopposed, inflicts  
Great harm upon our hosts! We deem it certain  
That a young, little wildling such as he  
Could not withstand the ardour and the power  
Of a proved hero like thyself. And yet,  
Because by the same warlike nurse ye both  
Were taught and trained, it is no shame to thee  
To meet him and thereby to avenge thy brother."

Then Lōk the Great the son of Emonis,  
Incited so, consented. He went down  
To meet Cucullin and to avenge his brother.  
“Come to the upper ford,” said Lōk, “Not here  
In this polluted ford where Long has fallen  
Will we decide our combat and contention.”  
They met in the upper ford; and then began  
Between Cucullin son of Sooaltim,  
And Lōk the Great the son of Emonis,  
Their powerful combat and their strong contention;  
And all who watched that combat and contention  
Were filled with dread and horror and much fear.

This was the hour and this the point of time  
When the More-reega daughter of Ernmas came,  
Even as she had sworn that she would come  
What time Cucullin should engage a foe  
Commensurate with himself in warlike skill.  
Forth from the green-grassed Shee-mound, where she dwelt,  
She came; and first in form of a lithe eel  
Swam down the stream, and round Cucullin’s feet  
Wound a close, triple coil. Straightway he fell;  
And though with speed, like to the swallow’s speed  
Above a pool on a hot summer’s day,  
He rose and struck the eel and brake her ribs  
Within her, so that she released her hold—  
Yet in that point of time wherein he had lain  
Prone in the stream, great Lōk had dealt a blow,  
Gashing Cucullin’s side; and all the stream  
Was reddened with his blood. Again she came,  
In semblance of a starved bitch-wolf she came,  
Chasing the startled cattle towards the ford,  
To overwhelm him there. Cucullin aimed  
A stone and struck her eye, and turned the cattle  
Hillward; nor had his adversary time  
To wound him newly. But again once more  
The bitter-vengeful, dread More-reega came,  
And, shaped like a red hornless heifer, led



One hundred red and hornless heifers down  
To overwhelm Cucullin. Swift he aimed  
A stone, and struck one of her hindward legs;  
And it brake under her; and then the Bive  
Vanished. But while Cucullin had turned round  
To cast the stone, great Lōk had dealt a blow  
And gashed Cucullin's second side; and all  
The stream was reddened with his flowing blood.

This was the hour and this the moment of time  
Wherein Cucullin called to his charioteer,  
Namely, to Laeg the son of Ree-angowra,  
To send him the Gae Bulg. 'Twas the first time  
He e'er had called for it; and 'twas because  
Of that tough conganess, the hornskin armour,  
Which great Lōk wore when fighting with a man,  
That he now called for that dread spear of Scawtha.  
And thus, indeed, was that dread spear of Scawtha:  
It would be floated down the stream, and caught  
And cast by the toes of the foot: a one-spear wound  
It made on entering a man; but thirty  
Sharp-wounding heads it had, which would spread out  
Within the man. The spear was floated down  
Swiftly by Laeg the son of Ree-angowra.  
Cucullin caught it with the toes of his foot,  
And cast it; and it pierced the conganess,  
And pierced Lōk's heart within his breast. Lōk cried:  
"I ask one warrior-boon from thee, Cucullin."  
"What boon?" Cucullin said. "'Tis no request  
For mercy or for safety," Lōk said: "merely  
Retreat from me one backward pace, that now  
It may be forward, eastward, that I fall,  
Not backward, westward, toward the men of Erin;  
And so no man of them will say of me  
That it was in retreat and flight and rout  
That I fell by thee here; for I now fall  
By the Gae Bulg." "I will indeed retreat,"  
Cucullin said, "for warrior-like the boon is

Which thou dost ask.” And he retreated then  
One backward pace, and Lōk the Great fell forward  
Upon his face there in that upper ford;  
And the dark mists of death encompassed him.

Since that same hour wherein Lōk fell, Ath Tray,  
“Ford of the Foot,” that is, “the Foot’s Retreat,”  
Has been the name upon that ford of combat,  
In which Lōk fell, in low Cann Teera More.

That day a dark dejection visited  
Cucullin, for that he was all alone  
Defending Ulster; and extreme fatigue,  
And the sharp anguish of those bleeding wounds  
Oppressed his spirit; and he said to Laeg:  
“Arise from me, strong Laeg of the hosts: complain  
For me in very-red Avvin. Say for me  
That I am wearied each day in the battle,  
And now am wounded and bathed o’er with blood.  
A wound is in my right side; and a wound  
Is in my left side. Say to kindly Conor  
That the dear son of Dectora has changed  
His form indeed, being wearied, wounded, now.  
Though he should come to me, ’twere not too soon.  
I am alone before the flocks and herds.  
I am in evil: I am not in good.  
I am alone on many fords, and now  
Very rough wounding has befallen me.  
No friend arrives to fight for me or help me,  
Except the charioteer of my one chariot.  
Were but a few to arrive, we still might fight.  
There is not music in one horn alone;  
But from a number of horns of differing sound  
You get sweet music. This is an old word:  
You get no flaming from one single stick;  
But two or three will cause the torch to flame.  
The portion for a host cannot be seethed  
On one fork only. I am here alone

Fronting Maev's hosts down at Cann Teera More.  
Lōk son of Emonis has torn my loins.  
The bitter-vengeful Bive came in three shapes.  
Lōk son of Emonis wounded my liver.  
Laeg sent the spear of Scawtha down the stream.  
Its course was quick. I hurled the dreadful spear,  
Whereby fell Lōk the son of Emonis.  
What ails the Ultonians that they give not battle  
To Al-yill and the daughter of Yōhee Fayla?  
Seeing that I am now in pain, disabled,  
Wounded, and bathed with blood, say unto them,  
That they must now come after their own Táin.  
The sons of Mahga have borne off their kine,  
And made division of the kine amongst them.  
Joyful the Bive before the hosts of Al-yill!  
Mournful the cries of woe on Moy Mweerhevna!  
Let Conor now come forth with his rangéd hosts.  
Rise, now, O Laeg: go unto very-red Avvin."

Then Laeg arose; but first he had gathered moss  
And healing herbs, and made soft pads and wisps,  
And dressed Cucullin's wounds, staunching the blood.  
Rising, he left his lord; and with all speed  
He fared to sword-red Avvin. But his words  
Were as a warning to the dead. Not yet  
Might the Ultonians rise from their long Kesh;  
And Laeg turned back to his own lord again.

Before good Laeg returned, and while Cucullin  
Lay all alone in the deep-hiding woods,  
The great More-reega daughter of Ernmas came,  
Appearing like some agéd wrinkled crone  
Milking her cow. And this was why she came:—  
That she might win her healing from Cucullin.  
For so it was, he having wounded her,  
Only through him might she again be whole.  
And the cow had three teats. Cucullin thirsted,

And begged one draught of milk to assuage his thirst.  
She gave him all the milking of one teat.  
He drank it, and cried out in thankfulness:  
“Health to the giver!” And the Great Queen’s eye  
Thereby was healed. Again he begged a draught:  
Again she gave the milking of one teat;  
And he cried: “Joy and health unto the giver!”  
And a third time he begged of her a draught,  
She gave the yield of the third teat; and then  
Cucullin cried: “The blessings of all beings,  
Of gods and no-gods—be upon thy head,  
O woman who hast succoured me!” Thereby  
Was the More-reega healed of all her wounds.  
The crone and cow had vanished; and Cucullin,  
Gazing bewildered, saw one carrion-bird,  
Red-mouthed, upon the bough beside him there,  
Who spake and said: “Remember thy great boast,  
That thou wouldst never heal me of my wounds!”  
And then Cucullin knew her; and in wrath  
He answered: “Had I known that it was thou,  
Thou most abhorréd and detested Queen,  
Thou drinker of men’s blood, grinder of bones,  
Wild shrieker-out for pale-lipped carcasses,  
Dispenser of confusion, famine, woe,  
I ne’er had healed thee,—nay though I had died  
Of thirst and want, I had not healed thy wounds.”

Then the More-reega vanished and went back  
To the far, hollow Shee-mound where she dwelt.

On Maev the daughter of Yōhee Fayla now  
Was joyfulness and triumph, seeing that now  
Cucullin, wounded, was laid low. She now,  
Taking a third part of her hosts, fared north  
To waste the lands of Crithny and of Ulster,  
E’en as she swore to waste them. She fared north  
Along the road of Meedlougher. She put  
A cloud of red-brown fire, heavy, widespread,

Above the lands of Ulster and of Crithny;  
And, for the folk of Ulster and of Crithny,  
There was no ill she did not do to them  
With liveliness. She took their sons and wives,  
Their steeds and flocks of mares, their troops of kine,  
Their herds of every sort of grazing kine,  
Their raiment, and bright silver and bright gold.  
And she not only burned unto the grass  
Their strongly timbered houses, wide and high;  
But their high, fortified green mounds, whereon  
Those houses were, she swiftly levelled down,  
So that their glens and trenches were filled up  
After her track. "When Conor son of Fahtna  
Hears of our deeds," Maev said, "they unto him  
Will cause heart-sickness, waste of flesh, cheek-whitening,  
So that no meat will please him, and no quiet,  
Sweet sleep will go to him; but he will be  
Tortured in mind, dark-spirited."

Howbeit,

Maev on that expedition dared not go  
To Avvin Maha, or to any doon  
Where Ulster warriors lay, pained by their Kesh,  
The curse of Maha; for if one should wound  
A warrior in that Kesh, that Kesh would leap  
Straight to that wounder. Therefore, she fared north  
Through Dalriada to the Northern Sea,  
To ever-bright Dunseverick, where dwelt  
Findmore the Great, the warrior-wife of Keltar  
The son of Oo-hider. Before the door  
Of ever-bright Dunseverick she gave  
Fierce battle to Findmore, and slew Findmore  
The wife of Keltar; and she pillaged all  
That famous doon; and she took fifty women  
Out of that doon as captives. Then she turned  
Southward toward Cooley once again. Each ford  
Which Maev upon that expedition passed  
Was thenceforth called Ath Vaeva. Each night-stead

Whereon her tent was pitched at night was thenceforth  
Called Poopal Vaeva. Each place where she set  
Her horse-switch, when she took her rest, was thenceforth  
Called Billi Vaeva. So she came again  
Southward to Al-yill; and they met at Faughard.

While Maev upon that vigorous expedition  
Was spoiling so all Ulster and all Crithny  
Unhindered, Laeg the son of Ree-angowra  
Had come again from sword-red Avvin Maha  
Unto his lord, telling him that his message  
Had been but as a message to the dead.

Cucullin then from his low sick-man's bed  
Had risen, though feeble; and his wounds were dressed  
Freshly with wisps and moss; and he went forth  
Again to fend his land, the land of Cooley.  
Then he saw something: he saw sixty men  
Of Maev's and Al-yill's household; and a bratt  
Folded round each; and the dark Donn of Cooley—  
With his two eyes burning like crooan-red,  
And gold on his high horns, and with fifty heifers  
Of his own heifers—running and being driven  
Before the men, after his being taken  
In Glen Samaska in Slieve Gullion. Then  
Cucullin went to them. "What is thy name?"  
He said to their chief man, who answered him:  
"One who nor fears nor loves thee, namely Boi  
The son of Bawn, of the especial folk  
Of Al-yill and of Maev." "This spear at Boi!"  
Cucullin said; and hurled at him the spear,  
Which pierced the shield above his breast, and pierced  
The heart within his breast, so that Boi fell.  
Howbeit, in the little space of time  
Wherein Cucullin and Boi son of Bawn  
Exchanged their words and spears, the Donn of Cooley  
With skill and swiftness was brought off from them,  
And driven to the camp and the encampment  
Of Maev and Al-yill and the men of Erin;

So that, indeed, that driving of the bull,  
The Donn of Cooley, was the worst dishonour  
And baffling and befooling, that was ever  
Put on Cucullin on that Táin and hosting.

Then Maev and Al-yill and the hosts of Erin,  
Having the bull, fared south; and at the place,  
Since called the Bressla More on Moy Mweerhevna,  
They made their camp at night, having first sent  
Their mighty prey in captives and in kine,  
And the great bull, the wondrous Donn of Cooley,  
Yet further south, even to Cleer Bo Ulla,  
For shelter and for safety. And Cucullin  
Against the high, green grave-hill in the Larguey,  
Exceeding near to the great hosts of Erin,  
Took up his post; and his own charioteer,  
Laeg son of Ree-angowra, kindled there  
His fire at eve that night. Cucullin, gazing  
Out from himself, perceived the fiery shining  
Of their clean-golden lance-heads and war-weapons  
Above the heads of the Four Fifths of Erin  
At falling of the eve that night. He, seeing  
Thus the great number of his enemies  
And the huge number of his foemen—knowing  
Too that his wounds were yet unhealed and yet  
He was but weak and feeble—was o'erborne  
By rage of anger. He took up his sword,  
And his two spears and shield; and shook his shield,  
And brandished his two spears, and whirled his sword.  
And from his throat he gave his hero-cry,  
So that the Bannanahs and Boccanahs,  
And the Glen-folk and Spirits of the Air,  
Answered him for the horror of that cry,  
Which thus he raised above him. And the Nowin,  
That is to say, the Bive, went through the hosts,  
So that the Four Great Fifths of Erin fell  
To weapon-trembling; and one hundred warriors

Of the good warriors of the men of Erin  
Died of heart-horror 'midst of their camp that night.



## BOOK XI

### BOOK XI

Now of the Bressla More, red, terrible,  
Cucullin's Bressla More on Moy Mweerhevna,  
We next must tell. While Laeg was on that grave-hill  
He perceived somewhat: he perceived a man,  
Out of the north-east quarter, slanting-wise  
Crossing the wide camp of the men of Erin  
In a direct line towards him. "Cucucawn,"  
Said Laeg, "there is a man approaching us."  
"What kind of man?" Cucullin asked. Laeg answered:  
"He is a man noble and fair and tall,  
Whose face shines glorious as the glorious sun  
Shines 'mid high clouds on a dry summer's day.  
His wide-spread, crispéd, curling hair is yellow  
Like bright bog-flags in flower. He wears a bratt  
Of bright grass-green, caught by a clasp of silver  
Above his breast; and next his bird-white skin  
He has a layna made from kingly sról,  
Richly inwoven with red threads of gold,  
And falling in rich folds down to his knees.  
A black shield with a rim of hard findrinny  
He bears. He bears a tall five-headed spear;  
And a forked javelin is beside it. Wonderful,  
Truly, the deeds are, and the feats of art,  
Which he displays as he comes through that camp;  
Yet in the camp no one salutes or greets him,  
And he himself greets no one. 'Tis as though  
Throughout that camp of the Four Fifths of Erin  
No man could see him." "That is true, O Laeg,"  
Cucullin answered; "no man there can see him;  
For that is one of my own helping friends

From a Shee-mound of Erin, who comes there  
To pity me and comfort me. They know  
The hardships and oppression I am in,  
Over against the Four Great Fifths of Erin  
Now on this Táin.”

That warrior reached the grave-hill  
Where then Cucullin was; and he began  
To comfort and to pity him. He said:  
“Thou hast been very manly, O Cucullin.”  
“It was not much,” Cucullin said. The warrior  
Said: “I will help thee now, thou little son.”  
“Who in all Erin art thou?” asked Cucullin.  
Whereat that warrior from the Shee replied:  
“I am long-handed Loo the son of Ethlenn,  
Who in old days—hundreds of years of days  
Before this day wherein I speak to thee—  
Led the bright, greatly skilled Dae Danann hosts  
To that dread battle of the North Moy Twirra,  
Wherein the Fomorian hosts were whelmed and slain.  
Yea, I am he who slew the one-eyed Bahlor,  
And afterwards reigned many years in Tara  
Above the Dae Danann host. And, little son,  
'Tis I who was thy father from the Shee,  
Sooaltim not being thy father.”

“Warrior,”

Cucullin said, “’twere well to heal these wounds.”  
“Sleep, sleep a little now, thou brave Cucullin,”  
The warrior said; “let thy deep swoon of sleep  
Be o’er thee on this grave-hill in the Larguey,  
Till the far end of three days and three nights;  
And I myself will watch against yon hosts.”

The warrior then above Cucullin sang  
His deep, low, rich faer-dord, whereat deep sleep  
Came on Cucullin and he slept. And then  
That warrior from the Shee threw healing herbs  
And roots from out the Shee, and leaves of curing,  
And powerful incantations of quick curing,

On the sore wounds and hurts which hurt that youth,—  
So that he in his sleep grew whole again  
Without perceiving it or knowing it.  
In his deep, gentle swoon of sleep Cucullin  
Slept so upon the grave-hill in the Larguey  
Till the far end of three days and three nights.

That was the time when the young lads of Ulster,  
Who played upon the playing-green of Avvin,  
Sons of the kings and chiefs of noble Ulster,  
Took counsel with each other. “It is grievous,  
Indeed,” they said, “that thus our friend, Cucullin,  
Should be alone and without any help.”  
Whereon Folloon the son of Conor questioned  
And said: “A question: Shall I have a band  
To travel south and help your friend, Cucullin?”  
And the young lads of Ulster answered him:  
“We do not wish to live without going south  
To aid Cucullin.” Then thrice fifty lads,  
Being a third of all the lads of Ulster,  
Made of themselves a band around Folloon  
The son of Conor; and they travelled south  
O’er the hill-region of Slieve Foo-id, and came  
Down on the level plain, on Moy Mweerhevna.

Al-yill perceived that brightly varied band  
Far out upon the plain. “That band,” said he,  
“Is a fresh troop of the young Ulster children,  
Who have come south from sword-red Avvin Maha,  
To help Cucullin. Let a troop go out  
Without Cucullin’s knowledge, and destroy them;  
For if they meet him, ye will not resist them.”

A troop went out; but the young lads avoided  
That troop which went; and they drew nigh the hosts.  
With their thrice fifty childish playing-clubs  
They thrice attacked the hosts; and by their hands  
Thrice their own number fell, ere, in the end,  
The little lads were overpowered and slain.

Folloon the son of Conor had declared  
That he would ne'er return again to Avvin  
Till he should take with him the head of Al-yill,  
Together with the glorious mind of gold  
Which Al-yill wore in battle. Difficult  
That was for him; for the two sons of Boi  
The son of Bawn, who were defending Al-yill,  
Attacked him; and by them he swiftly fell.

Cucullin on the grave-hill in the Larguey  
Slept his deep swoon of slumber and of sleep  
Till the far end of three days and three nights.  
That warrior from the Shee looked at his wounds  
Then, and perceived that they were clean; and then  
He sang his aely of awakening o'er him.  
"Awake," he sang, "O little battle-hound;  
Awake, and do thy feats of war and battle.  
Thy friend from out the Shee hath healed thy wounds.  
Awake, and mount once more thy battle-chariot.  
Rise, little son! Rise, slaughtering Hound of Ulster!"

Cucullin rose then out of that deep sleep,  
And passed his hand across his face, and flushed  
Rosy from crown to ground; and there was strength  
And freshness in his spirit, even as though  
He were about to travel to a feast,  
Or to a festival of Ulster women,  
Or to an ale-stead, or to a festival  
Amidst the great prime-festivals of Erin.

"How long have I remained in this deep sleep,  
O warrior?" said Cucullin; and the warrior  
Replied: "Three days and nights." "Alas for that!"  
Cucullin said. "Why so?" that warrior asked.  
"Because," Cucullin said, "those hosts have been  
For all that space without attack or harm."  
"It is not so, indeed," that warrior said.  
"Who came to harm them, then?" Cucullin asked him.  
Whereat that warrior from the Shee replied:

“The little lads came from the north, from Avvin—  
Thrice fifty lads, sons of the kings of Ulster—  
Commanded by Folloon the son of Conor.  
With their thrice fifty childish playing-clubs  
They thrice attacked the hosts, whilst thou wast here  
In thy deep swoon of slumber and of sleep;  
And by their hands thrice their own number fell,  
Ere they themselves were overpowered and slain.  
Folloon the son of Conor had declared  
That he would ne’er return again to Avvin  
Till he should take with him the head of Al-yill,  
Together with the glorious mind of gold  
Which Al-yill wears in battle. Difficult  
That was indeed for him; and he was slain.”

Cucullin heard those words; and, when he heard them  
So from that warrior, there broke from him  
A sharp, sad, woeful, heavy, passionate cry.  
“Alas,” he said, “that then my battle-strength  
Was not upon me! Had my battle-strength  
Been then upon me, the young lads from Avvin  
Had not thus fallen as now they have fallen: Folloon  
The son of Conor had not fallen as now  
He has fallen.” “Be thou comforted, O son,”  
The warrior said to him; “it is no stain  
And no reproach upon thy hero-valour:  
It is no stain upon thy honour.” “Warrior,”  
Cucullin said, “abide with us to-night,  
That we together may avenge our lads  
On yon great hosts.” The warrior, smiling, answered:  
“I will not so; because, however great  
The feats of valour and the deeds of arms  
A man might do beside thee, not on him  
Would be the fame and the renown for them,  
But only on thee. Therefore, I will not tarry  
Beside thee here. Howbeit, on this occasion,  
Fear not, but fare alone, thou little son;  
And alone do thy deeds on yonder hosts.

There shall be power upon thee from the Shee  
To-night. To-night thy foes and enemies  
Shall have no power above thy life. Take now  
This Covering of Concealment which was sent thee  
By the dark king o'er the far Land of Sorca,  
By Manannawn the son of Lear." The warrior  
Bestowed that Covering on Cucullin, and then  
He went from him, and was not seen.

Cucullin

Called to his charioteer, even to Laeg:  
"And the scythed chariot now, O Soul, O Laeg!  
If thou hast now its gear, equip it swiftly,  
That we may ride to-night to avenge our lads,  
Our sons of kings from Avvin." Laeg replied:  
"I have the chariot, and I have its gear.  
I can equip it swiftly."

It was then,  
Therefore, that that war-hero and that fighter,  
And that constructor of a Bive's Ring-fence,  
Put on his battle-dress of war and battle.

Of that good battle-dress of war and battle  
Which he put on, then, were his seven and twenty  
Waxed, board-smooth laynas, which with cords and ropes  
Next his white skin were wont to be tied fast,  
So that his prudence might not go from him  
When his war-fury should rise up. He put  
These round him then; and over these he put  
His tough war-hero's belt of hard, tanned skin,  
Made from the shoulders of the seven skins  
Of seven young bulls. It from the slenderness  
Of his mid-sides extended to the thickness  
Beneath his arm-pits. It was wont to be  
Around him so, to cast back spears and points  
And spikes and darts and spits; they would be cast  
Back from that belt as if they had struck on horn  
Or rock or stone. Next, he put round himself,  
About his soft and tender middle-parts,

His membranous filmy foo-a-vrōg of srōl  
Bordered with gold. And over that he put  
His brown and well-smoothed foo-a-vrōg of leather,  
Made from the shoulders of the four hard skins  
Of four young bulls to place on the outside  
Of that soft filmy foo-a-vrōg of srōl.

And then it was, indeed, that that war-hero,  
That battle-champion of the valorous Gael,  
Took up his battle-arms of war and battle,  
Of conflict and of combat. Of those arms  
Were his eight little swords, with his great sword,  
Which was bright-faced, bone-hilted. Of those arms  
Were his eight little spears, with his great spear,  
Which was five-headed, deedful. Of those arms  
Were his eight little darts, with his great dart,  
His great Dael Clish, fierce, dreadful. Of those arms  
Were his eight shields for feats, with his curved shield  
Black-red, wherein a boar meant for display  
Could lie, so great it was; and whose sharp edge,  
All round, would cut a hair against a stream,  
So sharply was it sharpened. Of those arms  
Was his high, noble, glorious, crested cathbarr  
Of battle and of combat and of conflict,  
Out of each angle of the which a cry  
Would be cried forth, like to the battle-cry  
Of one hundred warriors; for the Bannanahs  
And Boccanahs and Demons of the Air  
And the Glen-folk were wont to cry before it,  
Above it, and around it, every time  
That the blown blood of warriors and of heroes  
Would shower swift past it on the airs and wind.

Lastly, that fighter and that valour-champion  
Put on the wondrous Covering of Concealment,  
Druidic, strange, which had been sent to him  
By far-off Manannawn the son of Lear.

That was the hour and that the moment of time,  
When, while he thought of the dead lads from Avvin,

There came upon Cucullin his contortion  
And his war-writhing, till there was made from him  
A man misshapen, many-shaped, strange, awful,  
Dreadful, unheard-of. In that battle-writhing  
All his flesh trembled and was troubled round him,  
Till every limb and every joint of him  
Quivered, e'en like a tree against a stream,  
Or like a reed against a stream. Hard writhing  
Engaged his limbs: his calves and hindward parts  
Twisted to frontward: his two knees and feet  
Writhed backward. Hideous writhing and contortion  
Spread o'er his visage. He engulfed one eye  
Within his head: its fellow-eye broke out  
Bare, horrible, upon his cheek. His lips  
Twisted themselves strangely and terribly.  
Something was heard: it was the half-loud beating  
Of his stirred heart against the ribs of his side,  
Like the thick growling of a slaughter-hound  
Above his food, or like a Scythian lion  
Ranging 'mid bears. Then there were seen above him  
Thick showers of fiery sparks in clouds and airs  
Over his head, arising from the seething  
Of truly rough, fierce rage which raged within him.  
His hair rose up and twisted o'er his head,  
Stiff, like red branches of a stiff-branched thorn,  
Which close some gap in some high earthen rampart:  
E'en had a kingly apple-tree beneath  
Its kingly fruit been shaken around his head,  
Scarcely an apple of them would have fallen  
To groundward past those hairs; but on each hair  
An apple would have lodged, so strong the writhing  
And anger-stiffening of each hair of them.  
Last there arose from out the crown of his head  
A shaft of blood, dark, upright, straight, as tall  
And high and thick and steady as the mast  
Of some prime, kingly vessel; till above him  
A dark druidic mist was made of it,



Like the smoke-pall above a royal hostel,  
What time a king is coming for his guesting  
At eve in winter.

When that hard contortion  
Wherewith Cucullin so had been contorted  
Had past, that Head-of-Valour of the Gael,  
The Battle-champion of all Ulster, leapt  
On his scythed battle-chariot. For Laeg  
Meanwhile had dressed himself and dressed the chariot.  
He had put on his own light hunting-dress,  
Whereof was his soft innar made from deer-skin,  
Airy and light, so that it hindered not  
The movements of his hands: whereof was also  
His noble, glorious, crested, four-ridged cathbarr,  
Which was adorned with many hues and forms,  
And reached to his mid-shoulder, much enhancing  
The glory of his look: whereof was also  
His gleaming guipny of red-yellow gold—  
His curved thin band of anvil-beaten gold—  
Which with his hand he placed around his brow  
To be a token of his charioteering,  
Whereby all men might know him from his lord.

When Laeg had dressed himself, he on the steeds,  
Namely, the Leeha Maha and Doo Sanglenn,  
Had thrown their covering-armour, which was studded  
From end to end with little points and lances  
And spikes and darts. And, lastly, he had thrown  
Upon those steeds a Spell and Incantation  
Of Covering, which that warrior from the Shee  
Had taught to him that day, so that that night  
Within that camp of the Four Fifths of Erin  
No man might clearly see them on their course.

And so it was indeed that that war-champion,  
That high, proud Head-of-Valour of the Gael,  
The Battle-champion of all Ulster, leapt  
On his scythed battle-chariot—with its ends  
And boundaries of iron, with its edges

Cutting and thin, with its hard spikes and spikelets,  
With its hard, lacerating hooks and hooklets,  
With its sharp nails and spits and spikes and prongs,  
Which were upon its frame-parts and its thongs,  
And on each pole and hind-shaft. And he threw  
Out from him then before his enemies  
His noise-feats of one hundred and two hundred,  
Three hundred and four hundred; and he stood  
At the five hundred; and he went so far,  
Because it did not seem too much to him  
That all that number should be slain by him  
In his first onset and first battle-leaping  
Against the men of the Four Fifths of Erin,  
In vengeance for the lads. In this array,  
Then, he rode forth against his enemies;  
And with his chariot next he made a circuit  
Around the men of the Four Fifths of Erin,  
Without, outside. He put a ponderous course  
On to his chariot; and the iron wheels  
Ploughed through the ground, so that it was enough  
To form a doon—the way the iron wheels  
Ploughed through the ground; for there arose alike  
The sods and pillar-stones and rocks and flags  
And the fine sand and gravel of the earth,  
Till they were height for height with the iron wheels  
Above, beside them. It was for this reason  
That he thus put that ponderous Bive's-circuit  
Around the men of the Four Fifths of Erin  
Without, outside:—so that they might not scatter  
And might not flee from him, until by slaughter  
He should avenge the lads on them. He came  
So, 'midst the battle; and he felled great fences  
Of bodies of his foemen in a circuit  
And a wide circle round about the hosts  
Without, outside. He made a foeman's onset  
Upon his foemen, so that sole to sole  
And neck to neck they fell. Three times he so

Rode round the hosts, so that he left around them  
A sixfold slaughter-fence, in a great circuit  
All round that doon of the Four Fifths of Erin;  
For they fell, soles of three to necks of three,  
All round that doon of the Four Fifths of Erin.  
And hence the Shessra of the Bressla More  
(The Sixfold Slaughter of the Great Destruction)  
Was the name given to that dreadful slaughter  
Wrought by Cucullin then. And it is one  
Of three uncounted slaughters on the Táin,  
Which were, this Shessra of the Bressla More,  
The Imlee of Glendomna, and the battle  
Upon the fields of Gawrig and Ilgawrig,  
The battle of the Táin. For in this slaughter  
The slaughter was uncounted: no man knew  
How many had fallen. Of the common, poor  
People of little reckoning who fell  
There was no counting possible. Only  
The chiefs were counted. Of the chiefs who fell  
There were two each of Croo-ees, Kahlas, Keers,  
Keears, and Eckells; there were three each of Crommas,  
Cauriths, and Combeergas; four each of Fohairs,  
Furacars, Casses, Fotas; and five each  
Of Kermans, Cauris, and Coffys; and six each  
Of Saxons, Dooahs, and Dawras; and seven each  
Of Rohas, Ronawns, and Ruras; and eight each  
Of Rohties, Rindahs, Mullahs; and nine each  
Of Daigiths, Dawras, Dahmahs; and ten each  
Of Fee-acis, Fee-ahas, and Faylimies.  
Those were the chiefs who were mown down that night.

Cucullin went from them after inflicting  
That slaughter on the chiefs and folk of Erin.  
There was not any reddening on himself  
Or on his gillie, or on a steed of his steeds.

This was the Shessra of the Bressla More  
(The Sixfold Slaughter of the Great Destruction).  
This was the Bressla More on Moy Mweerhevna,

Cucullin's Bressla More, red, terrible,  
Cucullin's Bressla More on Moy Mweerhevna,  
Which Scawtha had foretold far in the East.

Upon the morrow morn Cucullin went  
To gaze abroad above the hosts of Erin,  
And to display his lovable, fair form  
To all their women and their wives and maidens,  
And to the poets and wise men of knowledge,  
Which were amongst those mighty hosts of Erin;  
Because that arrogant, druidic form,  
Wherein he had appeared to them at night  
That night, was not by him deemed fair or worthy.

Beautiful, truly, was that youthful son,  
Namely, Cucullin son of Sooaltim,  
Who there displayed his beauty and his form  
Unto the hosts of the Four Fifths of Erin.  
Three hues of hair were on him—a brown hue  
Next to the skin of his head, a blood-red hue  
Adjoining that, and a fair golden hue  
Adjoining that; and each thin, separate hair  
Had these three hues on it. A fair arrangement  
Was on those hairs: they made three well-formed wheels  
About the nape of his neck; and like a thread  
Of fine-drawn gold was each free, scattered, glorious,  
Long, separate hair of them which streamed and fell  
Backwards beyond his shoulders. And one hundred  
Crimsoned, fair links of rich, red, flaming gold  
Went round his throat and neck; and full one hundred  
Rich ornaments of mingled carbuncle  
Made a choice covering for his head. Four dimples  
Smiled in each cheek. Seven gems of light flamed bright  
In each of his two kingly eyes. That day  
He put his feast-array of feast-days round him.  
Of that array was his fit, crimson, fair,  
Five-folding fooan, in which, o'er his white breast,  
Was a white silvern spike inworked with gold,

And shining like some lamp filled up with light,  
So that the eyes of men could not endure it,  
Because of its great cleanness and its glory.  
Of that array was his rich silken innar,  
With hems and belts and fringes of rich gold  
And silver and findrinny, which reached down  
To the upper edge of his brown foo-avrōg,  
Which was red-brown and soldier-like, and made  
From kingly srōl, filmy and beautiful.  
Of that array was his brown-crimson shield,  
Which was upon him, with its pure white rim  
Of silver round it. And of that array  
Were his gold-hilted sword at his left side,  
And his long, grey-edged spear which was beside him  
Inside his chariot. In his hand that day  
Was Oak-fruit of the Red More-reega, namely,  
Dead heads of men. Nine heads were in his right hand,  
And ten were in his left hand; and he shook them  
And brandished them towards those great hosts of Erin.

This was the time when the young maids and daughters  
Amongst the men of Erin in that camp,  
Besought the men to raise them on their shields,  
And raise the shields aloft on to the shoulders  
Of sturdy warriors, that they thence might gaze  
Upon Cucullin's form; for wonderful  
That lovable, fair form, which they perceived  
Upon him there that day, appeared to them,  
When they remembered the druidic form,  
Arrogant, dark, which they had seen on him  
At night that night.

But upon Maev that morn,  
After the red, dread slaughter of the night,  
For the first time there was dismay and fear  
And trembling and sick dread and shuddering  
Before Cucullin. She concealed her face  
Beneath her impending shield: she dared not gaze  
Then on that Hound.

Howbeit in Maev that morn  
There was resolve and hard heart-resolution  
To find some warrior and some battle-champion  
Who would be fit to overcome that Hound;  
And, having found such, then, by gifts or blame,  
To induce him to go forth to slay Cucullin.  
She, scrutinizing in her mind, was sure  
That there were four men living still in Erin  
Who would be fit to meet him. One was Fergus  
The son of Roy; and one was Calateen  
Of dangerous arts, a dangerous, fierce opponent,  
With poison on his spears; and one indeed was  
Faerdeeah son of Daman son of Dawra,  
The mighty warrior of the men of Domnann,  
Cucullin's brother-in-arms; and one was Cooroi  
The son of Dawra, in the far south-west.

At eve that day Maev dispatched generous Lewy  
The son of Nōs the son of Alamac,  
To address Cucullin, and to ask renewal  
Of his war-terms—the terms of single combat.  
Then Lewy to that grave-hill in the Larguey  
Went forth to address Cucullin. "I have come,"  
He said, "to ask renewal of the terms."  
"I will renew them," said Cucullin, "seeing  
That now my wounds are healed, and I am whole,  
And able for hard strife and battle-combat."  
Lewy went back again, and gave that answer  
To Al-yill and to Maev. Then Maev besought  
The men of Erin that some man of them  
Should go for battle-combat with Cucullin  
Upon the ensuing morn. But each one said  
(Even as she had known that each would say,  
After the red, dread slaughter of that night):  
"It is not I who will go forth, or leave  
This place wherein I am. My race and kindred  
Are not beneath a bond to give a man  
To certain death and to foredoomed destruction."

This, therefore, was the evening when Maev spake  
To Fergus son of Roy, of great renown;  
And she implored him very earnestly,  
And she besought him and entreated him  
To go to combat at the ford of battle,  
And to bring back the head of the Ree-astartha.  
Fergus refused. "O Fergus," Maev said then,  
"Once thou wast greatest of all Ulster warriors,  
And naught was lacking to thee save to be  
The king in Ulster. Then, because thou wast  
Too great to be in the one Fifth with him,  
Conor the son of Fahtna Fahee drove thee  
Forth from thy place, landless and with dishonour.  
He slew the three Bright Candles of the Gael  
While they were underneath thy guard and honour.  
He drove thee from thy country and thy land  
And thine inheritance; and immense kindness  
Thou hast received from us. I gave, O Fergus,  
Support for thy three times ten hundred men,  
Together with their women and their poets  
And their young lads and their unnumbered gillies.  
I gave unto thyself perpetual feasting  
In royal Croohan. I myself maintained  
Thy honour, by myself paying thy debts  
Of honour, and fulfilling all thy vows.  
For seven long years has Connaught borne these burdens;  
And now it is a shameful thing in thee  
That thou dost shirk thy share of battle-danger,  
And that thou dar'st not meet the Ree-astartha  
Who is destroying us." These words Maev said,  
Speaking to Fergus; and many more she said;  
And she reproached him very heavily.

Fergus was silent. He returned no words  
Unto those heavy words; but Maev was sure  
That he would go unto the battle-ford  
At earliest dawn of rising on the morrow.

Fergus went back to his own tent and people.

He slept no sleep that night. His debt and bond  
To Maev were heavy on him and oppressed him;  
For it was difficult indeed to shun them;  
And it seemed bitter to him so to be  
Dependent on that queen. There in his tent,  
While thinking of the little lad of Ulster,  
Upon his breast he wept his showers of tears,  
So that his beard and breast were wet with them;  
And his own servants dared not speak to him  
Their words of consolation or of counsel.

At earliest dawn of rising on the morrow  
Fergus went down unto the battle-ford  
Of conflict and of combat; and Cucullin  
Saw his great guardian, Fergus, there before him.  
There was no joy made upon either side.  
There was great silence. In a little while,  
Cucullin said: "O my great guardian, Fergus,  
I see there is no sword in yon long scabbard,  
Which thou hast with thee there." Fergus replied:  
"It is indifferent to me, O my pupil;  
For even if my sword were here with me,  
It should not reach thee; and 'tis not on thee  
That it should now be plied. If I would ply it  
On thee, my pupil, he who has that sword  
Would yield it to me gladly. O my pupil!  
O my knee-fosterchild! will a wild doe  
Make war on her own fawn? Or will a brother  
Make war on his young brother? Or shall I  
Make war on my own pupil? But, my pupil,  
By all the nurture and by all the rearing  
Which I once gave thee, and which all the men  
Of Ulster since have given, and which Conor  
Himself hath given, I now beseech and pray thee  
To flee before me in this place to-day  
In presence of the watching hosts of Erin."  
Silence was on that youth, and then he said:  
"O my great guardian Fergus, it behoves me



To be reluctant to take flight or flee  
Before one man from 'midst the men of Erin,  
Now when I am alone before yon hosts,  
Guarding the folk and flocks and lands of Ulster.”  
Fergus made answer to him: “O my pupil,  
Now it behoves thee to be not reluctant;  
For in the last great battle of this Táin,  
If thou shalt still be living, and shalt come  
To meet me, thou being wounded, filled with wounds,  
And thou shalt bid me flee before thee, truly  
I then will flee before thee in that battle;  
And if I flee, the men of Erin all  
Will flee before thee likewise in that battle.”  
After those earnest words and that strong promise,  
Which Fergus so had made, Cucullin went  
In road of rout, of flight and of defeat  
In presence of the watching hosts of Erin.  
Fergus turned back once more, he having so  
Done treachery to Maev. “He flees, he flees,  
He flees before thee, Fergus!” each one cried:  
“He flees in road of rout and flight before thee.”  
“Follow him, Fergus!” Maev said; “let him not  
Thus go from out thine hands.” There broke from Fergus  
His savage laughter-voice. “Nay, verily,”  
Said he, “beyond this spot wherein I am  
I will not follow him. However little  
Ye deem that share of flight, that I have caused him,  
There is no man amongst the men of Erin,  
Who hath known how to put him to such flight  
Upon this Táin; and it is for that reason  
That, till each man of Erin in his turn  
Hath gone to fight with him in single combat,  
I will not go to threaten him again.”

Now of Cucullin's combat on the Táin  
With Calateen of deadly, dangerous darts,  
Together with his twenty-seven sons

And with his grandson, Glass the son of Delga,  
We must tell briefly.

In Maev's tent that night

The chiefs and kings considered who was fittest  
To send for battle-combat with Cucullin  
At earliest hour of rising in the morn.  
Then all agreed with Maev that it was best  
To send for Calateen of deadly arts,  
Together with his twenty-seven sons,  
And with his grandson, Glass the son of Delga.  
For thus those men of dangerous, deadly arts  
Were:—there was poison on each man of them,  
And poison on each weapon of their weapons;  
And he whom they but reddened, if he died not  
Forthwith, died surely ere nine days were past;  
And not a man of them e'er aimed an aim  
Unfit or false, or cast an erring cast.  
The men were sent for then; and huge rewards  
Were promised them for doing that famed combat;  
And for rewards they took in hand to do it.

And it was needful that in presence of Fergus  
This thing should be confirmed; and he, when called,  
Was powerless to cross or traverse it;  
For this is what men said:—that Calateen  
Together with his twenty-seven sons  
And with his grandson, Glass the son of Delga,  
Was as one man; for this is what they said:—  
His sons were merely limbs of his own limbs,  
And parts of his own parts, and it was right  
That Calateen should have the host and fullness  
Of his own body; and their contract therefore  
Was not a breaking of the faith of men.

Fergus went back to his own tent and folk.  
He breathed on high his groan of weariness.  
“’Tis grievous unto us the battle-deed  
That will be done to-morrow,” Fergus said;  
And he told all that tale. “And now,” said Fergus,

“There is no man to whom I will not give  
My blessing and my battle-dress of battle,  
If he will go from me to watch that combat,  
And bring me word when in that unjust combat  
Cucullin shall have fallen.” Feeaha  
The son of Conall Carna said to him:  
“I will myself go forth to watch that combat.”  
And they stayed there that night.

Upon the morrow

Cucullin went unto the battle-ford  
Early; and Calateen of dangerous arts  
Went jointly with his twenty-seven sons  
And with his grandson, Glass the son of Delga.  
Upon Cucullin who was there alone,  
They launched at once their twenty-nine sharp darts  
Whereon was poison; and no dart of them  
Went on an erring or a swerving course.  
Cucullin wrought his edge-feat with his shield,  
So that the twenty-nine unswerving darts  
Plunged to their mid-parts in his battle-shield;  
And not one dart of them had reddened him.

This was the time when he drew forth his sword  
From its Bive’s-scabbard, so that he might hew  
And lop the darts, and thus unload his shield.  
While he was so unloading it, the men  
Drew nigh him swiftly, warily. They placed  
Upon his head their twenty-nine right hands,  
That they might bend him and might bow him down  
Until his face and brow should be forced down  
Into the sand and gravel of the ford.  
While they were so bending and bowing him,  
Cucullin raised on high his warrior-moan  
And hero-sigh of hard, unequal combat,  
So that there was no man of Ulster living,  
And not in sleep, who did not hear him sigh.  
And the men bent and pressed and bowed him down,  
Until his face and brow and countenance

Were 'midst the sand and gravel of the ford.  
It was just then and at that point of time  
That Feeaha the son of Conall Carna  
Arrived and saw that thing. There came on him  
His thong and tie of Ulster love and kinship.  
He drew his sword out of his strong Bive's-scabbard,  
And gave one sweeping blow, till with that blow  
He had struck their twenty-nine right hands from them;  
And the men, owing to the urgency  
Of the deed and act wherein they had been, fell back  
Suddenly into the sand and ooze of the ford.

Cucullin raised his head and drew his breath;  
And he exhaled his sigh of weariness;  
And he perceived the man who thus had helped him.  
"Well nigh too late thy help arrived for me,  
O fellow-pupil!" said Cucullin. "Truly,"  
Said Feeaha, "however late and little  
The help appears to thee, it is not little  
To us there in that camp. We in that camp  
Are the best cantred of the Clan of Rury;  
And 'tis beneath the mouth of spear and sword  
That we should all be placed, if this one blow  
That I have struck for thee, were known of us."  
"I give my word," Cucullin said, "that now,  
Since I have raised my head and drawn my breath,  
Unless thou tell that tale about thyself,  
Not one of these shall henceforth live to tell it."  
Then turned Cucullin rapidly against them,  
And fell to hewing them and slaying them,  
Until he put them from him in their parted  
Quarters, and in their finely parted joints,  
Eastwards and westwards, lengthways of the ford.  
One man alone escaped him—namely, Glass  
The son of Delga; then Cucullin saw him,  
And, in his rushing of swift running, rushed  
Like the swift, rushing wind; and even as Glass  
The son of Delga came unto the tent

Of Al-yill and of Maev, Cucullin reached him;  
And while he panted, “Feea—, Feea—,” meaning  
To tell the deed of Feeaha, Cucullin  
Struck a swift blow, and struck his head from him;  
And then again, like the swift, rushing wind,  
He went from them; and no one caught him there.

“That was a sudden thing with that man there,”  
Said Maev; “what debt was that whereof he spoke?”  
(For “Feea” means “a debt.”) “Truly,” said Fergus,  
“I know not; but perchance within the camp  
There is some man who owed a debt to him;  
And it was in his mind whilst he ran hither.  
Howbeit one thing I aver,” said Fergus—  
And he spake loudly, roughly, joyously—  
“Now, in one time, his debts have all been paid.”

This was Cucullin’s combat on the Táin  
With Calateen of many dangerous arts,  
Together with his twenty-seven sons  
And with his grandson, Glass the son of Delga.

And upon Maev that day there was great grief,  
And great perplexity, because not yet  
Had she found one amongst the men of Erin  
Able to conquer and o’erthrow Cucullin.

## BOOK XII

### BOOK XII

That evening Maev unto her private tent  
Summoned the chiefs and warriors and brave men;  
And they stood round her, leaning on their spears,  
Holding a council. And Maev said to them:

“Unless we find a man to overcome  
This dread Cucullin, now my heart will break.”  
Then they all said that there was but one man  
Fitted to meet Cucullin at the ford—  
Faerdeeah son of Daman son of Dawra,  
The mighty warrior of the men of Domnann  
From Irrus Domnann in the storm-beat west;  
For like and equal were their modes of fight:  
They by one teacher had been taught and trained,  
Namely, by Scawtha; so that neither owned  
Advantage o’er the other, save that only  
Cucullin owned the art of the Gae Bulg.  
But then, as was well known, Faerdeeah owned  
A conganess, a tough protecting armour,  
The gift of Scawtha ere he left her land;  
And no edged weapons easily could pierce it.

Then there were sent envoys and messengers  
To bring Faerdeeah straightway; but Faerdeeah  
Denied, declined, refused those messengers,  
And came not with them; for full well he knew  
The thing that brought them there,—to make him fight  
In fierce encounter with his own dear friend,  
His loved companion and brother-in-arms, Cucullin.

And Maev dispatched her skilful slanderers,  
And men of irony and calumny,  
And bade them speak their dangerous lampoons

And hot, cheek-reddening satire and invective,  
To raise three shameful blisters on his face—  
Reproach, Disgrace, and Contumely—that so,  
If he died not immediately, at least  
He might be dead ere nine days should be past,  
Unless he came with them.

Faerdeeah then

Came to confer with Maev; for he desired  
To fall in battle-glory, not by shafts  
Of coward ridicule. And he resolved  
To offer every other battle-service,  
But not to combat with his own dear friend.

The hour that Maev and Al-yill saw him come  
They laughed a full loud laugh of triumph. Then  
With honour and attendance they received him,  
And brought him to the feast. And Findabair,  
Obedient to her mother, brimmed his cup  
With wine from Gaul, and gave him with each cup  
Three kisses, tenderly and fervently;  
And carried to him, folded in her layna,  
Red, well-stored apples; and she laid them down,  
And bade him eat, and said that he indeed  
Of all the men in Erin was the one  
Whom she could choose to love. And this was true;  
For now, since Frae had fallen, she had not seen  
So goodly a man to love as was Faerdeeah.  
So he grew gently merry. Presently,  
When he a while had quaffed the wine from Gaul,  
Maev spake and said: “Good, now, my friend, Faerdeeah,  
Knowest thou why I have sent for thee this night?”  
And he made answer: “Here are goodly chiefs,  
And men of valour and of warlike deeds;  
And where such men are gathered, ’tis but fit  
I should be found amongst them!” Maev replied:  
“Not only so; but I have sent for thee  
To offer thee great wealth and great rewards:—  
A chariot costing four times seven bond-maids,

And raiment for twelve men, of each right hue,  
With drinking-horns and bridles and fleet steeds,  
And kingly sról and rings of rich red gold,  
And the full measure of thy barren land  
Apportioned to thee from my smooth Moy Wee,  
With a fair share of plain and forest land,  
To be thine own, free of all tax and tribute,  
Free from demands for hostings, free to thee  
And to thy sons and to thy seed for ever,  
Until the brink of Judgment and of Doom.  
These shall be thine, and more; for Findabair  
Shall go to thee to be thine own one wife;  
And I will give to thee as highest honour  
The golden brooch from out my queenly robe.  
These shall be thine, if thou to-morrow morn  
Wilt meet Cucullin at the danger-ford,  
And if by thee he shall be slain and die.”

“Great the rewards and gifts!” exclaimed the chiefs.  
Faerdeeah said: “Though very great the gifts,  
Maev, as for me, may take them back again.  
I will not slay my brother-in-arms, Cucullin.”

They brimmed his horn again, and when again  
He for a while had quaffed the Gaulish wine,  
Maev spake and said: “Hearken, my friend, Faerdeeah.  
It is an ancient word that to each man  
His native land is dear. Cucullin fights  
For his own native land, the land of Ulster;  
And thou shouldst fight for thine, the land of Connaught.”  
Faerdeeah hearkened for a while, then said:  
“I cannot fight my brother-in-arms, Cucullin.”

They brimmed his horn again; and when again  
He for a while had quaffed the Gaulish wine,  
Maev spake and said: “Know’st thou, my friend, Faerdeeah,  
Throughout the camp to-night by every fire,  
There is no theme for jest and mockery  
Save this alone, namely, that thou, Faerdeeah,  
Who hast been trained to arms far in the east



By Ooaha, by Scawtha, and by Weefa,  
Lackest the valour for hard battle-combat.”  
Faerdeeah heard; and he grew red and pale.  
For thus Faerdeeah was:—there was to him  
No ill so hard to endure as mockery  
And raillery and scorn and mocking words.  
He paused a while in silence, but then said:  
“I may not fight my brother-in-arms, Cucullin.”

They brimmed his horn again; and when again  
He for a while had quaffed the Gaulish wine,  
Maev spake aloof, apart, in a low voice,  
According to the ways for great deceivings,  
And said: “O warriors, it was a true word  
Cucullin spoke.” Faerdeeah heard her words,  
Even as she had meant that he should hear them.  
He said to her: “What word was that, O Maev?”  
“Cucullin said,” said Maev, “that unto him  
It would not have appeared too much that thou,  
Faerdeeah, shouldst have been the first to fall  
In battle-fight with him upon this hosting.  
And this is what Cucullin says: he says  
That he, indeed, would think it little honour  
To slay thee now, after the true war-heroes  
Whom he has slain in combat on this Táin.”  
Faerdeeah heard those well-devised words  
Which Maev devised; and he grew red and pale  
With wrath; yet had it not been for the wine  
Which he had quaffed, he would not have believed  
Those words, as now with anger he believed them.  
“It was not right,” he said, “that even Cucullin  
Should speak of me in that wise. Never yet  
Hath he known cowardice or weariness  
In me by day or night. But now I swear  
I will be he who shall be found the first  
In readiness upon the ford to-morrow.”

“May victory and blessing be on thee,”  
Said Maev, “and all success and battle-triumph.”

“But thou, great Queen,” Faerdeeah said, “must give me  
Sureties and pledges that thou wilt fulfil  
The promises that thou hast made.” Then Maev  
Bound herself by the firm security  
Of six great chiefs and princes. Yet Faerdeeah  
Paused, and he said: “Nay, thou must give me, too,  
The sun and moon and wind.” And Maev complied.  
She gave to him in surety sun and moon  
And stars and colours and the falling dew  
And the four winds—that those great powers all,  
If she should break her word, might punish her.  
And after that she bound Faerdeeah fast  
By the same pledges and securities  
To fight Cucullin on the following morn.  
So they were bound on either side; and Maev  
Took from her crimson bratt her heavy brooch  
Of beaten gold; and kindly, royally,  
Yielded it to Faerdeeah as a sign  
Of mutual faith and truth and honour pledged.  
Faerdeeah then, the feast being ended, went  
Back to his tent and to his folk and people.

Fergus had witnessed all that speech and contract.  
He went to see Cucullin; and he came  
Unto that place wherein Cucullin was.  
“He who will come against thee in the morn,”  
He said, “is thine own friend and bosom-comrade,  
Faerdeeah son of Daman son of Dawra,  
Who with thyself was trained far in the east.”

Cucullin said: “It is not he, indeed,  
Whom I had wished to come against me—yet  
Not on account of any fear of him,  
But on account of my great love for him.”

Fergus replied: “Yet it is right to fear him;  
For not like others who have come is this  
Faerdeeah son of Daman son of Dawra,  
Who will confront thee at the ford to-morrow.”

Cucullin said: “Here I have been alone

Against the hosts of the Four Fifths of Erin,  
Since Sowin Eve till now when spring begins.  
I have not yielded one foot in retreat  
In all this time before one man of them,  
Save before thee, O Fergus; and I hope  
I shall not yield before Faerdeeah now.”  
Fergus went back to his own tent and people.

As for Faerdeeah, he had now returned  
Unto his tent and folk, to whom he told  
How he was bound by Maev to single combat  
With dread Cucullin on the ensuing morn.

The people of Faerdeeah’s tent that night  
Were not content and merry and full of joy;  
But they were sorrowful, dispirited;  
Because they knew in whatsoever place  
Those two great heroes, those two battle-breakers,  
Might meet in combat, either both would fall,  
Or one would fall; and if but one should fall,  
They thought that it would be their own dear lord;  
For now it seemed a thing impossible  
To overthrow Cucullin on this Táin.

During the earlier hours of that sad night  
Faerdeeah slept a deep and heavy sleep.  
Then his sleep went from him; and he awoke.  
All the inebriation of Maev’s wine  
Had gone; and now in the cold, misty morn  
The question and the trouble and the sorrow  
Of that vowed combat scourged and weighed on him.  
Then he arose, and bade his charioteer  
Harness his steeds and yoke his chariot quickly.  
The servant sought to hinder him, and said:  
“Better by far remain and take thy rest  
Until the sun arise. Go not yet forth  
Unto this grievous meeting and encounter.”  
“Be silent now, my man,” Faerdeeah said.  
“Thou speakest like a servant. We will go  
With strength and valour to the ford of wounding,

O'er which the Bive shall scream."

The horses then

Were harnessed, and the chariot yoked, and forth  
They rode, and reached the battle-ford; and not  
E'en yet had the full light of daylight come.

Through the dim, misty light of early morn  
Maev from her tent had seen Faerdeeah pass.  
She said: "Does Al-yill sleep?" "Not so," said Al-yill.  
Maev said: "Provided that Cucullin falls  
By yonder warrior, 'twill be well for us  
If he himself falls too; for this we know:—  
That if he slays his friend, 'tis we ourselves  
Whom in his woe he next will seek to slay."

Faerdeeah and his servant then had reached  
The battle-stream. "O gillie," said Faerdeeah,  
"Look, is Cucullin yet upon the ford?"  
"He is not," said the servant. "Look with heed,"  
Faerdeeah said. "Cucullin," said the servant,  
"Is not some little switch or goad concealed  
Amid long grass." "'Tis true," Faerdeeah said,  
"He is not there. He has not till this hour  
Heard of the coming of a true war-hero  
Against him on this Táin. Now, having heard,  
He has abandoned the dread ford." "Alas!"  
The gillie said, "it is unkind, disloyal,  
So in his absence to insult Cucullin.  
And dost thou not remember how, yon time  
When ye attacked rough, battle-skilled Germanus  
O'er the edge-borders of the Tyrrhene Sea,  
Thou with the host hadst left thy battle-sword;  
And 'twas Cucullin who regained it for thee,  
Slaying one hundred men to reach to it?  
And dost thou not remember where we were  
On that same night?" "I do not," said Faerdeeah.  
"We all were at the house of Scawtha's steward,"

The gillie said; “that night, with glowing pride,  
Thou wentst into that house before us all;  
Whereat the steward, the giant-hideous churl,  
With his long, three-pronged flesh-fork struck at thee  
Against the mid-part of thy back, and flung thee  
Out o’er the threshold of the door. Cucullin  
It was who slew that churl; and it was I  
Who served as steward so long as ye remained  
Within that stead. And that one day alone  
Makes it not right that thou shouldst boast thyself  
A better battle-hero than Cucullin.”

“Be silent, O my man,” Faerdeeah said.  
“What thou now dost is wrong, thus, when too late,  
Putting those days into my memory;  
But hadst thou spoken of these things last night,  
Then, notwithstanding Maev’s strong wine from Croohan,  
Yea, notwithstanding that o’erweening boasting  
Cucullin made, I had not come to-day  
Unto this fight and combat. And now, gillie,”  
Faerdeeah said, “desist from this, and spread  
The blankets and the skins of the firm chariot  
Beneath me here, that I may take my sleep,  
My deep repose and rest. In the last hours  
Of the dark night I slept not; for the thought  
And trouble of this combat weighed on me.”

The charioteer loosened the steeds, and then  
Spread for his lord the blankets and the skins;  
And soon the heavy deadness of deep sleep  
Fell on Faerdeeah, and he rested there.

And now about Cucullin. He arose not  
Until the day with its full light had come,  
That so the men of Erin might not say  
That fear and terror drove away his sleep.  
But when the day with all its light had come,  
He rose and said unto his charioteer:  
“Good now, my servant Laeg, harness the steeds  
And yoke the chariot. We will now ride forth.

He is an early-rising man, this friend,  
Faerdeeah son of Daman son of Dawra,  
Who comes against us at the ford to-day.”

“The steeds are caught: the chariot is prepared,”  
Said Laeg, “so mount it: it will not disgrace  
Thy valour or thy prowess and feats of arms.”

Then sprang into his chariot the adroit  
And battle-victorious, red-sworded hero,  
Cucullin son of Sooaltim; and round him  
Shouted the Boccanahs and Bannanahs  
And the Glen-folk and Spirits of the Air;  
And Thooaha Dae Danann raised around him  
Shoutings and cries, that so they might enhance  
The terror and fear and hate his foes should feel.

In no long time Faerdeeah’s charioteer  
Heard the dim roll of wheels, the tramp of hooves,  
The musical clang of swords and spears and shields  
Beating against each other, and the cries  
Made by the airy spirits. Then he went  
And laid his hand upon his master, saying:  
“Arise, Faerdeeah! for he cometh now—  
The Hound of Valour. Over wide Bray Ross  
Fleetly he cometh. Like a noble hawk  
He swoopeth southward, and is like the wind  
For swiftness. Not with waned dexterity  
Will he attack thee at the ford to-day.”

Faerdeeah, waking, spake with vehemence,  
And said: “Hast thou been bribed to praise this man?  
I think thou hast taken wages to extol  
The vaunting youth from Cooley. Know thou, then,  
That he shall find his downfall here to-day.”

And soon the charioteer, watching there, saw  
Cucullin’s comely, four-peaked chariot: green  
Its pleasant awning, thin and firm its frame.  
Beneath the one yoke was a fleet, gray horse,  
With long smooth hair: beneath the second yoke  
A black horse, tufty-maned and fierce like fire,

And like a hawk down-swooping from a cloud,  
Like a cold gust of spring wind o'er a plain,  
Or like a deer when started by the hounds  
On his first chase, were those two noble steeds.  
As though they trod on fiery flags they came;  
And the earth shook and trembled. So Cucullin  
Came to the ford. Faerdeeah on the south  
Awaited him. He on the northern side  
Drew up his chariot; and they faced each other.

"Welcome, Cucullin, is thy coming," then  
Faerdeeah said. Cucullin answered him:  
"Trusty and dear to me until this hour  
Those words had been. Now I accept them not.  
And, O Faerdeeah, it were fitter far  
For me to speak the welcome in this land.  
It is my land, not thine; and I am here  
Defending my own people and their wives  
And youths and little ones and flocks and herds,  
All that are left uncaptured and unslain;  
And thou hast come to combat with me here."  
Faerdeeah said: "Thereby I honour thee.  
What claim or right hast thou to fight with me?  
For, when we were with Scawtha far away,  
Thou wast my servant and subordinate,  
To fit my spears and to prepare my bed."

"Yea, for I was the younger," said Cucullin;  
"But, well thou knowest, it is not as thy man,  
Or as thy servant and subordinate,  
That men hereafter will remember me.  
Therefore withdraw in time, or thou shalt find  
That thou hast fallen in a gap of danger;  
And edgéd weapons here will hew thee down,  
And thou shalt never be a battle-chief  
From this time forth; but here thy life shall end."

"Away with all thy boasting and thy warning!"  
Replied Faerdeeah; "like a tame house-bird  
Thou art to me. Ere sun-down, ere the night,

Crimson shall flow thy blood athwart thy bridle.  
Thy head shall be upon a pointed spit,  
Thou upstart vaunter! I am here at length;  
And thou shalt fight and die.” So spake Faerdeeah,  
Indignant rage having laid hold of him.

Then, quick, Cucullin said: “O my Faerdeeah,  
Why didst thou listen to the fair-haired queen?  
She hath beguiled thee with deceiving words.  
We, when we were with Scawtha in the east,  
Went out together into every battle.  
In lands and forests many and far away  
We went with Scawtha, learning, practising.  
And we were heart-companions: side by side,  
After long toil, we slept our good, deep sleep.  
A dearer, trustier friend I have not known.  
We thought that never, indeed, between us two  
Could there be angry words or enmity.  
Come not against me now, O noble hero,  
Faerdeeah son of Daman. Break not so  
Our bond of friendship. Hold in memory  
The vow we made. There is not in the world  
One at whose hest I would do ill to thee.”

Faerdeeah paused in silence. Then he said:  
“It is too late. Too long have we been thus,  
Contending with words only. And what weapons  
Shall we select to-day?” Cucullin said:  
“Thine is the choice of arms until the night;  
For thou art he who first did reach the ford.”  
“Dost thou remember, then,” Faerdeeah asked,  
“The game with missive weapons that we played  
With Ooaha, with Scawtha, and with Weefa?  
If thou rememberest, let us try them now.”

Then they put on their two bright-bordered shields.  
Adapted for quick play of skill; and took  
Eight little lances made for feats of skill,  
With eight well-shapen feather-wingéd darts,  
Eight ivory-hilted poniards thin and straight,



And eight diminutive bone-hafted spears.  
And these flew forth from them and back again  
Like flying bees on a bright summer's day.  
No cast was badly aimed. From early morn  
To full mid-day they cast and shot and hurled,  
Until their various missiles were all spoiled  
And blunted on the well-directed shields.  
Though excellent the hurling, yet so true  
Was the defence that neither, in all that time,  
Wounded or injured or made red the other.

“Let us abandon these,” Faerdeeah said;  
“For not through these our fight will be resolved.”  
“Yea, let us leave them, if the time be come,”  
Replied Cucullin. And they ceased, and flung  
Into the hands of their good charioteers  
Their darts and lances and bright-bordered shields.  
“What arms or weapons shall we fight with now?”  
Faerdeeah questioned; but Cucullin said:  
“Thine is the choice of arms until the night;  
For thou art he who first did reach the ford.”

“Then,” said Faerdeeah, “let us now take up  
Our straight and shapely, smooth, well-hardened spears,  
Wherein well-tightened is the flaxen cord.”

“So let us, if thou wilt,” Cucullin said.  
Then they put on two strong, protecting shields;  
And took their shapely, smooth, well-hardened spears,  
Wherein well-tightened was the flaxen cord;  
And with these arms they shot, each at the other,  
From middle day until the evening fell.  
Though excellent the quick defence they made,  
So skilful was their hurling, and so true,  
That each was hurt and wounded in that time.

“Let us leave off now for the present while,”  
Faerdeeah said. “Let us, if it be time,”  
Replied Cucullin. And they ceased, and threw  
Into the hands of their good charioteers  
Their shields and fighting-weapons; and forthwith

Each one drew nigh the other; and each laid  
His arms around the other's neck, and gave him  
Three kisses ardently and fervently.  
Their horses all that night remained together  
In the one paddock; and their charioteers  
Stayed by one fire. Howbeit, ere darkness fell  
Each servant made for his own lord a bed  
Of newly-gathered rushes; and both made  
Pillows for wounded men; and then there came  
The folk of cure and healing, and applied  
Succulent herbs of healing and of cure  
To all their hurts and gashes and sore wounds.  
Of every herb and every healing salve  
That they provided for Cucullin's wounds  
He sent one half south-westward o'er the ford  
Unto Faerdeeah. And of all nourishment,  
And all inspiriting, well-flavoured ale  
Brought by the men of Erin to Faerdeeah,  
He sent one half north-eastward o'er the ford  
To freshen and delight and help Cucullin.  
They, in this manner, rested there that night.

And early in the morning they arose;  
And they came forward to the ford of battle.  
"What arms of valour shall we take to-day?"  
Cucullin asked; but briefly, courteously,  
Faerdeeah answered: "Thine the choice of arms  
Until the night; for in the day now past  
The choice was mine." "Let us," Cucullin said,  
"Take up our huge, wide-headed thrusting spears;  
And let our steeds be caught and chariots yoked,  
That from our chariots and from o'er our steeds  
We may deliver battle here to-day."  
Then they put on two durable, strong shields,  
Wide and protecting; and they took the spears  
That were wide-headed, huge; and these they thrust  
And drove against each other, from the gleam

Of early morning till the evening fell.  
Their steeds were weary, and their charioteers  
Dispirited; and they themselves—the heroes,  
The men of valour—they were weary too.  
“Now let us cease, Faerdeeah,” said Cucullin;  
“Our steeds are weary; and our charioteers  
Discouraged and fatigued. Why should not we  
Be weary likewise?” And they ceased, and threw  
Their spears and shields unto their charioteers;  
And each drew nigh the other; and each laid  
His arms around the other’s neck, and gave him  
Three kisses; and Cucullin said: “Faerdeeah,  
My loving heart is as one clot of blood;  
Almost my spirit has departed from me.  
What need hadst thou to come to combat here  
At bidding of the evil-minded queen?  
Let us withdraw from this, and strive no more.  
I have not heart or strength for feats of valour,  
Fighting with thee, Faerdeeah, my dear friend.”

Faerdeeah mused in silence. He recalled  
The strong securities and powerful bonds  
Wherein he was fast bound by Maev; then said:  
“O Hound of Valour, Hound of Battle-triumph,  
It is too late. We may not now draw back;  
But one of us must fall, or both must fall,  
In contest at this ford. And well we know  
What must be, must be. Man may not avoid  
His hour of birth, nor yet his hour of death;  
But he is driven and constrained to come  
Unto that sod where his last grave shall be.”

They rested there that night. Their charioteers  
Lay at one fire; and their horses stayed  
In one enclosure. And the men of healing  
Came to watch o’er the wounded heroes there,  
Putting unto each grievous hurt and wound  
Their powerful phrases, able words and charms  
And spells and incantations. Only so

Might they alleviate the sore pain, and staunch  
The flowing blood—so bitter and so deep  
Their hurts and injuries and gory wounds.  
Of every spell and every powerful charm  
Brought by the men of healing for Cucullin,  
He sent one half south-westward o’er the ford  
Unto Faerdeeah. And of all pleasant food,  
And all exhilarating, mirthful ale,  
Brought by the men of Erin to Faerdeeah,  
He sent one half north-eastward o’er the ford  
To help Cucullin.

In the early morn  
They rose and came unto the ford of battle.  
Cucullin saw a darkly-lowering cloud  
Upon Faerdeeah’s face that morn, and said:  
“Thou art not well to-day, my friend, Faerdeeah.  
Dulled is thy hair, and drowsy is thine eye:  
Thy freshness and thy form have gone from thee.”

“’Tis not through fear of thee that I am so,”  
Replied Faerdeeah; “there is not in Erin  
A champion I could not subdue this day.  
What arms or weapons shall we fight with now?”

Cucullin answered: “Thine the choice of arms  
Until the night; for in the day just past  
The choice was mine.” “Let us,” Faerdeeah said,  
“Take up our heavy and hard-smiting swords.  
Thereby we shall be nearer to our end  
Than by the thrusting we were yesterday.”

Then they put on two long and ample shields,  
And took their heavy and hard-smiting swords;  
And they began to hit and hew and strike  
And smite each other; and continued so  
From early morning till the evening fell.

“Let us forsake this now,” Faerdeeah said.  
“Let us, if it be time,” Cucullin answered.  
It was a parting of two mournful men,  
Two sorrowful, disheartened ones, that night.

Their steeds were not in the one fold that night,  
Nor lay their charioteers by the one fire.  
In woe and grief they rested that night there.

And early on the morrow morn arose  
Faerdeeah, and went forward all alone  
Unto the ford of battle; for he knew  
That was the day which finally should end  
Their striving and their combat; and he knew  
That one of them would fall, or both would fall,  
Upon that day. And then it was indeed  
That he put on his battle-suit of battle  
Before the coming of Cucullin towards him.  
He put against his whitely-gleaming skin  
His filmy foo-a-vrōg of kingly srōl  
Hemmed up with spangled gold; and over that  
His foo-a-vrōg of leather, brown, well-smoothed.  
And over that he placed a disc of stone,  
Huge like a mill-stone; and placed o'er these all  
His iron foo-a-vrōg, steadfast and deep,  
Of tempered iron; and all this he did  
Through fear and dread of the Gae Bulg that day.  
Then he put round his head his crested cathbarr,  
Whereon, in the divisions, forty gems  
Of carbuncle were set, which flamed and glowed;  
And it was outlined well with crooan-stones  
And crystal and jewels of light that men had brought  
From the far eastern world. In his right hand  
He took his stalwart, death-producing spear.  
He placed on his left hip his curvéd sword  
With golden hilt and hand-guard of red gold.  
He hung upon the broad slope of his back  
His shield with hornéd rivets, that was formed  
Of fifty strong concentric rings encircling  
A central boss of glorious, flaming gold.

That morn Faerdeeah practised many a feat,  
And many an art adroit and wonderful,

And many a movement that he ne'er had learned  
From Ooaha, from Scawtha or from Weefa,  
But had contrived himself, to be attempted  
That day against Cucullin.

And Cucullin  
Came to the ford, and saw each noble feat  
And all the arts adroit and wonderful  
Faerdeeah practised there; and then he said:  
"My good friend Laeg, thou seest the noble feats  
Faerdeeah practises; and well we know  
That all these arts in turn will here to-day  
Be tried against me. Therefore thou, good Laeg,  
If they prevail against me in the least,  
If I begin to yield or waver here,  
Thou shalt incite me and find fault with me,  
And rail at me with sour, disdainful words,  
That so thou mayst arouse my rage and ire.  
But if it be that I prevail, then praise me,  
Commend me, and speak kind, applauding words,  
That so my hope and spirit may grow the more."

And Laeg replied: "Thus, surely, will I do."  
Cucullin then put on his noble garb  
Of battle and of combat; and he too  
Performed adroit and accurate turns of skill,  
And feats and arts that he had never learned  
With Ooaha, with Scawtha, or with Weefa.  
Faerdeeah witnessed all those feats, and knew  
Each would be tried against him in its turn.

"What arms of valour shall we take to-day?"  
Inquired Cucullin; and Faerdeeah said:  
"Thine is the choice of arms until the night."

"Let us, then, try the ford-feat," said Cucullin.  
"Let us," replied Faerdeeah, "if so thou wilt."  
Howbeit, though thus Faerdeeah gave consent,  
The choice was unto him a cause of grief;  
For, until then, Cucullin had o'erthrown  
All champions and all heroes whomsoever

Who in the ford-feat had encountered him.

Illustrious and awful was the fight  
That they fought out upon the ford that day—  
Those two exalted warriors, those two heroes,  
Those high-born ones with gift-bestowing hands,  
Those well-belovéd pillars of all valour,  
Those keys of valour of the valiant Gael,  
Those two dear friends, brought to such dreadful fight  
Through the skilled instigation and inciting  
And the skilled wiles and slanderous words of Maev.

From early morning till the midday hour  
They cast and hurled; but when the midday came,  
Their battle-anger rose and boiled with fury.  
And from that hour their rage and battle-fury  
Seethed in their hearts, so that each knew no more  
That he was fighting with his friend and comrade;  
But each thought only of the strife and combat.  
And each drew nigh the other. Then it was  
That from the very brink of the wide ford  
Cucullin leapt, and lighted on the boss,  
The golden central boss, of the great shield  
Faerdeeah son of Daman held before him.  
For thus he hoped to strike Faerdeeah's head  
Over the border of the mighty shield.  
But, straight, Faerdeeah with his left elbow dealt  
The shield a blow, and cast Cucullin back,  
Light as a bird, on the ford's brink again.  
Again Cucullin leapt, and deftly lighted  
On the great boss, to reach Faerdeeah's head.  
Faerdeeah dealt the shield a mighty blow  
With his left knee, and cast Cucullin back,  
Light as a child, on the ford's brink again.

And Laeg perceived that thing. "Alas!" said Laeg,  
"The man who is against thee casts thee now  
As a lewd woman casts away her child:

He flings thee as the river flings the foam:  
He grinds thee as the mill grinds the fresh malt:  
He cuts thee as the wood-axe cuts the oak:  
He binds thee as the woodbine binds the tree:  
He pounces on thee as the hawk doth pounce  
On tiny birds: and thou hast now no kin  
And no relationship to men of valour  
From this time forth, thou small distorted sprite.”

Then, with the swiftness of the cold spring wind,  
With the adroitness of a swallow flying,  
Cucullin once again sprang through the air,  
And lighted once again upon the boss  
Of the great shield, to strike Faerdeeah’s head.  
Faerdeeah gave the shield a sudden shake,  
And cast Cucullin back on the ford’s brink,  
As though he had ne’er leapt from it at all.

Then, for the first time in their awful combat,  
Cucullin was distorted with his rage  
And filled with swelling, as a bladder is filled  
With a man’s breath; and he appeared to be—  
To those who watched—some giant, terrible,  
Strange, and discoloured. Like a Man of the Sea,  
Or huge Fomorian from the north, he stood  
In perfect height against Faerdeeah there.

So close the combat was, which there they made,  
That now their heads encountered o’er their shields,  
And now their feet below them; and their hands  
Met in the middle part, beyond the plates  
And borders of the shields. So close their fight,  
Their shields were burst and rifted from the rim  
Unto the central part. So close their fight,  
Their spears were bent and doubled from the point  
Unto the haft. So close the fight they made,  
The unseen Bannanahs and Boccanahs  
And the Glen-folk and Spirits of the Air  
Screamed from the edges of their shields, and cried



From each sword-hilt and spear-shaft; and the herds  
Of horses of the men of Erin brake  
In fright and fury from their rings and tethers,  
And fled in madness. And the little folk  
And women and youths and cowardly folk and fools  
Broke from the camp south-westwards in their fright  
And wild alarm and terror in that hour.

They now were at the edge-feat with their swords.  
Faerdeeah found a chance upon Cucullin  
For one brief instant; and he dealt a blow  
With his bone-hafted dagger, till its blade  
Was hidden in Cucullin's chest. The blood  
Fell on Cucullin's girdle; and the ford  
Was reddened with his blood. Cucullin then  
Held out no longer; for Faerdeeah still  
Was striking his annihilating blows,  
And his long blows, and his great middle blows,  
Upon him there; and he called out to Laeg  
To send him the Gae Bulg. Faerdeeah heard  
Cucullin calling for that spear of Scawtha.  
He made a downward stroke with his great shield  
To shield his under-part. Cucullin hurled  
Out of his palm a short, straight dart athwart  
The upper margin of Faerdeeah's shield,  
And through the throat-vent of his horn-skin armour,  
So that the point thereof was visible,  
After its piercing of Faerdeeah's heart,  
Within his breast and side. Faerdeeah then  
Made a swift, upward stroke with his great shield  
To shield his over-part; though this was help  
Arriving when too late. And Laeg meanwhile  
Directed the Gae Bulg along the stream.  
Cucullin with the toes of his feet received it.  
He gave a choice cast of the Scythian weapon  
Upward against Faerdeeah; and it pierced  
The iron foo-a-vrōg of tempered iron,

And clove the disc of stone into three parts,  
And pierced through all the coverings of his frame,  
So that each inward part of him was filled  
With spear-heads of the opening Gae Bulg.

“That is henceforth enough,” Faerdeeah said:  
“O Hound of beautiful and wondrous feats,  
I fall by that.” The heavy mist of death  
Came o’er Faerdeeah. And Cucullin ran  
And closed his hands around him; and he bore him  
With all his arms and his accoutrements  
North-eastward o’er the ford, and up the bank,  
That so the trophies of the victory  
Might be with him north-eastward of the ford,  
Not with the men of Erin on the south.

Then on the ground he laid Faerdeeah down.  
His battle-fury now had gone from him;  
And a thick cloud of faintness and of pain  
Descended densely on him while he bent  
O’er the dead body of Faerdeeah there.  
This was perceived by Laeg. “Master,” said Laeg,  
“Hasten away. The men of Erin come;  
And ’tis not single combat they will give us,  
Faerdeeah son of Daman being slain.”

“Why should I haste, my servant?” moaned Cucullin;  
“And what have I to do with rising now?  
The utmost folly and rage of grief is mine,  
After my swording of this noble one.  
Would rather he had lopped from me each limb  
Ere this thing had befallen!”

“Nay,” said Laeg,  
“Triumph, elation, spirit, and delight  
Befit thee now. At thee he dealt his blows  
Unfriendly, envious, lamentable. Now  
Faerdeeah of the Hosts has fallen. Now  
Maev has received her deadliest grief of all.  
Hasten away, O Slaughter-hound of Avvin,

And heal thy wounds; and when they are whole again,  
Great joy and exultation shall be thine.”

Cucullin heeded not; but he began  
To moan and to complain and to lament  
Above Faerdeeah there, and spake these words:

“Alas, Faerdeeah! great the treachery  
The men of Erin did thee! Wherefore now  
Didst thou lend ear to the deceiving words  
Of the fair western women? Didst thou think  
That Findabair would be for thee? As well  
Tie with a thong the shifting river-sand  
As think to win her! Unto many more  
Had she been promised, ere Maev promised thee.  
But never shall they find another hero  
Like thee to fight for Croohan—nevermore  
One of like deeds in battle, summoning  
The red-mouthed Bive to scream above the slain.  
And never shall they see the like of thee,  
Cloud-coloured son of Daman, whose bright face  
Was like the clouds of dawn. Oh, dear to me  
Thy ruddy freshness, dear thy shapely form,  
Thy pure blue eye and yellow-streaming hair,  
Thy gifts of wisdom and of eloquence!  
Oh, woe that thou shouldst die while I remain!  
I have not known one like thee, my Faerdeeah!”

So spake Cucullin and was silent. Yet  
He moved not; but he gazed upon Faerdeeah.  
And then he spake, and said: “My good friend Laeg,  
Remove Faerdeeah’s armour. Let me see  
The golden brooch that pledged him to this fight.”

And Laeg removed the armour; and they saw  
The golden brooch. Cucullin wept and said:  
“It was not right, Faerdeeah, so to come  
To fight with me. When we were far away  
With Scawtha in the east, we thought unkindness  
Could never be between us. Now, good Laeg,  
Open the body, and take out the spear.

I cannot be without the Gae Bulg.” Laeg  
Opened the body and took out the spear.  
Cucullin saw his weapon, red with blood,  
Lying beside Faerdeeah; and he said:  
“O my Faerdeeah, sorrowful the fate!  
I, with my merciless weapon still unwashed:  
Thou, pale in death upon a couch of gore.  
Sad—what has come of our meeting here—  
I, wounded, sinking, covered with rough gore:  
Thou, altogether dead! Oh, dear to me  
The friend to whom I have served a draught of blood!”

“Good, now, Cucullin, let us leave the ford,”  
Said Laeg; “too long have we been here.” “Aye, Laeg,”  
Cucullin answered, “we will leave.” But still  
He gazed back at Faerdeeah; and he said:  
“Now every other combat I have fought  
Seems but a game of play. Alas! I loved  
This pillar of gold whom now I have overthrown.  
Huge, like a mountain, he seemed yesterday:  
To-day his shadow only doth remain.  
There hath not come unto a gory battle,  
Nor hath old Banba nursed upon her breast,  
Nor hath there e’er been known on sea or land,  
Of sons of warriors, one of better fame.”

Laeg on the chariot placed his suffering lord,  
And drove a goad into the waiting steeds;  
And so Cucullin, while the evening fell,  
Into the blue-black forest rode away,  
Wounded well-nigh to death. The men of Erin  
Interred Faerdeeah in a noble grave,  
With his rich dress and war-accoutrements,  
And shield and spear and all his various arms.  
There the green-surfaced hill was closed above him,  
Beside the ford to which they gave his name.



“THE DEATH OF FAERDEEAH.”

## BOOK XIII

### BOOK XIII

From out of Ulster some few men arrived  
To help Cucullin, and console and aid  
And ease him. These were Shennel Ooaha  
And the two sons of Gaega—Muridah  
And Cotreb. These men carried him away  
To bathe his wounds and make clear water strike  
Against his gashes, plunged in brooks and streams  
Of Connallia Mweerhevna. For his friends,  
The unseen Thooaha Dae Danann, then  
Were strowing plants and herbs of health and healing  
On each pure stream of Connallia Mweerhevna,  
To help Cucullin; so that each bright stream  
Was greenly checkered with them. Now, the names  
Of those bestrown, bright streams which helped Cucullin  
Are these:—the Sawss, the Booan, the Billawn,  
The Finnglass, the light Glore, the Glenawin,  
The Baeg, the Tahg, the Telamet, the Rind,  
The Bir, the Brenid, the Deehaem, the Mooah,  
The Meelic, the cramped Cumung, and the Cullin,  
The Ganawin, the Drong, the Delt, the Dooglass.  
And so the soilure and the dangerous venom  
Were laved from out his wounds. And, after that,  
Dry wisps and pads of grass and moss were placed  
Against those wounds. And supple willow-wands  
Were arched above him to sustain his bratt;  
Because his wounds and gashes were so great  
That he might not endure it if his raiment  
Should reach his skin. And thus that day his life  
Was kept within Cucullin; yet it wanted  
Only a little, and he would have died

Despite that help, so bitter were his hurts  
After that awful combat with Faerdeeah.

And while Cucullin thus was bathed and tended  
The Four Great Fifths of Erin went south-west  
From Ath Faerdeeah; and they drew nigh Taltin—  
The burial-field of Ulster kings and queens  
And kingly princes; and they drove with them  
Their captives and their droves of Ulster kine,  
Thinking to drive them through the wide west ford,  
And into Connaught, ere the men of Ulster  
Should rise from out their Kesh; and Maev sent forth  
Mac Roth her messenger, e'en to the hills  
And crags and green-grassed summits of Slieve Foo-id,  
To watch the north, that thus in Avvin Maha  
The men of Ulster might not rise in arms  
Without her having swift advice and warning.

This is the time wherein the charioteers  
Of Ulster—three times fifty charioteers—  
Accoutering themselves with warlike arms,  
Came south against the hosts. There fell by them  
Thrice their own number, ere those charioteers  
From Ulster in the field themselves fell slain.

This is the time when aged Illiah  
The son of Cass the son of Bac the son  
Of Ross the Red-haired son of Rury More,  
Resting in old-age maintenance—maintained  
In green Rath Immil, by his son's famed son,  
By Laery the Victorious—was informed  
How, throughout all the cold, dark winter months,  
Even from Sowin till the opening spring,  
The Four Great Fifths of Erin had been spoiling,  
And laying waste and ravaging and burning,  
All Ulster and all Crithny. Illiah  
Took counsel with his folk. "What counsel now,"  
Said he, "would seem to you more wise than this,

Namely, that I should travel south forthwith  
To attack the men of Erin, and to take  
Spoils from their armies, and avenge a little  
The honour of all Ulster? If thereafter  
I fall myself and die, that is all one.”  
His folk approved of that. They caught for him  
His two old, yellow, withered, wasted steeds,  
Which were upon the shore beside the doon.  
They brought his old-time, antique chariot out,  
That was without cushion or coverlet,  
And yoked it on the steeds. His rough, grey shield  
Of iron, with its hard encircling rim  
Of hardened silver, he took up. He took  
His rough, grey-hilted sword on his left side.  
He took his two blunt spears with shaking heads  
Into his chariot; and his folk arranged  
Round stones and pillar-stones and great, flat flags  
About him in his chariot. Furnished so  
He travelled south against the men of Erin.  
Ere long the hosts perceived him. Then the men,  
Seeing that agéd, naked warrior come,  
His spittle of old age down through the gaps  
In the old osier-woven chariot-floor  
Slow-dripping, laughed aloud their mocking laugh.  
“Good would it seem to us,” they said, “if such  
Were the description of each man from Ulster  
Who e’er should come against us!” In that hour  
Dōha the son of Mahga passed that way.  
Full quickly he restrained the rabble-crowd.  
He went to Illiah, and welcomed him.  
“Welcome thy coming, noble Illiah!”  
Said Dōha. “What man is it who thus greets me?”  
Old Illiah queried. “’Tis the friend and comrade  
Of Laery the Victorious,” Dōha said.  
“’Tis Dōha son of Mahga.” “Dear to me  
Thy welcome is, then,” Illiah replied;  
“Therefore draw near me after some short while,



When all my valour shall have withered up,  
And all my weapons shall have been expended,  
That thou thyself and not some other man  
Among the men of Erin mayst be he  
Who strikes my head from me. And let my sword  
Be kept by thee for Laery.” The old man  
Then with his weapons wrought upon the hosts  
Until his weapons had been all expended;  
And when his weapons had been all expended,  
He wrought upon them with his rocky weights—  
Round stones and pillar-stones and great, flat flags,  
Which he had there—till these had been expended.  
And when his flags and stones had been expended,  
He wrought upon them with his arms. He seized  
Whichever man among the men of Erin  
Came near; and ’twixt his forearms and his fists  
Compressed and chafed him till he made of him  
A marrow-mass, wherein formless were mingled  
Sinews and skin and bones and hair and flesh.  
One of the three chief wonders of the Táin  
Is the great number whom he wrought on so,  
Ere all his old-age valour was expended;  
And when his strength and valour were expended,  
Descrying Dōha, he called out to him:  
“Come to me now, O Dōha son of Mahga!  
Now strike my head from me; but let my sword  
Be kept by thee for Laery.” Dōha came.  
With one swift sword-blow he struck off the head  
From the old warrior; and in this way ended  
“The stone-attack of agéd Illiah.”

Now—though the king and chiefs in Avvin Maha  
Arose not yet out of their blinding Kesh,  
Which had been paining them and blinding them—  
Yet, by degrees, in other parts of Ulster,  
Some few great Ulster chiefs arose with life,  
And came to attack the hosts.

The first of these

Was the famed warrior-poet, Avver-guin  
The son of Cass the son of Bac the son  
Of Ross the Red-haired son of Rury More.  
He was the father of great Conall Carna,  
Who at this time was gathering rent and tribute  
For Ulster, in the isles beyond the sea.  
Avver-guin reached the hosts as they were passing  
With all their throngs to westward over Taltin,  
The ancient burial-field of Ulster kings  
And princes; and he drove them back once more  
Before him over Taltin, toward the north.  
He put his firm left elbow under him  
In Taltin, and his folk provided him  
With stones and pillar-stones, and great flat flags;  
And with these missiles he assailed the hosts  
Throughout the space of three days and three nights.

This was the time when, in the far south-west,  
In Caher Conroi, Cooroi son of Dawra,  
Having returned from warfare in far Scythia,  
Was told how through those long, dark, winter months,  
Even from Sowin till the opening spring,  
The Four Great Fifths of Erin had been stayed  
And held in check and hindered and delayed  
By one man all alone. Now, as for Cooroi,  
Since first he had taken arms, he had not reddened  
His sword in Erin; for there was not room  
In Erin for his pride and haughtiness  
And warrior-fulness; and he e'er had reddened  
His sword in distant lands. But when he heard  
How the Four Fifths of Erin had been hindered  
By one man all alone, he said: "That man,  
Indeed, gives worthy matter for a combat."  
And Cooroi son of Dawra went forthwith  
To seek hard battle-combat with Cucullin.  
Then, when he came to the lone forest-hiding  
Wherein Cucullin was, and saw Cucullin  
Crying with bitter pain, and full of wounds,

And pierced and hurt, it did not seem to him  
Noble or hero-like or full of honour  
To seek a combat with him. "For," he said,  
"It would not be the wounds given by me,  
Which would now cause his death; 'twould be the wounds  
Which he obtained in combat with Faerdeeah."

Cooroi the son of Dawra therefore left  
Cucullin; and he went to join the hosts,  
And to have speech with his own household people  
Who were upon that hosting. When he came  
And joined the hosts, he perceived Avver-guin,  
Westward of Taltin, hurling at the hosts,  
With his left elbow under him. Then Cooroi  
Passed round the men of Erin toward the north  
Of Taltin; and his folk provided him  
With stones and pillar-stones and great, flat flags;  
And face to face he assailed Avver-guin,  
So that the rocks and pillar-stones and flags  
Answered each other in the air, and clashed  
Amidst the clouds and in the air above  
The heads of all those hosts. A hundred stones  
Were made of every separate stone of them  
Amidst the clouds and winds above their heads.  
"Upon the truth of valour which thou hast,  
O Cooroi," Maev said, "cease from this thy hurling:  
'Tis not good help that comes to us therefrom,  
But evil help." "I give my word," said Cooroi,  
"I will not cease until the Breast of Doom,  
Or until Avver-guin shall cease." Thereon  
Avver-guin said: "I will cease verily;  
And bind thyself to come again no more  
To help these hosts of Erin." Cooroi then  
Accepted that; and went upon his road  
To his own folk and his own high-walled doon—  
To Caher Conroi in the far south-west.

During this time the hosts of Erin passed  
O'er Taltin toward the west. "It was not this,"

Said Avver-guin, “which Cooroi bound on me  
Namely, that I should ne’er begin again  
To hurl against yon hosts.” Therefore, again  
He went to westward of them, and he drove them  
Before him over Taltin toward the north;  
And he began to hurl, and hurled at them  
For a long while and a great space of time.  
And then it was that all the men of Erin  
Said it would not dishonour Avver-guin,  
If they should leave their camp in Taltin empty,  
And if their hosts should go for one day’s journey  
Back toward the north, so that they might be stayed  
And be delayed upon their road to Connaught;  
And if, on his part, Avver-guin should stay  
His deeds of valour from the hosts of Erin,  
Until the day when, in a powerful battle,  
The Five Great Fifths of Erin should be met  
Upon the fields of Gawrig and Ilgawrig,  
As now their druids and their seers and prophets  
Were prophesying they should meet. He said  
He would accept that. Then the hosts went back  
One full day’s journey toward the north; and he,  
Keeping in Taltin, stayed his deeds of valour  
Against the men of the Four Fifths of Erin.

The next of the great Ulster chiefs to come  
To do his deeds against the hosts of Erin  
Was Rōhee son of Faha-win, who came  
From Reedonn in the north. He brought with him  
Thrice fifty warriors; and he seized a hill  
Facing the hosts of the Four Fifths of Erin.  
Findabair daughter of Maev and Al-yill  
Saw Rōhee on that hill not far from them;  
And he was thus:—a hero than whom none  
Could be more comely or more beautiful;  
For on his head there was a bushy grove  
Of hair red-yellow; and his pure-skinned face

Was broad above and narrowed toward the chin;  
His eyes were very blue, keen with high pride,  
Like laughing candles in his head; his lips  
Were rosy, thin; his teeth gleamed like clear pearls;  
His figure was erect and tall and even,  
Broad at the shoulder, narrow-hipped, white-skinned.  
He wore a layna made of royal srōl  
With margin-hems of gold. His bratt of crimson  
Was fastened with a princely yō of gold.  
He wore a white-bright shield, whereon were beasts  
Of twisted gold. His dazzling warrior-sword  
Was golden-hilted; and his spear was long,  
Grey-edged, and done with rivets of findrinny.  
In all wide Erin there had ne'er been seen  
A hero-chief more beautiful; and maidens  
Throughout wide Erin loved him for the tales  
Which were related of his shape and beauty.  
Findabair daughter of Maev and Al-yill,  
When she perceived that warrior Rōhee there,  
Grew rosy and then pale; and ere the eve  
She to her mother, even to Maev, spake all  
Her whisper and her secret. "O dear mother,"  
She said, "'tis yonder hero whom I love;  
And who (since I have seen him) e'er will be  
The man to whom my thoughts will cleave—the man  
Whom I would choose to be my love and wooer."  
And Maev replied: "Dear child, if thou dost love him,  
He shall be thine. Sleep with him, then, this night;  
But, first of all, ask of him that he stay  
His deeds of valour from these hosts of Erin,  
Until the day when, in a powerful battle,  
The Five Great Fifths of Erin shall be met  
Upon the fields of Gawrig and Ilgawrig,  
As now our druids and our seers and prophets  
Are prophesying they shall meet." And Rōhee  
The son of Faha-win accepted that;  
And Findabair daughter of Maev and Al-yill

Went to the tent of Rōhee that same night.

Now one among the seven under-kings  
Of Munster who had come upon that hosting  
Was told of this. He spake unto his people:  
“That maid was promised to myself,” he said,  
“Long before this. That was indeed the reason  
Why I came forth upon this war and hosting.”  
Each of the seven under-kings of Munster  
Said the same words; and that that was the reason  
Why he himself had come upon the hosting.  
“And wherefore should we not now go,” they said,  
“To avenge our honour on those seven men,  
Those seven Mahn-yas, sons of Maev and Al-yill,  
Who now keep guard to rearward of these hosts,  
In the low-lying Im-lee of Glendomna?”

This was the counsel which they deemed the best.  
Then they arose—each with his warrior-cantred.  
And, on the other part, Al-yill and Maev  
And all the seven sons of Mahga rose  
With their own people and their warrior-cantreds.  
And it was then that Fergus son of Roy  
Rose with his cantred to make intercession  
And peace between them. But to make that peace  
Was putting hand to a great work; for ere  
That peace was made, and all sat down in quiet  
Beside their comrades and beside their arms,  
Hundreds of very valiant men had fallen  
On both those sides. And this, indeed, was one  
Of three uncounted slaughters on the Táin,  
Which were: the Shessra of the Bressla More,  
This “Imlee of Glendomna,” and the battle  
Upon the fields of Gawrig and Ilgawrig,  
The battle of the Táin.

And Findabair

Daughter of Maev and Al-yill heard these tidings,  
Namely, that those unnumbered men had fallen  
Through her occasion. And she had not known

Of all the promises which had been made  
Before the Táin. Then, when she heard these tidings,  
Her heart within her breast broke and was cloven  
With shame and generous feeling towards those men.  
And she found death; and she was buried straightway.  
And that red, heath-grown, very lonely hill,  
Wherein that day with grief they buried her,  
After that time was called Slieve Findabair.  
And on that heath-grown hill they wailed above her  
Her death-wail, and her loud, long burial-cry—  
E'en as in old, old, very far-back days,  
Brigit the daughter of the mighty Dagda  
Had ordered and ordained; for it was Brigit,  
That woman-poet and that woman-druid,  
The goddess whom all poets love and worship,  
Who had ordained that in all time to come  
There should be wailing o'er the dead in Erin.

The hosts of Erin said: "White was this fight  
For Rōhee son of Faha-win—unnumbered  
Full-valiant men to fall through his occasion,  
And he without a redness or a wound."

The hosts of Erin travelled toward the west,  
And made their camps that night in Slane of Meath.

Of "Sooaltim's Repeated Warning" now  
We next must tell. Sooaltim had been told  
How his young son, the son of Dectora,  
Namely, Cucullin, was in hard oppression  
Of very wrongful and unequal combat  
With Calateen of many dangerous arts  
Together with his seven and twenty sons,  
And his young grandson, Glass the son of Delga.

Then, after some delaying, Sooaltim  
Went forth to find Cucullin; and he found him  
In wounds and pain, wounded well-nigh to death  
After his awful combat with Faerdeeah.

And Sooaltim began to wail above him,  
And to cry out with pity and with woe.  
Then to Cucullin it seemed loss of honour  
That Sooaltim should wail above him—seeing  
That, though he was in wounds and grief and pain,  
This Sooaltim could not avenge him. Thus  
Was Sooaltim:—no mighty, wondrous warrior,  
And yet no bad, mean warrior; but a good,  
Plain, homely, ordinary man-at-arms.

Cucullin then spake unto Sooaltim:  
“Good, now, my father Sooaltim,” he said,  
“Cease from thy wailing; and away with thee  
To Avvin Maha to the men of Ulster.  
Say to them that they now must come themselves  
After their wives and babes and driven kine.  
I am unfit to guard them any longer  
Amidst the gaps and passes of the land  
Of Connallia Mweerhevna. All alone  
I have been facing the Four Fifths of Erin  
Since Sowin, until now, when Spring begins.  
And I have slain one warrior at a ford  
Each day, or else each night one hundred men.  
The Faith of Men has not been kept with me  
In single combat at the battle-ford;  
For they sent many men to fight with one.  
They are bent willow-wands which hold my bratt  
Above me, that it may not touch my skin.  
They are dry wisps of moss which dress my wounds.  
E’en from my crown unto my soles there is  
No place whereon a needle-point might rest,  
Which is without some gash or hurt or wound.  
There is not on me e’en one single hair  
Without its dew-like drop of deep red blood  
Held on its point—save on my left hand only,  
Wherewith I held my shield; and my left hand  
Has thrice ten wounds. Unless they come to avenge  
These things forthwith, they never will avenge them



Until the Breast of Judgment and of Doom.”

Then Laeg led up the wondrous Leea Maha,  
Cucullin’s steed, who once from the Grey Lake  
On lone Slieve Foo-id had come forth to him,  
So that he cast his arms about his neck  
And wrestled with him, making him his own.  
(And now that steed would love him till his death.)  
And Sooaltim upon the Leea Maha,  
Cucullin’s steed, rode north to Avvin Maha,  
With warnings unto Ulster. When he reached  
The side of Avvin, he cried out the words:  
“In Ulster men are slain, O men of Ulster!  
Women are carried captive! Kine are driven!”

Howbeit, he found not from the men of Ulster  
The answer which he would have deemed sufficient.  
And, since he found it not, he went yet further,  
E’en to the top of the high, girdling rampart  
Of Avvin; and he called the same words there:  
“In Ulster men are slain, O men of Ulster!  
Women are carried captive! Kine are driven!”  
And still he found not from the men of Ulster  
The answer which he would have deemed sufficient.  
For thus the men of Ulster were:—’twas gass  
To all of them to speak before their king  
Should speak; and to the king himself ’twas gass  
To speak before the druids who were with him  
Should speak. And Sooaltim went further yet,  
E’en to the Flagstone of the Hostages  
’Midst Avvin; and he called the same words there;  
“In Ulster men are slain, O men of Ulster!  
Women are carried captive! Kine are driven!”

Then Cathbad, the great Druid, spake—yet spake  
As one who still was dreaming:—“Who has slain?”  
He said, “and who has captured? Who has driven?”  
“Al-yill and Maev have come despoiling you,”  
Cried Sooaltim, “and they have seized your women,  
Your youths, your tender lads and little ones,

Your horses and your troops of mares, your kine,  
Both milch and dry, your bulls, your numerous herds.  
Cucullin all alone has stayed and hindered  
And held in check the Four Great Fifths of Erin,  
Amid the gaps and passes and defiles  
Of Conallia Mweerhevna. In his combats  
They broke the Faith of Men with him. No man  
From Ulster goes to aid him or to help him.  
The lad was wounded. He is crushed and broken.  
They are bent willow-wands which hold his bratt  
Above him that it may not touch his skin.  
There is not on him any single hair  
Without its dew-like drop of deep red blood  
Held on its point—save on his left hand only,  
Wherewith he held his shield; and his left hand  
Has thrice ten wounds. Unless ye go to avenge  
These things forthwith, ye never will avenge them  
Until the Breast of Judgment and of Doom.”

“The man who thus incites his own high-king  
Is fit for death,” said Cathbad the great Druid.  
“That which is said by Sooaltim is true,”  
Said Conor. “It is true,” said all the men  
In Avvin all together; but they spake  
As men who still were dreaming. Sooaltim,  
Because he found not from the men of Ulster  
The answer which he would have deemed sufficient,  
Went from them, then, in anger and great rage  
And very venomous ire and fierce wrath,  
And spake no further warning. It was then  
That the dear steed, Cucullin’s Leea Maha,  
Who loved Cucullin and who grieved for him,  
Reared beneath Sooaltim; but Sooaltim  
Rode on o’er the high rampart-mound of Avvin  
Unheeding of that sign. Then his own shield  
Turned against Sooaltim; and the sharp rim  
Of his own shield struck at his neck, and struck  
The head from Sooaltim, whereat the steed,

Cucullin's steed, the loving Leea Maha,  
Himself went back to Avvin; and the shield  
Was on the steed, and in the hollow shield  
Was the swayed head of Sooaltim. The head  
Of Sooaltim cried out the self-same words:  
"In Ulster men are slain, O men of Ulster!  
Women are carried captive! Kine are driven!"

Then Conor heard the cry of the dead head  
Of Sooaltim. He rose and spake, yet spake  
As one who still was dreaming: he was dulled  
By his confusion in his Kesh and sleep.

"That cry of lamentation is a little  
Too mournful and too great," he said, "because  
The heaven is above us and the earth  
Is underneath us, and the blue-rimmed sea  
Is round us in a circuit. And unless  
The firmament with all its showers of stars  
Shall fall upon the firm face of the earth—  
Unless the many-furrowed, blue-rimmed sea  
Shall veil the thick-haired forehead of the world—  
Unless the earth shall break and yawn beneath us—  
I will bring back each of those captured women  
To her own place and her own Ulster dwelling,  
I will bring back each of those driven kine  
To her own stead and her own field for grazing,  
By victory of battle and of conflict,  
Of combat and of contest and of war."

And it was then that Conor saw his son,  
Finn-ha Faerbend. (And he was called "Faerbend,"  
"The Man of Horns," because he used to wear  
Horns of bright silver on his head.) And Conor  
Bade him go forth to muster and to gather  
The men of Ulster; and he named to him  
The men whom he should summon; and he named  
In equal way the living and the dead:  
He yet was one part dream-blind, and was dulled  
By his confusion in his Kesh and sleep.

He said: “O Finn-ha, go from me. Go forth  
To Conall Carna son of Avver-guin  
At Meedlougher; to Mend son of Sal-colgan  
Beside the white-bright Boyne; to the three sons  
Of Feeacna who own the Donn of Cooley,  
Namely, to Dawra, Ross, and Im-ha, south  
In Cooley; to great Connud son of Morna,  
Beside the Callan; to wise Avver-guin  
The poet, by the Bush in the far north.  
To Laery the Victorious son of Connud,  
By his own loch at Immil; to wise Finguin  
The leech of Finngower; to Cooscree Mend,  
The son of Conor, in green Innish Cooscree;  
To Foorbee Faerbenn son of Conor, at Seel  
On green Moy Innish; to renowned Cucullin  
The son of Sooaltim, on Moy Mweerhevna;  
To Owen son of Door-ha King of Farney;  
To Blai the brewy, in the Ards of Ulster;  
To Avver-guin of white-foamed Assaroe;  
To huge, thick-necked Munnrower son of Guerkind,  
From out of Mourne; to Kehern son of Finntan,  
At Carrloig; to great-spirited Folloon,  
Conor’s young son, who heads the lads in Avvin;  
To Illann son of Fergus son of Roy,  
In Gower; to strong Broo-aher, in Slawnga;  
To Shenca, the sweet-worded one of Ulster,  
In his own house; to Muridah and Cotreb  
And Shennel Ooaha; to the great queen,  
Namely, Findmore the warrior-wife of Keltar,  
In strong Dunseverick by the northern sea;  
To Rōhee, in bright Reedonn; to great Keltar  
The son of Oo-hider, in Doon Le-Glass;  
To Aerrga Ecbael, in his own Bree Aerrga.”

These are a few of those great kings and princes  
And hero-chiefs whom Conor named that day.  
But many more he named. Not difficult  
Indeed to Finn-ha was that mustering,

That congregating and that war-assembling,  
Which Conor gave to him to make. For those  
Who then were west or north or east of Avvin  
Came, without pause, unto the Green of Avvin,  
Under obedience to their ruling kings,  
And at the words of their own chiefs and princes,  
To serve this rising and this war of Conor.  
But those who then were south of smooth-bright Avvin,  
Went without pause along the track and road  
Of the great hosts of the Four Fifths of Erin.

The first day's travel which the men of Ulster  
Made around Conor brought them ere night fell  
To high Ardcullin. "Wherefore halt we here,  
O men?" said Conor. "We halt here," said they,  
"Awaiting thy two sons, Feeaha, namely,  
And Feeacna, who went from us to Tara,  
To fetch therefrom thy little grandson Erc,  
The son of Fedilmid, the Blooming One,  
Thy daughter. For, although he be the son  
Of Carpry Neea Faer, of Al-yill's brother,  
Who sides with Maev upon this war and hosting,  
They ask him now to come, with the full strength  
Which he can muster forth on this occasion,  
To help his mother's father." Conor said:  
"I will no longer halt upon Ardcullin;  
Because the men of Erin have not heard  
That I have risen from that darkening pain  
And Kesh wherein we were; they have not heard  
That I am yet alive after that pain."  
And it was then that Conor son of Fahtna  
And Keltar son of Oo-hider went forward  
With three times fifty well-armed chariot-heroes,  
Till they reached Ath Neermeeda. Nigh that ford  
They saw eight twenties of huge, powerful men  
Of the especial folk of Maev and Al-yill;  
And with them were eight twenties of the women  
Of Ulster in hard bondage and oppression.

This was their share of the rich spoil of Ulster:—  
A woman in the hand of every man.  
Conor and Keltar took from those huge men  
Their eight times twenty heads; and they delivered  
Those women from their bondage and oppression.  
After that time, that ford was called Ath Fayna,  
“Ford of the Warriors,” because thus the warriors  
Of east and west encountered there that day.  
Conor and Keltar turned again and stayed  
On high Ardcullin nigh their hosts that night.

That night on high Ardcullin 'midst his sleep  
Keltar the son of Oo-hider was troubled  
And stirred by visions, and he sang these words:  
“Gather yourselves, ye warriors and ye heroes!  
A mighty battle will be fought by you.  
The heavy-sodded earth will shake with you.  
Thick showers of spears will be hurled forth by you.  
Deep, vengeful wounds shall be thick-dealt by you.  
Ye shall inflict horror and fear and dread.  
Ye shall inflict pale death and lasting shame.  
Gather yourselves, ye warriors and ye heroes!  
A very mighty battle will be fought  
Upon the fields of Gawrig and Ilgawrig  
At morn upon a day which now is near us.”

That night on Slane of Meath amidst his sleep  
Cormac Conlingish son of Conor son  
Of Fahtna Fahee was perturbed and troubled  
And stirred by visions; and he sang the words:  
“Wondrous the morn! Wondrous the time of meeting!  
Hosts will be mixed. Hosts will be turned in flight.  
Throats will be broken, sand and earth be reddened.  
The kings of Ulster will arise round Conor.  
They will contend for their own Ulster women.  
They will contend for their own driven herds,  
Upon the fields of Gawrig and Ilgawrig,

At morn upon a day which now is near us.”

That night on Slane of Meath amidst his sleep  
Rough Duffa Dael from Ulster lands was troubled  
And stirred by visions; and he sang the words:

“Great are the hosts—the hosts on high Ardcullin.  
Great is the morn—the morn on wide, fair Meath.  
Great are the hosts of steeds—the hosts of steeds  
Which shall be seen on the long road of Assal.  
Great is the fight—the fight not far from Clahra.  
Great is the battle-storm—the battle-storm  
Of men of Ulster round their king, round Conor.  
They will contend for their own Ulster women.  
They will contend for their own driven herds,  
Upon the fields of Gawrig and Ilgawrig,  
At morn upon a day which now is near us.”

And this indeed is truth, and not a lie:  
To men of Ulster and to men of Erin  
This night was not the calmest and the gentlest  
Which they had ever known upon a hosting,  
Or e’er would know in any time to come—  
Because of all the songs and prophecies  
Which they thus uttered in their time of sleeping,  
And all the spectres and the loathly shapes,  
And all the apparitions and the visions  
Which in the darkness and the doleful gloom  
Appeared to them amidst their sleep that night.

## BOOK XIV

### BOOK XIV

At time of the delightfulness and beauty  
Of the red light of morning, Al-yill rose  
From out his royal tent on Slane of Meath,  
And said: "From Sowin until spring-tide now  
We have been devastating, wasting, burning  
All Ulster and all Crithny. We have taken  
From the rich folk of Ulster and of Crithny  
Their wives and sons and tender little ones,  
Their steeds and flocks of mares, their herds of kine,  
Their herds of every sort of grazing kine;  
And we have levelled down their turfy knolls,  
Till all their glens and trenches are filled up  
After our track. Therefore, this being so,  
I will no longer tarry on this plain;  
But let them give me battle on Moy Wee  
If so they will. And still, whate'er we say,  
Let some one go from us to view yon plain,  
The great wide plain of Meath, that we may know  
Whether as yet the men of Ulster come  
Upon that plain; and if indeed they come,  
We will not flee unto our rath, it being  
Unkingly so to flee before a foe."  
"Who shall go forth to view the plain?" asked each.  
"Who but Mac Roth, who is chief-messenger  
Of Erin all," said Al-yill; "he stands here."

Mac Roth went forth to view and to survey  
The clear, wide plain of Meath. Anon he heard,  
Floating from far away, a muffled roar,  
A crackling, thunderous murmur, and deep din  
Of many mingled sounds. It seemed to him



To mean no trifling thing—rather it seemed  
That the secure and solid firmament  
Descended on the firm face of the earth,  
Or that the boundless and blue-breasted sea  
O'erflowed the thick-haired forehead of the world,  
Or that the earth itself trembled and moved  
In some tremendous earthquake; or, at least,  
That the primeval and huge forest trees  
Fell, each upon the other, caught and grasped  
Each by the other's forked and branching boughs.  
One thing was certain: the wild forest-beasts  
Were from the distant forest fleeing forth,  
So that the heath and grass of the wide plain  
Might not be seen beneath them. And Mac Roth  
Went to relate his tidings at the place  
Where Maev and Al-yill were, and Fergus was  
With all the chiefs. And there he told his tale.

“What may that mean, O Fergus?” questioned Maev.  
“Not difficult,” said Fergus. “The dim roar,  
And crackling, thunderous murmur which he heard  
Mean that the northern warriors have awaked  
From their long Kesh, and now with sword and axe  
Attack the ancient forest, hewing there  
A road before their chariots; and all beasts  
Who in the forest dwell flee forth in fright,  
So that the heath and grass of the wide plain  
May not be seen beneath them.”

Once again

Mac Roth went forth to view the plain. He saw,  
Hovering far away 'twixt earth and sky,  
A long, grey mist. It seemed to him he saw,  
Rising from out the hollows and the dells  
Of the dim mist, clear eminences, firm,  
And like dark isles in silver-hollow lakes.  
He thought that he discerned in the forefront  
Of the same mist, deep, groaning caves and dens;  
And, at their openings, fair, white linen cloths

Blown by the wind; or a white fairy snow  
Soft drifting by. And then he seemed to see,  
Fluttering through the mist, a scattered flock  
Of various birds, all strange and wonderful;  
And seemed again to see that the same mist  
Was spangled all along, as with bright sparks  
Of newly-kindled fire, or as with stars,  
Clear-shining on a bright, still night of frost.  
And while he gazed he heard a growing roar  
Of mingled booming, crying, thundering,  
With shrill, sharp snaps and thuds, ringings and cheers,  
All floating towards him on the eastern wind.  
And he returned and came unto the place  
Where Maev and Al-yill were, and Fergus was,  
With all the chiefs: and there he told his tale.

“What may that mean, O Fergus?” Al-yill asked.  
“Not difficult,” said Fergus; “that grey mist,  
Which rose between the heaven and the earth,  
Was the white, cloudy breath of steeds and men,  
Fiercely expelled, and mingled with the sand  
And whirling dust and soilure of the plain.  
Those little darkling heights and crests he saw,  
Peeping from out the hollows of the mist—  
They were the heads of kings and mighty men,  
High-towering o’er their chariots. And the dens  
And deep engulfing caverns he discerned—  
They were the mouths and nostrils of the steeds  
And mighty men, opened, distended wide,  
Strongly respiring the free air and wind.  
And what unto Mac Roth seemed fairy snow  
Or linen-web was the white foam and froth  
Flung from the bridle-bits of fiery steeds,  
Urging their course with strength and vehemence.  
Again, what to Mac Roth seemed flocks of birds,  
All varied, numerous, strange, and wonderful,  
Were the quick turves and sods shot from the hooves  
Of the same fiery steeds as on they come.

And all the mingled uproar that he heard  
Was the loud shield-cry of the mighty shields,  
The hissing of the spears, ringing of swords,  
Clangour of helmets, friction manifold  
Of high-suspended weapons, and, besides,  
Creaking of cords and ropes, grinding of wheels,  
Tramping of steeds, and, through and over all,  
The ceaseless tread of battle-warriors there,  
Swift marching towards us o'er the plain of Meath.  
Lastly, the brilliant spanglings which he saw,  
Like stars of night, or sparks from ruddy fire—  
Those were the terrible and flaming eyes  
Of heroes and of warriors gleaming bright  
Beneath their shapely helmets. Angrily  
They shine and glow. And this I say to you,  
There ne'er have been, and ne'er will be again,  
Men like to those Ultonian men for fury  
And battle-anger and the rage of war."

"We care but little for all this," said Maev;  
"With us there are good youths and fighting-men  
Who will know how to greet them."

"Think not so,"

Said Fergus; "this is truth and not a lie—  
That not in Erin, not in all the world,  
From Greece and Scythia to the Isles of Orc  
And Isles of Gat, and south to Bregan's Tower,  
May ye find hosts to quell Ultonian hosts,  
Whose rage and anger have been once aroused."

That day the men of Erin left their camp  
In Slane of Meath; and, moving towards the west,  
Encamped at night in Clahra. When the sun  
Rose the next morn and shined with glowing face  
Above the fair-banked edges of the world—  
"Good now, O men of Erin!" Al-yill said;  
"Let some one go from us to view the plain—  
The great wide plain of Meath; and let him see

Whether the men of Ulster yet have come  
To Slane of Meath where we were yesterday;  
And let him bring to us a true account  
Of all their arms and war-accoutrements,  
Their kings and heroes and their well-known chiefs,  
Their breakers of great rifts in battle-ranks,  
With all their troops from all their different lands.  
To hear these all described will be to us  
A pastime and will while away the morn.”  
“Who then shall go?” they asked. “Who but Mac Roth?”  
Said Al-yill. So Mac Roth went forth once more;  
And he took up his post in Slane of Meath,  
Over against the men of Ulster there.  
From early morning till the evening fell,  
The Ulster hosts arrived in Slane of Meath.  
So great their numbers that in all that time  
The land was ne’er left naked, but was clothed  
By moving throngs. All orderly they came;  
For every throng surrounded its own king,  
And every band its lord. Each chief and lord,  
With the full muster of his hosting, camped  
In a clear place apart. When evening fell,  
All had arrived and camped in Slane of Meath.  
Mac Roth delayed not till the night had come,  
But, when the first three powerful bands arrived,  
Returned to tell his tale. “Good now, Mac Roth,”  
Said Al-yill; “in what order do they come,  
And who came first?” “I know not,” said Mac Roth,  
“But first there came an ardent, stalwart band  
Of very noble aspect. I esteemed  
Their numbers to be thrice three thousand. All,  
Quick flinging off their raiment, dug the earth,  
And lifted sods, and raised a mighty mound  
High on the rounded summit of a hill,  
To be a seat and station for their lord.  
And he, their lord, was tall and thinly-built,  
Courteous and proud, of princeliest way and style,

Accustomed to command and to restrain,  
And awful was his kingly gleaming eye.  
His yellow bush of crispéd drooping hair;  
His trimly forking beard; his crimson fooan,  
Folding five times about him; the gold pin  
Above his breast; the layna next his skin,  
Of purest white, adorned with threads of gold,  
Were all of princely mode. He wore, besides,  
A white-bright shield, adorned with monstrous beasts  
In deep red gold. In the one hand he bore  
A golden-hilted sword, and in the other  
A wide, grey spear. This warrior took his seat  
High on the mound, and calmly waited there  
Till all the rest should come; and his own troop  
Sat down there round about him. Next there came  
Two bands of thirty hundred, both alike  
In discipline and number and array.  
The man who led the first of these had hair  
And beard like crispéd gold. His warrior's layna,  
Of good brown-red with gold embroidery,  
Descended to his knees; and over it  
He wore a greenish bratt, with silver clasp.  
Besides his shield and ivory-hilted sword  
With golden thread-work, in his hand he bore  
A shining spear secured with silver bands  
And clasps of gold; and marvellous the games  
Played by that spear held in the warrior's hand;  
For first the silver bands whirled and revolved  
Over the clasps of gold from butt to socket,  
And after that the clasps of gold revolved  
Above the bands of silver back again.  
This warrior sat upon the left-hand side  
Of the great chief who earliest reached the hill;  
And his own band sat round him. 'Sat,' I said,  
Nay, but with knee to ground and shield to chin,  
They waited to spring towards us. One thing more,  
The leader of that band—he with the spear—

Wore on his head a mĩnd of glorious gold.

The second of those two companion-bands  
Was ruled o'er by a man sedate, grey-haired,  
With wide, white brow, and shrewd and kindly eyes.  
About his chin there hung a long, grey beard,  
Forking and slender. And his fair apparel  
Was all of silvery white and darkest grey.  
For dark grey was his bratt with leafy brooch  
Of white findrinny; and of purest white  
The layna next his skin. His shield was white,  
Adorned with silver. At his shoulder's height  
I saw a bough of bronze. This warrior sat  
High on the mound in presence of the chief  
Who first arrived there; and I say to you,  
Sweeter than murmuring of crested harps  
In hands of skilful players was the sound  
Of that man's voice discoursing with the chief  
Who came first to the hill, and giving him  
Wise admonition and discreet advice."

"Who may these be, O Fergus?" Al-yill said.  
"Assuredly, I know," said Fergus; "he,  
For whom was raised a mighty mound of sods  
Where he might sit till all the rest should come,  
Was Conor son of Fahtna Fahee son  
Of Ross the Red-haired son of Rury More—  
Conor, high-king of Ulster, and the son  
Of a high-king of Erin. He who came  
And sat on Conor's left, and wore a mĩnd  
Of glorious gold, was Cooscree Mend of Maha,  
From Innish Cooscree. He is Conor's son,  
And leads into the war the youthful sons  
Of lesser Ulster kings, besides the sons  
Of kings of Erin in his fosterage.  
The wondrous spear he has, with silver bands  
And clasps of gold, is known as Cooscree's Candle.  
And this, now, is the manner of that spear—  
The bands of silver never do revolve

Around the clasps of gold but at a time  
When some great prey is nigh. I therefore think  
They now revolve in sight of some huge prey  
And near-approaching slaughter. And for him,  
The wide-browed, gentle hero who did sit  
In Conor's presence, and did speak with him,  
Who could that be but Shenca? he who owns  
The sweetest oratory and eloquence  
Of all the men of Erin; he whose words  
Of eloquence and oratory calm  
The hosts of Ulster; he who with three words  
Might calm the war and tumult of the world.  
Howbeit, I give my word that at this time  
They are no timorous counsels which he gives  
Unto his lord, but counsels to fight well,  
And do great deeds of battle and of courage.  
Yea, and I give my word," Fergus exclaimed,  
"They are deed-doing men who woke from sleep,  
Round about Conor at earliest dawn to-day!"

"I make no great account of them," said Maev;  
"With us there are good youths and fighting-men,  
Who will know how to greet them."

"Nay, not so,"

Said Fergus; "this is truth and not a lie,—  
That not in Erin, not in all the world,  
From Greece and Scythia to the Isles of Orc  
And Isles of Gat, and south to Bregan's Tower,  
May ye find hosts to quell Ultonian hosts,  
Whose rage and anger have been once aroused."

Once more Mac Roth went out from them to view  
The wide great plain of Meath. He watched each band  
Arrive in Slane of Meath. When all had come,  
Almost at meeting-point of night with day,  
He came again with tidings to the place  
Where Maev and Al-yill were, and Fergus was,  
With all the chiefs, there to relate his tale.

“There came another band unto that hill  
In Slane of Meath,” Mac Roth continued then.  
“It is no lie; with raging impetus  
They gained that hill; and heavy was the dread,  
And huge the terror they conveyed. Their cloaks  
Streamed in the air behind them. In their front  
I saw a valorous leader, whose huge head  
Was streaked with sparse, grey hairs; and in that head  
Blazed yellow, full, large eyes. A yellow bratt  
Fell round about him; and a pin of gold  
Was in that o’er his breast. A yellow layna  
Lay next his skin. A wide, long-shafted spear  
Was in that warrior’s hand. A drop of blood  
Gleamed on its edge.” “What man was that, O Fergus?”  
Al-yill demanded. “Well I know,” said Fergus.  
“Nor single challenger nor mighty host  
Escapes that hero who approaches there;  
For that is Laery the Victorious, son  
Of Connud Boy, the son of that same Illiah,  
Who of late came from Immil in the north,  
And in his old age died assailing you.”

“There came another band to that same hill,”  
Mac Roth went on. “A great thick-sided man  
Commanded it. In truth, it little wanted  
But that each brawny leg and limb of him  
Was thicker than a mean man’s trunk! No lie!  
He is indeed a man! Brown, bushy hair  
He had upon him; and beneath the hair  
A scarred, blue-crimson face, and in the face  
High-up, bright-speckled eyes. He was, moreover,  
Noble and energetic. All his men  
Were dark-skinned, dark-eyed; and their red-bronze spears  
Flamed bright. They seemed not subject unto Conor.”

“Who is that, Fergus?” Al-yill asked. “I know,  
In truth I know,” said Fergus. “He, who there  
Approaches, is as one embodied thirst



For battle. He is a great lord of arms  
Above the men of Erin in the north;  
For he is my own foster-brother, Fergus  
The son of Leddy, from his wealthy rath  
In fertile green Moy Linny of the north.”

“There came another band unto that hill,”  
Mac Roth went on. “A four-square, bull-like man  
Commanded it; and he had bulging eyes,  
Grey, and set low down in his head. His hair  
Was curled and yellow; and a scarlet shield,  
Rimmed with hard silver, made a huge, bright disk  
Behind his head and shoulders. In his hand  
He held a smooth, long spear. A grayish bratt  
Fell round him, and a copper yō secured it  
Above his mighty chest. His hooded layna,  
Being up-girded, reached but to his thighs.  
Upon his left leg was a short, straight dagger.”

“Who was that, Fergus?” Al-yill asked. “I know,”  
Said Fergus. “He is a stockade of battle  
Against the face of all of you who go there;  
For he is Connud the great son of Morna,  
From green-banked, gentle Callan in the north.”

“There came another band unto that hill,”  
Mac Roth went on, “and they were firm of tread,  
And wondrously and diversely attired.  
A beautiful, unresting hero led  
That band; and he was robed in fine blue cloth,  
Which was adorned with stooags of findrinny,  
And at the openings of the garment bore  
Rich red gold buttons of distinctive stamp  
And character. Outside he wore a bratt  
Freaked out with every privileged tint and hue.  
He had five wheels of gold, namely, his shield.  
He had a dagger-straight, hard sword. His spear,  
Ridgéd and straight, flamed redly in his hand.”

“Who might that be, O Fergus?” Al-yill asked.  
“In truth, I recognize him,” Fergus said.  
“He is the choicest of all kingly poets;  
He is a road of learning and of wisdom;  
For he is Avverguin the great, good poet,  
And son of Ecket, the old smith and brazier—  
Avverguin from the Bush in the far north.”

“There came another band unto that hill,”  
Mac Roth continued. “Two soft, tender youths  
Went in the forefront of that band. Two bratts  
Of greenish hue were round them; two cassawns  
Of whitest silver clasped these o’er their breasts;  
Two laynas of smooth, yellow silk were next  
Their bird-white skin; and two white-hilted swords  
Hung at their girdles. Two five-barbéd spears  
With silver rings were in their hands. There seemed  
But little difference in age between them.”

“Who were those two, O Fergus?” Al-yill asked.  
“I know indeed,” said Fergus. “Two of one counsel,  
Two of one teaching, two alike in valour,  
Two fires, two flames, two torches equal burning,  
Two Ulster champions always next their king.  
Those there are Feeaha and Feeacna,  
Two sons of Conor son of Fahtna son  
Of Ross the Red-haired son to Rury More.”

“Another band arrived upon that plain,”  
Mac Roth continued; “and it was commanded  
By a white-chested, very comely hero,  
Much like to Al-yill there in form and style,  
In strength and whiteness, in array and arms,  
In bounty and in valour. On his head  
He wore a mīnd of gold. His shield was rimmed  
With gold. His sword-hilt was adorned with gold.  
His towering, five-barbed spear had gold upon it.”

“Who was that hero, Fergus?” Al-yill asked.

“I know that hero,” Fergus said. “His heart  
Is hard as is a flagstone, yet it has  
The rage of fire. He drives his enemies,  
E’en as a charioteer drives two swift steeds;  
For he is Foorbee Faerbenn son of Conor,  
From Conor’s own Moy Innish in the north.”

“There came another band unto that plain,”  
Mac Roth went on. “An all-white, powerful hero  
Commanded it. His eyes and hair and beard,  
His raiment and accoutrements, were all  
Of the one whiteness. Only his great shield  
Was rimmed with yellow gold, and his long sword  
Was golden-hilted. His tall five-barbed spear,  
Held in his hand, showed high o’er all the hosts.”

“Who may that be, O Fergus?” Al-yill asked,  
“Know’st thou perchance?” “Indeed, I know,” said Fergus.  
“Belovéd in our country of the north  
Is that white hero who draws near you there;  
Belovéd is that bear of blows and combats;  
Belovéd is that mountain-bear of actions;  
That is white Faeradah, the just and famous,  
From Nemud in Slieve Fooid in the north.”

“Another band arrived upon that hill,”  
Mac Roth went on. “A big and stalwart man  
Walked in its front. Red, fiery-tinted hair  
Was on him; and huge, fiery-tinted eyes  
Blazed in his head. He wore a mottled bratt.  
His shield was green; his spear rose thin and blue;  
His troop around him was all gory-red;  
And he himself amidst them was all red,  
Bloody, and scarred with numerous hurts and wounds.”

“Who was that man, O Fergus?” Al-yill asked.  
“I know him well,” said Fergus. “He, indeed,  
Is an illustrious, kinglike beast of combat.  
He is a raging bull, blocking a pass;

He is the challenger of Inver Colpa,  
And is the fortress-gate to all north Erin;  
For he is Mend son of Salcolgan, and hails  
From the north sand-spits of the white-bright Boyne.  
'Tis to avenge the prey which you have taken  
That he now comes against you," Fergus said.

"There came another band unto that plain,"  
Mac Roth went on. "In its forefront I saw  
A corpulent, thick-throated hero,—black  
His hair, and bushy, and his face all scarred  
And crimson. Brightly sparkled his green eyes  
Within his head. His spear had guarded eyelets.  
His black shield had a rim of hard findrinny.  
His bratt was of chill grey, clasped with pale gold.  
A layna of striped silk lay next his skin.  
His sword, which was adorned with carven bone  
And twisted work of golden threads, he wore  
Upon the outside of his raiment." "Who  
Was that, O Fergus?" Al-yill asked. "I know,"  
Said Fergus. "He is as a spring-tide wave  
Drowning small gentle streams upon the shore.  
He is thick-necked Munn-rower son of Guerkind,  
From the Mourne Territory in the north."

"There came another band unto that plain,"  
Mac Roth said. "Verily they seemed to be  
In multitude, a huge and drowning flood;  
In ardour, a red flame; in strength, a cliff;  
In violence, a thunderstorm; in force,  
A winter-torrent. In their front I saw  
A raging, hideous warrior; and he  
Had great ears, a great nose, and apple-eyes,  
And rough, grey hair. He wore a striped grey bratt  
Pinned o'er his breast by a huge iron spike,  
Which reached from shoulder unto shoulder. Next  
His skin he had a rough and streaky layna.

There was on him a big brown hill—his shield.  
At one side of his back he bore a sword  
Of seven pieces of well-tempered iron.  
He carried in his hand a great, grey spear,  
With thirty sewings through its eye-holes. Truly,  
Whoe'er he was, some folk amongst the hosts  
Already at that hill fell down with fear,  
At seeing that terrific warrior come  
With his own band about him."

"Who was that,  
O Fergus?" Al-yill asked. "I know, indeed,"  
Said Fergus. "He is as an ocean-flood  
Whelming the solid land—that man who comes  
There, with his band about him. He is Keltar,  
The mighty Keltar son of Oo-hider,  
From his own doon, Le-Glass in the east-north."

"There came another band unto that hill  
In Slane of Meath," Mac Roth said. "It was bold  
And powerful, and it was rude and dreadful;  
And at its head I saw a big-mouthed man,  
The measure of his mouth being like the measure  
Of mouths of stallions. He was big of belly,  
Blind of one eye, and with a low, flat head,  
And had long arms. His hair was frizzed and brown.  
His bratt was black, with surface napped and teased,  
And was secured by a round wheel of bronze.  
He wore a layna with distinctive markings,  
And a long sword, and a thick-studded shield."

"Who was that man, O Fergus?" Al-yill asked.  
"I know," said Fergus. "He who there approaches  
Is a red-handed and a raging lion.  
He is one cruel thirst for blood and combat;  
For he is Aerrga Ecbael—Aerrga Horse-mouth,—  
From his own stead, Bree Aerrga, in the north."

"Another band arrived upon that hill,"

Mac Roth continued. "And there could not be  
A man-at-arms more beautiful than he  
Who led that band. His figure was erect  
And tall and evenly proportioned, broad  
Of shoulder, narrow-hipped, white-skinned. His face  
Was broad above and narrowed towards the chin;  
And in the face his clear, blue, brilliant eyes  
Burned like two candles. His two lips were red  
And thin. His teeth gleamed like clear pearls. His hair  
Of a rich yellow-red fell thick and free.  
This warrior was arrayed in a full bratt  
Of crimson, fastened by a yō of gold.  
His layna was of kingly srōl, embroidered  
With bright, red gold. He bore a pure, white shield,  
Whereon were tortuous beasts of gold. His sword  
Was golden-hilted; and his spear was long,  
Grey-edged, and done with rivets of findrinny."

"Who is that warrior, Fergus?" Al-yill asked.  
"I know," said Fergus, "and ye know well, too.  
That man is a half-battle to each one  
Who goes there. He himself is a battalion.  
He is your kin by marriage. He it is  
Who slept with your own daughter, Findabair;  
So that the Munster princes rose in wrath,  
And many men were slain, and she thereafter  
Died for pure shame and generous feeling towards them.  
For that is Ro-hee son of Faha-win,  
From his own doon, from Reedonn in the north."

"There came another band unto that hill,"  
Mac Roth continued. "In their style and mode  
They differed from all other bands which came.  
For some men wore red bratts and some wore blue.  
Some bratts were of pure white and some were green,  
And some were blay or yellow; all alike  
Were beautiful and streamed upon the wind.  
'Midst of that troop I saw a little lad

With ruddy, freckled face, and crimson bratt  
Fixed by a yō of gold. Of kingly srōl  
His little layna was, and it was done  
With broidery of gold. His small, white shield  
Bore figured beasts of gold, and had its rim  
And central boss of gold. A golden hilt  
His sword had; and a little, light, sharp spear  
Held in his hand, rose high above his head.”

“Who may those be?” asked Al-yill. Fergus said:  
“I cannot recognize their style or mode,  
Nor know I such a royal child in Ulster;  
But there is one thing that I think. I think  
Those are the men of kingly Tara, coming  
Round about Erc, the son of Fedilmid  
The Freshly-blooming One, great Conor’s daughter.  
Erc is the son of Carpry Neea Faer,  
High-king of Tara, brother and ally  
To Al-yill there; yet think not that that child  
Comes, as a kinsman comes, to aid or help you.  
Without his father’s leave I think he comes  
To aid his mother’s father. And,” said Fergus,  
“If I am right in my surmise, a herd  
Trampling green crops that band will be to you.  
Loudly and wrathfully those mighty bulls  
Will roar, the while they guard the tender calf  
Of their own queenly heifer, in the fight  
Of Gawrig in the morning of to-morrow.”

“There came another band unto that hill,”  
Mac Roth went on. “Controlling it, I saw  
Three purple-faced and anger-kindled men  
Of honourable rank. Each had thick hair  
Of pale blay-yellow; and their ample bratts  
Were all alike, and were secured by pins  
Of brightest gold. Bright gold embroidery  
Adorned their three neat laynas. Their three shields  
Were all alike. A golden-hilted sword  
Each wore upon his thigh; in his right hand

Each grasped a grey, wide spear.”

“Who were those, Fergus?”

Asked Al-yill. “Three good chieftains of Moy Cova,  
Three heroes of the Road of Meed-lougher,  
Three lords of Cooley, three revered old men  
Of the east quarter of Slieve Foo-id,” said Fergus.  
“They are the three famed sons of Feeacna,  
The three good guardians of the bull, whose names  
Are Dawra and Ross and Im-ha,” Fergus said.

“There came another band unto that hill  
In Slane of Meath,” Mac Roth said. “It was last  
Of all the bands; and it contained not fewer  
Than thirty hundred. They were bright, clean warriors,  
And ruddy-cheeked, with long, light-yellowish hair.  
Their countenances seemed to glow. Their eyes  
Were bright and kingly. Garments glossed and bright  
Were held by golden pins. Their blue-white spears  
Shined like pure glass, flashing in the clear air.  
Their shields were yellow, threatening dangerous blows.  
Their swords were golden-hilted. As these came,  
Clamour of grief broke from each man of them;  
Sad, moanful mourning had invaded them;  
Sorrowful there seemed each mean combatant;  
And each high, kingly chief was sorrowful.  
Their heads were bowed with sorrow and with pain.  
Bereaved seemed that bright host illustrious,  
Orphaned of him who should have governed them.”  
“Who are those, then?” said Al-yill unto Fergus.  
“Truly we know, then,” Fergus answered him.  
“Those are fierce lions, lions of a battle;  
Those are the cantred out of Moy Mweerhevna.  
And this it is which makes them bowed of head,  
And sorrowful and void of joy—their being  
Without their own young, native king amongst them,  
Without Cucullin, red of sword, commanding,  
Battle-victorious and battle-triumphing.”



“There is enough of cause for them,” said Maev,  
“However scant of joy and sorrowful,  
And grieved at heart and downcast they may be.  
There is no ill we have not done to them.  
We were despoiling, burning, reaving them  
From Sowin unto Spring-tide. We have taken  
Their wives and tender sons and little ones,  
Their steeds and flocks of mares, their troops of kine,  
Their herds of every sort of grazing kine.  
And we have not alone burned to the grass  
Their strongly-timbered houses, wide and fair;  
But their high, fortified green mounds, whereon  
Those houses were, we have so levelled down,  
That all their glens and trenches are filled up  
After our track. And their unrivalled bull,  
Their wondrous Donn of Cooley, we have taken  
Away from them, to bring with us to Croohan.”

“O Maev, thou hast therein no ground,” said Fergus,  
“For triumphing or boasting o’er those men.  
There is no ill that thou hast done to them,  
The which the leader of that able band  
Hath not avenged upon thee. For each grave,  
Each flagstone, and each high, sepulchral mound,  
Between the ford wherein Faerdeeah fell  
And the east shore of Erin, is the grave  
Or flagstone, or high, bare sepulchral mound  
Of some good hero and good combatant,  
After his slaying by the noble leader  
Of that same band we speak of. Well for those  
For whom these strive in battle! Woe for those  
Whom they contend against! They will be equal  
To half a battle for the men of Erin,  
While they contend for their own lord and king  
Upon the fields of Gawrig and Ilgawrig,  
In battle in the morning of to-morrow.”

Mac Roth went on: “I heard a grievous cry  
Somewhere to westward of the battle-hosts,

Or else to eastward; it was not amidst them.”  
“What was that cry, then?” Al-yill asked of Fergus.  
“Truly, we know that,” Fergus answered him.  
“That was Cucullin, who, after his striving  
To rise and come and take his share in battle,  
Was being forcibly laid supine down  
Upon his sick man’s sod and sod of healing,  
Underneath hazel-boughs and hooks and ropes.  
The men of Ulster will not let him come,  
Owing to his sore hurts and harms and wounds;  
Because he is not fit for fight or combat  
After his fight and combat with Faerdeeah.”

That thing was true which Fergus said to them.  
It was Cucullin, who had striven to rise,  
Being again with force laid supine down  
Upon his sick man’s sod and sod of healing,  
Underneath hazel-boughs and hooks and ropes.  
Hearing that thus he lay, bound to his bed,  
Two poison-tongued, searing she-satirists,  
Fehan and Collac, namely, now went forth  
From out the encampment of the men of Erin,  
Till they were falsely crying and bewailing  
Beside Cucullin, crying unto him  
Of Ulster routed, Conor slain, and Fergus  
Slain in return in the great field of battle.

This was the night wherein the fierce More-reega  
Daughter of Ernmas came in the doleful dark,  
Between their two wide camps, inciting them  
The one against the other. She was heard  
To call these words, there, in the dark and gloom:  
“Ravens shall pick the throats of men to-morrow.  
Strife is promoted. Blue-mouthed bives shall scream,  
Hovering o’er breasts of prostrate men of Erin.  
Welcome, Ultonians! Memorable, feastful,  
Will be the slaughter of the flesh of men  
Upon these fields of Gawrig and Ilgawrig  
In battle in the morning of to-morrow.”

## BOOK XV

### BOOK XV

So, in a high hill-nook on Fedain Collna,  
'Mid whitening bushes of wild, spiky thorn,  
Cucullin lay, held to his sick-man's bed  
By hooks and ties and crooks. Through night's dark shades  
He heard the red More-reega's calls and cries,  
The blood-cries of the bitter-throated Bive.  
Then, in the first grey whiteness of day's light,  
He called and said to his own charioteer,  
Namely, to Laeg the son of Ree-angowra:  
"O my friend Laeg," he said, "through many a noon  
Thou hast been guarding and protecting me  
In my deep sleep in gaps and ways of danger;  
And thou hast been a prince of charioteers.  
It will be shameful to thee, truly, now,  
If aught shall happen on yon field to-day,  
On one side or the other, of the which  
Thou hast for me no knowledge." "Aught," said Laeg,  
"That I may know myself, O Cucucawn,  
Shall be made known to thee. And now," said Laeg,  
"E'en in the first grey whiteness of day's light,  
Out of the camp upon the west I see  
A herd of kine stray eastward. And I see  
A band of gillies speed upon the plain  
To hinder them and turn them; and I see  
Out of the camp upon the east a band  
Of beardless gillies speed upon that plain  
To take the kine and capture them." "'Tis true,"  
Cucullin said. "That is a true beginning  
Of a great contest and a good contention.  
The herd of kine goes forth upon the plain;

The gillies from the west and from the east  
Will clash together round the herd; and soon  
The kings and battle-warriors will be roused,  
And the great day of battle will begin.”

That thing was true which thus Cucullin said.  
The little herd went forth upon the plain.  
The gillies from the east and from the west  
Clashed and encountered round the herd. “O Laeg,”  
Cucullin asked, “who is now giving battle?”  
“The young folk out of Ulster,” Laeg made answer.  
“In what way fight they there?” Cucullin asked.  
“’Tis manfully that there they fight,” said Laeg,  
“Contending for that herd.” Cucullin said:  
“Alas! that I have not my battle-strength  
To go to them and help their gillie-fray!  
Had I my strength, then clear and evident  
My breach would be before them there this hour!”

“Comfort thyself, my Cucucawn,” said Laeg.  
“This is no shame unto thy battle-honour,  
No stain unto thy valour. Thou didst well  
Before this hour; thou wilt do well hereafter.”

“Yet, O my friend, O Laeg,” Cucullin said,  
“Arouse the men of Ulster towards this battle.  
’Tis indeed time for them to rise.” Laeg went  
To arouse the men of Ulster towards that battle.  
Amidst the tents, amidst the sleeping hosts,  
He spake his rhapsody of rousing words,  
Bidding them wake and rise. “Arise,” he said,  
“Arise with speed, deed-doing kings of Maha!  
Arise with strength of valorous hero-deeds.  
In all wide Erin there was never found  
One like Cucullin son of Sooaltim,  
Who hath defended you and fought for you,

And is laid, now, low with red, bitter wounds.  
To save the captives and the kine of Cooley,  
To-day with strength of valorous deeds arise!”  
And all the men of Ulster in that camp,

Together, in obedience to their kings,  
And in obedience to their chiefs and princes,  
Roused by these words of rising served to them  
Aloud by Laeg the son of Ree-angowra,  
Rose as one man; and in this wise they rose—  
Naked, save only for their sharp-edged weapons  
Held in their hands; and every man whose tent  
Opened to eastward, westward through his tent  
Tore his way out, he deeming it too long  
To circuit round the tent. And Laeg returned.  
Cucullin said: “How rise the men of Ulster  
Now toward the battle, O my friend, O Laeg?”  
“Full manfully,” said Laeg, “for thus they rise,  
Quite bare, quite naked, save for their sharp weapons  
Held in their hands,” said Laeg, “and he whose tent  
Opens to eastward, westward through his tent  
Tears his way forth, because it seems to him  
It were too long to make the circuit round it.”

“O Laeg,” Cucullin answered, “they are men  
And kingly heroes who have risen there  
Round about Conor at dawn of day to-day!  
To say so is not overmuch!”

Howbeit,  
This was the time when Conor son of Fahtna,  
On his own mound of camping, where he was,  
Said to wise-worded Shenca: “Go, O Shenca,  
Utter thy cry of knowledge and white wisdom  
Amidst the Ultonians. Let them not fare forth  
Into this fight before the strength and omen  
Of happy fortune shall have come to us,—  
Until the radiance of the sun shall rise  
Into the cloud-built rafters of the sky,  
And fill with light each knoll and slope and hill  
And hollow vale and glen throughout wide Erin.”

And the hosts tarried at the voice of Shenca  
Speaking that cry of knowledge and white wisdom,—  
Until the radiance of the sun arose

O'er the green-sided, chosen earth, and rose  
Into the cloud-built rafters of high heaven,  
And filled with light each glen throughout that Fifth.

"Good, O my friend, O Shenca," Conor said;  
"Arouse the Ultonians for the battle. Now  
It is the time for them to rise." And Shenca  
Aroused them; and he spake these words of rising.

"Arise!" he said, "deed-doing kings of Maha!  
Generous people! let the blood-red battle  
Be fought by you. Let shields be rent in twain.  
Let streams of blood flow beneath feet of men.  
Let edgéd weapons be ground down. Let earth  
Be angrily dug up. O men! O kings!  
Let grief and sorrow fill the hearts of queens.  
Let the Bive drink her crimson, bitter drink.  
Arise! If only for your Bull of Cooley,  
Arise! With strength of hero-deeds, arise!"

And Laeg was not long watching in his place  
Ere he saw somewhat; for he saw the hosts  
Of the men of Ulster and the men of Erin  
Rise as one man. Above their heads they raised  
The brown-sharp forests of their shining spears;  
And they marched forth, each chief of them inciting  
And heartening his own battle-troop. Ere long,  
Upon the lands called Gawrig those two hosts  
Clashed into combat; and they fell to smiting,  
To hewing down, dismembering and maiming,  
To slaying and to slaughtering each the other,  
For a long while and a great space of time.

This was the hour wherein Cucullin said  
To his own charioteer, even to Laeg  
(For a bright, lustrous cloud was o'er the sun):  
"Look for us, O my friend, O Laeg, how now  
Fight the Ultonians in that battle." Laeg  
Replied: "'Tis manfully that there they fight.  
For were I now to mount my battle-chariot:  
Were Aen, the charioteer of Conall Carna,

To mount his own; and were we, side by side,  
To drive our chariots from the one battle-wing  
E'en to the other, o'er the points of weapons,—  
Not hoof or wheel or hind-shaft would touch ground,—  
Owing to the true closeness, sureness, firmness,  
Wherewith their warrior-weapons are held firm  
In hands of Ulster warriors at this hour.”

“’Tis grievous that I am not now of strength,”  
Cucullin said, “to be amidst them there!  
Were I of strength, then clear and evident  
My battle-breach would be, e'en like the breaches  
Which other warriors on that plain of battle  
Will make amidst their foemen's hosts this day!”

“Comfort thyself, O Cucucawn,” said Laeg.  
“This is no shame unto thy battle-honour,  
No stain unto thy valour. Thou didst well  
Before this hour. Thou wilt do well hereafter.”

The hosts of Ulster and the hosts of Erin  
Held still to battle-striking and to smiting,  
To hewing down, dismembering and maiming,  
To slaying and to slaughtering each the other,  
For a long while and a great space of time.

This was the hour when, with great urgency,  
The Helping Triads of the men of Erin  
Arrived to help the battle. But the share  
Which Maev, when they arrived, allowed to them,  
Was this alone, namely, to render sure  
The slaying of great Conor son of Fahtna,  
If upon him the battle should be broken;  
And, on the other part, to render sure  
The safe retreat of Al-yill and herself,  
If upon them there should be rout and flight.  
And of these Triads of the men of Erin  
There were three Abrat-rooas of Loch Ree:  
There were three Mahn-yas of the Land of Murrisc:  
There were three Lussens out of Looahar:

There were three Fintans from the Plain of Femen:  
There were three each of very many names.

Now was the hour when, with great urgency,  
Three battle-castles, three huge battle-wheels,  
Arrived from Ulster, having come to Ulster  
Over the many-billowed, white-foamed sea,  
From a land nearer to the sunrise. Each  
Of those huge battle-castles, those Bive's-folds,  
Was cased with shining shields; and each one bristled  
With black, smooth, pine-long spears and blue-grey swords;  
And each one had four doors sprinkled with gems,  
So that from far they seemed like groups of stars;  
And each was filled with men having round shields;  
And each was drawn by full-maned, high, great steeds;  
And o'er the three there flew three flocks of birds,  
Whereof one flock was red and one was white  
And one was black like ravens. And three bives,  
Red-mouthed and black, circled around those towers  
Amidst the air, and prophesied and sang;  
And this is what they sang around those towers:

“Swaths of the battle—swaths and sheaves of slain.  
Force of compelling. Terrible the deed.  
Towers of Slaughter. Ravens shall be full.  
Flood-red the ground. Men in the clay. Long swaths.  
Swaths of the battle. Swaths and sheaves of slain.”

And Maev perceived those battle-castles come.  
She, in the first grey whiteness of day's light,  
Had risen, and had ridden round her hosts  
Three times, that she might know whether each band  
Was fierce and terrible and well-arrayed  
And active and prepared for valiant deeds.  
And when the great, wide battle had begun,  
She, from her mound of watching and of battle,  
Had watched, and she had seen that neither side  
Had gained advantage o'er the other side.  
Then, when she saw those battle-castles come,  
She said within herself: “If now in Fergus



The son of Roy there was that rage and ardour  
Which was within him, when, in former days,  
He broke great battle-rifts in distant lands—  
He, notwithstanding yon strange battle-towers,  
Would break this battle on the men of Ulster,  
So that they should be driven hence to-day  
With shame; and so that Conor here should fall.”

And then it was that she addressed to Fergus  
Her rousing words; and she said these words there:

“O royal warrior of the world, O Fergus,  
There was a time, of which men oft have spoken,  
When ’midst the heroes of the western world,  
There was not any greater than thyself  
In valour and in prowess and in battle.  
Thou, by thy prowess, brokest thirty battles  
O’er chiefs in distant lands, e’en to the City  
Of Moorn encircled by its wall of fire  
In the far distant isle of ice and snow.  
Thou, when thou wast with Esorb, King of Spain,  
Didst go, with hosts and multitudes of Spain,  
To Soda, King of Africa, and tookest  
A city of the warlike folk of Carthage  
By strength of war. There was none like to thee;  
And all men spoke of thy renown and glory.  
And then, because thou didst appear to him  
Too great to be in the one Fifth with him,  
Conor the son of Fahtna Fahee drove thee  
Forth from thy place, with contumely and shame.  
Much he deceived thee and insulted thee.  
He slew the brightest Candles of the Gael  
While they were underneath thy guard and honour.  
There is no theme for jest and mockery  
In Avvin and in Ulster and in Erin,  
Save this—thy cringing to the men of Ulster  
After they so have scorned and driven thee.  
Tell me, O royal warrior of the world,  
Whither have gone that great renown and power

And strength of hero-deeds which once were thine—  
So that men now account thee not at all  
When there is need of valour and achievements  
And hero-power?”

These were Maev’s words to Fergus.

And with great joy she saw his wrath of rage  
Come to his face, until it made his face  
Red like pure, crimson flame. “Truly,” said Fergus,  
“By all the gods by whom my people swear  
I swear that if I had my sword to-day,  
Skull-rooves of men should fly from cheeks of men;  
Middles of men should break from thighs of men;  
Fore-arms of men should part from arms of men;  
And throats of men should fall with throats of men;  
And fists of men should fall with fists of men;  
And heads of men should fall with ears of shields;  
Until they should be even as great in number  
As hailstones on a plain ’twixt two dry greens,  
Round which a high-king’s kingly steeds might race  
On a fresh morn in spring. To east and west,  
Through me, with heads and limbs of the Ultonians,  
If I obtain my sword!”

This was the time

When Al-yill said unto his charioteer,  
Namely, unto Faer-loga: “Let that sword  
Which destroys skin come to me now, O gillie;  
And I aver that if ’tis worse with thee  
To-day in bloom and tendance than it was  
Upon that day on which thou tookest it  
In Cooley,—then, although the hosts of Erin  
And Alba should attempt to save thee from me,  
They should not save thee.” And Faer-loga went,  
And brought with him the sword beneath its glory  
Of gentle tendance, and beneath its flaming  
Of flame-like radiance. And the sword was given  
Into the hand of Al-yill, and by Al-yill  
Was straightway placed into the hand of Fergus.

And Fergus made great joy before his sword.  
“My love to thee!” he said, “O Caladcolg!  
O sword of Leddy!—And on whom,” said Fergus,  
“Shall it now play?” “On the great hosts,” said Maev,  
“Around thee on the field on every side.  
And let not anyone obtain from thee  
Forgiveness or protection there to-day,  
Unless he be some true friend who obtains it.”

Fergus then took his weapons, and he went  
Forth to the battle; and the first great deed  
Which he performed there was to clear a gap  
Of a hundred with that sword, the Caladcolg,  
In his two hands. And Al-yill took his weapons;  
Maev took her weapons; and they each fared forth  
Into the battle, into that great battle  
Upon the fields of Gawrig and Ilgawrig—  
Into the last great battle of the Táin.

And Fergus played upon the Ulster hosts  
The singing of his sword, so that the battle  
Was three times routed toward the north before him;  
Until those battle-castles from a land  
Nigh to the sunrise, with their dreadful Coo-al  
Of spears and swords, wheeled toward the men of Erin,  
And three times forced and drove them backward.

Now,

Conor the son of Fahtna heard that thing  
In his own place of battle where he was,  
Namely, that thus the battle had been routed  
Against him three times toward the north. ’Twas then  
That Conor said to his own warrior-household,  
The inward heart of the Creev Roe in Avvin:  
“Keep ye this place a little, O ye men,”  
He said to them, “this place in which I am,  
That I myself may go to learn by whom  
The battle has been three times driven and routed  
So, toward the north, against us.” And ’twas then  
That his own household answered him with fervour

And dearness. “We will keep this place,” they said.  
“The heaven is above us and the earth  
Is underneath us and the blue-rimmed sea  
Is round us in a circuit. And unless  
The firmament with all its showers of stars  
Shall fall upon the firm face of the earth,—  
Unless the many-furrowed, blue-rimmed sea  
Shall veil the thick-haired forehead of the world,—  
Unless the earth shall break and yawn beneath us,—  
We will not yield a thumb’s breadth in retreat  
Backward, till thou shalt come to us again,  
Or till we shall be slain.” Then Conor went  
Forth to that place, where, as he had been told,  
The battle had been three times driven and routed  
Against him toward the north. And it was there—  
Even amid the hard-fought, crowded battle—  
That a shield struck a shield. The shield of Fergus  
Struck the *Ō-hawn’*, the many-victoried,  
Great shield of Conor, which had four peaked ears  
Of gold, and four ridged borders of red gold.  
And Fergus struck his three Bive’s slaughter-blows  
Against the shield of Conor; and thereat  
The great *Ō-hawn’*, the shield on Conor, moaned;  
And when it moaned, the three surge-waves of Erin,  
The Wave of Rury and the Wave of Cleena  
And the far northern Wave of Thoo-ig Inver,  
Moaned through the air athwart the lands of Erin  
In answer to the shield. And all the shields  
Amidst the men of Ulster in that hour,  
Upon their shoulders or within their chariots,  
Moaned through the air across the plain of battle  
In answer to the shield of Conor. Yet,  
However great the valour and the power  
Wherewith that warrior, Fergus, struck the shield  
On Conor,—yet so great the battle-strength  
And hero-power were wherewith the King  
Maintained the shield against him—that the ear

Of the Ō-hawn' ne'er touched the king's own ear.  
"Alas! O men," said Fergus, "who is he  
That can thus hold his shield against me here,  
On this my day of vengeance and of battle—  
Here where the Five Great Fifths of Erin meet  
Upon the fields of Gawrig and Ilgawrig—  
Here in the last great battle of the Táin?"

"Leave thou this place, O Fergus," Conor said.  
"He who is here is younger and more perfect  
Than thou art; and his mother and his father  
Were better born than thine. He who is here  
Is he who drove thee from thy patrimony  
And from thy land and thine inheritance.  
It is the man who put thee in the dwelling  
Of hares and foxes and wild, forest deer.  
It is the man who left thee not so much  
As thine own stride of all thy fields and lands.  
It is the man who put thee to be kept  
And to be paid and ordered by a woman.  
It is the man who violated thee  
Concerning the three Candles of the Gael,  
Slaying beneath thy very word and safeguard  
Those three unfaithful, valorous sons of Usna,  
Who had deprived him of his dearest jewel.  
It is the man who will now beat thee back  
In presence of these mighty hosts and throngs—  
Conor the son of Fahtna Fahee son  
Of Ross the Red-haired son of Rury More—  
High-king of Ulster and distinguished son  
Of a High-king of all the realms of Erin."

And Fergus heard these words which Conor said.  
Then 'midst his wrath of rage and battle-anger  
And strength of ire, he held in memory  
Those words he once had said in Avvin Maha,  
Namely, that e'en if Conor should betray him,  
And violate his honour and his safeguard  
(A thing which he was sure would ne'er be done),

He would not seek the king's own blood or flesh;  
Though there was not another man in Ulster  
Who should insult his honour and his safeguard  
And from his hands should not obtain red death.  
This was the promise which he once had given.  
Yet this, indeed, is truth and not a lie,  
Namely, that e'en had he ne'er given that promise,  
It would have seemed an evil thing to Fergus  
To seek to slay that king whom he had loved  
In happy days in smooth-bright Avvin Maha—To  
slay the High-king of his own dear land,  
The land of Ulster. Then he turned his anger  
Away from Conor; and he turned his anger  
Against the Ulster hosts on every side  
Throughout the battle. He hurled back his sword,  
The Caladcolg, till its point touched the ground  
Behind him, that he so might strike with it  
Its three enchanted blows of doom and judgment  
Upon the Ulster hosts on every side,  
That so the dead amidst those hosts of Ulster  
Might number more e'en than their quick should number;  
(Because that sword from out the Shee was thus:  
When a true warrior's hands would strike with it  
Its three enchanted blows of doom and judgment,  
It would put on the curve and length and sheen  
Of a rainbow in the air).

That now was seen

By Conor's exiled son, Cormac Conlingish,  
The head of the Black Exile; and he made  
A rush as of the quick spring-wind, approaching  
Fergus; and he closed his forearms round him.  
"Unfriendly, and not friendly, were that deed!  
Un-native, and not native, were that deed!  
Of out-lands, not of Ulster, were that deed!  
My master, Fergus!" Cormac said to him;  
"And, O my tutor and my master, Fergus,  
Let not the men of Ulster now be slain

By thy three blows of doom. Rather, O Fergus,  
Think of the honour of thy native land,  
Think of the honour of the men of Ulster,  
E'en in thy day of vengeance and of battle."  
"Leave me! Away from me! O son," said Fergus;  
"Because I shall not live unless I strike  
My three enchanted blows of doom and judgment  
Upon the hosts of Ulster here to-day,  
So that the dead amidst the hosts of Ulster  
May number more e'en than their quick shall number."  
"Bend thy hand sideways, O my master, Fergus,"  
Cormac Conlingish said, "and cut the hills  
Which are beside this field and plain of battle;  
And it will ease thy warrior-wrath of rage."  
Fergus delayed a moment; then he said:  
"Let Conor son of Fahtna then return  
To his own place of battle where he was."  
And Cormac said to Conor: "Go, my father,  
To thine own place of battle where thou wast;  
Because this man will not put forth his wrath  
Now on the men of Ulster in this place."  
And Conor turned and went to his own place,  
Where he had been. And Fergus bent his hand  
Sideways; and o'er the heads of the great hosts  
With the curved sword from out the Shee he struck  
His three enchanted blows of doom and judgment  
Upon the hills, which were beside the plain;  
And struck their summits from the three low hills—That  
those three Maels of Meath might be for men  
A sign of shame and of reproach to Ulster  
Even until the ending of all time.  
And it was thus that Fergus son of Roy  
And Conor son of Fahtna separated  
Upon this Táin.

And so the wrath of Fergus  
Was one part suaged; but still he made his path  
A path of reddening; and his warrior-slaughters

Were still unscanty.

On high Fedain Collna,  
Upon his sick-man's bed, while hearkening  
To the far noise and clamour of that battle,  
Cucullin heard the great Ō-hawn' of Conor  
Moan through the air, when it was struck by Fergus  
The son of Roy. "Good, O my friend, O Laeg,"  
Cucullin said. "What man has now this daring—  
The daring thus to smite the great Ō-hawn'  
Of my dear guardian, Conor King of Ulster,  
While I am yet alive?" Laeg said to him:  
"It is the best of warriors and of men  
Who smites it; he flings blood—increase of slaughter.  
It is the man, Fergus the son of Roy.  
His chariot-sword from out the Shee was hidden,  
And now is with him once again. The steeds  
Of Conor now have come unto the battle."

"Loosen these hazel-bands, O gillie, swiftly,"  
Cucullin said. "Blood shall be spent by men;  
Swords shall sing music." Then Laeg loosened them,  
Albeit unwillingly. Cucullin leapt  
Free from his bands, so that the hazel-bands  
Went to Moy Thooaga amidst of Connaught;  
And all his hooks flew to far Corcumroe,  
Amidst the barren places in the west;  
And the dry wisps and twists of moss and grass,  
Which were within his wounds, rose through the air,  
And through the firmament, even as far  
As a lark flies on a bright day in summer,  
Whereon there is no wind. His many sores,  
And many hurts and gashes and deep wounds,  
Seized him afresh thereat, so that each groove  
And furrow of the earth was filled with gore  
And with his streaming blood. None of his arms,  
None of his weapons, had been left to him  
Beside his sick man's bed. Only his chariot



He found beside him there. He took the chariot;  
And went unto the plain; and with the chariot  
He struck and felled and hewed the men of Erin,  
Until he reached the place wherein was Fergus  
The son of Roy. And then he spake to Fergus.  
“Come hitherward,” he said, “my master, Fergus!”  
But Fergus answered not, because he heard not.  
Cucullin spake and said those words again.  
“Come hitherward,” he said, “my master, Fergus!  
Or, if thou comest not, I then will grind thee  
E’en as a millstone grinds fresh barley-malt.  
Yea, I will cleave thee as a wood-axe cleaves  
An oak of the forest: I will bind thee hard,  
E’en as the woodbine binds great forest-trees:  
I will attack thee as the hawk attacks  
Small, helpless fledgelings: I will cast thee down  
As fishes are cast down upon the sand:  
Unless thou comest hitherward, O Fergus!”

“Is it to me that these Bive’s words are spoken?”  
Said Fergus; “and who dares to speak these words  
On this my day of vengeance and of battle,  
Here where the Five Great Fifths of Erin meet  
Upon the fields of Gawrig and Ilgawrig—  
Here in this last great battle of the Táin?”

Cucullin said: “It is thy foster-son,  
The son of Dectora, of Conor’s sister—  
The son who is beloved by all in Ulster,  
And who hath fought for all and fended all.  
And thou didst promise, O my guardian, Fergus,  
At thine own turn of combat on this Táin,  
That when thou shouldst behold me bleeding, faint,  
And filled with hurts and filled with dangerous wounds,  
In this last battle of the Táin, thou truly  
Wouldst flee before me on this day of battle;  
For I myself fled before thee, O Fergus,  
Then, at thy turn of combat on the Táin.”

And Fergus looked and saw his foster-son,

The Hound of Ulster, covered with rough gore,  
Bleeding and pierced and filled with dangerous wounds;  
And he remembered all that he had said  
Beside that ford on grass-green Moy Mweerhevna  
At his own turn of combat on the Táin.

And then it was, indeed, that Fergus fled.  
With his own war-troop—with the Ulster Exiles,  
Who had departed with him out of Ulster  
Full seven years before—he left the battle.  
Toward Connaught, toward the Shannon, toward the west,  
He strode his three all-powerful hero-strides;  
And he broke forth, over the western hill,  
Out of the battle. And the seven kings  
From Munster, which had come upon that hosting,  
When they perceived that Fergus left the battle,  
Broke likewise forth, over the western hill,  
Leaving the battle; and with each of them  
Was his own cantred. And the hosts of Connaught  
Were left alone, maintaining the great battle  
Against the Ulster hosts before them there.  
Those who were left maintaining it were these:—  
Maev with her cantred: Al-yill with his cantred:  
The seven Mahn-yas and the Sons of Mahga,  
Each with his cantred. In that hour of day  
When Fergus and the seven kings from Munster  
Abandoned Maev, leaving their share of battle,  
And this was told to her, there came, as 'twere,  
Before her eyes a dizzy, dim, blind mist,  
Blinding her eyes and eye-sight, so that men  
And trees appeared the same to her. Howbeit,  
From midday till day's waning she maintained  
The battle strongly. It was at midday  
That first Cucullin came into the battle  
From Fedain Collna. When the golden sun  
Sank 'mid the tresses of the western woods,  
The last of all the battle-troops of Connaught  
Was driven and routed o'er the western hill,

Out toward the west. And of his battle-chariot  
There remained then, grasped in Cucullin's hands,  
Only a handful of the curving ribs  
Pertaining to the body, and a handful  
Of spokes from the two wheels; for with his chariot  
He had been slaying, hewing, and destroying  
The men of Erin throughout all that time.

This was the hour when Maev took up her shield,  
And put her shield of guarding and protection  
Behind the hosts guarding their sad retreat.

This was the hour when she sent off the bull,  
The Donn of Cooley, swiftly to Rath Croohan  
By a long circuit, having fifty heifers  
And eight of her own messengers around him,—  
So that, at ending of that Táin and hosting,  
Whoever might arrive or not arrive  
In safety at Rath Croohan on Moy Wee,  
The Donn of mountainous Cooley should arrive,  
Even as she had promised and had sworn.

Then Maev herself came soon unto the place  
Where Fergus was, nigh the great river-ford.  
And on that queen at falling of that hour  
There was great weakness, faintness, weariness,  
After the long, hard, ever-toilsome battle;  
And there was anguish, bitterness, dejection,  
After that great abandonment by Fergus,  
And all that hard defeat and overthrow.  
She said to Fergus then: "O Fergus, put  
Thy shield of guarding and of sure protection  
Across their track, guarding the men of Erin,  
That I may rest a little." Fergus said:  
"'Tis an ill hour to rest in." "Yet," said Maev,  
"I shall not live unless I rest a little."  
Then Fergus put his shield of sure protection  
Across their track, guarding the men of Erin;  
And so Maev rested. E'en as she was resting  
'Mid some young trees, Cucullin came on her.

He slew her not. He deemed it were unworthy,  
Dishonourable, so to slay her. Then  
Maev lifted up her eyes and saw Cucullin  
Before her there. She said: "To-day, Cucullin,  
I ask a boon of thee." "What boon?" he said.

"Take thou these hosts," said Maev, "beneath thy honour  
And sure protection, that they so may reach  
Across the ford to westward." Of all men  
Of Erin who were living in his time,  
Cucullin was the best for giving gifts  
And generous bestowing; and thereafter,  
In after time, there would be only two  
Who should be equal to him, namely these—  
Neev Columkillé of the race of Niall,  
And Goory son of Colman in the west.  
And, because thus he was the best in Erin  
For giving gifts, he said to Maev: "O Maev,  
I give that boon thou askest." Then Maev rose  
(Though that was hard for her); Cucullin went  
Around the men of Erin, and he put  
His shield of guarding and of sure protection  
Across one side, guarding the men of Erin.  
The Helping Triads of the men of Erin  
Came to the other side; and Maev herself  
Returned to her own place and firmly put  
Her shield of guarding and of sure protection  
Behind their central troops; and, in that way,  
They which were left of all those hosts of Erin  
Passed the great ford and came once more to Connaught.

Before he left the Connaught river-shore,  
His famous sword was brought unto Cucullin,  
His wonder-sword, the wondrous Croo'-adeen;  
And in the dusk above the darkening ford  
It beamed like a king's candle (and in days  
To come that sword should come to Art's son Cormac,  
Greatest of monarchs of all Erin). Then,  
With that straight sword, the wondrous Croo'-adeen,

Cucullin struck its three straight wonder-blows;  
And struck their summits from the three low hills  
Beside the ford, that those three Maels of Connaught  
Beside the Connaught river-shore, for men,  
Might answer the three Maels of Meath.

And Fergus

Was watching all those hosts pass from the ford  
Westward toward Croohan and Moy Wee of Connaught;  
And through his heart there was great bitterness.  
He knew that now old age would come on him  
Without his doing hero-deeds, or winning  
Great battles like the battles he had won.  
For he—thus severed from his native land  
And from the folk and heroes whom he loved  
Fervently, passionately, zealously—  
Was (like a spear-head parted from its shaft)  
Deedless, of no avail. And he was sure  
That he would die in exile and be buried  
In exile, in a strange land not his own.  
'Twas then he turned to Maev, "Truly," said he  
(And he spake roughly, darkly, bitterly),  
"Truly," he said, "the outcome of this day  
Is fit and natural for all these hosts,  
Which have been led and marshalled by a woman.  
To-day these hosts have been deprived and robbed.  
And, e'en as when a mare precedes her foals  
Into a land unknown, without a head  
Of counsel and of guidance going before her,  
And her young foals are robbed and reft from her,  
So stands it with these driven hosts to-day."  
And Maev said naught to all those words of Fergus;  
For there was on her too much grief and woe  
And pain and dole and sadness, after all  
That treachery and that abandonment  
By Fergus son of Roy, whom she had welcomed,  
And had maintained and cherished royally;  
And there was anguish, grief, and hard dejection,

After that great defeat and overthrow.

Cucullin left the Shannon river-shore,  
And fared to eastward; and he reached that place  
Where Conor was, with all the chiefs of Ulster,  
Awaiting him. And faintness, weakness, trembling,  
Came on him there; because his rage and ardour  
Had gone from him, and now his many sores  
And many hurts and gashes and deep wounds  
Pained freshly. Then the gillies and the striplings  
From Avvin Maha, seeing thus their friend  
And dear companion filled with gory wounds  
And very faint, raised their great cry of woe,  
And their great outcry and their lamentation,  
Till even the stones and gravel of the earth  
Answered their grievous clamour. And men laid him  
On a fresh bed of comfort and of healing.

And Conor, the great king, came to that bed,  
And bent above him; and he spake above him  
His very earnest kingly words of pity  
And sad deploring and strong praise and love.

“O Hound,” he said, “O Battle-hound of Cooley,  
O King of Heroes of our own Creev Roe,  
For Ulster thou hast borne much grief and harm;  
And men in Ulster will remember thee,  
And all which thou hast wrought for war-like Ulster,  
Long as pure waves shall break on Ulster shores.  
Drink now, and sleep; and bide in rest and healing.”

So nigh the fields of Gawrig and Ilgawrig  
The hosts of Ulster made their camp that night.  
On Conor son of Fahtna Fahee there,  
In his own tent, in his own place of camping,  
There was depression and dark gloom that night;  
And he was heavy-hearted. For, indeed,  
Though he that day had broken that great battle  
Upon the fields of Gawrig and Ilgawrig  
Against the hosts of Connaught, ne’ertheless,

That did not change this fact, namely, that truly  
Maev scarce had left a stead in all his Fifth,  
E'en from the Boyne and fair Moy Bray to far  
Dunseverick beside the northern sea,  
Without destroying it and spoiling it  
And leaving it a burned and blackened ruin;  
And that great bull, the gold-horned Donn of Cooley,  
She had made fast and borne with her to Croohan.  
And this was true besides: to him a battle  
In which no king had fallen did not seem  
To be indeed a battle. So on Conor  
There was deep gloom and heavy woe that night.

After that time Cucullin lay at healing  
In Avvin Maha for a lengthened while;  
But when his wounds were healed, he donned once more  
His festal war-array, and travelled south  
To rich Loolohta Lōha nigh the sea,  
To take that maiden, who, 'midst other maidens,  
Was as a sun 'midst pale, faint stars. He did  
All that she had foretold that he would do  
Ere he could reach her. Then he wedded her.  
And they two—Emer daughter of Forgall Mona,  
And many-victoried Cucullin—dwelt  
In love throughout the space of twice five years;  
Wherein Cucullin wrought great deeds, until  
His foemen for the last time came against him  
And he died young in years—even as Cathbad,  
Cathbad, the lord of knowledge and wise druid,  
Speaking sad truth of knowledge, had foretold.

Before Maev let the men of Erin part  
And separate to reach their native homes,  
She gathered them around herself in Croohan,  
That they might see that combat of the bulls,  
And the contention which should finally  
Decide that contest and that strife and struggle,

Which had been fought through many lives and shapes.

When the high, gold-horned Donn of Cooley saw  
That beautiful, all unknown land, which spread  
Before him there in greenness and in beauty—  
Namely, Moy Wee of Connaught—he raised up  
His three loud-speaking, voiceful bellowings;  
And the Find-benna heard him. Now no bull  
Or male wild beast 'twixt the Four Fords of Wee—  
The Ford of Moga and the Ford of Bercna,  
The Ford of Shlissen and the Ford of Coltna—  
Was wont to raise more than a little murmur,  
Or a soft, timorous moaning, through his fear  
Of that Find-benna. And the red Find-benna,  
Hearing those speaking, voiceful bellowings,  
Raised up his head and shook his three white manes,  
Which were like snow upon a noble mountain,  
And he came vehemently on toward Croohan  
To meet the Donn of Cooley.

Of those bulls,  
Each saw the other soon. Then both, in frenzy,  
Raging, infuriated, frantic, maddened,  
Pawed up the ground and dug the earth between them,  
And flung the earth back o'er their shoulder-bones.  
And their eyes glared red-hot within their heads,  
Like fruits or berries of pure, sparkling fire:  
Their cheeks and nostrils swelled and bulged, as bulge  
A smith's huge bellows in a forge. And each  
Against the other dealt his sounding blow  
Of doom and judgment; and each one began  
To gore, to pierce, and to destroy the other.

This is the time wherein the red Find-benna  
Of bright Moy Wee caused the dark Donn of Cooley  
To swerve from his straight way and road and journey;  
And in his side he thrust a curved, white horn;  
And he was overcoming him. But Cormac  
The son of Conor saw that thing. He took  
A mighty spear-shaft which filled up his grasp;



And, with this spear-shaft, to the Donn of Cooley  
He gave three long stroke-blows from ear to tail.  
“This jewel is to us no lasting jewel,”  
Said Cormac, “for there is not force in him  
To match a calf of his own age.” That bull,  
The Donn of Cooley, heard these railing words;  
For he had man-like understanding. Then  
He turned again against the great Find-benna;  
And after that they, upon either side,  
Were piercing and destroying each the other  
For a long while and a great space of time.

And night descended on the men of Erin;  
And after darkening night had so descended,  
For all the men of Erin there was nothing  
But to be listening to the storm and roaring  
Of the great bulls throughout the land that night.  
That night the two bulls ranged through Erin all;  
So that there is not any place in Erin  
Named Clo-na-Darriv, Rath-na-Darriv, Drum-na-Darriv,  
Barna-na-Darriv, Moy-na-Darriv, Loch-na-Darriv,  
But it was named from those two bulls that night.

At very early dawn upon the morrow  
The men were not long watching nigh Rath Croohan,  
Ere they perceived the Donn of Cooley come  
From out the west; and their own great Find-benna  
Was borne in mangled fragments and dead pieces  
On his high, peaked horns. The men arose;  
And in the dusky dawn they were not sure  
Which of the bulls he was. But Fergus said:  
“O men,” he said, “if ’tis your own Find-benna,  
Whom ye discern approaching, let him be;  
And if it is the Donn of mountainous Cooley,  
Leave him his trophy; for I say to you,  
Unless ye leave it, that which has been done  
Because of these two bulls, indeed is little  
To that which shall be done to you this day.”

The Donn of Cooley came. He raised on high

His three loud, voiceful roars, vaunting his trophy.  
He turned his right toward Croohan; and he turned  
His face to go to his own far, dear land.  
He reached the margin of that Shannon-ford  
Which the great hosts had crossed. He stooped to drink,  
And there he left a loin of the Find-benna,  
Whence is "Athlone," "Ford of the Loin." He went  
Still eastward; and he came to high Ardcullin,  
And to the pillar-stone, and gazed abroad  
O'er Ulster there before him. Then he lifted  
His head with ardour, strength, and vehemence,  
And shook the fragments of the slain Find-benna  
Abroad o'er Erin; so that many places  
Are named from those divided parts and fragments  
Of the Find-benna. Then he reached Slieve Bray;  
And thence he saw against the north-east sky  
The pure-formed peaks of Cooley; and at seeing  
The peaks of his own native land and country  
There came on him a powerful mind and spirit;  
And he strove forward.

At the hour of eve  
The women and young lads and little folk  
Within the beautiful, high-mountained cantred  
Of Cooley of blossomful, sweet-watered glens,  
Were wailing for their Donn of Cooley. Then  
They saw him, where he came approaching them.  
But there was on him blindness and great ire,  
Because of his sore wounds. He, storming on,  
Stormed up amongst them; and full many there,  
Of women and young lads and little folk,  
Fell on that hill-slope of high Cooley, slain  
By their own Donn of Cooley. He lay down  
Against the hill, and his great heart broke there,  
And sent a stream of blood down all the slope;  
And thus, when all this war and Táin had ended,  
In his own land, 'midst his own hills, he died.



“CUCULLIN GUARDS THE RETREAT OF THE MEN OF ERIN.”

# THE WRITING OF THE TÁIN

## THE WRITING OF THE TÁIN

So to those saints that ancient warrior, Fergus,  
Having been called from out his low, sad grave,  
Had taught this history, this Táin Bo Cooley,  
With its beginning and its deeds and end,  
E'en as it had been acted in old days  
Before the holy Faith had come to Erin.  
And when he so had taught them all this tale,  
He went from them; and the blind mist and fog,  
Which had been round them, went; and they saw there  
Only the flag-stone in that lonely place,  
And the slow stream beside it. Then each saint  
Left with his friends his tender, faithful blessing;  
And each fared forth to his own place in Erin,  
To his own cell, or church, or field, or hill.

But agéd Shen'-cawn went with holy Kieran  
To Kieran's holy field; and, as they went,  
They crossed Moy Wee, and passed old, high Rath Croohan,  
And passed the Place of Graves, where many mounds  
Were green above high-kings and queens of Erin,  
And above many kings and queens and princes  
And noble chiefs of Connaught. There were buried  
Al-yill and Maev—within their deep, green mound,  
Enclosed from Gael and stranger. There were buried  
In turfy mounds the seven sons of Mahga,  
Brethren of Al-yill's mother. There were buried  
The seven Mahn-yas, sons of Maev and Al-yill,  
In one mound, side by side. And there was buried  
Dawthy, the last renowned high-king who reigned  
Ere the Faith came to Erin: he, at warfare  
In far-off Latin lands, had burned the home

Of a most holy hermit, and had died,  
Slain by God's lightning on the Alps; whereon  
Awley, his son, had brought him o'er far seas,  
For burial in Rath Croohan.

But those two,  
Shen'-cawn and Kieran, left that heathen field,  
And fared south-eastward; and at eve they came  
To Kieran's Green, to holy Clonmacnoise,  
To Clonmacnoise upon a flowery slope  
Amid a rushy by the pure, bright Shannon,  
Where all was blest and still. And in that place  
In after-time a sacred School and City  
Should rise—Neev Kieran's City—and should grow  
Like a tall tree, whence rule and truth and wisdom  
Should spread through half the land. And in that place,  
Even in dew-bright, red-rosed Clonmacnoise,  
Under rich, carven flags there should be buried  
In after-time great kings and lords and chiefs,  
And many prayerful abbots and wise bishops,  
And many poets, who in after-days  
Should die in faith. Yea, and Neev Columkillé  
Said that, because of God's great love for Kieran—  
Sweet helper of the oft-times erring Gael—  
It was at Clonmacnoise that the white souls  
Of Erin should be gathered and assemble  
Around Neev Patrick, when the Judgment-horn  
Should blow from high Croagh Patrick o'er the lands  
And hills and vales and sacred greens of Erin.

But at that time, when agéd Shen'-cawn came  
To that blest place, there were but nine small cells  
Of wattled boughs, and one small oaken church;  
And in that place there was not yet one grave.

Then, when they so had reached that fair, blest place,  
Neev Kieran took the wonder-working hide  
Of his dun cow, who had fared forth with him,  
Taking her calf, when he himself had fared—  
He being young—to high renowned Clonard,

To learn beneath Neev Findian; and that cow,  
While he was there learning pure truth and wisdom,  
Had stayed with him, and always faithfully  
Sustained him with her milk. He took that hide,  
Which he had ever cherished tenderly;  
And of that hide he made a noble book;  
And in that book he wrote the Táin Bo Cooley,  
With its beginning and its deeds and end,  
E'en as it had been acted in old days  
Before the holy Faith had reached their land;  
That this famed history, this Táin Bo Cooley,  
Which had been taught them by that warrior, Fergus,  
Who had been sent from out his lonely grave,  
Might so be known in after-days in Erin.

# **APPENDICES**

## APPENDIX A

### IRISH TERMS USED IN THE VERSE

**Aely** [*Éli*, L.U. 78<sup>a</sup>, margin]. A spell or incantation.

**An-dord'** [*Andord*, L.L. 261<sup>a</sup>31]. Apparently a kind of tenor singing. *Dord* means the bass in music. *An* here is probably a negative, not an intensive, prefix; for O'Curry (M. & C. iii. 379) says that the short strings of the harp were called *andord*, "not bass."

**Bălt'-thăănă** [*Beltene*. Mod. I. *Bealtaine*]. The first of May. This was one of the chief points of division in the year. See Corm., *Belltaine*.

**Ban'-a-nah** [*Bânanach*]. A kind of airy spirit.

**Barnbrogues** [*Bernbróic*]. Probably a long, close-fitting covering for the legs, breeches and hose combined. See Zimmer, K.S. 6, pp. 81-88.

**Bive** [*Badb*]. The raven, hooded-crow, carrion-crow, or other rapacious bird. Often used as a name for the More-reega, the goddess of war, who was wont to appear in the form of a carrion-bird.

**Boc'-a-nah** [*Bócanach*]. A kind of airy spirit.

**Boo'-an-bac** [*Buanbach*, *buanfach*]. A game, probably of the nature of chess or draughts. See Zimmer, K.S. 6, p. 78.

**Baw'-ee Brashee** [*Bái brassi*]. One of Cucullin's feats. *Brasse* means "quickness," "readiness" (see Féil. Index). But it seems impossible to determine the nature of the feat.

**Bran'-dub** [*Brandub*; Mod. Ir. *brannamh*]. Chess. Dr. Joyce (Soc. Hist. ii. 480, 1) says that nothing has been discovered to show the exact nature of this game. But in Keating's *Trí Bior-ghaoithe an Bháis* ("Three Shafts of Death"), p. 25, there is a passage in which the fate of men is compared to the fate of the troop in a game of *brandubh*. It is pointed out that just as in the game of *brandubh*, so long as the game is being played, each man has his own rank, the King being in the most honoured place on the board, and the Queen in the second place, and



so on,—similarly in the *brandubh* of life each man has his own place. And just as, when the game is over, the men of the *brandubh* are poured into the bag all mingled together without any respect to their rank,—similarly, when Death comes to men he pays no more honour to one than to another.

This passage shows that in Keating's time, at all events, *brandubh* meant "chess," not "backgammon" or "draughts."

**Bratt** [*Bratt*]. An outer covering, cloak, or mantle.

**Bressla More** [*Breslech mór*]. The great breaking or slaughter. The name *Breslech mór* seems afterwards to have been given to the spot where the slaughter took place. See L.L. 75<sup>b</sup>49.

**Brewy** [*Bríuga*]. "A lord of land," as (following Dr. Kuno Meyer) I render it in Book vii; a wealthy farmer; a hospitaller.

**Broo** [*Brúgh*]. A mansion; a fairy palace. "The Broo of Angus Ōg" was probably the great tumulus of New Grange on the Boyne. Angus Ōg was the son of the great Dagda and of Boand ("Boyne"), whose name was given to the river. See *Aislinge Oengusso*, Rev. Celt. iii. 344.

**Călăd-colg** [*Calad colg*]. The name of the sword of Fergus. Apparently from *calad*, "hard," and *colg*, "a straight sword," "a dagger." But from its being compared to a rainbow, I judge that the *Calad colg* was curved, and I have treated it so. It is sometimes called the *calad bolg*.

**The two Cann-bracks'** [*na da chend bricc*]. The two dappled-heads: Conor's two steeds.

**Cantred** [*Tricha cét*]. Following the usual custom, I render the Irish term, *tricha cét*, "thirty hundred," by the Welsh word "cantred." A *tricha cét* (defined in the Laws, vol. v, 50, 3, as "one *tuath*") was a territory containing thirty ballys or townlands. It corresponded roughly to the modern barony. When *tricha cét* is used to denote a division in an army, it seems uncertain whether it means literally 3000 men, or simply the complement of fighting men which a cantred of land was able to furnish forth.

**Cass-awn'** [*Cassán*]. A brooch or pin.

**Cathbarr** [*Cath barr*]. A helmet, a head-piece.

**Cloth-nell'** [*Cloth nell*, L.L. 261<sup>a</sup>29]. I am not sure whether I have been right in interpreting this as the name of the song. It may be merely a *cheville*, a stop-gap, such as often occur in Irish poetry. In any case, I do not understand what it means.

**Cōla** [*Coblach*, L.L. 261<sup>a</sup>30]. Apparently the voice or a mode of singing between bass (*dord*) and tenor (*andord*). O'Curry (M. & C. iii. 252, 379) says that the middle strings of the harp were called the *cobhlaighe*.

**Con'-gan-ess** [*Congan-chness*]. Horn-skin; the name of Faerdeeah's armour. It may have been a close-fitting dress of leather, sewn all over with little plates of horn.

**Coal** [*Cual*, L.L. 102<sup>a</sup>37]. The word seems to refer to the bristling mass of swords and spears with which each of these battle-castles was surrounded. See the description of them: Windisch, *Táin*, pp. 809-821. Compare L.L. 115<sup>b</sup>19, where *cual gai* seems to mean a *cheval-de-frise* of spears.

**Crann-dord'** [*Crandord*]. The musical lowing made by the Donn of Cooley. *Crann* means "a tune," "a melody." *Dord* means "a humming," also "the bass in music." O'Brien has *crann dordáin*, "a kind of music made by putting the hand to the mouth."

**Crann-towl'** [*crantaball*]. A sling-staff, or perhaps a kind of crossbow, for shooting stones.

**Creev Roe** [*Cráebrúad*]. "The Red Branch": the name of Conor's great banqueting-house at Avvin Maha.

**Croo'-a-deen** [*Cruadín*]. The name of Cucullin's sword; formed from *cruaidh*, "hard." *Cruaidh* is the modern word for "steel."

**Crooan** [*Cruan*]. Probably a kind of red enamel. Very beautiful examples of early Irish enamel-work may be seen in the collection of the R.I.A. in Dublin.

**Curragh** [*Currach*]. A coracle: a light boat made of a wooden framework, which in ancient times used to be covered with hides, and in modern times is covered with tarred canvas.

**Dael** [*Dáel*]. Some kind of black chafer or beetle.

**Dael-clish** [*Deil chliss; deil chniss*]. Of somewhat uncertain meaning. In the passage in Book xi., where it occurs (see L.L. 77<sup>b</sup>5; L.U. 79<sup>b</sup>9), the context seems to suggest that it was a dart greater and more important than the eight little darts; but it may have been some kind of bow or sling for shooting the little darts. In Book v. I have rendered the word vaguely, “dael-feat”; it may mean a sling-staff with which the ball was to be cast. *Del* or *deil* meant “a rod,” or “switch.”

**Dael-feat.** See **Dael-clish**.

**Doon** [*Dún*]. A fortress; a fortified residence.

**The Enga** [*an Engach*]. The name of Conall Carna’s ship, as given in the *Foghlaime Chonchulainn*.

**Eric** [*Eric*]. “A fine or penalty exacted from an offender, according to the assessment of established custom, or the determination of the Brehons.” Laws vi., p. 311.

**The Eura** [*An Iubrach, in Ibhrach*]. The name of the boat belonging to Fergus. It seems to be connected with *ibar* (Mod. Ir., *iubhar*), “a yew-tree.”

**Faen-feat** [*Foenchless*]. One of Cucullin’s feats. From *foen*, “supine,” “flat.” A passage in the “Destruction of Da Derga’s Hostel” shows that this feat was performed with the shield. See L.U. 97<sup>b</sup>20, 21, where Mac Cecht performs the faen-feat with his shield, and the edge-feat with his sword.

**Faer-dord**’ [*Ferdord* L.U. 78<sup>a</sup>23, 24]. *Fer* (Mod. Ir., *fear*) is “a man.” *Dord* means “a humming,” also “the bass in music.” Thus *ferdord* was probably some kind of deep bass crooning with the intent of inducing sleep.

**Feea** [*Fiach*]. A debt.

**Feehill** [*Fidchell, fithchioll*]. Often translated “chess.” But *fidchell* and *brandubh* seem to have been distinct games. In the *Agallamh* (I. T. Vierte Serie, 1 Heft. p. 196) we are told that on a certain occasion a *fidchell* was given to every six men, a *brannabh* to every five men, and so on. As *brandubh* seems certainly to have been chess, perhaps *fidchell* may have been a game like draughts. Dr. Stokes and Dr. Meyer

translate it “draughts.” At the same time, a line occurring in a poem in “The Pursuit of Diarmuid and Grainne,” *idir triath agus laoch*, “both chief and soldier,” seems to show that in *fidchell* there were pieces of more than one value. See Oss. iii. 154.

**Fertas** [*Fertas*]. A distaff; a spindle; the pole of a chariot. Hence, probably in place-names, a sandy bar across the mouth of a river. Was the modern *fersad*, which has all these meanings, formed by metathesis from *fertas*? See Windisch, *Táin*, line 5650, where *ferrsat* is used for *fertas*.

**Fin-drin'-ny** [*Findruine*]. Often translated “white bronze.” It seems to have been some kind of white alloy.

**Fooan** [*Fúan*]. This seems to have been a kind of very ample wrap or mantle.

**Fooavrōg** [*Fuathbróc*]. A covering for the lower part of the body, probably short breeches. See Zimmer, K.S. 6, pp. 81-88.

**Gae Bulg.** The name of Cucullin's famous spear. *Gae* means “a spear,” “a dart.” In the L.L. text of the *Táin* we have the forms *gai bulgga*, *gae bulgae*, *gae bulga*. Perhaps I ought to have adopted the form *gae bulga*. But in the *Foghlaimh Chonchulainn* we have *cles an gadh builg*. In the curious poem translated by O'Curry, M. & C. ii. 311, we twice have the form *Gae Bolg*. This poem says that the spear was made from the bones of a sea-monster by Bolg mac Buain a famed champion of the east, and that after passing through various other hands it came to Scawtha.

**The Gantree** [*Gentraide*]. A kind of music. From *gen* (Mod. Ir. *gean*), “laughter,” “a smile.” See L.L. 249<sup>a</sup>; also M. & C.

**Gass**, pl. **gassa** [*Geis*, pl. *gesa*. Mod. Ir. *geas*, pl. *geasa*]. A prohibition or injunction, magically imposed and involving magical penalties if disregarded. Often translated “taboo.”

**Gillie** [*Gilla*, Mod. Ir. *Giolla*]. “A lad,” “a youth,” generally “a servant-lad.”

**The Goltree** [*Goltraide*]. A kind of music; from *gol*, “the act of weeping or crying.” See L.L. 249<sup>a</sup>.

**Greeanawn** [*Gríanán*]. A sunny apartment; from *grian*, the sun.

**Guipney** [*Gipne*]. A fillet passed round the forehead.

**The Iarngool** [*Ind ierngúali*, L.U. 121<sup>b</sup>8]. “The Iron-coal,” the name of the wonderful vat or cask in the Creev Roe. It would appear to be the same as the *ól-nguala*, the mighty *dabach* or vat of brass, which Conor took as loot from the fortress of Gerg. See L.L. 258<sup>b</sup>14-19; L.L. 107<sup>b</sup>11.

**Imbas Forosnai** [*Imbas Forosnai*]. A method of divination. It is said to have been prohibited by St. Patrick. See Corm., *Imbas Forosnai*.

**Imda** [*Imda, imdae*]. A small sleeping compartment or cubicle contained within the great dwelling-house or hall. See the excellent account given by Joyce, Soc. Hist. ii. 45-54.

**Imlee of Glendomna** [*Imslige glennamnach*, L.L. 78<sup>a</sup>52; *Imsligi gleannndomnach*, Y.B.L. 43<sup>a</sup>25]. *Imslige* means “mutual slaughter.” The name seems afterwards to have been given to the spot where this slaughter took place (see L.L. 92<sup>a</sup>24); but I cannot identify it.

**Innar** [*Inar*]. This would seem to have been a kind of short, close-fitting body-coat or tunic.

**Inver** [*Inber*, Mod. Ir. *Inbhear*]. The mouth of a river.

**Kenn’caem** [*Cend-chaem*]. “Handsome head,” the name of Conor’s playing-board for feehill.

**Kesh** [*Cess*]. Suffering, torture. The *cess* (more fully, *cess noinden*) was the name of the peculiar suffering into which the Ultonian warriors were thrown as the result of the curse of Maha.

**Layna** [*léne, léine*]. A shirt or smock; a linen garment worn next the skin.

**Liss** [*Lis*, Mod. Ir. *lios*]. A dwelling or space protected by a circular mound.

**Mĩnd** [*Mind*]. A crown, a diadem.

**Neev** [*Nóeb, nóem*]. Holy. “Neev Kieran” means “Saint Kieran.”

**Nomad** [*Nomad*]. A period of nine days.

**The Nowin** [*ind Neamain*]. At L.L. 76<sup>a</sup>14 this name is glossed *in badb*, “the Bive,” and it evidently refers either to the More-reega or to a sister-goddess.

**Ogam** [*Ogum*, Mod. Ir. *ogham*]. A kind of writing, the letters of which were formed by combinations of points and short lines set at both sides of a stem or middle-line. In the Book of Ballymote, p. 308, there is an ancient treatise on ogam, with fascinating diagrams. Readers interested in the subject may consult <sup>1</sup> Brash: *The Ogam inscribed Monuments of the Gaedhil in the British Islands*. <sup>2</sup> Macalister: *Irish Epigraphy*.

**The Ō-hawn´** [*in n-ócháin*]. The name of Conor's great shield. This shield had four ears of gold. Ó means "an ear"; and Dr. Windisch (*Táin*, p. 864) thinks that this element is contained in the name.

**Ollav** [*Ollam*, Mod. Ir. *ollamh*]. A doctor of learning; a chief professor; a man in the highest rank of learned poets.

**Partar** [*Partar*]. This is the form of the word that occurs L.L. 259<sup>b</sup>36 and 40. At L.L. 55<sup>b</sup>41 we have the form *partaing*. According to Dr. Windisch (*Táin*, p. 28), it was the name of the *Purpureae Parthicae*, "the Parthian purple."

**Rath** [*Ráith*, *raith*]. A fort, usually a circular earthen fort; a dwelling or collection of dwellings enclosed by an earthen rampart.

**The Reeastartha** [*in ríastarde*]. "The Contorted," a name sometimes given to Cucullin, owing to the contortion to which he was subject when overcome by rage. A description of this contortion occurs in Book xi.

**Shee or Shee-mound** [*Síd*]. A hill or mound which was believed to be the dwelling of supernatural beings, gods or fairies.

**Shee** [*Síde*, Mod. Ir. *sídh*]. The supernatural inhabitants of a Shee-mound.

**Shessra** [*Seisrech*, L.L. 78<sup>a</sup>50]. This is evidently derived from *sesser*, six (persons), which in its genitive form occurs two lines previously. I have rendered it "the six-fold slaughter."

**Sooantree** [*Suantraide*]. A kind of music, from *suan*, "sleep." See L.L. 249<sup>a</sup>.

**Sowin** [*Samain*]. The first of November, now Hallowe'en. This was one of the chief points of division in the year. It was believed that evil spirits and also people of the Shee were specially wont to appear on that night. See the wild, weird tale of the *Adventures of Nera*, edited by Dr. Kuno Meyer, *Rev. Celt.* x. 212. There can be no doubt that many

Hallowe'en customs of the present day, both in Ireland and Scotland, have come down to us from pagan times.

**Srōl** [*sról*]. This was some kind of silken material of delicate texture. An old Connaught native speaker tells me that in her youth *sról* was the name of a kind of very beautiful tabbnet made of a mixture of silk and wool.

**Stooag** [*Stuag*]. Something arched or curved or peaked; a hook.

**Táin** [*Táin*]. A cattle-raid, a cattle-driving.

**Tal'-kend** [*Tal-cend, tail-cend*]. See Lib. Hym. i. 100. "Adze-head," a name given to St. Patrick in allusion to his tonsure. It was evidently meant to express derision. I hope I do not err in using it as a term of honour! But compare *Battle of Magh Rath*, p. 182, line 17, "*Tricha Tailgenn togaide*," on which O'Donovan remarks: "Here the word 'Tailgenn' is used to denote a distinguished saint or ecclesiastic."

**Timpan** [*Timpan*]. Derived from the Latin *Tympanum*; yet it was certainly a stringed instrument. See O'Curry's discussion of the whole subject, M. & C. vol. iii. lecture xxxii.

**Turlough** [*Taurloch*, L.L. 59, 31]. A lake which dries up in summer.

**Yō** [*Eó*]. A brooch; probably a brooch of the familiar Irish type, having a long spike or stave. *Eó* was an old word for "tree." See L.L. 200<sup>a</sup>12, *Dair dano eo Mugna*, "Now the tree of Mugna is an oak." "Spike" or "stave" was probably a derivative meaning.

## APPENDIX B

### THE PLACE-NAMES OCCURRING IN THE VERSE

[The “learned terms” in Book vii. are not included.]

**Aenloch** [*Énloch*, L.L. 245<sup>b</sup>10]. I adopt this form in L.L. which means “bird-lake,” and have supposed it to be somewhere to the north or north-west of Croohan. Elsewhere (See L.L. 31<sup>b</sup>29, and Archiv. iii, p. 5) the place of the death and burial of Fergus is called Findloch, “white-lake”; and this, probably, was the lake still called *Findloch*, about seven miles south-east of Croohan. *Énloch for Maig Ai*, “Aenloch on Moy Wee,” is mentioned Silv. Gad. i. 256, but its whereabouts is not indicated.

**Africa** [*Affraic*]. See Windisch, *Táin*, p. 819.

**Alba** [*Alba*]. Scotland.

**Alps**. See [Appendix E](#).

**Ard A'-had** [*Ardachad*]. “High-field.” There were many places so named. This “High-field” comes next after Ath Gowla in the Itinerary L.L. 56.

**Ardcullin** [*Ard Chuillend*, L.L.; *Iraird Cuillend*, L.U.]. In L.U. we are told that this place is called “*Crossa Cúil* to-day.” *Crossa Cúil* may perhaps be the village of Crossakeel in Meath, and the pillar-stone may have been on some adjoining height from which a wide view could be obtained. The boundary of ancient Ulster, which extended from the mouth of the Boyne to the point where County Leitrim touches the sea, may very well have passed through this place.

**Ard-keen'-aht** [*Árd Chiannacht*]. The whole of the present barony of Ferrard, in the County Louth, was called *Árd Cianachta*. (See B.R. p. 186, note). But in the *Táin*, *Árd Ciannacht* seems to apply to some one definite spot.

**Ards of Ulster**. In the *Mesca Uladh*, L.L. 267<sup>b</sup>3, we have the words: *Blad briuga mac Fiachna a Temair na hArda*, “Blad (= Blai) the brewy, the



son of Fiachna from Tara in the Ards.” This, I feel no doubt, was the very fine earthen fort still called Tara, which crowns a hill at the southern extremity of the Ards peninsula to the east of Strangford Lough. This *Bruiden* or “house of hospitality” of Blai the Brewy was one of the six most celebrated houses of entertainment in ancient Erin. (See L.L. 112<sup>a</sup>4).

**Armenia.** See [Appendix E](#).

**Assal.** See “Road of Assal.”

**Assa-roe’** [*Ess Rúaid*]. The falls at Ballyshannon in County Donegal.

**Ath Carpat** [*Áth Carpait*]. A ford on the Nith. See “Goola Milhy.”

**Ath Cleea** [*Áth Cliath*]. The usual Irish name for Dublin. Cf. L.L. 104<sup>a</sup>47, *Dublind rissaraiteir Ath Cliath*, “Dublin, which is called Ath Cliath.”

**Ath Faerdeeah** [*Áth Fhir diad*]. “The Ford of Faerdeeah,” now shortened to Ardee, the name of a little town on the river Dee (the ancient Nith) in County Louth. O’Donovan says: “The grave of Ferdiah is shown at Ardee, 14 yards long, 9 or 10 feet wide. About two yards of the tumulus in the middle is cut away, so as to be level with the ground. It lies ... about 80 perches west of Ardee.”

**Ath Fayna** [*Áth Féinne*]. Not an uncommon ford-name. This may be the same as the *Áth fhéne* of the *Amra Choluim Chille* (see L.U. 6<sup>a</sup>29).

**Ath Frae** [*Áth Fráich*, L.U. 63<sup>b</sup>24]. “The Ford of Frae.” Not identified, so far as I know. At L.U. 63<sup>b</sup>11 we are told that its former name was *Ath Fúait*; but it was not therefore necessarily near *Sliab Fúait*, for the element *fúait* enters into various place-names.

**Ath Gowla** [*Áth n-Gabla*]. This has sometimes been spoken of as a ford on the Boyne, but it was not: the host came past Kells and did not go south of the Boyne. At L.L. 59. 31, we are told that it was at “the turlough of the great forest, northward of Knowth of Kings.” Knowth is about two miles east of Slane. A turlough is a lake which dries up in summer. L.U. 58<sup>a</sup>33 (gloss) speaks of the pass (*beloch*) through the great forest. Was the turlough a flood-like expansion of the little river Mattock?

**Ath Greena** [*Áth n-grena*]. The older name of *Ath Gowla*.

**Ath Lahan** [*Áth Lethain*]. A ford on the Nith. See “Goola Milhy.”

**Athlone** [*Áth luain*]. “The Ford of the Loin.” The town of Athlone on the Shannon.

**Ath na Foraire** [*Áth na Foraire*]. See “Ford of Watching.”

**Ath Neermeeda** [*Áth n-Irmidi*]. The older name of *Ath Fayna*, which see.

**Ath Tray** [*Áth Traiged*]. “Ford of the Foot.” Said to be in Tir Mór; but but I cannot identify *Tir Mór*.

**Ath Vaeva** [*Áth Medbi*]. “The Ford of Maev.”

**Avvin Maha** [*Emain Macha*]. The ancient capital of Ulster was two miles due west of the present city of Armagh. The great mound, with what remains of its fosse, is now called Navan Ring. A townland to the west of the Ring still bears the name of Creeve Roe. Avvin Maha was destroyed by the three Collas, A.D. 331; and the Ulstermen did not dwell in it afterwards. It has been conjectured that Avvin Maha was Ptolemy’s *Regia*.

**Baeg** [*Bedg*]. One of Cucullin’s rivers of healing. Not identified. *Bedg* means “a sudden spring or start.”

**Bally Al’-yone** [*Bélat aileáin*]. “The Crossway of the Island.” (See “Cooley”).

**Banba** [*Banba*]. One of the ancient names for Ireland.

**Barna na darriv** [*Berna na d-tarb*]. “The gap of the bulls.”

**Barna Tána Bó.** (See “Cooley”).

**Ben Edar** [*Bend Etair*]. The Hill of Howth, near Dublin.

**Bill-awn’** [*Bithlán, Bithslán*]. “The Ever-full,” or “the Ever-healthy.” One of Cucullin’s rivers of healing. Not identified.

**Billi Vaeva** [*Bile Medba*]. “Maev’s Tree.” *Bile* means generally a large, venerable or sacred tree.

**Bir** [*Bir*]. One of Cucullin’s rivers of healing. Not identified. *Bir* means “a spit.”

**Booan** [*Buan*]. One of Cucullin's rivers of healing. Not identified. *Buan* means "enduring."

**Boyne** [*Boand*]. The river Boyne, which joins the sea at Drogheda.

**Bray Ross** [*Breg Ross*]. Evidently the district just north of Ardee.

**Bree Aerga** [*Brí Errgi*]. I do not know that this famous place has yet been identified; but I think it should be looked for in County Donegal, not far from Ballyshannon. I take the *Raith Argi* of Trip. Life, p. 328, to be the same place, and this was in the barony of Tirhugh, County Donegal. Compare Trip. Life, 352, where it is said that the extent of the boundary of St. Patrick's see was to be: "*a pinna montis Berbicis* [= probably *Benna Boirche*, the Mourne Mountains] usque ad montem *Mis* [= Slemish in County Antrim], a monte *Miss* usque ad *Bri Erigi*, a *Bri Erigi* usque ad *Dorsos Breg* [= Drum Bray]." If, as I conjecture, *Raith Argi* and *Bri Erigi* were the same place, the extent of St. Patrick's see, as promised by the angel, was practically to coincide with the extent of ancient Ulster.

**Bregan's Tower** [*Tor m-Breogain*]. After the Gaels had come from Scythia to Spain, one of their number, Bregan, erected a tower and city which were named after him, Brigantia. It was from this tower that Ith, his son, in the evening of a winter day first perceived Ireland in the distance! (See L.L. 3 and 4). Brigantia was on the coast not far from the modern Betanzos, in Galicia. See the account of O'Donnell's visit to Bregan's Tower in 1602. "He was rejoiced to have landed at that place, for he deemed it to be an omen of good success that he had arrived at the place from whence his ancestor had formerly obtained power and sway over Ireland." (F.M. 1602).

**Brenid** [*Brenide*]. One of Cucullin's rivers of healing. Not identified. It probably means "stinking," "rotten." Let us hope that the stream belied its name at the time when Cucullin was bathed in it.

**Bressla More** [*Breslech Mór*]. (See the same name, [Appendix A](#).) It must have been somewhere in the northern half of County Louth. *Ath Aladh* was another name for the same place. Windisch, *Táin*, p. 337, n. 6.

**Britain** [*Bretain, Breatain*]. Those western parts of Great Britain which were inhabited by the Britons.

**Bush** [*Buas*]. The river Bush in County Antrim. It was “one of the sovereign waters of Ireland.” See Rev. Celt. xxii. 321.

**Caha** [*Catha* L.L. 56<sup>b</sup>42]. Apparently a river flowing into the Boyne, some way to the west of Slane.

**Cahir Conree** [*Cathir Conruí*]. “The City of Cúruí.” The remains of this cahir are still to be seen on Slieve Mish, near Tralee, in Kerry. In the Triads (Y.B.L. 415<sup>a</sup>2) it is mentioned as one of the Three Doons, or strong places of Ireland, the other two being Dunseverick and Duncermna.

**Callan** [*Calland*]. The river which flows past Armagh, and joins the Blackwater near Moy. It is still called the Callan.

**Cann Teera More** [*Cend Tiri Móir*]. “The Head of the Great Land.” The same term occurs *Rennes* 66. I do not understand it.

**Carrloig** [*Carrlóig*, L.L. 94<sup>b</sup>1]. I think that this place, from which Kehern was to be summoned, was probably an old name for *Dun-Ceithirn*, now the Giant’s Sconce, in the parish of Dunboe, in the north of County Londonderry. Kehern’s father, Finntan, and his grandfather, Niall Niamhghlonnach, lived at *Dún dá bheann*, now Mount Sandel, not very far away. The words *laoch* and *carn* occurring in the two last lines of Inda’s Lament (Windisch, *Táin*, p. 639), though they suggest a different etymology, contain, I fancy, an allusion to this place-name. The *Carrlaoigh* of “Fragments of Irish Annals,” p. 14, and the *Cairloegh* of F.M. 478, appear to be the same place as the *Carrlóig* of the *Táin*.

**Carthage**. See Windisch, *Táin*, p. 819.

**Cenannas** [*Cenannas*]. Now Kells, in Meath.

**City of Moorn** [*Cathair Muirne*]. See the full account in “The Martial Career of Conghal Cláiringhneach” (Irish Texts Soc., vol. v.). Is the story founded on an account of Iceland and its volcano by some very early traveller? Fergus was said to be a fortnight and a month sailing to it from Lochlann (Denmark).

**Clahra** [*Clathra*, *Clartha*]. This may possibly be Clara on the Brosna in King’s County; but it is more likely, I think, to be *Caislean Clártha*,

now anglicised Clare Castle, which “is situated on a conspicuous hill in the parish of Killare, not far from the celebrated but now poor village of Ballymore Lough Sewdy, in the County of Westmeath.” See F.M. 1544, note y.

**Cleer Bó Ulla** [*Clithar bō Ulad*]. “The shelter of the cows of the Ultonians.” Probably somewhere towards the centre of County Louth.

**Cletty** [*Cleittech*]. This was a famous royal residence “above the brink of the Boyne” not far from Slane.

**Clon-ard’** [*Cluain Iraird*]. On the Boyne about ten miles above Trim. See the account of it in Wilde’s “Beauties of the Boyne.”

**Clō-na-Darriv** [*Clodh na d-tarb*]. “The dyke, or earthen wall, of the bulls.”

**Clonmacnoise** [*Cluain-mic-Nois*]. On the Shannon about nine miles below Athlone.

**Connallia Mweerhevna** [*Conailli Muirthemni*]. See “Moy Mweerhevna.”

**Connaught** [*Connacht*]. The ancient Connacht included the present County of Clare. See O’Mahony’s Keating, p. 88.

**Cooley** [*Cualnge*]. In dealing with the topography of Cooley we are met by two difficulties. The first lies in our ignorance of the exact extent of the ancient Cooley, the Cooley of the Táin. It would seem to have included not only the mountainous Carlingford peninsula in County Louth, but also Slieve Gullion in County Armagh, and the Mourne Mountains in County Down.

Compare 1. *Echtra Nerai* (Rev. Celt. x. 224), where there is a poem containing the line *i m-Bairchi hi Cuailgniu*, “in Bairchi in Cooley.” *Bairchi* seems to mean the Mourne Mountains, the old name of which was *Benna Boirche* (or *Bairche*).

2. *Cóir Anmann*, 269 (I.T.) where *Glenn Samaisce* is said to be in Cooley. In the Táin we are told that it is in Slieve Gullion.

3. Y.B.L. 53<sup>a</sup>26, where we are told that the bull on returning to Cooley, “went upon the Road of Meedlougher into *Cuib*. It is there that he used to be with the dry kine of Dawra.” *Cuib* is “Moy Cova” in the baronies of Upper and Lower Iveagh in County Down. Hence it seems

likely that the house of Dawra may have been on one of the northern slopes of the Mourne Mountains.

Our second difficulty lies in this: we have three versions of the harrying of Cooley. The first is contained in L.L. 69<sup>a</sup>44-69<sup>b</sup>46. It is the simplest and clearest; but much of the most interesting material is omitted. The other two accounts are in L.U., whose redactor in his usual scholarly manner gives them successively, so that the reader may compare them for himself. The second of these two L.U. accounts is chiefly in poetry, archaic and difficult, and it perhaps represents the oldest Táin-material which has come down to us. To reconcile the topography of these three versions is impossible, though there are some points wherein they seem to agree. Thus, up to the present we have been able to identify hardly any of the places in Cooley. I can only make the following suggestions:—

*Drumenna* [*Druim En* L.L., *Druim Féne* L.U.]. I think this was perhaps the wooded height now called Trumpet Hill, near Ballymascanlan, County Louth. In the very interesting old “map of County Down” by Gerard Kremer-Mercator this hill is marked *Drommena*, and an old woman living near the place told me that in her childhood Irish-speakers called it by this name. The situation would fit the story: it was just on the borders of Cooley and Connallia.

*Slieve Fauhan* [*Sliab Ocháine*]. If Trumpet Hill was *Druim En*, Slieve Fauhan, whence Cucullin hurled at the camp, must have been one of the higher mountains to the east of it. Now, in Mercator’s map one of these mountains is marked *Slew Wyaghno*, a name which might easily be a corruption of *Sliab Ocháine*. Perhaps the name applied to the whole line of mountains between Ballymakellett and Piedmont. Does it still survive? I failed to find it.

*Glen Fauhan* [*Glend Focháine*]. If the identification of Slieve Fauhan is right, Glen Fauhan was probably the valley of the little river which joins the sea a short mile to the east of Bellurgan Station.

*Glass Crond* [*Crond*; *Glaiss Cruind*]. It seems likely that this may have been the stream now called the Piedmont River. It issues from the mountain just below the Windy Gap (at “the Long Woman’s Grave”)

by which the roadway crosses the Carlingford Peninsula, and it falls into Dundalk Bay.

*Barna Tana Bo Cooley*. If the Piedmont River is Glass Crond, then the famous pass which Maev caused to be made is the above-mentioned Windy Gap.

*Glass Colpa* [*Glaiss Colptha*]. This seems to be the same as the *Aband cholpthai i cualngiu* of L.L. 110<sup>b</sup>33 (the story of Goll and Garb). But I cannot identify it.

These are all the suggestions I can make.

The account of the harrying of Cooley which I give in Book viii. is a much abbreviated conflation of the three versions described above. Those, therefore, who wish to work at the topography of Cooley, will not find help in it; they must work from original sources.

**Cool Shibrilly** [*Cúil Sibrilli, Cúil Sibrinni*]. Said in the Táin to be south-west of Kells. According to F.M., A.M. 3991, *Dún Chuile Sibrinne* was an old name for Kells.

**Cool Shillinny** [*Cúil Silinne*]. Now Kilcooley, only four miles or so to the south-east of Croohan. See F.M. 1418.

**Corann** [*Corann*]. This territory is now represented by the barony of Corran in County Sligo.

**Corcum-roe'** [*Corcumruad*]. Now represented by the barony of Corcumroe in County Clare; but in ancient times the territory of Corcumroe included Burren.

(The) **Corry of Glenn Gatt** [*Dub cairiu glinni Gatt*. L.U. 65<sup>a</sup>21]. See "Cooley."

(The) **Craggs of Manann** [*Cairrge Manann*]. Rocks on the coast of the Isle of Man.

**Crannig** [*N. Crandach; G. Crandche; D. Crandaig*]. In making Crannig the old name of Faughard, I was relying on L.L. 73<sup>a</sup>47-51; but in reality *Crandach*, "the Woody Place," seems to be used somewhat vaguely; and it may have been applied to a good stretch of country.

**Crithny** [*Cruithnech*]. The Land of the Picts. The Irish Picts were settled in the ancient *Dál araidhe*, namely, the southern half of County Antrim and the northern part of County Down.

**Croagh Patrick** [*Cruach-Phádrúig*]. A high mountain on the southern side of Clew Bay in County Mayo. On a clear afternoon it may be seen from Rath Croohan, fifty miles to the east of it.

**Cromma** [*Cromma*]. Apparently a river flowing into the Boyne a little to the west of Slane.

**Croohan** [*Cruachan* or *Rath Cruachan*]. The ancient capital of Connaught, now Rathcroghan, near Bellanagare in County Roscommon. Many mounds and raths are still to be seen there, as well as the ancient royal burial-field and the pillar-stone over the grave of Dawthy.

**Cullin** [*Cuilend*]. One of Cucullin's rivers of healing. Is it the Cully Water which flows southward from County Armagh into County Louth to the west of Forkill?

**Cumung** [*Cumung*]. One of Cucullin's rivers of healing. Not identified. *Cumung* means "narrow," "constricted."

**Dalriada** [*Dál riada*]. The northern part of County Antrim. See the account of it, Reeves, p. 318.

**Deehaem** [*Dichaem*]. One of Cucullin's rivers of healing. Not identified.

**Delind** [*Delaind*]. A river crossed by the hosts on their way eastward to Kells. Not identified.

**Delt** [*Delt*]. A river crossed by the hosts on their way eastward to Kells. Not identified.

**Delt** [*Delt*]. One of Cucullin's rivers of healing. It may possibly have been the *Doailte* in *Crich Roiss* which is mentioned F.M., A.M. 4169. *Crich Roiss* was partly in the barony of Farney in County Monaghan, and partly in the adjoining portion of County Louth.

**Dooglass** [*Dubglass*]. "The black stream." One of Cucullin's rivers of healing. Not identified.

**Doolough** [*Dubloch*]. "The black lake." Somewhere between Kilcooley and Slieve Bawne in County Roscommon.



**Doon Borrig** [*Dún Borraig*]. This famous fortress was on the headland of Torr in County Antrim, a point at which there are only about twelve miles between the coasts of Ireland and Scotland. It would now be pronounced “Dunwarry” or “Dunvarry.” See the very interesting account, O’Lav. iv. 479 and 520.

**Doon Dalgan** [*Delga* L.U. 68<sup>a</sup>8; *go Dun Dealgan* C.R.R. 66]. Now anglicised Dundalk. The ancient doon, now called the Castletown Moat, is about a mile inland.

**Doon Feea** [*Dún-fidhgha; Dûn fiodhaigh*]. “The doon of the wood, or thicket.” Perhaps near Loch Etive.

**Doon Finn** [*Dún Finn*]. “The white doon.” Perhaps near Loch Etive.

(The) **Doon of the Sons of Nahta Scaena** [*Dún mac Nechtáin Scéne*]. O’Curry says this was “on the right bank of the little river Mattock, where it falls into the Boyne.” See M. and C. ii., p. 292. This doon is mentioned in the *Dindsenchas*. See Rev. Celt. xvi., p. 83; but outside the Táin, I remember no other reference to it.

**Drong** [*Drong*]. One of Cucullin’s rivers of healing. Not identified.

**Drum Bray** [*Druimne Breg* T.E. § 38.] = Slieve Bray [*Sliab Breg*]. A line of low heights stretching across the barony of Upper Slane in Meath and the barony of Ferrard in Louth, and forming the northern watershed of the Boyne.

**Drumenna**. See under “Cooley.”

**Drum Keen** [*Druim Cáin*, L.L. 56<sup>b</sup>20]. “The fair or beautiful ridge.” There were many places so named.

**Drum Leek** [*Druimm Licci*]. “The ridge of the flagstone.” Somewhere near Slane.

**Drum-na-darriv** [*Druim na d-tarbh*]. “The ridge of the bulls.”

**Drum Saulinn** [*Druim Salaind*, L.L.; *Druim Sálfínd*, L.U.]. Is this Drumshallon about six miles north of Drogheda? It seems possible.

**Dunseverick** [*Dún Sobairche*]. About three miles east of the Giant’s Causeway in County Antrim. One of the Three Doons of Ireland. (Triads, Y.B.L. 415<sup>a</sup>2).

**Duv** [*Dub*]. “The Black.” The first river passed after leaving Kells. Therefore, almost certainly, the Blackwater.

**Edon More** [*Eo dond mór*]. “The great brown tree.” Somewhere towards the middle of County Louth. Probably the same place as that in which the battle of *Euduind móir* was fought. See F.M. 590.

**Erin** [N. *Eriu*; G. *Erend*; D. *Erind*] Ireland. I have adhered to the dative form, which has already been adopted in English.

**Farney** [*Fernmag*]. “The plain of alders.” Now the barony of Farney in County Monaghan.

**Faughard** [*Fochaird*]. The height still called Faughard about three miles north of Dundalk.

**Fauhan.** See under “Cooley.”

**Fawl** [*Fál*]. An old name for Ireland. See L.L. 261<sup>a</sup>37. Sometimes we have *Inis Fáil*, “the Island of Fál.” The name was derived from the *Fál* or *Lia Fáil* in Tara, “the stone that used to roar under the feet of every king that would take possession of Ireland.” See Rev. Celt. xv. 281 and 285.

**Fedain Collna** [*Fedain chollna*, Y.B.L. 50<sup>a</sup>28]. This must have been somewhere near Clahra, which see.

**Fěven** [*Femen*]. The Plain of Femen was in the south of Tipperary. It is now the barony of Iffa and Offa East. I do not know whether the famous Sheemound of Bove has been identified or not; but see *Ac. na Sen.* 2775, where we are told that in somewhat later times it was called *Sidh ban find*, “the Shee-mound of white women.” O’Donovan says that *Sliabh na mban bhfionn*, “the mountain of the white women,” was the ancient name of Slieve-na-man; so, probably, it was this striking mountain which was the residence of Bove.

**Findabair.** (See under “Cooley”).

**Finncarn.** (See under “Slieve Mourne”).

**Finnglass** [*Finnglais*]. “The white stream.” One of Cucullin’s rivers of healing. Not identified.

**Finnglass** [*Finnglass Assail*]. A river crossed by the hosts. Not identified. See “Road of Assal.”

**Finngower** [*Fingabair*]. Probably in Slieve Foo-id; for at L.L. 89<sup>b</sup>26 Fingin is said to be at *Leccain Sleibe Fúait*.

**Fo-dromma** [*Fodromma*]. This seems to be a river flowing into the Boyne very close to Slane.

**Ford of Bercna** [*Áth Bercna*]. Probably to the north-west of Croohan, near Bellanagare or Frenchpark. See also *Ac. na Sen*. 7862.

**Ford of Coltna** [*Áth Coltna*]. This seems to be connected with *Coltain* L.L. 56<sup>b</sup>15, and *Móin Coltna* L.L. 58<sup>a</sup>17. It must have been somewhere near Slieve Bawne, and south-east of Croohan.

**Ford of Moga** [*Áth Moga*]. A ford over the river Suck. Now Ballymoe, about ten miles south-west of Croohan.

**Ford of Shlissen** [*Áth Slissen*]. A ford over the Owenure River, near Elphin, now Bellaslishen Bridge. See F.M. 1288. It is about six miles to the north-east of Croohan.

**Ford of the two Magic Deeds** [*Áth da Ferta*, Y.B.L. 55<sup>a</sup>23, cf. *vadum duarum virtutum* (*Mirabilium*), An. Ulster 818]. At L.L. 79<sup>b</sup>7 this ford is said to be in Slieve Foo-id. Elsewhere it is said to be in Moy Mweerhevna. Therefore, probably, it was at a point where the hills (Slieve Foo-id) join the plain (Moy Mweerhevna) on the southern border of the barony of Upper Fews in County Armagh.

**Ford of Watching** [*Áth na Foraire*]. This was evidently on the road between Avvin Maha and Loch Ahtra (Lake Muckno). Outside the *Táin* I remember no reference to *Áth na Foraire*; but there are many references to *Carn na foraire*, “the Cairn of Watching”; and the latter may perhaps be identified with Carnagh, a hill about four miles south of Keady. This hill must have commanded a wide view towards the territory of Mourne and the sometimes hostile sub-kingdom of Farney in the south.

**Gan'-a-win** [*Gáinemain*]. “The sandy.” One of Cucullin’s rivers of healing. Not identified.

**Gaul.** See the remarks by Dr. Kuno Meyer, *Rev. Celt.* xi. 438.

**Gawrig** [*Gárech*, dat. *Gárig*]. I think the site of the great battle was near Ballymore, in Westmeath. See “Clahra.”

**Glass Colpa** [*Glaiss Colptha*]. See under “Cooley.”

**Glass Crond** [*Crond*; *Glaiss Cruind*]. See under “Cooley.”

**Glass Gatlig** [*Glaiss Gatlaig*]. See under “Cooley.”

**Glen'-a-win** [*Glenamain*]. One of Cucullin's rivers of healing. Not identified.

**Glen Bray** [*Gleunn mBreogaind*, T.E. § 39]. A glen between Drum Bray and the Boyne. Moy Bray, Glen Bray, &c., are said to have been named after Bregan, the builder of Bregan's Tower.

**Glen Daw Roo** [*Glenn Da Rúadh*]. Said to be Glendaruel, in Argyle. For an account of the various glens in Argyle, supposed to be those which are described in Daerdra's song, see “Loch Etive and the Sons of Uisneach,” by the late Dr. Angus Smith.

**Glendomna**. See “Imlee of Glendomna,” [Appendix A](#).

**Glen Etive** [*Glenn Eitchi*]. Glen Etive in Argyle.

**Glen Faer-bay'** [*Glend Firbaith*, L.U. 74<sup>a</sup>11]. This must have been close to Faughard.

**Glen Fauhan** [*Glend Focháine*]. See under “Cooley.”

**Glen Gatt** [*Glend ngat*, L.U. 65<sup>a</sup>23]. See under “Cooley.”

**Glen Law'-ee** [*Glend Láid*]. Said to be Glenlochry in Argyle.

**Glen Massan** [*Glend Masain*]. Said to be Glenmasan, at the head of Loch Striven, in Argyle.

**Glen Samaska** [*Glend na Samaisce*]. “Glen of the heifers.” This must have been close to Slieve Gullion, in County Armagh.

**Glen Taul** [*Glend Táil*]. See under “Cooley.”

**Glen Urkeen** [*Glend Urchán, Orchaoin*]. Said to be Glenorchy, in Argyle.

**Glore** [*Gleóir*]. One of Cucullin's rivers of healing. Not identified.

**Goola Milhy** [*Guala Muilchi*]. On the river Dee (the ancient *Nith*). Is this the townland of Drumgoolestown between Dromin and Stabannan in County Louth?

**Gower** [*Gabair*]. Perhaps to the west of Loch Neagh. See *Fir Gabrae*, Trip. Life, Index.

**Granard** [*Granard*, L.U. 57<sup>a</sup>30 gloss]. The town of Granard, in the east of County Longford.

**Great Greece**. See [Appendix E](#).

**Great Snowy Land**. See [Appendix E](#).

**Greece**. See [Appendix E](#).

**Grellah Cul'-gäry** [*Grellach Culgairi*]. "The miry place of the chariot-noise." One gathers from *Táin Bo Regamna* that this was the old name for Grellah Dollud, which see.

**Grellah Dollud** [*Grellach Dolluid*]. O'Donovan (F.M. 693, note) suggests that this place was Girly near Kells. But *Tochmarc Emire* and *Táin Bo Regamna* show clearly that it was somewhere in Moy Mweerhevna.

**Grey Lake** [*Lind Liath*]. Somewhere in Slieve Foo-id.

(The) **Height of Willows** [*Árd na Sáilech*]. Now Armagh, cf. Trip. Life, ii. 473.

(The) **Hill of Usna** [*Uisneach*]. In the barony of Rathconrath, in Westmeath. "The reputed centre of Ireland."

**Ilgawrig** [*Ilgáirig*]. See "Gawrig."

**Imlee of Glendomna**. See [Appendix A](#).

**Immil**. See "Loch Laery."

**Innish Cooscree** [*Inis Cuscraid*]. Now Inch, near Downpatrick.

**Innish Draiguen** [*Inis Draigen*]. Perhaps "a projecting rocky land called *Ruadh nan Draighnean*," near Bunawe, in Argyle. See "Loch Etive and the Sons of Uisneach."

**Inn'-yone** [*Indeóin*]. This was the old name of the Dungolman River, which separates the baronies of Rathconrath and Kilkenny West, in

Westmeath. It seems to mark the southern limit of “the long devious course” by which Fergus led the hosts.

**Inver Colpa** [*Inbher Colptha*]. The estuary of the Boyne.

**Iona** [*I Choluim Chille*]. An island off the Ross of Mull in Scotland. Of great fame in connexion with St. Columba.

**Irrus Domnann** [*Irros Domnand*]. Now the barony of Erris in County Mayo.

**Islands of the Athishec.** See [Appendix E](#).

**Islands of the Foreigners** } [*Insi-Gall*]. The Hebrides, or Western Isles  
**Islands of the Gall** } of Scotland.

**Isles of Gat** [*Indsi Gaid*, Y.B.L. 46<sup>a</sup>27]. When writing, I understood these to be the same as the *Insi Cadd* of C.R.R. p. 10, and the *Insi Cat* of G. and G., p. 152, namely, the Shetland Islands; and I recast the passage. But Dr. Windisch (*Táin*, p. 722) quite rightly, I think, understands them to be the Islands of Cadiz. The sentiment expressed by Fergus is not affected by the difference!

**Isles of Orc** [*Indsi Orcc*, Y.B.L. 46<sup>a</sup>26]. The Orkney Islands.

**Kell Cooan** [*Caill Cuan*]. “The Wood of Cooan.” I cannot identify this; but there was a high road leading to it from Moy Mweerhevna. *Cuan* means “a harbour.”

**Kyle Cooan** [*Caill Cuan*]. Somewhere in Argyle. I don’t know whether it has been identified.

**Knowth** [*Cnogba*]. A great tumulus on the Boyne, a couple of miles east of Slane. In the Triads the Cave of Knowth is one of the three Dark Places of Erin.

**Land of Sorca** [*Tír na Sorcha*; *Tír Sorcha*]. A supernatural country, the same as *Tír Tairngiri*, “the Land of Promise.” In the story called *Serglige Conculaind* (L.U. 43-50) it is described in very beautiful poetry: the name occurs at L.U. 48<sup>a</sup>41.

(The) **Larguey** [*Lerga*]. *Lerga* means “a slope,” “a hillside,” and is found in very many place-names in Ulster. The Larguey of Book xi. must have been close to the place afterwards called the Bressla More.

**Leek More** [dat. *ic Líc Móir*]. Not identified.

**Leesa Leek** [*Liasa liac*]. See under “Cooley.”

**Le-Glass** [*Lethglais, Dún Leithglaisse*]. Now Downpatrick. The great doon of Keltar, which has given its name, “Down,” to the whole country, may still be seen there.

**Leinster** [*Lagen*]. An ancient name for Leinster was *Gailean*. In the *Táin* the men of Leinster are called the *Galeóin*.

**Letteree** [*Leitir-Ruige*]. Unfortunately I have not read the *Cath Leitreach-Ruige*, of which there is a copy, R.I.A. 23 k. 37. It may supply data for the identification of this place.

**Lind Format**. See [Appendix E](#).

**Loch Ahtra** [*co Fertais Locha Echtrand*]. Now Muckno Lake, County Monaghan. See F.M., A.M. 2535, note t.

**Loch Etive** [*Loch Eitche*]. Loch Etive in Argyle.

**Loch Laery** [*Loch Laoghaire*, Haliday’s Keating, p. 390]. This must have been Belfast Lough. Compare “Death-Tales of Ulster Heroes” by Dr. Kuno Meyer, p. 22, and “Deaths of some Irish Heroes” by Dr. Stokes, Rev. Celt, xxiii, pp. 320, 325, 335: from these passages we learn that the house of the great Laery the Victorious was on the brink of *Loch Láí*, *Loch Laogh*, *Loch Láig*, *Loch Lóig*, all various spellings of the old name for Belfast Lough. The country near his house was called *Críoch Láoghaire Bhuadhaigh*, “the Territory of Laery the Victorious.” In the *Táin* the name of his rath is variously given as *Immiailli*, *Impail*, *Ráith Imbil*, *Ráith Impail*, &c., a name which possibly, I think, contains an allusion to its situation on the edge of the sea, for *Imbel* means “an edge,” “a border.” I would suggest that it may have been at Carnalea, the last syllable of which name is probably derived from the ancient name of the Lough.

**Loch-na-darriv** [*Loch-na-d-tarb*]. “The lake of the bulls.”

**Loch Ree** [*Loch Rí*]. Lough Ree, an expansion of the Shannon.

**Loo’-a-her** [*Luachair*]. Perhaps Slieve Lougher near Castleisland in County Kerry.

**Loolohta Lōha** [dat. *Luglochtaib Loga*]. In “*The Battle of Magh Rath*,” p. 52, we are told that the *bruighean* of Forgall Mona was *i taeb Lusca* “beside Lusk” (County Dublin).

|                                                            |   |                        |
|------------------------------------------------------------|---|------------------------|
| <b>Maeda of the Bird</b> [ <i>Méide ind eóin</i> ].        | } | These places must have |
|                                                            |   | been near the          |
|                                                            |   | middle of the          |
| <b>Maeda of the Squirrel</b> [ <i>Méide in togmaill</i> ]. | } | County Louth.          |
|                                                            |   | <i>Méide</i> means “a  |
|                                                            |   | neck.”                 |

(The Three) **Maels of Meath** [*na tri Maela Mide*]. There is a reference to these *Silv. Gad. i. 308*; but I cannot identify them.

(The Three) **Maels of Connaught** [*na tri maoláin Atha Luáin*, “the three Maels of Athlone”]. These must be three hills close to Athlone, on the Connaught side.

**Meath** [*Mide*]. The ancient Meath contained the present counties of Meath and Westmeath and much territory besides. See O’Mahony’s Keating, p. 86.

**Meedlougher**. See “Road of Meedlougher.”

**Meelic** [*Miliuc*]. One of Cucullin’s rivers of healing. Not identified.

**Mone Coltna** [*Móin Chóiltrae*, L.U. 57<sup>a</sup>9]. This seems to be the same place as the *Coltain* of the Itinerary L.U. and L.L. Apparently a moor between Slieve Bawne and the Shannon.

**Mooah** [*Muach*]. One of Cucullin’s rivers of healing. Not identified.

**Mound of Ercmon** [*Sid Ercmon*, Celt. Zeit. 241]. In the unedited *Coga Fergusa agus Conchobar*, “Wars of Fergus and Conor,” R.I.A. 23 k. 37, there is a *Síodh Ealcmar*, which may be the same place; but I cannot identify it.

**Mourne** [*a Moduirn atúaid*, L.L. 98<sup>a</sup>42]. It seems likely that this territory of Munnrower son of Guerkind was *Mughdhorn Breagh*, “Mourne of Bray,” which was partly in Cavan, partly in Meath. Munnrower met his death “in his own lake,” Loch Munreamair (Rev. Celt. xxiii, 327) now Lough Ramor, County Cavan. At L.L. 114<sup>a</sup>38 he is called



*Munremur lond Locha Sáil*; and *Loch Sáil* seems to be *Loch Sailind*, now Lough Sheelin, not far from Lough Ramor.

**Movilla** [*Magh bhile*]. Near Newtownards in County Down.

**Moy Bray** [*Magh Breagh*]. Used vaguely for the whole of the comparatively level country between Dublin and Kells and Dundalk.

**Moy Cova** [*Magh Cobha*]. The plain north-west of the Mourne Mountains, in the baronies of Upper and Lower Iveagh, County Down.

**Moy Cronn** [*Magh Cruinn*]. This would seem to have been part of Moy Wee.

**Moy Innish** [*Magh Inis*]. Now the baronies of Upper and Lower Lecale in County Down.

**Moy Linny** [*Magh Line*]. Chiefly in the barony of Upper Antrim, County Antrim.

**Moy Mweerhevna** [*Magh Muirthemne*]. The level plain in the north of County Louth.

**Moy-na-darriv** [*Magh-na-d-tarbh*]. The plain of the bulls.

**Moy Thooaga** [*Mag Tuaga*]. Somewhere in Connaught.

**Moy Traega** [*Mag Trega*]. The level country in the barony and county of Longford.

**Moy Twirra** [*Mag Tuireadh*]. Near Lough Arrow in the barony of Tirerrill, County Sligo. See F.M., A.M. 3330, note s.

**Moy Wee** [*Mag Ái, Mag Aei*]. The plain in County Roscommon on which Rath Coohan was situated. It extended from Ballymoe to Elphin, and from Bellanagare to Strokestown.

**Munster** [*Muma*].

**Murrisc** [*Muiresc*]. The barony of Murrisk in County Mayo.

**Nemud** [*Nemud*]. Somewhere in Slieve Foo-id. It may be the same place as the *nemed* in Trip. Life, p. 240.

**Nith** [*Nith*]. The ancient name of the river of Ardee. See F.M., A.M. 4169, note. Now called the Dee.

**Ohawn** [*Ochun, Ochuind*]. This seems likely to be the *Ochonn* of Meath, where Niall of the Nine Hostages was buried. (See Rev. Celt. xv, p. 295.) I don't know whether it has been identified.

**Ollbinni** [*Ollbine, Ailbine*. T.E. § 46]. The river Delvin, which falls into the sea at Gormanstown a little north of Balbriggan. See Reeves, Col., p. 108, note d.

**Ooanub** [*Uanabh, Uanuib*]. Is this the White River between the baronies of Ferrard and Ardee in County Louth?

**Oorawn Garad** [*Uarán Garad*]. In O'Donovan's map of Hy Many this is marked due south of Croohan. Our old literature contains some singularly charming references to this well.

**Orkill** [*Oircel, Orcel*]. Now Forkill; the valley of the Forkill river, west of Slieve Gullion in County Armagh.

**Oughter Netmon** [*Ouchter Nedmon*]. Somewhere a little to the north of Drum Bray.

**Partry** [*Partraigi*]. Does this name still survive a little to the south-west of Kells?

**Pass of Awny** [*Belach náne*, L.U. 63<sup>b</sup>7]. *Belach* being a neuter noun, I take the following *n* to be "transported." Not identified so far as I know.

**Poopal Vaeva** [*Pupall Medba*]. "Maev's tent."

**Raeda Lōha** [*Réde Loche*]. See under Cooley.

**Rath Aerheer** [*Ráith Airthir*]. "The Eastern Fort." There was a *Ráith Airthir* close to Taltin (See Trip. Life, p. 70), but this was not in Farney, of which Owen was king.

**Rath Immil**. See "Loch Laery."

**Rathlin** [*Rachriu*]. A large island off the northern coast of Antrim. An old name for it was *Inis Cuilinn*.

**Rath-na-darriv** [*Ráith na dtarbh*]. "The rath of the bulls."

**Reedonn** [*Rígdond*]. Is this the same place as that in which St. Patrick afterwards founded his church of *Domnach Rígduind*, "The church, or cathedral, of Rígdond"? *Domnach Rígduind* was in the south of

County Derry, between Slieve Gullion and Loch Neagh. See Trip. Life, p. 169, and Reeves, p. 294. At Y.B.L. 47<sup>b</sup>45, the place whence Rohee came is called *Brig dumaë*.

**Rind** [*Rind*]. One of Cucullin's rivers of healing. Not identified.

**Road of Assal** [*Slighe Asail*]. One of the great high roads of ancient Ireland. It ran from Tara westwards, at least as far as *Tig Lommain* (now Portloman) on the western shore of Lough Owel, in Westmeath. See L.U. 6<sup>a</sup>31-33.

**Road of Meedlougher** [*Slighe Midhluachra*]. One of the great high roads of ancient Ireland. It ran northward from Tara; and from various passages in the literature (especially Y.B.L. 53<sup>a</sup>26) we are able to gather that it went through the western part of Cooley—perhaps through the Moyry Pass—and so past Newry into Moy Cova.

**Sawss** [*Sás*]. One of Cucullin's rivers of healing. Not identified.

**Saxon land** [*Saxain*]. England. But the Saxons had not come to Britain at the time when the *Táin* took place. The first mention of Saxons in F.M. is under the year 683 A.D.

**Sayer** [*Saighir*]. Now Seir-kieran, about six miles to the east of Parsonstown, in the King's County.

**Scythia**. See [Appendix E](#).

**Seel** [*Síl*]. Somewhere in Lecale, in County Down.

**Shannon** [*Sionainn*]. The river Shannon.

**Slahta** [*Slecht*a]. To the south-west of Kells. Does the name survive?

**Slane** [*Sláne*]. The town of Slane, on the Boyne.

**Slane of Meath** [*Slemain Mide*]. "Now divided into Slanebeg and Slanemore, two townlands in the parish of Dysart, County Westmeath." An. Ulster i., p. 33, note. An adjoining townland is called Slanestown. This district is about three miles to the west of Mullingar.

**Slawnga** [*Slánge*]. The ancient name of Slieve Donard, the highest of the Mourne Mountains.

**Slieve Bawne** [*Badbgna*]. “A mountainous territory extending from Lanesborough to Rooskey, on the west side of the Shannon, in the County of Roscommon.” F.M. 678, note.

**Slieve Bray** [*Slíab Breg*]. See “Drum Bray.”

**Slieve Fauhan** [*isin tsléib tuath ocháine*, L.U. 67<sup>a</sup>15]. See under “Cooley.”

**Slieve Findabair** [*Findabair Slebe*]. There were many places named Findabair. I cannot identify this one. The name is usually anglicised Fennor.

**Slieve Foo-id** [*Slíab Fúait*]. This name seems to have been applied vaguely to almost all the mountainous country west and north-west of Slieve Gullion, in the southern half of County Armagh. One could make a long list of names of places which in our old literature were said to be “in Slieve Foo-id.”

**Slieve Gullion** [*Sliab Culind*]. A striking mountain in the barony of Upper Orior, County Armagh. See under “Cooley.”

**Slieve Mourne** [*Sliab Moduirn*]. A country of low hills in the southern part of the barony of Cremourne, County Monaghan. Finncarn, “the white cairn,” must have been on a height which commanded a wide view towards the south.

**Spain** [*Espain*].

**Suir** [*Siúir*]. The river which forms the northern boundary of County Waterford.

**Tahg** [*Tadg*]. One of Cucullin’s rivers of healing. Not identified.

**Taltin** [*Taltiu*; dat. *Tailtin*]. Now Teltown, on the Blackwater between Kells and Navan. A very famous place in ancient Erin.

**Tamlaht Orlam** [*oc Tamlactain órláib*, L.L. 68<sup>a</sup>28]. Said in L.L. to be to the north of *Disert Lochad*, but where was this? *Tamlachta* means a plague-grave. Near Drumshallon, to the west, there is a townland called *Kiltallaght*. Was this the place?

**Tara** [*Temair*]. The ancient capital of Ireland. In the barony of Screen, County Meath.

**Tara in the Ards.** See “Ards of Ulster.”

**Tara of Cooley.** See under “Cooley.”

**Teffia** [*Tethba*]. North and south Teffia were large territories, the boundaries of which doubtless varied at different periods. In early times the river Inny, which flows into Lough Ree, divided north Teffia from south Teffia. See B.R., p. 11.

**Telamet** [*Telaméit*]. One of Cucullin’s rivers of healing. Not identified.

**Thromma** [*Tromma*]. A river evidently flowing into the Boyne close to Slane. In F.M. 512 there is mention of a *Sidh Truim* close to Slane. The names are probably connected. *Sidh Truim* is also mentioned L.U. 47<sup>a</sup>33.

**Toom Mona** [*Tóm Mona, Tuaim Mona*]. Now Toomona, two or three miles south of Rath Croohan. See the interesting note, F.M. 1488, note *a*.

**Tyrrhene Sea** [*Muir Toirrian*]. See [Appendix E](#).

**Ulster** [*Ulaid*]. The boundary of ancient Ulster extended from the estuary of the Boyne to the river Drowes, which flows from Lough Melvin into Donegal Bay. In the Táin, however, *Ulaid* is occasionally used in a more restricted sense, and seems to apply only to the north-eastern corner of Ireland, Antrim and Down and Armagh.

**Wave of Cleena** [*Tond Chlidna*]. In Glandore Harbour, County Cork. See the very interesting note by O’Donovan, F.M. 1557.

**Wave of Rury** [*Tond Rudraige*]. In the Bay of Dundrum, County Down. This place was also called *Inbhear n-Gaath*, “the River-mouth of Winds.” See I.T.S. v. 168.

**Wave of Thooig Inver** [*Tond Tuage Inbir*]. At the mouth of the Bann, in County Derry.

## APPENDIX C

### NAMES OF PERSONS, TRIBES, AND ANIMALS OCCURRING IN THE VERSE.

Three **Abrat-rooas** [*Trí Abrat-rúaid*].

**Aen**, charioteer of Conall Carna [*Oen*].

**Aen**, son of Mahga [*Én mac Magach*].

**Aerrga Ecbael** [*Errge Echbél*].

**Āl'-yill** [*Ailill*].

**Angus** [*Oengus*].

**An'-looan** [*Anlúan*].

**Annly** [*Ainnle*].

**Ar-dawn'** [*Ardán*].

**Av'-ver-guin** [*Amargin*].

**Awley** [*Amhalgaidh*].

**Baefinn** [*Befind*].

**Bahlor** [*Balor*].

**Bas** [*Bas*].

**Bashny** [*Baiscne*].

**Baskell** [*Bascell*].

**Blai** [*Blai*].

**Blawth** [*Bláth*].

**Bled** [*Bled*].

**Blod** [*Blod*].

**Bō'-guin-ă** [*Bogaine*].

**Boi** [*Bude*].

**Borrig** [*Borrach*; gen. *Borraig*].

**Bove** [*Bodb*].

**Boyne** [*Boand*].

**Brendan** [*Brenainn*].

**Bress** [*Bress*].

**Brian** [*Brian*].

**Brigit** [*Brigit*].

**Broo'-ă-her** [*Brúachar*].

**Bwinn'-ye** [*Buinne*].

**Caillin** [*Caillin*].

**Căl'-a-teen** [*Calatín*].

**Carpry neea Faer** [*Carpre Nia fer*].

Four **Casses** [*Cethri Caiss*].

**Cathbad** [*Cathbath, Cathbad*].

**Catt** [*Catt*].

**Caur** [*Caur*].

Three **Cauriths** [*Trí Caurith*].

**Clothra** [*Clothra*].

Five **Coffys** [*cóic Cobthaig*].

**Collac** [*Collach*].

**Colum-killé** [*Columb-cille*].

Three **Com'-beergas** [*trí Combirgi*].

**Conall Carna** [*Conall Cernach*].

**Conmac** [*Conmac*].

**Conn** [*Conn*].

Eight **Connlas** [*Ochtar Conlai*].

**Connra Cae** [*Connra Caeach*].

**Connud** [*Connud*].

**Conor the son of Fahtna Fahee son of Ross the Red-haired son of Rury**  
[*Conchobar mac Fächtna Fathaig meic Rossa Ruaid meic Rudraigi*].

**Cooar** [*Cuar*].

**Coor son of Daw-loath'** [*Cúr mac Da Lóth*].

**Cooroi son of Dawra** [*Cúruí mac Daire*].

**Cooscree Mend Maha** [*Cuscraid Mend Macha*].

**Corc** [*Corc*].

**Cormac Con-ling'-ish** [*Cormac Condloinges*].

**Cotreb** [*Cotreb*].

**Crin'niuc** [*Cruinniucc*].

Three **Cromms** [*trí Cruim*].

Two **Croo'-ees** [*dá Chrúaid*].

**Crunniuc the son of Agnoman** [*Crunniuc mac Agnoman*].

**Cruthen** [*Cruthen*].

**Cullan** [*Culand*].

**Cu-cullin** [*Cúchulaind*].

**Daerbra** [*Derbriu*].

**Daerdra** [*Derdriu*].

The **Dagda** [*In Dagda*].

Nine **Dahmahs** [*nói n-Dámaig*].

Nine **Daigiths** [*nói n-Daigith*].

**Dawra son of Feeacna** [*Dára mac Fiachnai*].

**Dawthy** [*Dathí*].



**Dec'-tor-a** [*Dechtíre*].

Ten **Delbaes** [*deich n-Delbaith*].

**Dess** [*Dess*: explained in a gloss to mean *Dia*, “God.”]

**Dōha son of Mahga** [*Dóche mac Magach*].

**Domnall** [*Domnall*].

**Donn of Cooley** [*Dond Cualnge*].

Six **Dooahs** [*sé Duaich*].

**Doo Sanglenn** [*Dubh Sainglend*].

**Dorndoll** [*Dorndoll*].

**Duffa Dael** [*Dubthach Dóel*].

Six **Dungalls** [*Sé Dungail*].

Two **Eckells** [*Dá Éicell*].

**Ecket** [*Ecet*].

**Edarcool son of Feda and Leth'-rinny** [*Etarcumul mac Feda ocus Lethrnini*].

**Ella** [*Éle*].

**Emer** [*Emer*].

**Erc** [*Ercc*].

**Err** [*Err*].

**Esorb** [*Esorb*].

**Ethna** [*Ethne*].

**Etty** [*Eitte*].

**Faebur** [*Faebur*].

**Faer'-a-dah** [*Feradach*].

**Faer-bay' son of Baet'-an** [*Fer báeth mac Baetain*].

**Faer-bay' son of Faer-bend'** [*Fer báeth mac Fir bend*].

**Faer-daet´ son of Dăm´-an** [*Fer dét mac Damáin*].

**Faer-dee´-ah son of Dăm-an** [*Fer diad mac Damáin*].

**Faer-lō-ga** [*Fer loga*].

**Fann´-la** [*Faindle*].

**Faylim** [*Feidlimid*].

**Faylimy** [*Feidlimid*].

**Fedelm** [*Feidelm*].

**Fed´-il-mid** [*Fedlimid, Feidilmid*].

Ten **Fee´-acs** [*Deich Féic*].

**Fee´-ac-na** [*Fiachna*].

**Fee´-a-ha** [*Fiacha*].

**Fee´-al** [*Fíal*].

**Fehan** [*Fethan*].

**Fergus son of Leddy** [*Fergus mac Leti*].

**Fergus the son of Roy the son of Yōhee Lenny** [*Fergus mac Roeich meic Echdach Lenni*].

**Findabair** [*Findabair*].

**Find-benn´-a** [*Findbennach*].

**Findian** [*Finnén*].

**Fīnd-more´** [*Find mór*].

**Finguin** [*Fingin*].

**Finn the son of Ross the Red** [*Find mac Rosa Ruaid*].

**Finn´-caem** [*Findcoem*].

**Finn-ha Faer-bend´** [*Findchad Fer bend*].

**Fintan** [*Fintan*].

**Fohair** [*Feochair*].

**Fohnam** [*Fochnam*].

**Foill** [*Fóill*].

**Foll-oon´** [*Follomain*].

**Foorbee Faer benn** [*Furbaide Fer bend*]

**Forgall Mona** [*Forgall Monach*].

Four **Fotas** [*Cethri Fotai*].

**Frae the son of Eedath** [*Froech mac Idaith*].

Four **Furacars** [*Cethri Furachair*].

**Germanus** [*German*].

**Glass the son of Delga** [*Glass mac Delga*].

**Ibbur** [*Iubar*].

**Illann Finn** [*Illann Find*].

**Ill´-i-ah** [*Iliach*].

**Imha** [*Imchad*].

**Inguen** [*Ingen*].

**Inn´-yel** [*Innell*].

**Ivor** [*Ibar*].

Two **Kahlas** [*Da Chaladh*].

**Kear** [*Cíar*].

**Keen´-bĭlĭ** [*Cáinbili*].

Two **Keers** [*Dá Chír*].

**Kě´-hern** [*Cethern*].

**Keltar the son of Oo´-hĭder** [*Celtchar mac Uthecair*].

Five **Kermans** [*Cóic Cerman*].

**Ket the son of Mahga** [*Cet mac Magach*].

**Kieran** [*Ciaran*].

**Laeg son of Ree-angowra** [*Lóeg mac Riangabra*].

**Laer'-iny** [*Lairine*].

**Laery** [*Lóegaire*].

**Lath Gobla** [*Lath Gaiblie*].

**Lath son of Daw-brō'** [*Lath mac Da Bro*].

**Lawry Ling-sha** [*Labhraidh Loingseach*].

**Leddi** [*Leiti*].

**Leea Maha** [*Liath Macha*].

**Lewy son of Nōs son of Alamac** [*Lugaid mac Nois mac Alamaic*].

**Lewy son of Solmoy** [*Lugaid mac Solamaig*].

**Lō'-har** [*Lóthar*].

**Lōk son of Emonis** [*Lóch mac Emonis*, L.U. 74<sup>b</sup>9].

**Long** [*Long*].

**Loo son of Ethlenn** [*Lug mac Ethlend*].

**Looan** [*Lúan*].

**Looath** [*Luath*].

Two **Looees** [*Da Lui*].

**Low'-er-cam** [*Leborcham*].

Three **Lussens** [*Trí Lussin*].

**Mac Roth** [*Mac Roth*].

**Maccorb** [*Maccorb*].

**Maellia** [*Meille*].

**Maev** [*Medb*].

**Maha daughter of Sanrith son of Imba** [*Macha ingen Sainrith mac Imbaith*, L.L. 126<sup>a</sup>13].

**Mahn'-ya Ath-roo'-il** [*Mane Athremail*].

**Mahn'-ya Con'-da-gau Illy** [*Mane Condagaib uile*].

**Mahn'-ya Math-roo'-il** [*Mane Mathremail*].

**Mahn'-ya Mō-aepert** [*Mane Moepert*].

**Mahn'-ya Meen'-gar** [*Mane Mingor*].

**Mahn'-ya More'-gar** [*Mane Mórgor*].

**Mahn'-ya Toi** [*Mane Táí*].

**Manannawn** [*Mannanáń*].

**Marc** [*Marc*].

**Mar-vawn'** [*Marbhan*].

**Mawta Murrisc** [*Máta Murisc*].

**Mend son of Sal-colg'-an** [*Mend mac Salcholgan*].

**Mess Lahan** [*Meslethan*].

**Mess Leea** [*Mesláighe*].

**Mess Linny** [*Meslinni*].

**Mil** [*Mil*].

**Milhy** [*Muilchi*].

**Moo'-gawn** [*Mugain*].

The **More-reega daughter of Ernmas** [*In Mórrígu ingen Ernmais*].

**Mu-gar'-ny** [*Mugairne*].

Eight **Mullahs** [*Ocht Mulaig*].

**Munn-row'-er son of Guerkind** [*Munremur mac Gerrcind*].

**Mur'-i-dah** [*Muridach*].

**Nahta Scaena** [*Nechta Scene*].

**Nath-corp'-a** [*Nathcoirpthe*, L.U. 70<sup>a</sup>12].

**Nath-crant'-il** [*Nathcrantail*].

**Neesha** [*Nóisi*].

**Ōkill** [*Ochall*; gen. *Ochaill*].

**Oo'-a-ha** [*Uathach*].

**Oo'-al** [*Ual*].

Seven **Oo-arguses** [*secht nuárgusa*, L.U. 75<sup>a</sup>5].

**Oola** [*Uala*].

**Orlam** [*Orlám*; *Orláb*].

**Owen** [*Eogain*].

**Patrick** [*Patraic*].

**Raen** [*Ró-en*].

**Renc** [See L.L. 58<sup>b</sup>4. I think I ought to have read this word *rechtaire*, “steward,” as Dr. Windisch does. I took it to be an abbreviation for the name of the mother of Err and Innel, and made her *Renc*].

**Riccný** [*Ruiccní*].

**Rind** [*Rind*].

Eight **Rindahts** [*Ocht Rindaich*].

**Rinn** [*Rinn*].

Seven **Rohas** [*Secht Rochaid*].

**Rōhee son of Fa'-ha-win** [*Reochaid mac Fathemain*].

Eight **Rohties** [*Ocht Rochtaid*].

**Roncu** [*Roncu*].

Seven **Ronawns** [*Secht Ronáin*].

**Rooad** [*Ruad*].

**Root** [*Rucht*].

**Ross the son of Feeacna** [*Ros mac Fiacna*].

**Roy** [*Rói*].

Seven **Ruras** [*Secht Rurthig*].

Six **Saxans** [*Sé Saxain*].

**Scandall son of Mahga** [*Scandal mac Magach*].

**Scaw** [*Scath*].

**Scawtha daughter of Aird'-gămă** [*Scathach ingen Airdgeme*, cf. Y.B.L. 214<sup>a</sup>4].

**Setanta** [*Setanta*].

**Sheen** [*Sin*].

**Shenca** [*Sencha*].

**Shen'-cawn** [*Senchan*].

**Shennel Oo-aha** [*Senal Uathach*].

**Skeeath** [*Sciath*].

**Skibbur** [*Sciuhar*].

**Soda** [*Soda*].

**Soo'-al-tim** [*Sualtaim*].

**Sreb-loo'-ah** [*Srebluath*].

**Srub Dawra son of Fedaig** [*Srub dare mac Fedaig*].

**Tethra** [gen. *Tetrach*].

**Thoo'-a-ha Dae Danann** [*Túatha Dé Danann*].

**Tin'-niuc** [*Tinniuc*].

**Tinny son of Conrig Cass** [*Tinndi mac Conrach Cais*].

**Toohal son of Nahta** [*Tuachall mac Nechtain*].

**Trescath** [*Trescad*].

**Triath** [*Triath*].

**Ultonians** [*Ulaid*].

**Ul'-becawn** [*Ulbecan*].

**Weefa** [*Aiffe*].

**Yōhee Bec** [*Eochaid Bec*].

**Yōhee Fayla** [*Eochaid Feidlech*].



## **APPENDIX D**

### **THE PRINCIPAL SOURCES FROM WHICH THE NARRATIVE HAS BEEN DRAWN**

#### **THE FINDING OF THE TÁIN**

1. *Do fallsigud tána bó cualnge*, “The revealing of the Táin bo Cualnge.” L.L. 245<sup>b</sup>3-42.

2. *Imtheacht na Tromdháime, Ina bh-foillsighthear cionas do fuaras an Táin ar tús*, 7c. “The journeying of the burdensome learned men, in which it is revealed how the Táin was first found,” &c. Oss. vol. v.

3. The version of the Revealing of the Táin in Egerton 1782, fol. 87<sup>b</sup>. Printed in Archiv. iii. 3.

4. The version of the Revealing of the Táin, MS. D. 4. 2 (R.I.A.) fol. 49<sup>b</sup>2. Printed in Archiv. iii. 4.

[These four versions differ very much from each other.]

5. “Lives of the Saints from the Book of Lismore,” edited by Dr. Whitley Stokes, Oxford, 1890.

6. “Life of St. Kieran of Saighir.” Silv. Gad.

#### **BOOK I**

1. T.B.C.; L.L.

2. *De chophur in da muccide*, “of the Generation (?) of the two Swineherds.” L.L. 246<sup>a</sup>-247<sup>a</sup>. Also the Egerton Text, edited by Windisch, I.T., Dritte Serie, 1 Heft.

3. *Ferchuitred Medba*. “Maev’s Three Husbands,” Rawlinson MS. B 512. [I made a transcript of this in the Bodleian several years ago.]

4. *Cath Boinde*. “The Battle of the Boyne,” Book of Lecan, 351<sup>b</sup>-353<sup>a</sup>, a text almost identical with *Ferchuitred Medba*. It has been edited by Mr. Joseph O’Neill, in *Ériu* ii. 173.

In causing the Druid to give the account of the transmigrations of the swine-herds, and in causing Maev to be the narrator of her own youthful history, I merely adopt the characteristic Gaelic device for introducing episodes from the past, the same device which is used in the texts of the Táin itself, where the three distinguished exiles from Ulster are made to relate the boyish exploits of Cucullin.

## BOOK II

1. *Cid dia mboi loniges mac nUsnig*. “What caused the exile of the Sons of Usna?” L.L. 259<sup>b</sup>-261<sup>b</sup>. This text has been edited by Dr. Windisch, I.T., first series.

2. *Oided mac nUisnig*. “The Tragic Deaths of the Sons of Usna,” edited by Dr. Stokes, I.T., Zweite serie, 2 Heft.

3. *Déirdre*, edited by Dr. Douglas Hyde from a manuscript in the Belfast Museum, *Zeitschrift für Celtische Philologie*, vol. ii.

4. *The Glenmasan Manuscript*, Advocates’ Library, Edinburgh. This ms. is invaluable for the account which it gives of the events that occurred between the deaths of the sons of Usna and the opening of the Táin. Some years ago I began to make a copy of it; but I was happily saved from continuing this difficult labour by its gradual appearance, edited by Professor Mackinnon, in the *Celtic Review*.

5. *Caithréim Conghail Cláiringnig*, “Martial Career of Conghal Cláiringhneach,” edited by P. M. MacSweeney, M.A., I.T.S., vol. v. This tells us also of the “martial career” of Fergus in the days before the exile of the Sons of Usna.

It is necessary to know the story of the children of Usna in order to understand the position of Fergus in the Táin. In supposing Lowercam to be exiled in Connaught, and in making her the narrator of the story, I again merely adopt the characteristic Gaelic device.

## BOOK III

1. T.B.C.; L.L.

2. T.B.C.; L.U.

3. *Cóir Anmann*, “Fitness of Names,” edited by Dr. Whitley Stokes, I.T., Dritte Serie, 2 Heft.

4. *Ferchuitred Medba* and *Cath Boinde*, as in Book I.

5. *Táin bo Fraech*, “The Driving of the Kine of Frae,” L.L. 248<sup>a</sup>-252<sup>b</sup>.

6. *Noinden Ulad cid di-atá*, “What was the origin of the ‘noinden’ of Ulster?” L.L. 125<sup>b</sup>-126<sup>a</sup>.

In making the Druid the narrator of this tale I again, as in Books I and II, adopt the Gaelic method. A knowledge of the tale is essential to the proper understanding of the *Táin*.

## BOOK IV

1. T.B.C.; L.U.

2. T.B.C.; L.L.

The description of the making of Maev’s camp was suggested by a passage in *Cath Mhuighe Léana*, “The Battle of Magh Léana”; and the account of the harpers and their music was suggested by *Táin bo Fraech*.

## BOOK V

1. T.B.C.; L.L.

2. T.B.C.; L.U.

## BOOKS VI AND VII

(See [Appendix E.](#))

## BOOK VIII

1. T.B.C; L.L.

2. T.B.C; L.U.

The account of “Laeg’s one combat on the Táin” was taken from the ms. marked H. 2. 17 in Trinity College, Dublin.

The account of Cucullin’s meeting with the More-reega is from the *Táin bo Regamna*, edited by Dr. Windisch, I.T., Zweite Serie, 2 Heft.

## **BOOK IX**

1. T.B.C.; L.L.

2. T.B.C.; L.U.

## **BOOK X**

1. T.B.C.; L.L.

2. T.B.C.; L.U.

I took the account of the combat of Laeriny from the ms. marked Addendum 18748 in the British Museum. The same narrative from Egerton 93 is printed by Nettlau, *Rev. Celt.* xiv, 261.

## **BOOK XI**

1. T.B.C.; L.L.

2. T.B.C.; L.U.

For the account given of himself by Loo the son of Ethlenn see “The Second Battle of Moytura,” edited by Dr. Whitley Stokes, *Rev. Celt.* xii; and for the substance of Maev’s speech to Fergus, see the Glenmasan ms.

## **BOOK XII**

1. T.B.C.; L.L.

2. T.B.C.; L.U.

3. "The Ferdiad Episode in the Táin Bo Cuailnge," by Nettlau, Rev. Celt. x and xi.

### BOOK XIII

1. T.B.C.; L.L.

2. T.B.C.; L.U.

3. T.B.C.; Y.B.L.

For the description of Cooroi see the passage in *Fled Bricrend*, L.U. 110<sup>b</sup>44-111<sup>a</sup>3.

For *Taltin*, see passage in *Senchas na relec*, "History of the Cemeteries," L.U. 51<sup>b</sup>1; also L.U. 38<sup>b</sup>34.

For *Brigit*, see *Corm*, s.v. *Brigit*; also Rennes, section 159; also L.L. 170<sup>b</sup>55 and L.L. 187<sup>c</sup>55.

### BOOK XIV

1. T.B.C.; L.L.

2. T.B.C.; Y.B.L.

### BOOK XV

1. T.B.C.; L.L.

2. T.B.C.; Y.B.L.

For the Battle-castles see Windisch, *Táin*, pp. 785-803, where a long extract from the Stowe MS. is given.

For the idea of Maev's going three times round the hosts see a passage in "The Battle of Magh Rath."

For the substance of Maev's first speech to Fergus see the above-mentioned extract from the Stowe MS., also the Glenmasan MS., &c.

For the Three Waves see C.R.R.

For the comparison of Cucullin to St. Columcille see the “Life of Columcille,” edited by Dr. Henebry.

For the sword of Cucullin see the “Decision as to Cormac’s sword,” edited by Dr. Whitley Stokes, I.T. Dritte Serie, 1 Heft.

For the cry of the striplings see Rennes, section 120.

For Conor’s gloom and depression see opening of C.R.R.

For the wedding of Emer, see close of T.E.

For the death of Cucullin (only alluded to here, since it does not come within the scope of the narrative) see the text abridged from L.L. by Dr. Whitley Stokes, Rev. Celt. iii, 175.

## **THE WRITING OF THE TÁIN**

1. The same materials as in “The Finding of the Táin.”
2. *Senchas na relec*, “History of the Cemeteries,” L.U. 50<sup>b</sup>-52<sup>a</sup>.
3. *Aided Nathi ocus a adnacol*, “The Violent Death and the Burial of Dathi,” L.U. 38.
4. “Christian Inscriptions in the Irish Language,” edited by Petrie.
5. “Life of Colum cille,” edited by Dr. Henebry.

## APPENDIX E

### NOTES ON BOOKS VI AND VII

It is necessary to know the story of Cucullin's training to arms, in order that we may understand his relationship to his fellow-pupils in Books X and XII.

Most writers who in recent times have touched upon this story have assumed that the place of his training was the Isle of Skye, in Scotland. The treatment of the subject which I present in Book VII will, therefore, be regarded by some readers as a new departure, and one which requires justification.

The story of his training is found in two quite different versions. One version forms a part of the *Tochmarc Emire* [T.E.], "The Wooing of Emer." An account of the various mss. in which the *Tochmarc Emire* has come down to us is given to us by Dr. Kuno Meyer, *Rev. Celt.*, vol. xi. I have used chiefly the Harleian text, printed by Dr. Meyer in the *Zeitschrift für Celtische Philologie*, vol. iii. The other version of his training is found in the *Foghlaimh Conchulaind* [F.C.], "The Education of Cucullin," a tract which, so far as I know, has not yet been edited. I have worked from a copy which is in the R.I.A. This version exists now only in rather modern mss.; but its substance is ancient. It represents the version of Cucullin's training which is presupposed both in the L.L. and L.U. recensions of the Táin; it is the version which tells of the solemn binding together of her pupils by their teacher, Scawtha.

Now, in F.C. Cucullin is trained, not in Skye, but in the east of Europe—in Scythia, and in "Great Greece" [*san nGréig mhóir*]. Scythia was a vague term for a region extending from what is now Hungary, eastward, far into Asia. In Ptolemy Scythia is made to cover a vast expanse. The name occurs frequently in our old Irish literature. "Great Greece," I think, was an equally vague term for the countries in which Greek was spoken, and which bordered on Scythia. It is to be remembered that at the time of the Táin the Celts were found over a great part of central Europe, and probably in "Scythia"; and they still spoke their own language. That there should have

been frequent intercourse between them and the Celts of Ireland, and that our young nobles should have gone from Ireland to get a warlike training amongst the Celts of the Continent, is only what we might have expected. Compare various passages in Professor Bury's "Life of St. Patrick," concerning the frequency of intercourse in early times between Ireland and the continent of Europe. The tradition of this intercourse has never died out in Irish literature.

In T.E., which contains the first-named version of Cucullin's training, if we look closely into it, we find the same continental tradition. Owing to their close likeness, it was very easy to confuse the Gaelic words for Scotland and for the Alps. I believe that the *Alpi* of T.E. means the Alps. The land of Scawtha was *fri Alpi allaanoir*, "eastward from Alpi." That would not answer to the position of Skye with regard to Scotland; but it would answer very well to the position of Scythia with regard to the Alps.

In the text of the Táin itself we have references to Cucullin's training in the East. One of these is at L.L. 69<sup>a</sup>6, where he is said to have gone to the mountains of Armenia, and also to have brought slaughter amongst the *Cichloiste* (read *-loiscthe*). *Cichloiscthe* is the Irish word for Amazons. It occurs in Middle-Irish translations from the classics, and it means "Burnt-breasts." The classical "myths" concerning the Amazons, and the apparently quite independent Irish tradition of warrior-women in Scythia and "Great Greece," are interesting in relation to each other. Why should we suppose that such warrior-women did not really exist?

Other references in the text of the Táin are in the Germanus poem, L.L. 88<sup>a</sup>4-88<sup>b</sup>24. At Y.B.L. 37<sup>b</sup>51-2 we are told that the fortress of Germanus was above the edge-borders of the *Muir Toirrian*, which, following Dr. Stokes and others, I have rendered by "the Tyrrhene Sea." But the *Muir Toirrian* really meant the whole Mediterranean. (Compare L.L. 3<sup>a</sup>23-28, where Bráth, starting from somewhere in the East, sails along the length of the *Muir Toirrian* to Crete and Sicily, and finally to Spain.)

As to the whereabouts of *Lind Format* I can offer no suggestion. In the *Isles of the Athisech* we might suspect an allusion to Athens; but it seems doubtful whether the *n* would have disappeared.

Did the later statements that Scawtha lived in the Isle of Skye arise from a double confusion between the Irish words for Skye and for Scythia on the



one hand, and for Scotland and for the Alps on the other hand? Or was there really an early and independent Scotland-tradition? Perhaps some Scottish Gael will work out the subject.

The sources for Books VI and VII, besides the texts mentioned above, are the L.L. text of the Táin, and “The Fer Diad episode of the Táin Bó Cuailnge,” by Dr. M. Nettelbladt, in *Rev. Celt.* x. and xi.

I have chosen Faerdeeah as the teller of this tale in order that he may become known to us as the friend of Cucullin. From the artistic point of view the great defect in the account of the combat between Cucullin and Faerdeeah, as it occurs in both the recensions of the Táin, is that in one of the pair of combatants we have no previous interest.

I had completed the writing of Books VI and VII, and prepared my notes on them, before I had the gratification of seeing that on the question of the geography implied in T.E., Dr. Windisch is in agreement with me. See his *Táin*, pp. 436-437.

Dr. Whitley Stokes allows me to have the great pleasure of saying that he hopes some day to give us an edition of the *Foghlaimh Conchulaind*.

## ABBREVIATIONS USED IN THE APPENDICES

|                    |                                                                                                              |
|--------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Ac. na Sen.</b> | <i>Acallamh na Senórach</i> , edited by Dr. Whitley Stokes. Irische Texte, Vierte Serie, 1 Heft.             |
| <b>An. Ulster.</b> | <i>Annals of Ulster</i> , edited by W. M. Hennessy.                                                          |
| <b>Archiv.</b>     | <i>Archiv für Celtische Lexicographie</i> , herausgegeben von Whitley Stokes und Kuno Meyer.                 |
| <b>B.R.</b>        | <i>Book of Rights</i> , edited by O'Donovan, 1847.                                                           |
| <b>Corm.</b>       | <i>Cormac's Glossary</i> , edited by Dr. Whitley Stokes. Calcutta, 1868.                                     |
| <b>C.R.R.</b>      | <i>Cath Ruis na Ríg for Bóinn</i> , edited for the Royal Irish Academy by Edmund Hogan, s.j. Dublin, 1892.   |
| <b>F.C.</b>        | <i>Foghlaimh Conchulaind</i> .                                                                               |
| <b>F.M.</b>        | <i>The Annals of the Kingdom of Ireland by the Four Masters</i> , edited by O'Donovan.                       |
| <b>Fél.</b>        | <i>The Calendar of Oengus</i> , edited by Dr. Whitley Stokes, 1880.                                          |
| <b>G. and G.</b>   | <i>The War of the Gaedhil with the Gaill</i> , edited by James Henthorne Todd, D.D. 1867.                    |
| <b>I.T.</b>        | <i>Irische Texte</i> , edited by Stokes and Windisch.                                                        |
| <b>I.T.S.</b>      | <i>Irish Texts Society</i> .                                                                                 |
| <b>Laws</b>        | <i>Ancient Laws of Ireland</i> .                                                                             |
| <b>Lib. Hym.</b>   | <i>The Irish Liber Hymnorum</i> , edited for the Henry Bradshaw Society by Drs. Bernard and Atkinson.        |
| <b>L.L.</b>        | The lithographic facsimile of the Book of Leinster, published by the Royal Irish Academy in 1880.            |
| <b>L.U.</b>        | The lithographic facsimile of the <i>Leabhar na h-Uidhri</i> , published by the Royal Irish Academy in 1870. |
| <b>M. and C.</b>   | <i>Manners and Customs of the Ancient Irish</i> , by Eugene O'Curry. 1873.                                   |
| <b>O'Brien.</b>    | <i>O'Brien's Irish-English Dictionary</i> . Dublin, 1832.                                                    |
| <b>O'Lav.</b>      | <i>An Historical Account of the Diocese of Down and Connor</i> , by the Rev. James O'Laverty. Dublin,        |

- 1878.
- Oss.** Transactions of the Ossianic Society. Dublin, 1854-1861.
- Reeves.** *Ecclesiastical Antiquities of Down, Connor, and Dromore*, by the Rev. William Reeves. 1847.
- Reeves, Col.** Adamnan's *Life of St. Columba*, edited by William Reeves, D.D. 1857.
- Rennes.** "The Prose Tales of the Rennes Dinsenchas," edited by Dr. Whitley Stokes. *Revue Celtique*, vols. xv. and xvi.
- R.I.A.** Royal Irish Academy.
- Rev. Celt.** *Revue Celtique*.
- Silv. Gad.** *Silva Gadelica*, by S. H. O'Grady. 1892.
- Soc. Hist.** *A Social History of Ancient Ireland*, by P. W. Joyce. 1903.
- T.B.C.** Text of the *Táin Bó Cúalnge*.
- T.E.** *Tochmarc Emire la Coinculaind*, edited by Dr. Kuno Meyer. *Zeitschrift für Celtische Philologie*, vol. iii.
- Trip. Life.** *The Tripartite Life of St. Patrick*, edited by Dr. Whitley Stokes. 1887.
- Windisch, Táin.** The *Táin Bó Cualnge*, edited, with German translation, by Dr. Windisch. Leipzig, 1905.
- Y.B.L.** Photographic facsimile of the Yellow Book of Lecan, published by the Royal Irish Academy, 1896.
- Zimmer, K.S.** Zimmer, *Keltische Studien*.

\*\*\* END OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK THE TÁIN \*\*\*

Updated editions will replace the previous one—the old editions will be renamed.

Creating the works from print editions not protected by U.S. copyright law means that no one owns a United States copyright in these works, so the Foundation (and you!) can copy and distribute it in the United States without permission and without paying copyright royalties. Special rules, set forth in the General Terms of Use part of this license, apply to copying and distributing Project Gutenberg™ electronic works to protect the PROJECT GUTENBERG™ concept and trademark. Project Gutenberg is a registered trademark, and may not be used if you charge for an eBook, except by following the terms of the trademark license, including paying royalties for use of the Project Gutenberg trademark. If you do not charge anything for copies of this eBook, complying with the trademark license is very easy. You may use this eBook for nearly any purpose such as creation of derivative works, reports, performances and research. Project Gutenberg eBooks may be modified and printed and given away—you may do practically ANYTHING in the United States with eBooks not protected by U.S. copyright law. Redistribution is subject to the trademark license, especially commercial redistribution.

START: FULL LICENSE

# THE FULL PROJECT GUTENBERG™ LICENSE

PLEASE READ THIS BEFORE YOU DISTRIBUTE OR USE THIS WORK

To protect the Project Gutenberg™ mission of promoting the free distribution of electronic works, by using or distributing this work (or any other work associated in any way with the phrase “Project Gutenberg”), you agree to comply with all the terms of the Full Project Gutenberg License available with this file or online at [www.gutenberg.org/license](http://www.gutenberg.org/license).

## **Section 1. General Terms of Use and Redistributing Project Gutenberg electronic works**

1.A. By reading or using any part of this Project Gutenberg electronic work, you indicate that you have read, understand, agree to and accept all the terms of this license and intellectual property (trademark/copyright) agreement. If you do not agree to abide by all the terms of this agreement, you must cease using and return or destroy all copies of Project Gutenberg electronic works in your possession. If you paid a fee for obtaining a copy of or access to a Project Gutenberg electronic work and you do not agree to be bound by the terms of this agreement, you may obtain a refund from the person or entity to whom you paid the fee as set forth in paragraph 1.E.8.

1.B. “Project Gutenberg” is a registered trademark. It may only be used on or associated in any way with an electronic work by people who agree to be bound by the terms of this agreement. There are a few things that you can do with most Project Gutenberg electronic works even without complying with the full terms of this agreement. See paragraph 1.C below. There are a lot of things you can do with Project Gutenberg electronic works if you follow the terms of this agreement and help preserve free future access to Project Gutenberg electronic works. See paragraph 1.E below.

1.C. The Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation (“the Foundation” or PGLAF), owns a compilation copyright in the

collection of Project Gutenberg electronic works. Nearly all the individual works in the collection are in the public domain in the United States. If an individual work is unprotected by copyright law in the United States and you are located in the United States, we do not claim a right to prevent you from copying, distributing, performing, displaying or creating derivative works based on the work as long as all references to Project Gutenberg are removed. Of course, we hope that you will support the Project Gutenberg mission of promoting free access to electronic works by freely sharing Project Gutenberg works in compliance with the terms of this agreement for keeping the Project Gutenberg name associated with the work. You can easily comply with the terms of this agreement by keeping this work in the same format with its attached full Project Gutenberg License when you share it without charge with others.

1.D. The copyright laws of the place where you are located also govern what you can do with this work. Copyright laws in most countries are in a constant state of change. If you are outside the United States, check the laws of your country in addition to the terms of this agreement before downloading, copying, displaying, performing, distributing or creating derivative works based on this work or any other Project Gutenberg work. The Foundation makes no representations concerning the copyright status of any work in any country other than the United States.

1.E. Unless you have removed all references to Project Gutenberg:

1.E.1. The following sentence, with active links to, or other immediate access to, the full Project Gutenberg License must appear prominently whenever any copy of a Project Gutenberg work (any work on which the phrase “Project Gutenberg” appears, or with which the phrase “Project Gutenberg” is associated) is accessed, displayed, performed, viewed, copied or distributed:

This eBook is for the use of anyone anywhere in the United States and most other parts of the world at no cost and with almost no restrictions whatsoever. You may copy it, give it away or re-use it under the terms of the Project Gutenberg™ License included with

this eBook or online at [www.gutenberg.org](http://www.gutenberg.org). If you are not located in the United States, you will have to check the laws of the country where you are located before using this eBook.

1.E.2. If an individual Project Gutenberg electronic work is derived from texts not protected by U.S. copyright law (does not contain a notice indicating that it is posted with permission of the copyright holder), the work can be copied and distributed to anyone in the United States without paying any fees or charges. If you are redistributing or providing access to a work with the phrase “Project Gutenberg” associated with or appearing on the work, you must comply either with the requirements of paragraphs 1.E.1 through 1.E.7 or obtain permission for the use of the work and the Project Gutenberg trademark as set forth in paragraphs 1.E.8 or 1.E.9.

1.E.3. If an individual Project Gutenberg electronic work is posted with the permission of the copyright holder, your use and distribution must comply with both paragraphs 1.E.1 through 1.E.7 and any additional terms imposed by the copyright holder. Additional terms will be linked to the Project Gutenberg License for all works posted with the permission of the copyright holder found at the beginning of this work.

1.E.4. Do not unlink or detach or remove the full Project Gutenberg License terms from this work, or any files containing a part of this work or any other work associated with Project Gutenberg.

1.E.5. Do not copy, display, perform, distribute or redistribute this electronic work, or any part of this electronic work, without prominently displaying the sentence set forth in paragraph 1.E.1 with active links or immediate access to the full terms of the Project Gutenberg License.

1.E.6. You may convert to and distribute this work in any binary, compressed, marked up, nonproprietary or proprietary form, including any word processing or hypertext form. However, if you provide access to or distribute copies of a Project Gutenberg work in a format other than “Plain Vanilla ASCII” or other format used in the official

version posted on the official Project Gutenberg website ([www.gutenberg.org](http://www.gutenberg.org)), you must, at no additional cost, fee or expense to the user, provide a copy, a means of exporting a copy, or a means of obtaining a copy upon request, of the work in its original “Plain Vanilla ASCII” or other form. Any alternate format must include the full Project Gutenberg License as specified in paragraph 1.E.1.

1.E.7. Do not charge a fee for access to, viewing, displaying, performing, copying or distributing any Project Gutenberg works unless you comply with paragraph 1.E.8 or 1.E.9.

1.E.8. You may charge a reasonable fee for copies of or providing access to or distributing Project Gutenberg electronic works provided that:

- You pay a royalty fee of 20% of the gross profits you derive from the use of Project Gutenberg works calculated using the method you already use to calculate your applicable taxes. The fee is owed to the owner of the Project Gutenberg trademark, but he has agreed to donate royalties under this paragraph to the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation. Royalty payments must be paid within 60 days following each date on which you prepare (or are legally required to prepare) your periodic tax returns. Royalty payments should be clearly marked as such and sent to the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation at the address specified in Section 4, “Information about donations to the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation.”
- You provide a full refund of any money paid by a user who notifies you in writing (or by e-mail) within 30 days of receipt that s/he does not agree to the terms of the full Project Gutenberg™ License. You must require such a user to return or destroy all copies of the works possessed in a physical medium and discontinue all use of and all access to other copies of Project Gutenberg™ works.
- You provide, in accordance with paragraph 1.F.3, a full refund of any money paid for a work or a replacement copy, if a defect in the electronic work is discovered and reported to you within 90 days of receipt of the work.



- You comply with all other terms of this agreement for free distribution of Project Gutenberg™ works.

1.E.9. If you wish to charge a fee or distribute a Project Gutenberg™ electronic work or group of works on different terms than are set forth in this agreement, you must obtain permission in writing from the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation, the manager of the Project Gutenberg™ trademark. Contact the Foundation as set forth in Section 3 below.

#### 1.F.

1.F.1. Project Gutenberg volunteers and employees expend considerable effort to identify, do copyright research on, transcribe and proofread works not protected by U.S. copyright law in creating the Project Gutenberg™ collection. Despite these efforts, Project Gutenberg™ electronic works, and the medium on which they may be stored, may contain “Defects,” such as, but not limited to, incomplete, inaccurate or corrupt data, transcription errors, a copyright or other intellectual property infringement, a defective or damaged disk or other medium, a computer virus, or computer codes that damage or cannot be read by your equipment.

1.F.2. LIMITED WARRANTY, DISCLAIMER OF DAMAGES - Except for the “Right of Replacement or Refund” described in paragraph 1.F.3, the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation, the owner of the Project Gutenberg™ trademark, and any other party distributing a Project Gutenberg™ electronic work under this agreement, disclaim all liability to you for damages, costs and expenses, including legal fees. YOU AGREE THAT YOU HAVE NO REMEDIES FOR NEGLIGENCE, STRICT LIABILITY, BREACH OF WARRANTY OR BREACH OF CONTRACT EXCEPT THOSE PROVIDED IN PARAGRAPH 1.F.3. YOU AGREE THAT THE FOUNDATION, THE TRADEMARK OWNER, AND ANY DISTRIBUTOR UNDER THIS AGREEMENT WILL NOT BE LIABLE TO YOU FOR ACTUAL, DIRECT, INDIRECT, CONSEQUENTIAL, PUNITIVE OR INCIDENTAL DAMAGES

EVEN IF YOU GIVE NOTICE OF THE POSSIBILITY OF SUCH DAMAGE.

1.F.3. LIMITED RIGHT OF REPLACEMENT OR REFUND - If you discover a defect in this electronic work within 90 days of receiving it, you can receive a refund of the money (if any) you paid for it by sending a written explanation to the person you received the work from. If you received the work on a physical medium, you must return the medium with your written explanation. The person or entity that provided you with the defective work may elect to provide a replacement copy in lieu of a refund. If you received the work electronically, the person or entity providing it to you may choose to give you a second opportunity to receive the work electronically in lieu of a refund. If the second copy is also defective, you may demand a refund in writing without further opportunities to fix the problem.

1.F.4. Except for the limited right of replacement or refund set forth in paragraph 1.F.3, this work is provided to you 'AS-IS', WITH NO OTHER WARRANTIES OF ANY KIND, EXPRESS OR IMPLIED, INCLUDING BUT NOT LIMITED TO WARRANTIES OF MERCHANTABILITY OR FITNESS FOR ANY PURPOSE.

1.F.5. Some states do not allow disclaimers of certain implied warranties or the exclusion or limitation of certain types of damages. If any disclaimer or limitation set forth in this agreement violates the law of the state applicable to this agreement, the agreement shall be interpreted to make the maximum disclaimer or limitation permitted by the applicable state law. The invalidity or unenforceability of any provision of this agreement shall not void the remaining provisions.

1.F.6. INDEMNITY - You agree to indemnify and hold the Foundation, the trademark owner, any agent or employee of the Foundation, anyone providing copies of Project Gutenberg™ electronic works in accordance with this agreement, and any volunteers associated with the production, promotion and distribution of Project Gutenberg™ electronic works, harmless from all liability, costs and expenses, including legal fees, that arise directly or indirectly from any of the following which you do or cause to occur: (a)

distribution of this or any Project Gutenberg work, (b) alteration, modification, or additions or deletions to any Project Gutenberg work, and (c) any Defect you cause.

## **Section 2. Information about the Mission of Project Gutenberg**

Project Gutenberg is synonymous with the free distribution of electronic works in formats readable by the widest variety of computers including obsolete, old, middle-aged and new computers. It exists because of the efforts of hundreds of volunteers and donations from people in all walks of life.

Volunteers and financial support to provide volunteers with the assistance they need are critical to reaching Project Gutenberg's goals and ensuring that the Project Gutenberg collection will remain freely available for generations to come. In 2001, the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation was created to provide a secure and permanent future for Project Gutenberg and future generations. To learn more about the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation and how your efforts and donations can help, see Sections 3 and 4 and the Foundation information page at [www.gutenberg.org](http://www.gutenberg.org).

## **Section 3. Information about the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation**

The Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation is a non-profit 501(c)(3) educational corporation organized under the laws of the state of Mississippi and granted tax exempt status by the Internal Revenue Service. The Foundation's EIN or federal tax identification number is 64-6221541. Contributions to the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation are tax deductible to the full extent permitted by U.S. federal laws and your state's laws.

The Foundation's business office is located at 41 Watchung Plaza #516, Montclair NJ 07042, USA, +1 (862) 621-9288. Email contact

links and up to date contact information can be found at the Foundation's website and official page at [www.gutenberg.org/contact](http://www.gutenberg.org/contact)

## **Section 4. Information about Donations to the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation**

Project Gutenberg™ depends upon and cannot survive without widespread public support and donations to carry out its mission of increasing the number of public domain and licensed works that can be freely distributed in machine-readable form accessible by the widest array of equipment including outdated equipment. Many small donations (\$1 to \$5,000) are particularly important to maintaining tax exempt status with the IRS.

The Foundation is committed to complying with the laws regulating charities and charitable donations in all 50 states of the United States. Compliance requirements are not uniform and it takes a considerable effort, much paperwork and many fees to meet and keep up with these requirements. We do not solicit donations in locations where we have not received written confirmation of compliance. To SEND DONATIONS or determine the status of compliance for any particular state visit [www.gutenberg.org/donate](http://www.gutenberg.org/donate).

While we cannot and do not solicit contributions from states where we have not met the solicitation requirements, we know of no prohibition against accepting unsolicited donations from donors in such states who approach us with offers to donate.

International donations are gratefully accepted, but we cannot make any statements concerning tax treatment of donations received from outside the United States. U.S. laws alone swamp our small staff.

Please check the Project Gutenberg web pages for current donation methods and addresses. Donations are accepted in a number of other ways including checks, online payments and credit card donations. To donate, please visit: [www.gutenberg.org/donate](http://www.gutenberg.org/donate).

## **Section 5. General Information About Project Gutenberg electronic works**

Professor Michael S. Hart was the originator of the Project Gutenberg concept of a library of electronic works that could be freely shared with anyone. For forty years, he produced and distributed Project Gutenberg eBooks with only a loose network of volunteer support.

Project Gutenberg eBooks are often created from several printed editions, all of which are confirmed as not protected by copyright in the U.S. unless a copyright notice is included. Thus, we do not necessarily keep eBooks in compliance with any particular paper edition.

Most people start at our website which has the main PG search facility: [www.gutenberg.org](http://www.gutenberg.org).

This website includes information about Project Gutenberg, including how to make donations to the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation, how to help produce our new eBooks, and how to subscribe to our email newsletter to hear about new eBooks.